
Tragic
EMPIRE
K.L MANN

Tragic Empire

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Author's Note

Tragic Empire is a mafia romance with a **large** cast and a huge emphasis on found family and healing. There are dark themes as well as explicit scenes.

Possible TW/CW
Explicit Language and Graphic Violence
Trauma
Weapons and Murder
Torture
Grief
Loss of a spouse
Loss of a child
Suicide (mentioned)
Kidnapping
Brain Tumor (mentioned)
Fertility Struggle (mentioned)
Stalking
Consensual Somnophilia
Past Step Sibling Relationship (not main couple)

Please reach out to me if you have concerns or questions about any of the listed warnings. Your mental health matters.

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For all the characters who had to die to make this story possible. I'm so sorry.

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Chapter One



Ana

Heavy rain pouring from the night sky is almost too thick to walk through. It makes the air muggy, and forces an unwelcome wave of warm liquid to cling to my skin. Earth-shaking thunder cracks from above, and lightning runs along the black horizon, shattering in sharp glowing streaks.

I can hardly hear anything over the sound of the storm, not even most of my own thoughts. *Probably safer that way.*

Headlights from a running car allow me to see where I'm going, my steps cautious but swift. I have to get out of the rain before I faint, or worse, before I start to cry. If I let the emotions take hold of me, I think I might drown myself in them.

Go numb, I remind myself, knowing full-well I don't have the skills necessary to black out completely. Not after everything that I've just seen.

Still, I latch on to the concept and try as hard as I can.

Numb.

Numb.

Numb.

The familiar porch awning puts an abrupt stop to the rain pelting down on me, but it only muffles the sound of the storm raging on behind me. Without breathing, my fingers stretch out, reaching for the bell. It's cold against my fingertip, the touch sending a zip of shivers down my neck.

Guards would typically have stopped me at the gate and asked for permission before waving me in. But I've been here so many times now that I've been put on the "wave through" list. I was able to pull up straight

to the door, putting my vehicle in park without turning it off. I *couldn't* turn it off. I couldn't possibly bear the thought of walking in the complete dark.

Not now.

I start to chew on my lip, feeling so utterly alone. I'm not quite sure how I'm even still standing with my knees so weak—like they could give out at any second. I avoid looking at the small window in the door where my reflection lingers like a shadow I can't bring myself to face.

It's hard to say how many moments pass before I reach to ring the bell again, but before I can touch it, the door creaks open. I don't know the man at the door well, but I know enough to feel significantly safer just looking at him.

"Ana?" Anatoly asks, giving me a surprised look. "I didn't know you were coming." His eyes scan the storm behind me and the state of my clothes. "Come inside, you look freezing."

Anatoly Petrov is a huge man. Like, a building of a person. Even so, he has soft, kind eyes, and I know how protective he is of Jade. As one of her best friends, his protection extends to me. It's not as fierce, of course. But it's reassuring either way.

Wordlessly, I step over the threshold and physically tremble as my body adjusts to the warmth of the home.

It's then that Anatoly sees the blood on my hands.

He stiffens and reaches for his watch, hitting a button I know is meant to notify Dmitri Morozov. His boss, and my best friend's husband. He's the future Pakhan of the Morozov Bratva. A lethal killer, but a marshmallow of a man for Jade. Just like Anatoly, he'll help me because of her. No matter how new our relationship is.

I'd only just begun to develop my friendship with Jade Moretti eight months ago, and we'd only been able to hang out in person five months after that. It was an instant connection and grew quickly. We've had sleepovers, and we text or video call every day when we can't see each other.

Even as a new mom of twins, Jade continuously makes time for me. She's a good friend and someone I can truly trust. Which is good, because she's the only person I have to turn to right now.

"Ana, are you all right?" Anatoly asks cautiously. I open my mouth to respond, but we're interrupted before any words can come out.

“Hey you,” Jade calls out in greeting, jogging over to us with a bright smile. She’s wearing sweats but doesn’t look tired, which means her babies are likely already asleep and she’s enjoying her time relaxing. “You’re soaking wet girl, is it raining outside or are you just happy to see me?”

All of my composure cracks.

I’m safe, I’m safe, I’m safe.

Jade is here.

A hysterical laugh bubbles from my lips, and I cup a hand over my mouth. I can taste a tinge of blood through my lips at the contact, but I don’t pull it away. The urge to contain myself is strong, but it’s impossible.

My knees give out and my body shakes as I fall toward the floor. Anatoly’s arms wrap around my middle to catch me just before I crash. Jade’s eyes widen and she reaches for me too, her face becoming blurry through unshed tears. They fill my eyes with a thick sheen that no amount of blinking can seem to clear up.

“Ana,” she soothes, trying to comfort me. “What happened? Whose blood is this?” My stomach gives an awful churn at the question.

I don’t want to think about it.

I don’t want to believe it’s true.

“Cole,” I croak, breathing out his name.

Her small hands squeeze my wrists, and she lets out a noise of worry.

“Cole? Is Cole with you?”

I wish.

I’d give anything to say he was here with me.

My throat burns and I look at my crimson-stained hands.

“They killed Cole,” I wheeze, chest shaking.

Saying it out loud only makes the pain worse. It’s sharper, more direct, an invisible ice pick to the heart.

“Oh my god,” my friend whispers with a haunted tone.

“*Fuck*,” I hear muttered. Anatoly, I think.

“Dmitri!” Jade calls out, voice laced with worry. “Bring Apollo!”

She squeezes me again, and I shudder, the panic and grief slowly beginning to pull me under.

“It’s going to be okay,” she vows, wrapping her arms around my shoulders. “We’ve got you now. Everything is going to be all right, Ana.”

It’s not going to be okay. How can it?

Cole is *gone*.

Voices surround me, questions fired back and forth, but I can't seem to find any words. I'm losing myself in this wallowing, finding it harder and harder to breathe.

"She said they killed Cole—"

"Who's *they*?"

"I don't know! She's clearly distraught, Apollo, I—"

Hands grip my shoulders and Jade makes a noise of protest.

"Be gentle with her—"

"Krasotka, let him." That's Dmitri's voice, and his nickname for his wife, meaning he isn't the one touching me.

I continue to cry through the discussion, feeling like I've lost the ability to stop. It's like I'm suspended in time, frozen in despair.

"*Ana!"* Apollo snaps, shaking my shoulders hard.

The motion jars me so much that it sort of hurts, but I don't hate it. It almost feels as though he's rocking my brain back into place. Like maybe I can get a hold of myself if I try.

"Apollo!" Jade cries out in return, affronted by his treatment of me.

"Let him," someone instructs again. Dmitri, I suppose.

Apollo Moretti is Jade's scariest brother, which says a lot because she has nine of them. And from what I've gathered, Nico is literally a psychopath. But Apollo? He's something else entirely. The firstborn of Dante Moretti, making him the future Capo of The Outfit—the Italian Mafia that dominates the East Coast of the United States with ease.

So yes, I find him quite frightening. Scary or not, I know he'll never truly hurt me. Not only is The Outfit a friend to The Kings, the British Mafia my family controls, but he loves his little sister fiercely. Hurting one of her friends in any way would make his home life miserable.

What is he trying to say?

His large hands frame my face, lightly tapping my cheeks. He's not slapping me hard enough to hurt, just clapping my nervous system into recognition.

I have to calm down.

Just push it away for a little longer.

Numb, Ana, the ghost of Cole's voice instructs.

"There you are," Apollo states, looking into my watery eyes like he knows I can hear him now. "Where did this happen, Ana? Where's Killian?"

My chest aches. *Killian*.

“They s-shot him too,” I sob.

Apollo grips my chin, refusing to lose my focus again. His signature Moretti blue eyes bore into my face and I wince at the intensity.

“Where, Ana?” he asks, voice cold and hard. “Do you know where this happened?”

I try to search my racing mind for the location, yet I struggle. I can picture it, but I can’t for the life of me remember where it is.

My lips wobble as I scramble to answer.

“I’ve got an address,” a new voice reports and my shoulders drop with relief. “I reversed her car’s GPS, and I have the coordinates.”

Remo, Nico’s twin. He’s the techy one of the Moretti brothers.

“Is this the place?” Apollo demands, shoving his phone in front of my eyes.

I nod instantly, recognizing the words on the screen.

“Ana,” Apollo says, tapping my cheeks again to keep my attention. “This is the most important part, okay?”

It takes every ounce of effort in me to bob my head.

“Did you escape or were you let go?”

“Let go,” I rasp. It was the strangest thing. “They killed them, and let me go. W-why would they do that?”

My obvious grief doesn’t affect the eldest Moretti. “Did they leave as well?”

I swallow thickly because that was odd too. “Yes.”

Without another word, Apollo gets to his feet, and I realize my tears have nearly dried. He’s somehow pulled me into a trance-like state, somewhere between despair and numbness.

At least it’s better than hysterics.

“Dmitri and Nico, grab the spare guards, we need to go now.”

“Be careful,” Jade immediately says, becoming nervous.

Apollo doesn’t respond to her. “Armani can be our eyes in the sky. Tell him to get onto the nearest roof there.” I don’t know who he’s directing specifically, but everyone seems to be moving. “Let’s go, Ivan, you too.”

“Ivan needs to stay here,” Dmitri tells him immediately. Firmly.

The eldest Moretti son blinks at him. “We could use him.”

Jade looks at them. “Dmitri, it’s fine, we don’t have time—”

“I’m not leaving you without him, don’t try to convince me. Not now.”

Jade swallows, wincing.

Apollo glances between the two of them. “What do you mean not now?”

“She’s on new medication. It’s not important right now,” Dmitri explains sharply and Jade groans, burying her face in her cupped hand. “I won’t leave her without Ivan here.”

“*Medication?*” Matteo blurts out. “I thought I was the family dispensary, why haven’t I heard about this?”

I’m not surprised to hear the youngest Moretti brother trying to make a joke at a time like this. Matteo thrives on humor and chaos, especially when everything else seems bleak. He makes himself the light.

“*Go*,” Jade snaps at them. “Leave Ivan and Anatoly so Dmitri can focus and go. If they have any chance, their clocks are ticking!”

When the men surrounding us leave without another word—save for Dmitri who whispers something into Jade’s hair before kissing her head in goodbye—I silently thank my friend by reaching up and squeezing her arm.

“Come on, honey,” Jade whispers, threading my arm through the crook of her elbow to help me off the floor. “Let’s get you cleaned up.”

I don’t have the words to tell her that I don’t want to clean up. It’s Cole’s blood I’m covered in, and I know it’s the last of him. Maybe there’s still a sliver of hope for Killian’s life, but Cole is gone.

I can still see the lifelessness in his eyes when I shut mine.

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Chapter Two



Ana
Hours Before

My head is pounding. It feels like water is swimming in my ears, whooshing around to the beat of my heart. Confusion fills my every fuzzy thought as my eyes try to crack open, wincing as my skull throbs in response.

"Don't move," Cole's familiar voice instructs. His whispered command brushes against the shell of my ear, and I cease all movement. "They think you're still asleep, keep it that way, love."

Fear creeps down my spine and tumbles around in my stomach. Memories try to float to the surface, fighting back the fuzzy confusion consuming my muddied thoughts.

The only clear picture I can paint is a flash that doesn't quite seem real. Riding in the car… Cole, Killian, and me.

Everything was so normal. Cole was being grumbly about something. Killian was ignoring him and I was ignoring them both, trying to read the latest society chatter in my text messages.

Everything was fine.

And then there was a crash.

I can hear a faint echo of Cole yelling in the memory before it all goes blank. A rush of nausea hits me, and I nearly whimper at the sick feeling.

"In a minute, they're going to come in here," his silky voice warns in a hushed tone. "It's going to be bad, Ana. I don't know who they are and the fact that they haven't said what they want…"

I barely withhold a flinch at his implication.

We've been taken by a group of people, and they aren't the friendly kind.

"I'm so sorry, love," Cole whispers. "We both are."

My heart drops. Killian is here too.

He can't save us if he's here too.

This isn't Cole's fault—it isn't anyone's fault—but I understand why he apologizes. He knows I wouldn't be here if my mother never married his father. I would be back in London, probably helping her plan her next gallery show or studying in some stuffy university. My whole life would be entirely different if Bron never fell for her.

But I would have also never met him. I would have never found the St. Mary's Orphanage and all of the sweet souls I met within it over the last few years. I most certainly wouldn't have met any of my friends or found my place amongst the New York City elite. But with all the glitz and glamor comes the risk of horrors beyond the typical human imagination. Mafia living comes with hazards, and I wasn't ignorant of them.

Being the stepdaughter to Bron Knight, Monarch of The Kings, put me in a position to be protected, but also one to be targeted. And still, Cole didn't ask to be born a Knight more than I asked to become one at sixteen.

I don't understand why this is happening now, though. Bron hasn't warned us to be on alert, The Kings are in a time of peace, and no eminent threats have been made. A car accident could be just that—an accident. But being nabbed by people that even Cole doesn't recognize? That's a plot.

A well-constructed, planned down to every last detail plot. Kidnapping me, well, I'm not stubborn enough to deny how easy that could be for someone with any level of mafia training. Kidnapping me alongside Killian and Cole? That's not something amateurs could pull off.

Cole is good at what he does. He's a genius in multiple forms of combat and smarter than most people know. And Killian… Killian is a ruthless leader. Men cower at the idea of him—and for good reason. He's demonstrated time and time again why it's a bad idea to fuck with him. The man is built like a machine and fights like an animal. He could take down his own father to take over as Monarch without a fraction of effort, and everyone knows it.

"For what it's worth, I always knew I'd die young," Cole murmurs softly. "I'm just glad I got to have you before it happened. I love you, Ana."

His confession causes a sob to catch in my throat.

He sounds so sure of what's about to happen, and I can't believe he isn't terrified. His voice is steady and remorseful, but there isn't a hint of fear to be heard. I don't want him to die. I don't want any of us to die.

"I'm going to do my best to keep you alive, love," he vows, the soft words barely audible. "If you get a chance to flee, you run like hell. Promise me."

No, I can't.

My lips wobble, and I barely resist the urge to shake my head.

Like he can read my mind, he whispers, "Yes, you can, Ana. Promise."

The sound of a door hinge rattles and my stomach drops. Our time alone is up.

"Awww, lookie here, is your pretty little sister awake?"

I don't recognize the sound of the man's voice, and when my eyes flutter open, I don't recognize his face either. My brain automatically begins to categorize details about him, filing them away behind the forefront of my fear.

Tall.

Bald.

Middle-aged.

White.

Rough beard.

"She's not my sister," Cole growls, baring his teeth at our captor.

The room that we're in is cold and depleted. Dirty tile floor and brick walls painted white that are stained with burned orange water damage. Long, rectangular hanging lights flicker above us, illuminating the small space. There's a large window on one wall, but it doesn't look external, more like it's meant to see into another room, and the ceilings are short. A basement, maybe?

While scanning the place, my heart lurches as I find Killian. He's tied down to a metal chair. His suit is ruffled, and he's bleeding from his mouth. Feeling my gaze, his eyes find mine and he gives me a remorseful look. He doesn't think we're getting out of this alive either.

Our captor gives a barking laugh at Cole's outburst, followed by a nasty grin. "Nah, I suppose I wouldn't want someone calling my whore my sister either."

"Don't fucking call her that—"

The man ignores Cole, not even letting him finish. "Gotta say, that step-sibling shit is twisted—even to someone like me. Mommy and Daddy boning in the same house that you screw? That's fucked up, man."

"What do you want?" Killian demands, ignoring the man's attempt to goad us.

"We," a new voice chimes. "Don't want anything."

Two other men join the first, filling up the room. They look like bouncers at a club, or enforcers of some kind, not master kidnappers.

"Well, aside from your lives, that is," the first man adds, smirking dangerously. A broken whimper leaves me, and tears start to stream down my cheeks. It only seems to amuse him, making him chuckle. "Get the sister-fucker in his chair, I'm ready to start this shit."

What is his obsession with our relationship? Step-sibling relationships aren't exactly the pinnacle of taboo. Especially since Cole and I weren't raised together. We've only known each other for three years!

"No, no, no," I scream, feeling Cole ripped away from my side.

My hands are bound impossibly tight behind my back, and my shoulders scream in protest as I try to wiggle free. Though hardly given room to move outside of how they are manhandling him, Cole still manages to knee one of the men right between the legs. He goes down hard with a howl, but the hit isn't worth it.

The bald man in charge punches Cole so hard that a crack echoes through the room, and a yelped scream bursts from my lips.

"Fucking brat," he spits, shoving Cole into a chair that matches Killian's. "These spoiled rich kids never know when to quit, do they?"

"Whatever point you're trying to make here, you can make it with me and me alone," Killian growls. "Let them go, you don't need them."

"Ohhhh, how noble," our kidnapper coos. "Big brother willing to take the hit to keep you both safe."

"I'm the heir," Killian spits. "If you want to hurt The Kings, you do it through me. Cole doesn't need to die, and Ana is innocent."

"She's about as innocent as a hooker on the side of the road," the man snorts. "And you're wrong about your brother, he definitely needs to die. He's half the reason we're here, the little troublemaker."

Cole grunts as the goons tie him down. "Fuck you."

"Luckily for the girl, she doesn't die tonight. We're just going to give her a nice little show, and we'll send her on her way. That is, if you cease

pissing me the fuck off!"

They aren't going to kill me?

"W-what? Why?" The question spills out of me before I can stop it.

"That's privileged information, little girl," he coos, waving at me in a creepy flirtatious manner.

"Now," he continues, clapping his hands together in one sharp motion. "Shall we begin?"

In the blink of an eye, his body snaps forward, sending a heavy punch straight across Cole's jaw. His head flies to the side, and the sound of the hit connecting makes me scream in protest. Cole hardly grunts, taking the strike and righting himself. He glares up at the man, spitting a glob of blood at his feet.

"You hit like a pussy," he taunts, grinning a vicious crimson smile.

"Cole," Killian warns, his voice deep and commanding.

Large, scarred fingers grip Cole's chin and hold him tight. "You should listen to your big brother, you cocky fuck. This night can get much, much harder for you. I don't typically have a taste for torture, but I'd make an exception for you."

Cole arches a brow, unaffected by the threat. "Are you flirting with me? Sorry, you're not my type."

Please stop, I want to plead.

There would be no use, though. Cole refuses to die on someone else's terms. If they want him to do something, he'll do the opposite. He'll disobey every order out of spite; it doesn't matter what they threaten to do to him.

"I should cut your tongue out," our captor snaps. "But you know what I'm going to do instead? I'm going to take something else from you. Something much more important than the slippery organ in your mouth."

Savage eyes zero in on me, and I swallow hard, throat constricting at the threatening gaze. The vile man takes one step in my direction, causing both Killian and Cole to thrash in their seats.

"Don't fucking touch her!" Cole snarls.

A callous laugh erupts from the man and he tips his head back, relishing in the reaction from both men.

"Touchy, touchy… didn't I tell you? She's not dying tonight." He spins, tearing his stare from me. "Our next guest, though? Oh, he's already at death's door as we speak!"

This is a horrible dream. It has to be. Everything is happening too quickly to process. It's wrong. Nothing happening in front of me is computing properly. It's illogical, and I refuse to believe it.

Still, I don't wake up.

This nightmare isn't coming to an end. I'm not going to wake up in my bed, panting from lingering terror. Any chance of clinging to hope is slowly diminishing with every passing moment.

Please, please, I need to wake up.

A new source of bright light bursts into the room as the latest degree of horror is revealed. The singular window does, in fact, lead to another room. A room that isn't empty, and shreds any remaining optimism for being rescued.

"Here's Daddy," our captor announces, a sinful chuckle punctuating his words.

A sob racks out of me at the sight of Bron, beaten and bloody. His face is swollen, and he can hardly keep his eyes open. Cole blinks at the scene like he can't believe it. It doesn't seem real to him either.

Looking directly at Killian, the bald man grins. "You didn't think I would kill you and leave your father alive, did you? You don't kill a cobra without cutting off its fucking head."

Turning to me, he adds, "Don't worry, girl. I won't make you witness this part. We have to warm you up, don't we? I can't have shock setting in before we get to the truly juicy bits."

Suddenly, the other room goes dark again. And then in a flash, a gunshot rings out. With only the flare from the firearm going off, we all witness Bron's head snapping back.

My throat burns with a helpless, "Noooo!"

Breathing becomes impossible, and I'm panting for each gulp of air, hyperventilating as my mind races.

They killed him, they killed him!

My stomach turns, and cold chills rush up my neck.

Oh god, I'm going to throw up.

One of the goons pulls a wad of polaroids from his pocket and tosses them at Cole and Killian, one by one. "Since you missed all the fun we had with your old man earlier, we thought we'd give you these mementos."

They took pictures?

Why! Why is this happening?

“You’re going to regret that,” Killian says, voice cold and malicious.

“Yeah? Who’s going to make me regret it? Your ghost?”

Killian doesn’t waver. “You think killing us will be the end? You think we don’t have allies that will avenge us? For your own sake, you should learn to sleep with one eye open.”

“I’ll take that under advisement.”

I watch in silent horror as the man pulls a gun from the back of his belt. He aims the shiny black pistol directly at Killian’s chest. My ears start to ring before he even squeezes the trigger, and when he does, I feel my face drain white, my blood going cold.

“Fuck!” Cole roars, watching as Killian’s white shirt floods red and his face goes pale. He’s unconscious, his life slowly fading.

“Where’s that smart mouth now?” the man sneers, turning his aim toward his body next.

“Please, stop!” I cry, hardly recognizing my own voice.

All of the men in the room laugh at my outburst.

Cole’s gaze meets mine, and he studies my face like it’s the last time he’ll ever see it. This nightmare is a prison that neither of us are escaping. We’re trapped here, facing each other as death looms near.

He’s too young.

We’re both too young for this.

I’m not even twenty yet.

We were supposed to die together sixty years from now.

“Go numb,” Cole mouths, the instruction slowly sinking into my soul without permission.

There still isn’t a hint of fear in his eyes, only an air of longing creeps up to the surface. He doesn’t want to die, but he’s resigned to the fact that it’s going to happen. Silent tears pour down my face as a whine catches in my throat.

“Go numb,” he mouths again. “For me.”

Retreating into my mind while it feels like the world is crashing in around me isn’t easy. In fact, it hurts. It burns like nothing else I’ve ever felt.

I’ve practiced this very method time and time again, but it’s never felt so awful before. It’s never been so difficult to disappear into the secure and dark corner hidden in the back of my mind.

Still, I fight the instinct to beg, plead and hysterically cry for mercy. Using every technique Cole has instilled in me to shut out the darkness surrounding us. My conscious mind flees, crawling on broken hands and withered knees to a guarded space in my head. A place where Cole and I are perfectly safe.

The heartache and panic brewing inside of me begins to soften and as I blink to clear my foggy sight, I see him smile. His teeth, stained with the remnants of bright blood, are the last peaceful thing I witness.

"Any last words?"

"Yeah," his voice rasps. "See you in Hell, you fucking cunt."

A piercing bang rings out, and Cole's whole body goes stiff.

A single hole blooms between his eyes with thick crimson goo.

I hear myself screaming and recognize my throat aching with the strain of it. But I don't feel the pain, I don't feel anything. Not really.

I'm an empty shell, just as he trained me to be. So, no matter how hard they try to carve me up, they won't find me.

But they don't try to find me. They don't even attempt it. Not as they untie me and I claw my way to Cole. Not as my hands slip in his blood and I shake his body, trying to will him back to life. No one attempts to kill me, or even inflict any sort of physical pain.

Instead, I'm shoved out of the building and sent away. I'm told to go home to tell the tale of horrors that I've just witnessed.

In a daze, I find my car waiting for me, realizing that this event was far more thoroughly planned than I could have imagined. They crashed into Killian's SUV and had my vehicle fetched at the same time. I was always meant to be left standing, and I don't understand why.

Even though my eyes remain open, everything seems to go dark.

My custom-built walls begin to crack with every minute that passes, and I know that my time is limited. I won't make it home before my resolve detonates.

But I know somewhere closer than home.

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Chapter Three



Ana

The whole time Jade takes care of me, the memory of today plays on a loop. Every horrible moment of it won't seem to fade away, continuing to torment me while I fight to stay sane.

Hot steam fills my nose as warm water cascades around the tiled space. It should be comforting, but even as the bitter chill from outside washes away, my sadness stands firm. I wish I could wake up from this nightmare, but it seems this one is here to stay.

Sitting on the built-in bench of the shower, I look up at the woman scrubbing blood from my skin and breathe out. Before Jade, most of my friendships were cemented for the benefit of connections and considered acquaintances more than anything else.

I would never let any of them help me the way I'm letting Jade. She has me in her bedroom shower, stripped of everything except for my underwear. Minutes ago, she didn't even hesitate to drop her own clothes to get in with me. Leaving us both in a state of undress that would be scandalous if not for the circumstances.

Without making me talk, she sat me down on the small, tiled bench in the corner and began to wash me carefully. It hasn't been awkward or uncomfortable for me so far, and it doesn't seem to be for her either.

Squeezing out the once clean washcloth, she sends pink-tinted water down the drain. It's disturbing how easy it is for water to dilute something as meaningful and important as blood.

"Are you sick?" I eventually ask, looking at her through wet lashes.

Jade shakes her head with a forced smile. “I’m not sick. Dmitri shouldn’t have said anything. We should all be focusing on you.”

I shrug, blinking some water away. “The distraction is nice.”

Nice is too strong of a word. I’m not sure anything will ever be *nice* again. It feels impossible to imagine. But the distraction will help, I think. At least it will put something else into focus, forcing some of the dreadful memories to dull.

My best friend nods, kneeling down to clean my legs and feet while trying to smile again. “It’s nothing serious. I’ll feel like a fucking asshole telling you why he’s so worried when something so much worse just happened to you, honey.”

“Tell me anyway?”

I was serious when I requested the distraction.

I need to think about anything other than death.

“I let Doc give me a birth control shot,” she admits with a slightly nervous glint in her eyes. “It’s stupid, but ever since everything with Bruce, medicine kind of freaks me out. He used to imply that he could poison me at any time. In my food, while I slept… and I guess I’m not over that yet. I had a bit of a freakout after the injection and Dmitri has been helping me through it. I mean, neither of us expected me to panic so hard, but I did.”

She’s so careful with how she explains the situation, like she truly does feel guilty for her own struggle. But just because she isn’t suffering something as supreme as witnessing a massacre, it doesn’t make her pain foolish or unimportant.

“That’s not stupid,” I reply softly.

Jade’s home life before finding Dante and her brothers was vile. The now deceased man called Bruce used to torment her day in and day out, playing with her life for sport. She was alone with a “mom” that despised her and no knowledge of her true biological family. It makes sense that her trauma still affects her, even in new and unexpected ways.

“It was the strangest thing,” she continues, frowning. “I trust Doc, he literally delivered my babies, but as soon as the needle was in my arm it was like all the blood left my body. I was cold, crying, shaking, and overall freaking out. Nothing was wrong with the medicine, I just lost it, I guess. It’s only been a few days and Dmitri has been so good about it.”

“He’s the best,” I agree quietly. Needing the conversation to continue to keep my mind busy, I add, “Why did you decide to get on birth control? I

thought you didn’t want it?”

“I didn’t want it,” she confirms. “It still kind of freaks me out, if I’m being honest. Just the warnings and potential side effects concern me, but it was the best option for us. Because as much as I want an army of that man’s children someday, I’m not ready for another baby. I like our little family as it is right now.”

“I get that,” I agree quietly. “We’re still young.”

Too young to be dying.

Her lips curve up slightly on the sides. “And besides, Cesar is already the biggest little menace. Can you imagine two of him?”

Automatically, my mouth twitches. Jade is a great mom. She could handle it, even if it would be hard. Cesar is a bit of a terror, in the best way. The five-month-old has the most infectious chaotic energy, though his twin sister is the gentlest little sweetheart.

I’ve become fond of them both, and Jade has taken to calling me Auntie Ana to the pair of little ones. I hope all of this commotion hasn’t disturbed them. From what I can tell, they’re asleep safe and sound, likely with a team of guards at their door.

Dmitri is incredibly protective of his children, and I doubt he’d leave the house without being absolutely sure of their safety. Remembering that fact, I breathe out, feeling a bit better about any possible disruption I’ve caused by storming into the Moretti home.

Soon, Jade’s hands move closer to my inner thighs, and she freezes.

“They didn’t… right?”

“No,” I answer, knowing exactly what she’s asking.

She doesn’t say it, but her face screams her relief.

We lapse into more silence as she takes care of my hair like it’s her own, taking meticulous care when conditioning to remove any knots or snarls. The intimate gesture is so soothing that I lose myself in the soft massaging of my scalp.

Once my clean hair is rinsed, she looks down at my body again. “Do you want to wash under?”

Under my bra and knickers, she means.

Unashamed but unable to move, I nod. My muscles feel like complete and utter goo, so I ask, “Will you? It’s okay if you don’t want to—”

“Of course I will,” she interrupts without hesitation.

The whole process is smooth and gentle, it isn't sexually charged or drawn out. She removes the wet fabric and takes care of the rest of me like second nature. If I wasn't already grateful for her friendship, I would be now. Immensely so.

Jade notes a small bruise on my left breast and gives me a sad look. She's wondering if I lied before, and I didn't.

"Cole," I tell her simply.

Her expression falls. "You guys finally..?"

"Last week," I whisper. "I was waiting to tell you when I saw you next."

I didn't even get to dish about Cole to my best friend before he was murdered in front of me. How messed up is that?

"I'm so fucking sorry, honey," she tells me, not caring about my naked state as she throws her arms around me in a firm embrace.

I hug her back just as hard.

I cling to Jade like the connection is going to keep me alive. My grief is still a vicious beast, raging inside of me, but it doesn't feel so lethal with her arms wrapping me up tight.

We haven't gotten an update from her brothers yet, but there's no coming back from a bullet between the eyes. The man I chose to give my virginity to is dead, no matter how badly I want it to be a lie.

Eventually, Jade helps me step out of the shower on wobbly legs and wraps me up in a warm robe. She does the same for herself before guiding me to her room with a towel to tie my wet hair into. But when we enter, we aren't alone.

Ivan Morozov is sitting on her bed talking quietly on his cellphone. He's not just Dmitri's little brother, he's like Jade's *other* other half. The two of them are like twin flames, the best of friends in their own little unique way. When I first noticed how close the pair were, I'd wondered if there was something more between them. I realized how decidedly wrong that assumption was after spending more time with them both.

They may cuddle and hold hands, but there is absolutely nothing romantic in the way they look at each other. Ivan may as well be another Moretti son. He's Jade's brother, through and through.

Noticing us emerge from the bathroom, he looks up and lets out a breath. "Gotta go, see you soon."

"Dmitri?" Jade guesses.

Solemnly, Ivan nods, eyes darting in my direction.

“It’s okay,” I mumble at him. “I know they’re gone.”

Jade sucks in a breath and Ivan hesitates. “Cole is, yes.”

My eyes widen. “Killian?”

“We aren’t sure yet, but he had a pulse. They’re getting him to a secure hospital right now.”

My heart thumps. “He had a pulse?”

“He still does,” Ivan confirms carefully. “It’s not a guarantee he’ll make—”

“Killian has a pulse,” I echo, interrupting him. Turning to Jade at my side, I cover my lips with a cupped hand. “Killian isn’t dead.”

She smiles hesitantly and agrees. “He’s alive.”

“Stubborn bastard,” I say, surprising myself with the humorous comment.

Killian has always been notoriously pigheaded. I should have known that the bullet he took wouldn’t be enough to snuff him out. Especially since he wasn’t shot the way Cole was. He was given an opportunity to live, even if it was a slim one. I wonder if whoever did this, did that on purpose.

But why?

Suddenly, the relief for Killian is gone and only the realization that Cole is dead remains. Even if Killian ends up recovering, he’ll wake up to his little brother gone.

“Ana?” Ivan asks. My eyes snap to his face, and he frowns. “Why didn’t you mention Bron?”

I blink once, shaking myself out of my head. “Did they find him?”

“You don’t remember?” Ivan questions, confused.

Thinking back, I try to focus on my stepfather’s face, attempting to conjure any memories of him from tonight. Cole’s death and Killian being shot are easy to locate in my mind, but Bron doesn’t come easy. I focus and focus harder until a gasp bursts from my lips. All of a sudden, the recollection comes easily.

Compartmentalization is a part of dissociation for me, and apparently Bron was easier for me to bury in my brain than his sons. Then again, my head does still have a slight throb. Did I hit it in the crash? Did the drugs they shot me up with after the fact make me foggy?

Anxiety builds and builds and I shake my head as if that will brush off the ache radiating there.

“I forgot,” I croak. “How did I forget that?”

Jade squeezes my hand and asks, “Forgot what? What’s wrong with Bron?”

When I don’t answer, Ivan clears his throat.

“It appears that he was killed or taken by the group who has done this,” Ivan replies. “There was no body but there were—”

“Pictures,” I rasp. “Polaroids of him being tortured and killed.”

“Potentially killed,” Ivan says gently.

“No, no, no,” I chant. “They killed him in the other room. They showed us, it was dark but we—we had to w-watch.”

“Okay,” Ivan replies gently. “It’s going to be all right now, Ana. You’re safe here.”

“My head hurts,” I whimper, clutching the side of it with one hand while squeezing Jade’s in the other. “I don’t want to talk about this anymore.”

“Ana, did you hit your head?” Ivan asks, growing concerned.

“Car crash,” I confirm in a tired grunt. “I think they gave me a sedative too. Why can’t I remember?”

All the memories are scattering, flying away as panic threatens to consume me. Ivan swears under his breath and reaches for me, ushering me gently to sit on the bed.

“Anatoly,” he calls out. “Get Doc or your father in here *quickly*.”

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Chapter Four



Dante

Death is an ever-present shadow for men like me. It looms over us daily, and strikes when you least expect it. Made men are all familiar with the loss of life. We know that the clock stops ticking for every single one of us eventually. Knowing that doesn't make it hurt any less when the cold chill of murder sweeps through a kingdom.

The Kings have been a formidable organization for decades now. A strong but smart force of British mobsters residing in the heart of New York City crime. And yet, somehow, they've been slain in a manner that makes even my stomach churn. The youngest Knight son executed like a dog in front of his young love's eyes. The heir son moments from bleeding out when my kin found him—the man may still lose his life. And their father, their *Monarch*, missing but assumed gravely harmed if not deceased. All in one fell swoop.

None of it is logical.

The Kings have enemies, all Empires worth noting do, but they aren't at war. They're in an era of peace—or at least, they should be. Who would have the Knight children kidnapped and toyed with to their demise? Who would leave Ana physically untouched in the process?

She'd be a regular young woman if it weren't for her mother marrying Bron. When you attach yourself to the head of any crime family, you *become* family. And still, she wasn't made into a target. She wasn't harmed or murdered by Cole's side.

So, why does it seem like even though she's alive, she was the true target of this assault? Her stepbrothers, one of whom she appears to have been dating, shot in front of her… only for her to be released?

Why is one of my daughter's best friends at the center of this?

Who the hell would want to torture *Ana Knight* of all people like this?

"Ana has a concussion," Anatoly reports, seconds after letting himself into my office. Apollo, Cassio, Elio, Armani, and Nico all look up at the sound of his voice.

The five of my sons and I have been scouring our contacts, looking for any information to go on. They returned shortly after Ivan called for Doc on Ana's behalf. She believes she was drugged after the car crash that assisted in capturing herself and her stepbrothers. Dmitri, Matteo, and Remo are all upstairs with Ivan and my daughter, rallying around Ana for support.

"It is mild," he continues, the tall Russian guard walking closer to our group. His accent is still thicker than Dmitri or Ivan's, but his vocabulary and cadence have come more naturally after months of living with our family. "Her memory lapses seem to be a symptom of disassociation, rather than a side effect of the head trauma. She is remembering things, but her brain is trying to stop her."

"Drugs?" Nico asks while his eyes scan his computer.

"Da," Anatoly confirms. "A light sedative. No traces of anything lethal in her blood."

"Did they touch her?" Cassio inquires with a cold tone. My third-born son hasn't appeared this disturbed in… years. Violence of any kind against women unsettles us all, but perhaps him the most.

"She says no," Anatoly replies, looking conflicted.

Apollo lifts a brow. "Does Doc say no as well?"

"There are no physical indicators."

"You're not saying something," Nico drones the accusation without even eyeing the Russian. For a man with a kill count as high as his, my Nico sure seems to understand the human psyche better than most.

"She has a bruise on her breast," he admits with a small wince. "But Jade told Dmitri that it was from Cole."

Nico practically yawns at the information. "And that's worth withholding because?"

"I feel it is odd to report on the intimate lives of my Koroleva's friends. But it is new, Cole and Ana had never…" He trails off, trying to find the

words.

“You think they started fucking recently and perhaps that act could have prompted the situation we’re currently in?” Elio concludes, brows knitting down.

“I would not bet money on it.” Anatoly shakes his head. “If it were the reason and I did not say anything—”

“You did the right thing,” I interrupt. “Nothing is too personal when something like this happens. Ana could still be in danger, we need all of the information we can get our hands on.”

“Since no one seems to know a fucking thing,” Cassio grits out, angerly typing on his tablet.

“Have you made contact with anyone from The Kings?” Armani asks, swinging his eyes between Apollo and me. His tattooed knuckles crack as he fidgets while his knee bounces. He’s unsettled after coming back from the bloody warehouse, and I don’t blame him.

“Bron’s second was Killian,” I reply, rubbing a hand down my face. “I don’t know who to trust. This could very well be an inside job.”

“They’re going to notice all of The Knight family is missing,” Apollo points out amicably.

“We could ask Colton,” Armani suggests with a frown. “Dustin was friendly with Cole, he might know who the safest contact would be.”

Colton Wyatt is Armani’s long time best friend and heir to The Outlaws. His younger brother Dustin is a quiet kid, but if my son trusts his judgement, it’s a good enough place to start.

“Call him on a secure line,” I advise before pointing my gaze to Apollo. “We need to contact Ana’s mother as well.”

“We’re going to have a difficult time with that,” he mutters gravely, eyes locked on the screen in his lap.

My head shakes, devastation for Ana threatening to creep in. “No.”

“Remo has been hacking into their security systems from his phone. Vivian was staying in their London home. There’s a lapse in footage and then—” He turns the screen.

My hope for Ana sinks at the clear sight.

Vivian Knight lies on her back, pale face unblinking at the ceiling. Both of her forearms are slashed from wrist to inner elbow, pools of blood surrounding her body. All around her, soaking in her spilled DNA, are

pictures of her daughter. Pictures that make it look like she wasn't just kidnapped, but was killed along with her stepbrothers.

"This is a live feed," Apollo reports with his monotone voice and a blank expression on his face.

"That's fucking sick," Elio grimaces, looking away from the screen.

"What is it?" Armani asks, not able to see from his chair.

Waving Apollo off so that he'll remove the gruesome video from my sight, I heave a deep sigh. "Her mother is dead."

"What the fuck?" Cassio seethes. "How?"

"She killed herself, or someone did an excellent job of making it look like she did," Apollo replies. "Either way, someone made her think Ana was dead before it happened."

"This is seriously twisted," Armani says, pinching his brows. "Colton's calling on a secure line. He's with Dustin."

"Put him on speaker," Nico directs. "I want to hear if they lie."

Armani scowls at him. "It's *Colton*, he's not on trial."

"Just do it," Nico insists.

"Whatever."

Seconds later, Armani's phone rings and he accepts the call, switching the volume to speaker.

"It's me, we're here," Colton says with his familiar southern drawl.

"Hey, we've got a situation here," Armani greets, wasting no time. "The Kings have been attacked."

A beat of silence passes.

"Seriously?" Colton asks.

"Attacked *how?*" his brother tacks on.

"Cole Knight is dead," Armani reports robotically. "Killian's supposed to be as well, but he's hanging on. Ana is here, she's pretty fucking shaken up, but they didn't hurt her physically."

"Cole is dead?" Dustin's voice is all husk as he asks. "Are you sure?"

"They shot him in front of Ana," my son replies with a wince. "Right between the eyes. We have his body now. Killian is only still breathing because they nicked the side of his heart instead of hitting it head on. He still might not make it, though."

"Jesus fucking Christ," Colton curses harshly. "What about Bron?"

"Ana thinks he's dead too, but they didn't leave his body if he is. They could have taken him alive and injured."

There’s a crackle of silence and then Colton’s southern drawl returns. “Do you know who…?”

“Not yet,” Armani answers like a vow. “Does Dustin know who we should reach out to in that camp? We don’t even know where to start or if we can trust anyone at all.”

“What about Ana’s mother?”

Armani clears his throat, working the words up. “She’s no longer with us. Found dead in London.”

“Jesus Christ,” one of them curses.

“Yeah,” Armani agrees. “So, you can see we’re in a bit of a bind. Any connection you might have… it would help.”

A few seconds of quiet follow my son’s request. And then—

“The Duke,” Dustin finally says. “Gerard Davies. He’s a sarcastic cunt, reminds me way too much of every Jason Statham character but he… He was like a mentor to Cole. Cole trusted him to guard Ana multiple times, and Killian is his kid’s godfather. I’ve met him before and would bet my life on him being safe. No way he’d be involved in this.”

Armani doesn’t respond until I give him a signal of approval. Watching my chin dip, his shoulders relax an inch. “Can you both come? We’ll arrange a meet, but it might be good for him to see Dustin as a familiar face.”

Nico makes a low sound of protest but doesn’t open his mouth when I pin him with a stern glance. His aversion to “outsiders” is going to have to take a back seat for a while. There’s going to be a lot of shit happening in the next few days that he’ll hate, but they’re going to happen regardless.

“We can be there in five hours,” Colton says. “I’ll need to let our father know.”

“No,” Nico says immediately.

I don’t have time to reprimand him before Colton chuckles. “See you soon, Nico. So nice talking to you, as always. Dad won’t say a word, I’m only warning him that his children are diving face first into danger once again.”

“Informing Levi is fine,” I finally voice. “Watch your backs, we don’t know what the fuck we’re dealing with.”

“No worries, Father Dante, we got this.”

Despite the somber situation, my lips twitch at his preferred nickname for me. He’s called me Father Dante since we met when he was five years

old and he assumed that I was a Priest. Apparently, the only men in Texas wearing suits like mine were men of God or the ones in their funeral boxes. At least, that's what Levi Wyatt told me after the interaction.

Any other smart alec little shit calling me something other than Capo, Dante, or Dad, would get put on their ass. But I have an apparent soft spot for the cowboy my son calls his best friend.

The phone call ends quickly and Nico begins to silently sulk while I think of our next steps. Ana needs to be under our protection, no matter how trustworthy we find this *Gerard* to be. I will not let my daughter lose her best girlfriend on top of everything else. Jade has been through enough.

Even if the two girls weren't such close friends, I would feel inclined to step in. Protecting women is something that Moretti men will always do. We're called to it. It's in our blood.

Turning to Apollo, I find him already watching me. We don't need to say a word to know that we're on the same page. We can read each other better than anyone else. I've taught him everything my father taught me, and in turn, he's taught me more as he's grown. I may currently be in the position of Capo, but he could step in at any moment and run The Outfit confidently and without hesitation.

"Keeping Ana and Killian safe has to be our main priority." My words are firm, a command, not a question or suggestion.

Apollo slowly nods. "Well, Killian is as secure as he's going to get. He's with doctors in the same place any one of us would be if we were dying. He's not going to get any more protected than where he is."

"What do we do about Ana?" Elio asks, looking at his brothers and then to me. "She can't just hide out here. The Kings will assume we took her."

"Let them think what they want," Nico says menacingly. He doesn't care about angering people.

"Too bad we don't have a formal alliance," Armani mutters. "That'd be really fucking helpful right now."

Apollo's ears seem to twitch at that.

Cassio notices it, too. "You just thought of something. What?"

"We don't have a formal alliance, but we could make one," he notes casually. As easily as he makes the suggestion, I can tell that he's still mulling it over in his head, unsure.

Cassio arches a doubtful brow. "How exactly do you propose we do that with no Bron and no Killian?"

“Funny you should use the word *propose*,” Apollo remarks, tilting his head at his brother.

“You want her to marry into the family?” I gather, badly masking my surprise. Far be it from Apollo to suggest anything having to do with an arranged marriage. He’s been avoiding one himself for nearly a decade now.

He merely shrugs. “It seems like the simplest solution.”

“You’re not serious,” Elio protests.

“Why not?” Apollo challenges. “If she’s married to one of us, it’s quite clear we’re protecting her, and her friendship with Jade is an easy explanation for a relationship forming between our families. Whoever she is attached to can stand in Bron’s place until Killian is awake. We’ll have a connection to keep her safe, and a reason to snoop in The Kings ranks for information about who’s responsible for this fucking mess.”

“She’s bound to be traumatized and you want to throw her into a marriage,” Armani grimaces. “Is that really the best idea?”

“It’s not like any of us are going to expect an actual wife out of her,” Apollo argues. “At least not any time soon. She’ll be like a roommate.”

Cassio looks wary. “I don’t know…”

“Someone is going to need to make sure she doesn’t hurl herself out of her penthouse,” Nico mutters darkly.

“That’s so fucked.” Elio shakes his head.

“This whole situation is fucked,” Nico counters.

That it is.

Armani scrubs a hand down his face and groans. “Who exactly are you suggesting she marry?”

“I’m suggesting we give her a choice between two of us,” Apollo decides. “Give the girl a sliver of control over this disaster and it just might make her feel safe.”

“I’m not volunteering,” Elio says immediately. “I have no interest in going to New York to run a syndicate of Brits who’ll hate my goddamn guts.”

“Pussy,” Nico scoffs.

Elio glares at his younger brother. “You fucking marry her then.”

“I scare her, good luck getting her to agree to that match.”

Nico doesn’t use his sexuality as an excuse, and I understand why, but it also concerns me. I worry that despite being openly gay he seems to have little desire for romantic human connection. I hope that he doesn’t expect to

marry a woman for The Outfit one day. I hope he understands that I would never do that to him—even if he was willing.

I'll talk to him in private soon, even though he'll brush me off. It's times like this that I wish my brother were by my side. Cesar always knew how to get through to Nico, much better than I have ever been able to.

"I'll marry her," Apollo cuts into the bickering. Just the sound of his voice uttering those words shuts the whole room up.

"Fucking plot twist," Armani says, his jaw slack.

"If she picks me, she'll need to give me an heir," Apollo points out. "I'm not the best match, but I wouldn't despise being married to her. The Kings would certainly cower under my leadership, though. That could be useful."

"If you want to give her a choice, who else do you suggest?" I ask, trying not to sound excited by the prospect of Apollo finally tying the knot. I'd hoped after all this time he might find a love match, but I'll take anyone for him at this point.

"Definitely not Matteo," he quips. "Too young, too unserious. The Kings wouldn't accept him."

I resist the urge to roll my eyes. I agree with him, but he doesn't need to be so pleased about insulting his youngest brother.

"Any *helpful* suggestions?"

"You could volunteer," he points out, looking unbelievably smug.

It's impossible not to gape at him. "You want your stepmother to be the same age as your little sister?"

"I think you're the only one of us who won't eventually pursue a physical or romantic connection with her and that might be the best thing you can offer the poor girl."

"Who's to say she won't eventually want him?" Armani scoffs. "Let's face it, the ladies love a DILF."

"Gesù Cristo, Son," I hiss. "She's not even *twenty*."

"You'll be good to her," Elio says with an air of indifference.

I shouldn't even consider putting myself on the line. I shouldn't allow myself to be subjected to another nightmare of a marriage. But if I'd do it for anyone, I would do it for Jade. A political marriage wouldn't be the end of my world. I could provide for Ana without crossing boundaries, give her a life free of being attached to some other mafioso douchebag who sweeps in for an alliance.

With a resigned sigh, I scrub a hand down my face. “I’d prefer to be a last resort. Anyone else want to throw their hat in the ring?”

My sons share measured glances, quiet mumbling filling the room.

Until…

“You can give her my name as well.”

The room snaps into startled silence.

I don’t think a single one of us expected *that* offer.

A rough sound leaves my throat, clearing it before I shake out of my shock. “Well, first things first. We need to inform her about her mother.”

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Chapter Five



Ana

Jade's room is quiet but not in a tense way. Matteo and Dmitri left Jade, Ivan, and me alone only a few minutes ago. They didn't want me to feel crowded, and I'm certain Matteo didn't want to say something insensitive. When you crack jokes about any and everything, it's hard not to say the wrong thing at the extraordinarily wrong time.

At least he's self-aware enough to know he isn't the comforting type.

"Are you sure you don't want to try and eat anything?" Ivan asks hesitantly. "Sometimes calorie intake can help after a shock."

"No," I answer hollowly. The idea of food makes my stomach roil.

I can't imagine having an appetite when all I can see is the memory of Cole's death playing on a loop. The way his head snapped back with the force of the gunshot, and the way the bullet hole bloomed with sickeningly dark blood. My throat still burns with the screams I couldn't hold back, the ones I couldn't hear but I could *feel*.

"How does your head feel?" Jade checks, trying not to frown.

I can tell that she's shaken up, like me. Scared and hurt from hearing what happened to me, even if she wasn't there for it. And still, she's keeping a brave face on. She wants to remain strong for me, even if it's difficult. Friends like Jade Moretti don't come around often, and I wish I could articulate how much she means to me.

"Sore, but not any worse than before," I tell her with a shrug.

The physical pain isn't what's bothering me. It's the thick and undeniable ache in my chest, the desire to cry, and the horrible need to

escape my body. Maybe if I could step out of my skin, I wouldn't be able to feel so sick. Like my soul is rotting me from the inside out.

"Do you think it's like this for everyone?" The words leave my lips without permission, and the emptiness in my question is so clear even I can hear it. "I don't understand what I'm feeling or how I'm still breathing. How does my brain even continue to work after tonight?"

I'm operating somehow, even though I don't feel it. There's an emptiness where my consciousness belongs. I'm here and absent at the same time. An ugly contradiction I don't know how to escape.

"Death affects everyone differently, I think," Jade offers quietly. "When Uncle Cesar died, I didn't understand what I was feeling most of the time either. He was the first person I ever cared about that I lost. And watching it happen… it's not an easy thing to forget, or even process."

"What about you?" I ask Ivan, catching a hesitant look in his eye.

"Losing someone you're close to like this, Ana… it takes a piece of you. Seeing someone you love hurt, fatally or otherwise, you can't get rid of what that does. It's permanent, like a scar you'll carry with you for the rest of your life. It fades, and it heals, but it's always there."

Breathing out shakily, I sniff. "That's not very comforting."

"It's not," he agrees. "But it's also not a lie."

"Seems like you know from experience," I reply dully. "Who died in front of your eyes, then?"

Jade sucks in a breath, but Ivan doesn't even blink.

"My sister isn't dead, but after what happened to her, she wanted to be," he tells me in a dark tone. "There is more than one way to be scarred permanently. Finding Anya in the state she was left in, looking at her and finding no life left in her eyes—"

Ivan cuts himself off, and I see his fists clench, knuckles turning white.

He doesn't need to finish his sentence for me to catch his meaning. No one he loves has been killed in front of him, but he still understands. I've heard rumors about the Morozov daughter. The prima ballerina beauty was kept out of our society, only scarcely allowed to perform at exclusive, lavish events. Despite being a perfectly respectable mafia princess, she was hidden more than she was ever seen—for protection. But at age fifteen, she was taken by a group of the worst kind of men.

I don't know who was truly responsible for the hit, but I know she was broken in the ways of nightmares. Torn apart on film for her family's

torment, only to be saved hours later, barely alive and entirely shattered.

She hasn't danced since.

Jade hasn't even met the girl, and I'm not sure how much she knows about her. Despite being married to Dmitri, and twin flames with Ivan, Jade has experienced her own world of trauma, and I doubt she would pry into another girl's—family or not.

"Ana, Jade," Dmitri's voice floats into the room as he steps quietly inside. "Dante asked for you both. He's in the office."

Jade looks surprised. "He did? Did he say why?"

"No." Dmitri gives her a firm shake of his head.

"He probably just wants to check on us," I reason with a limp lift of my shoulder. It's a good thing that I changed into some of Jade's clothes after meeting with the doctor like she suggested. A bath robe would not be a suitable outfit to meet with a mafia boss—friend's father or not. Although, before tonight, I never would have dreamed of meeting one wearing sweatpants, a frayed pullover, and fuzzy socks either.

My best friend looks reluctant to make me get out of bed, even to go see her father. But I shrug off her soft white blanket and get to my feet, waiting for her to follow. When she does, she takes my hand and threads our fingers together. My eyes track the action and a warm buzz of appreciation swells in my chest.

The walk to Dante Moretti's office doesn't take long, and despite the trip being toward a Capo's office, it doesn't feel daunting. The man has been nothing but welcoming to me since my friendship with Jade blossomed. I don't know him especially well, but I trust him enough not to fear him. Unless I suddenly become a threat to him or his family, Dante is inarguably safe for me to be around.

The door is slightly ajar when we approach, and Jade takes that as a sign to enter without knocking. Two men dressed in smart suits stand behind a large cherry oak desk, their quiet conversation coming to an end.

I gulp, suddenly feeling nervous. There's tension in the air, and I don't know why. I want to curl in on myself, but I attempt to look brave.

"Please, have a seat, Ana," Jade's father says softly. His eldest son is standing next to him, and neither of them look happy.

Is there more bad news?

Please, please don't let there be more.

“Oh my god,” I croak, assessing their solemn faces before fully entering the room. “Is Killian dead? Did he not make it?”

“Killian is stable,” Apollo immediately reports. Somehow his words don’t reassure me. After all, a remorseful looking Dante is by his side, and if the Capo of The Outfit looks rattled, there’s a reason.

Jade gently guides me by the small of my back, walking me further into the pristine private office. She sits with me in the middle of a leather sofa, rubbing light circles between the center of my shoulders.

“Dad, what is this about?” Her voice is concerned, reassuring me that she’s noticed their troubled expressions.

Dante exhales slowly. “I’m afraid I have some difficult news for you, Ana. We were looking into leads to make some sense of what happened to you today, and unfortunately we’ve only found another awful discovery.”

He pauses, and Jade stiffens next to me.

“Apollo?” she asks, looking to her brother as her voice wavers.

“We attempted to locate your mother, hoping to bring her here for support,” Dante continues.

A gasp bursts from my lips. “Is she missing?”

She’s supposed to be in London. *Safe*, in London. Bron’s security in our New York building is tight, but it’s *impenetrable* in London. The Kings own that city. I’ve never felt at risk there, so much so that I haven’t even thought about my mother since coming here.

It’s been easier to file her away as the one thing I don’t need to worry about. Have I been naive? After all, I used to think Killian and Cole were untouchable and tonight has proven drastically otherwise. Has someone used Bron’s absence to take her?

“What did you find?” Jade adds, looking between the two men.

Dante can’t hide his sorrowful frown. “I’m so sorry, Ana.”

My ears ring with a high-pitched sound, and I feel all the blood drain from my face. A swarm of cold nausea festers in my gut and my eyes begin to burn. That apology isn’t one that follows telling someone their mother is missing. It’s the kind of remorseful endearment one would hear at a funeral.

“No,” I whisper, denying it. My head shakes, forcing hot tears to drip from my eyes. “You’re lying. Please, why would you say that?”

“Dad…” Jade’s voice is ghostly at my side. “What did you find?”

Dante doesn’t answer her, he hesitates instead, like he can’t bring himself to say the words.

“I wish we were lying, Ana,” Apollo says darkly. “Your mother’s body was found in the London apartment. I know it doesn’t help with your loss—*losses*—but we’re getting in contact with a man called Gerard to safely retrieve her. She’ll be brought here where we can have her examined for signs of foul play.”

My mother is dead. Bile burns up the back of my throat, and I use what little control of my body I have left to swallow it down.

Cole is gone, Bron is gone, Killian is barely hanging on, and now my mother? My mum? The woman who I’ve loved and admired my whole life is just *gone*? Just like that?

My heart pounds to the point of feeling like my chest is bruised or fuck, carved open. Why is this happening to me?

Mum has always believed in a merciful God. Being raised in a Catholic orphanage, she’s kept up her faith. She always said the world could be a beautiful place, even through the carnage that happens.

I never got into religion like she did. It didn’t call to me, but I respected her desire for there to be a higher power. People use God to explain the things they can’t understand and to find comfort in the darkness that life can surround you with.

Am I being punished for being indifferent to divinity?

No, I can’t go there. That doesn’t even make sense, does it?

Why would God take my mother, a faithful follower, when he could have slain me instead?

Cole, I could understand. He was the definition of a sinner. Greedy, prideful, full of wrath and lust. A made man with blood on his hands. He was so many things God wouldn’t be okay with, but sinners live every day.

Clutching the silver cross necklace I wear for my mother, I swallow hard. The jewelry that I hardly ever remove sits over my heart, but it doesn’t bring me a single scrap of comfort. I don’t feel anchored to her, I don’t even feel anchored to earth. My soul could hover out of my body, and I wouldn’t even be surprised to watch it float away.

Now is not the time to question the universe. Whatever the reason, if there even is one, my mother is *dead*.

She’s not coming back, and no amount of reasoning will make it okay.

“We won’t rest until we’ve assured your safety,” Dante continues carefully. “No one will touch you in my home.”

The words are thoughtful, and yet they feel meaningless.

I exhale, feeling hot tears fall from my lashes.

“What does it matter if I’m safe?”

Jade flinches, reaching for my hands. “No, don’t say that.”

“You shouldn’t waste your time protecting me, Mr. Moretti. If I’m going to die, no one else should put themselves at risk in the process.”

“Ana,” my best friend croaks, squeezing my hands more firmly.

“You will not die,” Dante Moretti declares, his voice suddenly all Capo. “I’m vowing to you that no one will touch you now, Ana Knight. You are in my house and you are under my protection. We are formulating a plan for our next move, but right now, all you need to do is rest.”

Apollo nods, showing his agreement. “Our doctor is still here if you want to be medicated. There isn’t a pill in the world that cures the anguish you’re feeling, but dulling it is more than possible.”

I’ve never really taken drugs before. Nothing more than occasional sick meds and local anesthesia to have my wisdom teeth removed a few years back. The temptation for recreational fun has never really been there for me. But if some kind of pill can take away even a fraction of the ache radiating through my whole body, I’ll try it.

I find myself nodding, no words able to rise from my throat.

Like she can’t resist it any longer, Jade tucks me into a fierce hug. The affectionate gesture only makes me cry harder, but I embrace her back. We squeeze each other so hard that it becomes difficult to breathe. I don’t know how many moments pass before the same doctor who checked out my head comes into the room.

He talks and I hear every other word. He’s giving me some kind of injection that will make me tired and take away the worst of my grief. I don’t ask what it’s called or if it’s safe, I just roll up my t-shirt sleeve and watch as he presses a small needle into the juncture of my muscle.

The small sting barely registers and it’s over as quickly as it began.

I don’t expect the exhaustion to hit me so quickly, but within a few blinks, I can feel myself dozing off. I feel Doc check my vitals and hear voices speaking softly before I’m lifted off the couch and into strong arms.

My blurry eyes creak open just in time to see Apollo tucking me into a bed. I can smell Jade’s perfume, sweet and citrusy as she climbs in with me. I’m not sure if she’s staying, but I can’t fight the call to slumber for a second longer.

The world goes dark, and I experience a modicum of peace at last.

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Chapter Six



Ana

Pulsing pain throbs in my temples, pulling me out of a deep and unsatisfactory sleep. Feeling disoriented and sleepy, I untuck my knees from their curled up state, stretching out slowly. Pointing my toes causes my ankles to crack, and I whine softly into my pillow, feeling soreness creep in. My whole body aches, worse than it ever does after a grueling day at the gym.

Reluctantly, I allow my eyes to crack open and immediately frown. I'm not in my bedroom, I'm in Jade's. Yesterday wasn't the worst nightmare I've ever experienced, it was all real. Every single horrible second of it.

The realization should send me into a depressive panic, but whatever drug Doc gave me must still be in effect. I still see flashes of Cole and Killian being shot, the images are impossible to ward off, but their effect on me seems to be dulled. I'm not sure if I could cry if I tried.

Sitting up on the bed, I rub my eyes before looking around the room. I'm alone, and from the small crack in the curtains, it looks like it's dark outside. Frowning, I walk on unsteady legs to take a closer peek. Sure enough, the sun has set almost entirely and the sky is a deep blue, slowly turning black. I knew I must have slept for hours, but I didn't think it was long enough for this.

My bladder suddenly screams to be relieved, another sign that I was unconscious for far too long. Padding over to Jade's ensuite, I quickly do my business and wash my hands. In the mirror, my gaze looks hollow and

haunted. Dark circles shadow the skin beneath my eyes, and streaks of red cloud the whites.

You've looked better, I comment silently.

Splashing some cold water on my dry skin, I take a few deep breaths before leaving the bathroom. There's nothing else I can do to make myself look more alive, and if there was, I wouldn't have the energy to actually execute any of it.

My stomach grumbles as I head for the bedroom's exit. I need a glass of water and maybe something to eat if I can manage it. As soon as the door creaks open, I wince from the brightness of the hall. A hall that isn't empty.

Sitting in an out-of-place chair right across from Jade's door, Remo Moretti looks up from his laptop. His blue eyes widen at the sight of me, like he didn't expect me to wake any time soon.

"Hello," he says, slightly dazed. "You're awake. Are you all right?"

As soon as he asks it, he grimaces.

"Stupid question, sorry. Jade's been in and out of the room, checking on you all day. My brothers and I have been taking shifts in the hall, making sure nothing is wrong. My turn just started."

His explanation makes me feel tender and warm. "You have?"

"Of course," Remo replies assuredly. "Jade probably would have stayed in there all day with you if not for the twins. Cesar tried to cling to her to be carried in a few different times, but she knew he'd wake you up in a second flat with all his screeching."

My mouth quivers, like it's trying to form a smile but can't quite figure out the mechanics to make it happen.

"Oh," Remo blurts abruptly. "I almost forgot."

Reaching into his pocket, he pulls out a pink smart phone and extends the device. "Apollo found your phone. It was crushed and unsalvageable, but I found your data and transferred everything to this. It should be the same make and model. It's charged too."

My hand shakes as I move to accept the thoughtful gift. The screen flashes on at my touch, and my heart beats painfully hard. Cole's smiling face with my lips attached to his cheek stares at me in picture form. Remo even got my original lock screen correct.

The time also catches my eye; it's almost seven in the evening.

"Thank you," I husk, watching the image fade back to black. "You didn't have to go to so much trouble for me."

“It was easy, I didn’t mind,” he replies softly.

“Still.”

I can’t stop staring at the offering, wondering what I could have possibly done to deserve it. Remo and I have hardly spoken before. But I guess this is just how the Moretti men are. Jade has told me time and time again how kind her brothers act toward her, and I always believed her. Though, being on the receiving end of her family’s thoughtfulness feels entirely different than hearing about it.

Remo’s voice stirs me out of my musing. “Jade is downstairs if you’re looking for her. She’s been waiting to see you.”

“Right,” I mutter, stashing the new phone into my sweatpants pocket. I look down the hall toward the stairs and frown. My brain still feels foggy, and I’m not certain that I won’t lose my way trying to navigate the Moretti Mansion. I’ve strolled these halls many times, and still I’m unsure.

“I’ll walk with you,” Remo suggests, sensing my hesitation.

Closing his computer, he stands up, reminding me just how tall all of the Moretti siblings tend to be. Jade is the only one shorter than me, a trait I’m sure she must have inherited from her mother.

Awkwardly shifting a step ahead of me, Remo leads the way and we walk together in silence. Descending the grand staircase, I breathe easier as the sounds of my friend and her children grace my ears. It feels safe, absorbing the sense of normalcy—a reminder that *everything* has not fallen apart. There’s still good in the world, even while I’m smothered under the weight of foggy grief and anguish.

Following the muffled sounds and voices, Remo leads me to one of the main sitting rooms. Cozy sofas surround a large flatscreen television that plays relaxing music, several bodies occupying space on the various couches and chairs, while others lounge on the soft carpet.

My gaze locks on my beautiful friend first. Jade is blowing raspberries on Cesar’s bare tummy, eliciting the most precious giggles from the small boy. Dmitri is watching her too, sitting in a large leather chair while holding their daughter who looks sleepy but content. The father-daughter pair are observing mother and son with happy gazes.

Matteo, on the other hand, is sprawled out on one of the sofas, missing a shirt as he typically tends to be. He’s absently scrolling on his phone when he notices us enter.

Narrowing his eyes at Remo, he releases his phone to throw his hands up in exasperation. “Bro, I *just* left. What’d you do to wake her up?”

Jade’s head whips around at Matteo’s question, and her smile radiates warmth right to me. Scooping Cesar up from the floor, she secures her son on her hip and begins maneuvering around the room in our direction.

“I didn’t do shit,” Remo grumbles, lifting a finger to his younger brother.

“He didn’t,” I confirm just as Jade makes it to us. She doesn’t hesitate to pull me into a hug, her soft and sweet-smelling hair brushing into my face. I exhale, carefully returning the gesture while trying not to squeeze Cesar. The little guy giggles and wiggles on her hip, reaching forward to try and grab my shirt.

“You slept for ages,” she tells me, pulling back. “You must be starving. Do you want to try and eat?”

Cesar’s eyes go wide at the word eat and he swings his head to look at his mother’s chest. Before I can answer the question, he buries his face in Jade’s cleavage, trying to latch through her shirt.

Face going red with embarrassment, Jade laughs and pulls him back. “Not you, you greedy little beast. You already ate.”

“He’s smart,” I comment, watching them fondly. “Knowing what the word means.”

“It’s one of his trigger words,” she admits sheepishly. “E A T for food, and B E D for sleep, but that one wakes him right up. I’ll never understand his aversion to getting some shut eye. It’s like he thinks he’s going to miss something incredible if he actually takes a nap.”

“It’s hilarious when he’s too tired to fight it,” Matteo pipes up, chuckling. “He can hardly keep his eyes open but he refuses to lie down.”

“Yes, soooo funny,” Jade drawls sarcastically. “Why don’t you entertain your hysterical nephew while we find a bite, hmm?”

“Don’t have to ask me twice,” Matteo says with a grin, sitting up and holding out his hands. Jade huffs at him but her lips can’t hide her wry smile as she passes him her baby.

Cesar wastes no time slapping his hands on either side of Matteo’s face, babbling happily. “That’s right,” he says with a boastful grin. “Uncle Matteo is your favorite, isn’t he? Stinky Uncle Apollo can’t even compete, can he? No, he can’t.”

Even with the lingering effects of the medicine in my system, watching the exchange tugs at my heartstrings. Before meeting Jade, the only thing I knew about Matteo Moretti was that he was a chaotic mobster, not to be underestimated by his playful demeanor. Now he's this infectiously goofy but protective figure in Jade's life, baby-talking to her son like it's second nature. He lights up every room, all the while remaining an effective killing machine.

"Come," Jade insists, taking me by the hand. "Martha made some soup that should be nice and easy on your stomach. We have leftover pasta too, if you're feeling up to it."

"Soup sounds like a good start," I agree quietly, letting her lead me to the kitchen.

Seconds later, I'm seated at the kitchen counter, watching as Jade heats up a pot of soup on the stove. She insisted on doing it herself, instructing me to sit and sip on a cold glass of lemon water.

"How are you feeling physically?" Jade asks, absently stirring over the stove. "Doc is going to want to check on you again soon."

"Sore," I admit, thumb tracing small beads of condensation on my cup. "I don't remember what he said he gave me, but I feel foggy, too. Like I'm here but I'm not."

Frowning, she replies, "I'm sorry. I wish I could make it better."

"You're already doing so much," I tell her earnestly. "I don't know what I would have done if I didn't have you."

Her lip trembles and her eyes go glassy, but she sniffs back the impending emotions and tries to smile. "You'll always have me, Ana."

I feel the weight of her promise settle in my chest, it battles through my numbed defenses and wraps around my heart in a warm caress.

"Thank you," I rasp, rubbing my sternum over my shirt, hoping to absorb and spread the sensation. "Taking me in… you and your family didn't just help me, Jade. Your brothers saved Killian by acting so quickly. I won't ever forget that. I owe you—"

"Nothing," she cuts in. "You owe me absolutely nothing because if the roles were reversed, you'd do exactly the same for me."

She's entirely right. I would.

Thankfully, nothing like what happened to me will ever happen to Jade. She has an army of a family at her back, and I'm so grateful that she does.

Her precious soul has been through enough tragedy, and I hope from the bottom of my heart that she won't have any more.

Clearing her throat so that she doesn't cry, she pours the brothy soup into a small blue bowl, puts a spoon into it, and passes it over the counter.

It doesn't take long for me to finish the offering. Despite knowing that Martha is an excellent cook, and enjoying her food repeatedly in the past, every bite is bland. It's not her fault, I think. I felt the distinct craving for sustenance in my gut, but I wasn't quite hungry.

I think anything I would have tried to eat would taste unappetizing. So much so, that when Jade asks if I want some pasta or anything else, I decline. I know I should fit more nutrients in, but I can't find the strength or the desire to eat another bite.

"Are you okay to see Doc now?" she asks, worrying her bottom lip. "He'll just want to check your vitals, nothing crazy."

Mostly, I want to go back to bed and stare at the ceiling until I inevitably pass out, but I agree to see the doctor instead. He's already here, and I don't want to worry Jade by refusing.

"I can have him meet us back in my room? Or we can just go back to the living room if you're comfortable?"

Going back upstairs sounds like a lot of work for my sensitive legs, and the soup didn't provide me with much energy. But I don't say any of that, deciding on, "The living room works," instead.

Dmitri, Matteo, and the twin babies are all still there when we arrive. Remo must have disappeared elsewhere, but Ivan and Anatoly are also present now. Isabella sits peacefully in her Uncle Ivan's lap, watching some colorful cartoon on the telly. Meanwhile, Cesar is being passed back and forth between Dmitri and Matteo, like it's a game.

Like they somehow knew we'd be ready for them, Dante strolls into the room, Doc at his side.

"Ana," Jade's father greets softly. "If you're feeling up to it, I'd like to discuss our next steps with you after Doc checks you out."

"That's fine," I say automatically. I want any updates he has and to hear whatever plan he and his sons have thought up. Maybe I'll be able to think more clearly if I have something concrete to hyper fixate on.

"Next steps?" Jade asks, nose scrunched up like she hasn't been updated.

“Ana can discuss it with you after, if she wants,” Dante tells her calmly. There’s a subtleness to his authority when he’s speaking to his daughter rather than his sons. He doesn’t leave room for argument, but he isn’t quite stern either.

“Dmitri will be in the room, won’t he?” Jade asks, lifting her chin. “To look out for her best interest?”

Dante gives her a quirk of his lips and a confirming nod. “Dmitri is welcome to join us.”

Jade shares a look with her husband before nodding back. “Good.”

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Chapter Seven



Ana

It didn't take Doc long to verify that my vitals are at safe levels. He offered me a pill at the end and stipulated that I could have it if I drank a packaged protein beverage with it. The mood stabilizer was a low dose, but with the promise that the relief it would offer would be much milder than what he gave me last night, I couldn't resist.

Downing the protein drink helped my stomach feel fuller, and the small pill was easy enough to take. Doc planned to stay overnight again, and he encouraged me to seek him out if I started to experience any concerning symptoms.

Now sitting in Dante's office with Apollo and Dmitri present, I don't feel as foggy as before. Whether it's the medicine or the food kicking in, I'm not sure. All I know is I want to hear what these men have to say.

"So…" I start, feeling awkward. "You have a plan?"

"We do," Dante confirms. "I apologize, but it may be a lot to digest."

With a helpless shrug, I reply, "I don't mind."

I truly don't. There isn't much I wouldn't do to resolve this situation—to hopefully begin recovering from it, at the very least.

"We're going to help you, Ana," Dante continues, his promise firm. "But with the… *politics* of it all, there's something we need to do first."

"A legitimate connection needs to be forged," Apollo adds, speaking more plainly. "Friendship only creates so much trust when it comes to things like this."

Both men are choosing their words wisely, but even with new medicine coursing through my veins, I'm picking up what they're putting down.

"You want to arrange a marriage," I guess quietly. "To me, I assume? So that someone can run The Kings while Killian is recovering, and no one suspects foul play on your end?"

Marriage is the oldest and most respected method of forging relationships between mafias. It creates a bond nearly as good as blood. *Family* is a language that all made men speak.

"At least she's smart," Apollo says under his breath.

Dante makes a low noise in his throat at his son before giving me a soft smile followed by a nod. "Exactly. A marriage is what we have in mind. I understand it may be a difficult time—"

"I'll do it," I interrupt, decision made.

It's a sensible idea, and it's not like I have many other options. I don't just need to stay safe, I need to make whoever is responsible for upending my life pay. I want justice for Cole. Cold and bloody justice.

Who better to help me with such a task than a Moretti husband?

Dante blinks, appearing shocked. "I don't want you to feel like we're forcing this on you, Ana. Especially while you don't have Killian or Bron here to advocate for your contract terms. But I'm afraid I don't see another way."

It's not ideal… Even so, he's right. The Kings need to be preserved. In order for that to happen, the men will need a leader to trust. My husband would be the best option to step in, especially if he were a Moretti.

Of course, I need to be protected as well. Whoever did this to my family left me alive, but to hurt me. They wanted me to live with the pain of what they did, and that doesn't mean they won't come back to finish me off. Maybe they'll even come for Killian, if they've found out that he's still breathing. *God, they better not.*

Killian *has* to wake up, and when he does, I want his organization to be alive. He deserves to take his place on the throne—he's worked his whole life for it. He's lost enough without losing his birthright on top of it all.

"I agree," I tell them, fiddling with my hands while trying not to pick at my cuticles. "A marriage is the most logical option. Dmitri can advocate for me for the contract." Turning to the man in question, I wince. "I mean, if that's okay with you?"

"I can do that," he agrees easily.

I let out a silent breath and nod. Jade's husband won't allow me to sign something against my best interest.

"Um, did you have someone in mind?"

"We do," Dante says cagily. "Due to the nature of the situation, only a few matches made sense. The Kings need a leader, temporary or otherwise. I'm sure you can see why Matteo is not an option."

He's too young and nice to be respected by a bunch of gangster strangers. He won't intimidate anyone the way some of his older brothers might.

"I understand."

"My first thought was Apollo," Dante continues. "He's in the highest position of power, and likely to be accepted as Monarch easily. But Apollo needs an heir, sooner rather than later."

I swallow hard.

Dante looks sympathetic. "I don't want that to be a requirement for your marriage, Ana. So it's not the best fit, but if you believe you want that choice, you have it."

"I won't love you, it would be a business arrangement," Apollo says, almost startling me. "Try to keep that in mind."

"You're giving me choices?" I realize, eyes widening in surprise.

"Three of them," Dante says.

Wow.

That's… thoughtful?

He continues, "Cassio makes the most sense."

Cassio? I have to hide a bewildered look.

Cassio is a widow who I've never even seen smile. The man lost his wife and son in childbirth two years ago. How can he be the perfect fit? He probably loathes the idea!

"He's an advisor and strategist, which makes him perfect for temporary leadership. You both have lost greatly and I assume, are not ready for a relationship?"

"Definitely not," I confirm, relieved that he's being so realistic about it.

"So there would be no pressure in that area. You'd be roommates and friends. He'll take care of you and the Kings. He's agreed to the arrangement if you pick him."

He did!?

Holy shit.

“And the last one?” I rasp.

Dante lets out a breath. “This arrangement would never be more than platonic and is being offered only because we believe you may feel the safest this way.”

Intense…

“But I’ll marry you if it’s what you choose, Ana. I’m old enough to be your father so believe me when I say I will not pursue you romantically. I would step down as Capo, putting Apollo in my place while I took Killian’s.

Holy. Bleeding. Fuck.

Dante notes my surprise and continues. “The community would—”

“Accuse you of being evil,” I burst out, so shocked that he knows that and is still offering.

Men who respect him would freak out if he married a woman his daughter’s age. They’d see him as some old perv. Yes, age gaps are common in this world but ten to fifteen years max, not over thirty!

I start to get choked up. “I can’t believe you’re willing to do that.”

“I think you’ll find that there are few things I wouldn’t do for my daughter,” Dante replies gently. “In any case, we’ll need to act quickly. The ceremony should be here with witnesses. It will be small and fast, but necessary. The last thing we need now is accusations of some sort of plot.”

A different kind of plot, he means. He doesn’t want it to look like The Morettis are trying to take over The Kings.

Because this marriage can be an arranged deal—plenty of mafia marriages are—but it needs to be one forged without a hint of bad blood.

“We’ll give you some time with your advocate,” Apollo says, gracefully standing up while buttoning his suit jacket. “Try to pick your husband and how you’re comfortable with the marriage going. We’ll negotiate as a group from there.”

“Okay,” I respond, attempting not to sound nervous.

Apollo leaves the room without another word, but Dante offers a soft squeeze to my shoulder on his way out. His reassuring eyes let me know that everything is going to be fine… eventually.

Once the door latches shut, I turn to my friend’s husband. Dmitri isn’t a man that’s easily read. He’s an expert at concealing his feelings. It should be unnerving, but I’ve seen him with Jade. I know he isn’t as cold and unaffected as he tends to appear.

“I don’t know where to start,” I admit. I keep my voice low and small, refusing to let emotion clog my throat.

“That’s okay,” he assures me. “We can start small. Do you have any questions about being arranged? I know you aren’t as new to the world as Jade is, but I’m sure there are things you’re worried about.”

Because I was never meant to be arranged. I know it, and he knows it.

When Bron fell in love with my mother four years ago, she refused to marry him unless he promised to let me find love on my own as well. In fact, he made a very public proclamation at their wedding that he wouldn’t entertain offers for my hand.

Wiping my clammy hands down on my thighs, I try not to grimace. “If I picked Apollo, how soon do you think we’d have to have a baby?”

“Honestly?”

“Please.”

“Being pregnant within the next year would be best, if not expected.”

My stomach flips with discomfort.

“You don’t think they’ll be insulted if I pick a different option, do you?”

“Because he’s the heir?” Dmitri shakes his head. “Apollo won’t view this as a rejection. He isn’t pursuing you for his own needs or desires.”

I breathe out, relief washing over me.

“Okay, no Apollo then.”

“For what it’s worth, I think that’s a good choice,” he replies amicably.

“It’s worth a lot, actually,” I admit. “I’m worried that I’m not in the best state to make decisions.”

Nodding sympathetically, Dmitri sits straighter in his seat. “That’s what I’m here for, Ana. I hold no stake in your marriage outside of making sure you’re in a situation that you feel happiest in. The Morozovs stand to gain nothing from this. I’m only here for my wife.”

Trying not to let his words choke me up, I nod and sniff away the sentiment. “Who do you think I should pick? Like, if you were me, what would you do?”

His eyes scan mine as he contemplates his answer. “Dante’s offer is an attractive one. He’ll assure your safety like you’re one of his own. The Kings likely won’t protest him stepping in while Killian recovers.”

Dmitri hesitates to continue.

“But?”

“But he’s fifty,” he deadpans. “And you’ll be bound to him until death. Meaning unless he’s killed, you’ll be in a loveless marriage until you’re into your forties. I know the idea of that may not seem so bad now, but it will in the future.”

I swallow, nodding as I digest his words.

Can I live like that? For decades?

Looking down at my lap, I absently pick at my chipped nail polish. “You don’t think it will be a loveless marriage with Cassio, too?”

Cassio lost his wife and his newborn baby years ago now, but you don’t just get over that. No matter how much time passes.

“I *know* that it will be with Dante,” Dmitri counters. “I’m not sure how things will progress with Cassio as I’m not especially close with him. I do know that he’s a good man. Eventually, his grief will lessen.”

I’m not so sure that it will.

And still, I think he’s right. Cassio might be the only logical choice.

“Jade would be livid if I didn’t also mention, a marriage isn’t your *only* choice. Though, she’s unaware we’re currently discussing this.”

So, they didn’t tell her their plan. I’m not surprised. Men typically try to keep non-inducted women out of “business” talks.

Confused, I scrunch my nose. “What do you mean?”

He sighs. “I mean, as annoying and dangerous as it would be, a hostile takeover is doable.”

My eyes must double in size, flaring open wide.

“You can’t be serious.”

“I didn’t say it was advisable,” he replies with a shrug. “But if you want the Kingdom to be yours while we wait for Killian, we can take it in a much less agreeable manner.”

Physically, he means.

War, he means.

Swallowing, I shake my head. “I don’t want people to die.”

And people *would* die. Anyone opposing my position of power would need to be eliminated. Good men with families… no, I can’t.

His lips twitch on either side. “Spoken like a true mafia princess.”

“Princess,” I agree begrudgingly. “I don’t want to be a queen, Dmitri. I don’t want the responsibility of running a Kingdom of any kind. It’s not supposed to be mine.”

Maybe if I was born a Knight, I might feel differently. But I'm only in this family because my mother fell for a man with an Empire. An Empire I cherish and appreciate, but not one I want to rule over. That's always been Killian and Cole's job.

"So, Cassio," Dmitri muses. "You're sure?"

I'm not *sure* about anything.

But this is what I'm going to do anyway.

"Yes," I say with an exhale. "How does this work?"

"The contract is just a guideline," he begins to explain easily. "Basic expectations, requirements, and such. It really isn't difficult. Would it be easiest if I ask you direct questions?"

I nod eagerly at the suggestion. I don't even care that he can tell how obviously nervous I am.

"Please."

"Moretti marriages all come with a fidelity clause," he prefaces, opening up a spare notebook and beginning to write. "Both you and Cassio will be bound by it after your vows. Neither of you are free to seek out lovers. Are you comfortable consenting to that?"

"Definitely," I confirm immediately. If I'm going to be married, I'm not going to have my husband with other women—marriage of convenience or not.

He jots something down and nods. "Good. I assume you'll be living together in New York until Killian is fit to rule again. Where you settle afterward can be negotiated. Do you have a preference I should note?"

I shrug. "I don't think so. Should I?"

"It's meant to be more of a deal-breaker thing," Dmitri clarifies. "Essentially, could you only be happy living somewhere specific? Do you have a location in mind?"

I hum in understanding. "As long as we're a short flight from our families, I'm okay with anywhere."

"Got it," he notes. "Any questions so far?"

"Do we have to consummate?" I blurt out, my face burning up as the words leave my mouth. "I-I just know that some families are very strict about it…"

I've heard some arranged marriage horror stories over the past couple of years. Every mafia princess has.

"That can be negotiated as well," Dmitri answers diplomatically.

“Can it?” I ask in disbelief.

“Officially speaking, no one is going to force you into anything,” he assures me. “However, if you’re asking for advice, I’d say you should. Consummation makes your marriage official. No one will respect your union if they know it to be false. If you don’t want to, there is always the option to lie. No one is going to check that you’ve slept with your husband.”

“But you think I should?” I verify.

“I think it’s not difficult to point out a man who has never seen his wife naked,” he replies gently. “I believe the safest bet for you and Cassio is to appear to be in love. At least in front of The Kingsmen. If not in love, in a caring friendship.”

“You don’t want them to think I’m being forced into this since Cole is gone,” I summarize. “Because of our… relationship.”

“It would be best, yes,” he agrees. “But like I said, no one will force you. Ever. Consummation doesn’t need to be immediate, either.”

“No,” I finally say. “I think we should do it and get it over with. I don’t want there to be any reason for us to be questioned. I just want everything to be okay again.”

“We’ll add a consummation clause then,” he states casually. “Consent required, of course. If you change your mind, we’ll take it off the table.”

“Thank you,” I breathe out. “For understanding.”

“It’s not a problem, Ana.” He tries to offer a reassuring smile, but it doesn’t do much to quell the natural nervousness building in my gut. “Moving on…”

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Chapter Eight



Cassio

It doesn't matter how many times I've visited my late wife's grave, the feeling never changes. Despair radiates through me like heat, sinking in through my skin and infecting my blood with ease. I don't just see dirt and earth covering the bodies of my infant son and his mother, I see the day they died—in exact detail.

It's a sick and twisted movie that I can't turn off, playing on a loop in my mind. It *haunts* me, and there's nothing I can do to stop it. I still hear her screams during the labor and the impossible quiet that followed. The way an eerie sense of dread filled the birthing room before she turned pale white.

But not even the memories of that vile day can keep me away from their burial site. The need to see them is a compulsion I have no power to fight. The need to talk to them is impossible to avoid, even when they can't reply. It's not healthy, and I've known that for a long time.

"Hey, Bels," I whisper, sitting down and leaning against the side of her gravestone. "It's been a crazy couple of fucking days."

Lost for words, I pull out a small silver case, popping it open with a soft click. The faint smell of clove melts into the cool air as I pluck a single cigarette from within. Popping it between my lips, I trade the case for a light.

Rolling the lighter with my thumb, a bright orange flame flickers wildly. It burns, crackling quietly against the cig, and smoke fills my mouth swiftly.

Taking a long drag, I sigh and exhale the familiar taste, savoring the bit of warmth that the action brings. “I’m getting married.” I say the words, hardly believing them to be true. “My sister’s friend… Ana. She needs someone, and I’m going to be that someone.”

Some people think it’s crazy—talking to the dead. But I have to believe that she hears me. I couldn’t survive if I thought I was truly just talking to the wind and the earth.

“I gotta say, I feel like I’m fucking betraying you right now, and I’ve hardly even talked to the girl,” I admit with a grimace.

Blowing out another long breath of smoke, I shake my head. It’s like I can see her face, and hear her disagreeing with me.

“I know you always said you’d want me to find someone else if I lost you. I hated that shit, you know I did. When you’d talk about me hypothetically losing you—*shit*, I wanted to rage. I kept telling you it would never fucking happen. It was me and you ’til the goddamn end.”

It was supposed to be.

“You brought it up far too much for my liking and I just—” My throat clogs up, emotions running high.

“Did you know?” I demand, suddenly getting angry. “Did you have some sixth fucking sense that I’d have to live my life without you, Bels? It still eats me up inside, you know? Remembering everything you told me that you’d want.”

Her funeral, her deathbed wishes, her plans for me. *Just in case*, she’d say. *Nobody prepares for accidents, and I’m prepared for everything*, she’d boast.

One of her most firm demands was always that I move on. She told me how angry she would be in the afterlife if I wallowed in my grief for too long. I couldn’t understand the concept. I wouldn’t want her to be with another man, the thought made me sick to my stomach. But Isobel always was more selfless than me. She cared about people so deeply, me more than anyone else.

Despite her wishes, moving on is a concept that feels like it will never be fulfilled… and still, progress is necessary. If I continue to exist like this, I won’t continue to exist at all.

Throwing myself into the firing line to save my sister months ago wasn’t just a brotherly sacrifice that any Moretti would make. I *hoped* I would take a bullet to the chest. I desperately wanted the sweet fucking

relief of death because if I weren't breathing, maybe I would have my Isobel again. Just fucking maybe we'd be at peace with our son on some inhuman plane of existence and I could feel whole again.

Thinking like that… I can't afford to do it any longer. My uncle took the bullets meant for me, and dying now that he's gone would be a mistake. Squandering his sacrifice isn't something anyone would forgive me for, least of all myself.

My family isn't just the brothers I grew up with anymore—it's Jade, too, the sister whose life I missed for nearly two decades. It's her son and daughter, the latter of whom she named after my deceased wife. There's too many people who would mourn me unnecessarily. There's two little babies who need all of the Moretti protection they can get.

So, no, I can't say it's time to move on, because I doubt I can. But it's time to move forward. And there's no way I can do that if I'm living in this house. At least not for a little while. I need a responsibility, something to *make* me progress.

At the sound of footsteps, slightly muffled by the thick lawn, I look up from my hands and find my brother —my future capo.

He speaks and I blink, trying to shake myself out of my mood.

"She picked me?" I double check despite hearing Apollo clearly as he informed me of Ana's decision. A decision I was sure she would make.

She's too young, and too hurt to marry Apollo and give him an heir. And marrying my father seemed out of the question. I couldn't see her making that choice, knowing how it would affect her life in the future.

"She did," he confirms simply. Eyeing the clove cigarette between my fingers, he scrunches his nose in disgust. "She might change her mind if she notices that filthy habit, though."

Taking a small drag and blowing out a puff of smoke, I shake my head. "Pretty sure if the widow thing didn't scare her away, this won't either."

It's not even a habit. I hardly smoke, just on the hardest days. I don't think I've smoked a whole pack in under a month or so since… I can't even remember how long.

"Besides, this is my last. I doubt I'll need them when I'm away from this place." Too many fucking memories here.

"Not to mention the grieving bride you'll have to take care of and the syndicate you'll have to run. Where would you find the time?" he drones, snark dripping from his every word.

Apollo isn’t the sort of man to coddle. He doesn’t treat me like a man sitting by his dead wife’s grave, smoking while feeling sorry for himself. He treats me like his little brother who is sulking. I think if he were any other way, I wouldn’t know how to react. Being the oldest, he’s meant to keep us all in order. He can’t do that if he manages the lot of us with kid gloves.

“Tell me about her,” I request, stubbing my smoke out into the ground, growing tired of it before it’s even finished.

My brother chuckles. “We’re pretending like you don’t already know everything about her? She’s our little sister’s best friend, among other things. You even knew she’d pick you.”

“Of course, I did,” I grunt.

And of course Apollo picked up on the fact that I came out here to bid Isobel goodbye. We’re the perceptive siblings after all. We need to be. With him as our future capo and me as his lifelong advisor, we’re trained to be as assessing as possible.

“Haven’t you heard? I know everything.”

He snorts, knowing that I’m citing our youngest brother. Matteo seems to think I can hear through sound-proof walls and predict the future. I don’t have the heart to tell him that he’s just the most easy to read person on the planet. He wears every emotion on his face. In a lot of ways, Matteo is the most human of us all.

Needing to hear whatever information my brother has gathered, I sigh irritably. “Just tell me, Apollo.”

“Ana Knight,” he starts, vocalizing her name with an air of boredom. “Nineteen years old, twenty in a couple of months. Stepdaughter to Bron Knight, and until yesterday, girlfriend to Cole Knight.”

“So, they *were* dating?”

“Not publicly, but Jade confirmed it.”

“Continue.”

Apollo rolls his eyes. “Ana is a society type, playing the dutiful mafia daughter as if she was born into the role. She attends fundraisers and events and no one has a bad word to say about her, at least that they’ll say out loud.”

I figured as much. Why anyone would put her through the horror of yesterday when no one seems to hate the girl, I have no idea.

“Most of her free time she spends volunteering at the orphanage twenty minutes from her Penthouse on the upper west side of Manhattan. She’s a black belt in Judo, despite her acting like she can hardly throw a punch in her Empire training classes.”

Now *that’s* something I wasn’t aware of.

“Keep going.”

“Ana hates cooking. She thinks that food always tastes better when someone else makes it for you. She doesn’t like bugs or dirt or clutter, which is why the Knights employ a housekeeper who cooks.”

“Name?”

“Agnes. She’s a fifty-eight-year-old widow who is grouchy but has an apparent soft spot for your fiancée and her now deceased mother.”

“Great, I’m sure she’ll love me,” I grumble sarcastically.

“Ana Knight also has an eidetic memory,” he drones on. “She appears to be able to disassociate to some degree, a skill I’m sure Cole was helping her with.”

My cold dead heart gives a painful beat at the information. Sympathy for the poor girl, I’m sure. Ana Knight is never going to be able to forget that day, because Ana never forgets anything.

And now she’s stuck with me.

“Armani and Colton have decided to go to New York with the pair of you. They’ll live in the same building and watch your backs. Ana doesn’t have a developed friendship with either of them, but I’m sure they’ll be helpful in warming her up eventually. She’ll need a friend, and obviously Jade can’t go. She and Dmitri won’t risk the twin’s safety.”

“I wouldn’t want them to,” I agree quickly. “Neither would Ana.”

I think.

“We’ve made positive contact with Gerard, and he’s firmly on our side. Whatever we need to keep Ana alive, he’ll back us. He wants to confirm her safety, so he’ll speak with her before the contract is signed.”

“That’s fine.” It’s not like Ana is going to say anything concerning to him. She’s agreed to this.

“We’ll do the wedding here, tomorrow evening. No need to waste time. The depression is going to hit her hard and soon, I can see it in her eyes. She’s waiting to fall apart, and the sooner she does—”

“The sooner we put her back together,” I finish.

My father has always told me that I’m the kind of man that needs to be needed, just like him. I thrive when people rely on me. It’s the only thing that fills me with a sense of pride and purpose.

Ana Knight needs someone more than anyone else in my life has needed me in a long time, so I volunteered to marry her. And she chose me.

If anyone can get her through tremendous grief, it’s me.

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Chapter Nine



Ana

The next morning happened in a whirlwind of chaos. Before I even woke up, the Moretti mansion was filled with countless people, all of them working together to set up a wedding.

My wedding.

When Dante and Apollo suggested doing the ceremony as soon as possible, I agreed. I didn't expect them to suggest the very next day, but still, I didn't protest. There was no reason to wait, especially when every moment counted. I knew that I'd need to return to the city, to give The Kings a leader and to mourn.

I knew that if Killian didn't wake within the next few days, I'd need to arrange funerals without him—something I sincerely hoped would not end up falling on my shoulders. All I could think about doing was crawling into my bed to sleep for days, maybe weeks. So, a wedding thrown together in a single day would have to do.

It's nearing noon now, and Jade and I are sharing a bowl of fruit salad. She's shoving as much as she can get into her mouth while she has a free minute—a mom habit she developed since Cesar has started trying to grab every bit of food he's too young to even eat. The mixed berries, melons, and grapes are cold and fresh, but I pick at them slowly, still finding it difficult to feed myself.

I haven't taken any other medicine since last night, not wanting to be drugged up and groggy on my wedding day. Thankfully, there's enough

distraction and noise going around the house to keep me from retreating into my mind and being bombarded with unsavory images.

Mostly, I find myself wondering about my husband-to-be. I haven't seen or spoken to him since agreeing to this union, though I haven't exactly asked after him. I would hate to be a bother, especially since he likely has a million things to do in order to make today a success. And like me, I'm sure he's still processing what we've agreed to.

Jade was possibly even more shocked than I was when we talked after last night's meeting. She didn't have the faintest idea that her father was going to suggest I marry into the family—let alone that Cassio of all people would volunteer to be my groom. After the surprise wore off, and I assured her that I was happy with the arrangement, she was thrilled.

We're going to be sisters, she gushed, hugging me tight.

That excitement quickly turned to light stress when she realized we had less than twenty-four hours to pull a wedding together. She was a bit bummed when I told her that I had little interest in making any decisions regarding the final details, but I'll try to make it up to her when it comes time to plan the ceremony she and Dmitri are yet to have. Not that she complained or made her disappointment known, because of course she didn't. Jade has been nothing short of an angel to me this entire time.

A glistening bit of strawberry hovers inches from my lips when footsteps catch my ears. Letting my fork fall, I set it back on the corner of the bowl and look toward the sound.

Dressed in a white t-shirt, tactical jeans, black boots, and a leather jacket, Gerard Davies marches into the room. As our eyes meet, he comes to an abrupt stop and releases a heavy breath.

"Gerard," I greet plainly. "You're here."

"You're all right," he says with a sigh, like he needed to hear the words aloud to believe them. "I wanted to see you as soon as I got here, but getting these men to trust me has been a task—even with Dustin's word."

"Dustin is here?" I swallow hard.

Dustin was probably Cole's closest friend. And Cole didn't have a lot of friends. It was one of the things we had in common. Slow to trust, surrounded by acquaintances, and picky about who we choose to let in.

"He is," Gerard confirms. "He and his brother have been helping out. The mutual connection is how they knew to find me."

"Oh." *That makes sense.* "Okay."

“Ana, I’m so—”

“Sorry,” I cut in, frowning. “Yeah, everyone is.”

A tense silence follows my snappish response, but I don’t regret it. I don’t need to hear more apologies and condolences from people who aren’t to blame. They won’t change anything.

“Your mum’s body has arrived in New York,” he informs me with a sorrowful timbre, shifting the topic. “She’s with the Catholic church’s morgue for now. The Russians in the area make sure no one messes with the sanctity of the place, so she’ll be safe there. I know that she’d want to be in a house of God—”

“Don’t,” I croak, interrupting him.

Jade looks between the pair of us and gives Gerard a tight smile that looks more threatening than friendly. “I’ll give you both a moment.”

I thank her with a single look, and she squeezes my shoulder before silently leaving the kitchen. Once she’s out of sight, I suddenly wish that I asked her to stay.

“I can’t hear about this right now, Gerard,” I whisper, trying to bury the painful thoughts of my mother before they sink in. “All I need to know is that it’s handled until we get back to the city.”

His sympathetic gaze makes my stomach twist. “It’s taken care of,” he assures me softly.

“Good.” Releasing a held breath, I rub my sweaty palms on my pants and steady myself. “Dmitri told me this morning that you wanted to review my marriage contract. Have you?”

“I have,” he confirms, sounding reluctant. “I vehemently objected to the consummation clause, until I was informed that you requested it.”

A warm blush reddens my cheeks. “Thank you for trying to defend my honor, but if I’m going to be married, it’s going to be legitimate.”

I don’t see Gerard as a father figure, but he’s old enough to be one, and I do not want to have this conversation with him. I know he’s only trying to do what Killian would want him to in this instance. The two men are close friends, and Killian trusts him absolutely. Still, I don’t need his approval, nor do I even want it. Dmitri looked out for me, and Gerard may not know or trust him, but *I* do.

“If that’s what you want,” Gerard relents, not in the position to argue.

“Are you staying for the ceremony?”

He dips his head in a nod. “I’ll be here. The Kings will want as much reassurance as possible, and having me in photos will help. As far as anyone knows right now, Bron is in London, and Killian is unavailable. Your groom, his father, and I all agreed that it’s better to keep it quiet until we’re back in the city to handle the fallout.”

“Okay.”

“This Cassio bloke,” Gerard begins, brows knitting like he’s searching for the right words. “He seems to have good intentions. Though, he isn’t very warm and friendly, is he?”

I shrug. “He’s nice enough. I haven’t spoken to him recently, but he’s probably just wary of you.”

“I don’t bloody blame him,” he gruffs. “I’m wary too—of everyone and everything. This shouldn’t have happened.”

“No,” I bite out. “It shouldn’t have.”

Sensing the strained shift in my mood, Gerard nods, taking a step back. “Let me know if you need anything, Ana. I’ll be here, and I’ll leave with you when it’s time to go home.”

Home.

The word is almost laughable.

Where is my supposed home? In the empty New York penthouse where the ghost of Cole will haunt my every sight? Or the London apartment where my mother’s life ended?

I doubt either location will ever be *home* again.

Nodding mutely, I turn back to the counter. The fruit looks even more unappetizing than before. Scowling at the bowl, I push away from the offensive food and slide off of the upholstered seat.

Determined feet guide me through the Moretti house, desperate to find comfort in the chaos. Being alone with my thoughts is not a good idea.

Fortunately, I don’t have to wander for long.

“Look at all these dresses Armani found!” Jade practically squeals. She’s holding an armful of white fabric, basically hugging it to her chest. The sitting room surrounding her is covered in it. There must be at least ten wedding gowns sprawled all over the space.

The man who Jade credits for the scene is standing nearby, a fond smile on his lips as he watches his sister gush. Armani’s actually one of the Moretti brothers I’ve had more interaction with. He was a weapons instructor at Empire Academy last semester, and he’s been home every time

that I've come to visit Jade. He's also one of the easiest brothers to remember, since he's covered in tattoos and has silky brown hair down to his shoulders.

"Jade said you didn't want to go shopping yourself, so I grabbed a few options in your size," he tells me, nodding to the piles of dresses. "If you don't want to rummage through all of these, I can tell you my top picks."

Armani cares about fashion unlike any other mobster I've ever met. Jade's closet is filled to the brim with unique pieces because of him, and he's always dressed in something magnificent. So I have no problem trusting his judgement.

While trying on dress after dress might help to pass the time, I'm in no mood to play dress up. As it is, wedding dress shopping is something that girls tend to do with their mothers. I'd like to avoid the somber reminder that that isn't an option for me.

"Do you have anything with sleeves and a high back?"

His lips quirk into a grin. "I do indeed. One of my favorites is this classically simple floor-length. It has sleeves, a fully buttoned-up back, but a lower neckline that has some lace peeking out in the middle. Very elegant but understated, which I prefer for someone with your natural beauty."

Despite my abysmal mood, his compliment makes me flush.

"I'll try it."

"Eep!" Jade tosses up her hands in exclamation. "You're going to look stunning! I can't wait to see it. Do you want to go to my room to see how it fits?"

I'm glad that Jade is allowing herself to be happy. I like that she isn't censoring her excitement. Maybe her joy will be infectious enough to seep into me through the air. And if it doesn't, it's still keeping me steady.

If I can give even a sliver of that back to her, I'm going to try.

"Do you want to try one on too? It'd be a shame to let all of Armani's work go to waste."

Jade gasps. "Really? You wouldn't mind?"

"I'd like it if you would," I admit with a shrug. "Neither of us ever went to prom, so we never got dresses then. Maybe doing this will be like that."

Her responding smile is blinding. "Okay, let's do it!"

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Chapter Ten



Ana

I didn’t need to try on a second dress. The lovely gown Armani suggested fit like a glove and covered my body in all of the ways I prefer. It must have cost a fortune, judging by the quality of stitching and the Italian label I didn’t recognize. But when I asked to pay for it, Armani scoffed and told me not to insult him by asking a second time.

There was no room for further argument as he put a veil in my unstyled hair and asked if I wanted it trimmed shorter. When I told him I didn’t want a veil at all, he took it off to look at me without it for a long moment.

We shouldn’t hide this pretty face, should we? He eventually agreed, tossing the fabric aside. After giving three pairs of short heels to choose from, he left Jade and me to get out of our dresses. She’d tried on this over-the-top, glittery ballgown-style dress that made her look like a sparkly cupcake in the best way.

Though I didn’t want to try another, I told her to keep going. She opted to show me the sleek, baby blue dress Armani found for her to wear to the wedding instead. We decided she would stand by my side as my only bridesmaid, and I was relieved to know I wouldn’t be standing in front of the crowd all on my own.

A few hours after sorting our dresses, Jade is finishing the final touches on my hair. Time has gone by mercifully fast. With her babies keeping us busy, and another quick visit with Doc, I’ve been able to maintain a relatively high spirit.

Nothing about today has gone the way I imagined my wedding would when I was a young girl, but I couldn't be more appreciative to my best friend for her part in ensuring everything goes smoothly. She and her brothers have made sure that no one bothers me with decisions I don't want to make, nor problems I don't have the capacity to handle.

"I'm so happy Cesar took a nap," Jade tells me, sighing in relief. "I was worried he would have too much energy to sit with Dmitri for the ceremony. If he screeches during the vows, I'm going to turn redder than a tomato."

"I won't mind," I promise. "He makes people smile."

"Yeah," she says wistfully. "He does do that."

The dreamy look in her eye makes my heart swell.

"You look stunning by the way," Jade adds, arranging a half-halo, diamond hair piece around the back of my head. "I wish I could do my makeup the way you do. It looks professional, seriously."

I open my mouth to thank her when three soft knocks sound against the door to her room. Jade smooths out my last curl, smiling at me in the mirror before turning to go see who's there.

I don't immediately recognize the manly voice that comes through, nor am I able to see him from my chair at Jade's vanity. But it quickly becomes clear who's on the other side.

"You're not supposed to see the bride before the wedding," my friend softly protests, taking a step forward to make the crack in the door smaller.

"Yes, well, I listened to that superstition last time and my wife and son are still dead. You'll forgive me if I don't put any stock in frivolous traditions the second time around."

"Cassio…"

"It's okay," I interrupt, getting to my feet and approaching from behind Jade. "I'm not even in the dress yet. Give us a few minutes?"

My friend gives me a sad smile and dips her head. "I'll be right in the next room."

She quickly maneuvers out the door and allows her brother to step inside. I may not be in my dress, but he's certainly in his wedding attire. It's a black three-piece suit, tailored to him perfectly. His black tie and white shirt are crisp, like they've never seen a single wrinkle. And his trousers… I shouldn't be looking at how nicely they fit his frame.

Once the door clicks shut, Cassio meets my eyes with his crystal blues. They're soft but assessing. I'd forgotten how handsome he was, or maybe I'd never looked at him long enough to think about it. His bone structure is strong, with its lovely defined lines and distinctly masculine shape. He used to have stubble all over his jaw but he's clean shaven now. And his smooth brown hair is longer on top, giving him some wavy texture that draws my attention.

Blinking out of my observation, I hope that he hasn't caught me gawking at him. Luckily, he either hasn't seen or doesn't care if he has.

"Doc told me he gave you something?"

I swallow a small wave of embarrassment, feeling an unnecessary hit of weakness. I wasn't strong enough to go into my wedding without medication, not while knowing my mother won't be here to see it. She won't ever see anything ever again. I shouldn't feel ashamed for finding strength difficult to hold on to, but it seems I can't control much of anything going on in my mind now.

"A light mood stabilizer," I explain, looking down at my hands. "It's only half the dose of what he gave me before. Are you upset?"

"No," he answers without hesitation. "Merely concerned with how you're feeling. You're not too fatigued, are you?"

The sincerity in his words helps me relax. I don't know why I assumed Cassio may be angry or offended by my choice. This family has been nothing but patient and understanding with me thus far.

"I'm okay."

I'm not. But physically, I'm fine.

And I'm not tired. The medicine can make people drowsy, so I realize why he would ask. Having your bride pass out from exhaustion while walking down the aisle isn't a good look for any groom—let alone one who is doing this entire ceremony for appearance's sake.

"I apologize that I didn't come speak with you sooner." He shifts slightly on his feet. "I've been packing, mostly. And organizing our trip."

"It's fine." I shrug. "I didn't expect you… I didn't expect anything more. You're already helping me by agreeing to this."

His head tilts. "Expect more."

"W-what?"

I must have misheard him.

Cassio takes a single step forward, erasing most of the distance between us. We stand mere inches apart now.

“Expect more from me, Ana. This marriage is arranged, but it is very much real. Expect me to act as a husband should. I should have made time to come and see you sooner. I’m going to do better, and you should feel comfortable calling me out if I don’t.”

I don’t think I breathe the entire time he speaks, feeling more and more shocked with each word that passes his lips.

“Is that what you came here to say?” I ask, forcing my voice to remain steady.

“It’s part of it,” he confirms.

“But not all?”

“No.” Reaching into his back pocket, he retrieves a small black box. Startled by the implication, I stare at his hand as nerves rush through me.

“I wanted to give you this,” Cassio continues. He cracks open the jewelry case, revealing a sparkling ring. It’s a silver band with a square blue stone cushioned in the center with small diamonds surrounding the edges.

My hand flies up, covering my mouth before a gasp can escape.

“It’s a Moretti family heirloom,” he says, plucking the gorgeous piece between two fingers. I find my left hand captured and don’t flinch at the touch, reveling in how secure I feel in his presence. “My great-grandfather mined the stone himself, on a small island off the coast of Italy. He and his brother found a small deposit near this cave they used to explore as boys. It’s a blue diamond, and my great grandmother asked for it to be made into her engagement ring, since it reminded her of his eyes.”

Bloody hell.

“Cassio, that’s…” I breathe out, trying to find the right words. “This ring must mean so much to your family. How can I possibly accept this? “

The man doesn’t listen to my protest, choosing to slip the ring onto my left finger instead. It glides on without struggle; somehow the fit is flawless.

“Seems as if it were made for you,” he notes, nodding to my hand as he releases it. “The ring *does* mean a lot to our family. And that’s exactly why I’m giving it to you.”

It’s undeniably beautiful, and I don’t want to take it off.

“Are you sure?” Gulping, I wiggle my fingers to watch the gemstones shine. “It wasn’t hers, was it?”

As soon as the question comes from my mouth I want to shove it back in. I would never want to share a ring with another woman, especially one that my husband-to-be loved, but that was horribly insensitive.

"I am *so* sorry," I blurt out quickly. His body has gone stiff, and I immediately feel terrible. "I don't know why I just said that. You're being so kind to me, and I never meant—"

"It wasn't." He cuts off my rambled apology. "Isobel was buried with her ring, it was her mother's."

"Please don't feel like you need to explain yourself." I wring my hands and wince. I cannot believe I'm already making a mess of things with Cassio and we haven't even been married yet. "I'm all out of sorts, I don't normally behave this way, I promise."

"You're allowed to ask," he offers, posture softening once again. "We'll get to know each other and questions like these won't feel like an invasion after a while. Communication is how we develop, Ana."

"You're being too nice to me."

"It's not difficult, I assure you." He offers a small, heartening smile. "Since we're running out of time, we should get to the crux of why I'm here."

My throat constricts with nerves. "There's more?"

He's already checked on my health and given me a family heirloom that is probably worth more money than a car. It appears my groom is more intense than I expected.

"Indeed," Cassio tells me with a nod. "I have a proposal for you."

"We're already getting married," I attempt to joke, cringing at the lame reply.

"We are." He offers a smile. "But I wondered, perhaps, if you would be interested in adjusting the type of marriage we are about to enter?"

Frowning slightly, I ask, "Is something wrong with the contract?"

"No, no," he denies. "This kind of adjustment doesn't need to be noted in any contract. It's above the typical laws of men."

"Oh?"

"Have you heard of a Moretti Blood Marriage?"

I must look as bewildered as I feel, because Cassio chuckles and doesn't wait for my answer before offering clarification.

"I'm not surprised, it's a centuries old tradition in our family. A ceremony that few Morettis have chosen to partake in. Essentially, you

wouldn’t just become my wife, you’d become a Moretti.”

Blinking at him wildly, I wrap my arms around my stomach. “What does that even mean?”

“Instead of becoming Dante Moretti’s daughter-in-law, he would recognize you as his own blood. As far as our family is concerned, you would be Jade’s sister. All of my brothers would consider you one of our own. It’s like a marriage and an adoption, all in one.”

“That sounds… are you serious?”

“It’s not something that is done often. We all know about it, we all understand it, but not many of us choose to do it. Moretti men already consider marriage a life commitment, but a blood marriage is so much more.”

“And you want this? With *me?*”

“I do,” Cassio pledges. “I want you to have more than a husband, Ana. I want you to have a family. Someone took yours far too soon, and I don’t mean to replace them, but I want to give you everything I can. My family is the biggest strength I have to offer, so let me share it.”

My heart is beating so fast, I can feel it drumming in my neck. I can’t deny that it’s an attractive offer, nor that I want to greedily accept.

“How do we do it?”

Cassio breathes out, like he’s relieved that I haven’t shot him down. He insists that we take a seat, and for the next few minutes, jumps into an in-depth explanation of how the ceremony will go. I know he called it a Moretti *Blood* Marriage, but I didn’t expect to actually bleed.

The reality of the new type of wedding doesn’t scare me away. In fact, it draws my interest the more he talks. He tells me the specific words needed to be exchanged, and the way we’ll be bound. He also says that we don’t need to prepare anything differently, and that all of the required elements will already be in the vicinity.

Before I know it, I’ve already agreed to participate.

“It might hurt,” he eventually warns. “Just a little.”

“What could possibly hurt me more than the pain I’m already drowning in?”

“I’m so sorry, Ana,” he says, hesitantly threading his hand in mine. His hold is comforting, and our fingers tangle neatly together despite their difference in size.

“I don’t know how much longer I can keep this brave act,” I admit in a whisper, my throat going tight. “I feel like I’m seconds from cracking, Cassio. How do I make it stop?”

“You’re strong, Ana. Stronger than you probably ever thought you could be.”

“I don’t feel strong.”

“You can do this,” he insists.

My lips tremble. “H-how?”

“Remember why you’re doing it,” Cassio advises. “Remember that somewhere out there, the people responsible for tormenting you could be watching. Don’t give them the satisfaction of seeing your pain. These bastards want you to break, Ana, and you’re allowed to. But they don’t get to see that from you, do they?”

My head shakes and he hums in encouragement.

“No, they don’t.” His large hands wrap around the top of my arms, offering a firm source of solace. “Once we’re done here, and on that plane, you break however you need to. I’ll be with you through every step, but now, now you hold your head high, and you show everyone why you aren’t to be fucked with. Can you do that, Ana?”

“I can,” I determine, straightening my shoulders.

“Good.” He squeezes my arms softly before standing. “I’ll see you at the altar, *forza*.”

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Chapter Eleven



Cassio

Standing at the makeshift altar in our family's garden, my mind whirls with worries for my bride. Ana has remained strong for most of the day, keeping her head held high and hiding the anguish in her eyes. But less than twenty minutes ago, she confided in me that she was barely hanging on. She was so vulnerable in that moment, and all I wanted to do was scoop her up and shield her from any more possible harm.

The woman has been through enough in the past two days to last a lifetime. Grief is a vicious beast, especially when you're young and have no family to help you shoulder the burden. I hope my words of encouragement were enough to keep her steady until the end of our wedding—for both of our sakes. I very much doubt she wants a crowd to see her cry, and I certainly don't want rumors of a forced union to spread.

We've been set up for success, at least. My father had an entire team of workers turn the garden into a scenic wedding venue fit for Vogue, and the amount of guards surrounding the property could rival most high-security prisons in the country. We'll have no outside interference, and the pictures that will come out of this evening will be whispered about for years to come. I can hear the gossiping society murmurs already.

Did you see the secret Moretti wedding?

I was almost invited, you know?

It was so beautiful! A shame they didn't invite more people…

Positive chatter will help keep heavy suspicion from clouding this arrangement, but it means nothing more than that. Anyone who knows me

and Ana well enough to be concerned is already clued in. The rest of the mafia world will have a glimpse, but they'll never truly *see*.

Shaking out of my over-analyzing state, I try to focus on the present.

The stone arch behind me is wrapped with flowers and vines in various shades of blue that permeate the air with a delicate scent. Since the afternoon sun has descended from its peak height, there's a faint chill in the air. A light breeze dances around the wedding space, touching every guest like a friendly greeting.

Most of the white chairs facing me are filled with family. My brothers, a few of their friends, high ranking Outfit members and their spouses, along with a few extra editions. Gerard is seated on Ana's side of the aisle, flanked by Dustin and Colton. Armani chooses to sit with his friend as well.

Apollo, on the other hand, is located to my left, standing in as my best man. If I wasn't going to surprise the family with the blood ceremony, I might have asked Leon to be by my side. Hell, had this been a planned out event, I might have a few more of my brothers up here as well. But for what I need, Apollo is my best option.

He's also the most fearsome brother I have, and if there are any spies watching us somehow, I want them to remember that Ana isn't just marrying Cassio Moretti. She's marrying Apollo Moretti's brother.

"Look alive," he mutters under his breath. "Your girl is coming."

My posture straightens immediately at his warning. My eyes follow the length of the simple aisle—a narrow strip of mowed grass covered with a creamy white cloth.

Instead of the traditional bridal chorus signaling the arrival of the bride, a rendition of Beethoven's *Moonlight Sonata* begins to softly play. Only seconds after the music begins, Ana appears.

I have to school my expression to keep my eyes from flaring open wide. Her dress is molded to her frame like it was custom-made for her, and though there is not a hint of sparkle to the material, she is *glowing*.

Jade walks arm and arm with her, guiding her down the path to me like a father normally would—yet I barely glance at my sister. My eyes are firmly set on my bride. I shouldn't find her to be such a fascinating sight. After all, I saw her not long ago, but she didn't look like *this*.

Ana's eyes meet mine, and her chest rises with an intake of air. A silent message passes between us, an offering of mutual courage. We're in this together, and she has me to lean on.

In a matter of leisurely seconds, the two women stop walking. Jade presses a light kiss to Ana's cheek and takes her hand to pass it to me. My future wife's eyes don't leave mine the entire time, and she wraps her fingers around my hand tight. I use our connection to help her make her last step, giving her a small supportive smile.

As we face one another, the priest settles behind us.

"Dearly beloved," he begins, voice clear and practiced. "We are gathered here today under the eyes of God, to join together this man and this woman in Holy Matrimony. Marriage is a sacred covenant, which should be entered into reverently. You are here to bear witness to this loving union."

He looks to Ana and me. "Please, join hands, so we may begin."

"I'm sorry, Father Benedict," I tell him, attempting to sound genuine. "I'm afraid that my brother will be stepping in now."

You could hear a pin drop following my statement. Even the wind seems to halt, bated breaths being held all around us.

"Of course," he replies. Despite the wide-eyed look of shock on his face, he'd never deny a Moretti's word. Without another word, he steps away, disappearing into the crowd.

I can feel the gazes of every Moretti in the room, but I do not return them. I'm sure I'll be fielding their reactions later, but I won't entertain their collective surprise until my bond is fully forged. My eldest brother slips into the priest's place, no prompting needed to get him there. He knows there is only one reason I would send Father Benedict away before reciting vows.

"The blade," I request, holding out a hand.

Apollo lifts a brow as if to ask me if I'm sure, but he doesn't refuse me. Slipping his hand into his jacket's inner pocket, he carefully extracts the ceremonial knife. As our family's heir, he's required to carry it during any and all Moretti weddings—just in case.

Holding the silver blade by its textured hilt, he keeps the tip pointed toward the ground. Without missing a beat, he opens his mouth to recite his lines.

"This knife has been held by generations of men. It has bathed in the blood of a select few, but all of whom share the same blood. The cutting edge has only ever broken Moretti skin, and it will be melted down into scrap before that changes. Do you recognize its purpose?"

“I do.”

“Does your bride?”

“She does.”

The handle is pressed into my open palm, and Father Benedict silently passes Apollo a bowl of blessed water.

Bringing my eyes back to Ana, I’m relieved to see she doesn’t appear scared. There is the faintest hint of shining in them, but she won’t cry.

“Do you intend to be mine?”

My question prompts a rehearsed smile to paint her lips.

“Only yours,” she agrees, the quiet words hitting me straight in the chest. “Will you belong to me?”

“And only you,” I pledge.

With our preliminary promises finished, the most important part of the ceremony must begin. The sacrifices.

I go first, softly scoring my finger with the tip of the silver blade. Handing the knife off to Ana, I dip my thumb into the bowl of holy water, purifying my blood before reaching toward her. Carefully tracing a downward cross into her pale skin, I watch, mesmerized as the bright red liquid stains between her breasts.

For the first time in years, my heart starts to pick up in an excited beat. Something like desire stirs in my stomach, and I blink, flicking my gaze to Ana’s face. Her honey brown eyes stare back at me and the feeling only grows. She’s beautiful, that much has always been obvious.

I’ve never been blind to how Ana looks. She has glowing ivory skin, silky hair, pink and puffy lips, and a million other features that can’t be ignored. And her body… I’ve seen more of it than I should admit. She’s swum in our pool with Jade a few times, and even seeing her in a bikini didn’t do this to me before.

In fact, no woman has garnered a reaction like this from me, not since Isobel. I haven’t had the urge to even search for the sensation, and now it’s hitting me all on its own. I’m marrying this woman, vowing my life to hers, and I can’t believe how relieved I am that Apollo isn’t standing in my place.

A surge of fierce possessiveness slams through me. It’s *my* blood on her skin, marking her right over her heart. It’s the ring *I* chose on her finger, and it’s *my* responsibility to keep her safe and happy. From now, until my last breath.

Ana pricks her thumb next, and despite the wound being small, I have to force myself not to tend to it. Dipping her cut into the holy water, she breathes out heavily before reaching toward my throat. Her hand is steady as she traces the same downward facing cross right over my Adam's Apple.

Before she can retract her hand, I catch her by her fingers. Ana lets out a tiny gasp, and I hold her eyes while taking my pocket square from my jacket. Without a word, I wrap her slowly bleeding thumb in the fabric, tying a knot over the cut.

Her throat bobs in a swallow, and I reluctantly let her go. I'd insist on having Doc check her out right this second if it wouldn't make me look insane to both my bride and my entire family.

"Father?" I ask, flicking my eyes to the man.

Dante Moretti stands from his seat in the first row, already pulling the scrap of blue ribbon from his pocket. He's held onto the very same silky strip for three weddings before, and never once has he needed to use it. Still, he doesn't show a hint of objection or uncertainty.

He faces Apollo, his back to the crowd and looks between my bride and me with something akin to pride. I hadn't worried that he would be upset with my decision to bond Ana in this way, but I hadn't expected such obvious approval either.

"Blue is the color of loyalty and trust," Dad says thickly. "This material represents an invisible tie that will connect you for all of time."

Taking Ana's wrist first, he ties a small loop around it, leaving plenty of slack behind. He ties the same knot around my wrist next. Within seconds, we're fastened together, each of us having our own bracelet of ribbon with a cord tethering them.

Dad returns to his seat, letting our guests witness the joining.

"Your rings," Apollo prompts, pulling them from his pocket.

An unembellished, thick silver band for me, and a slim diamond-speckled halo for my bride. He offers us each the correct ring to hold, and awaits our next move. Ana takes a collecting breath and peers up at me.

Offering her an encouraging nod, I watch her lips part, preparing to say the vows I taught her only a short time ago.

"With my blood, I bind my life to your name," she starts, her hands shaking but her voice steady. "I shed who I once was, sacrificing my past for our future. With this ribbon, we are tied. Even as it is cut, our bond remains sealed. Now, and in every moment on, I am yours."

With her final word, she glides my wedding band into place.

I squeeze her untied hand, a small gesture that she's done perfectly.

"With my blood, I dedicate my life to you." I pick up where she's left off, taking my turn. "I shed who I once was, sacrificing my past for our future. All my strength, I share with you. With this ribbon, we are tied. Even as it is cut, our bond remains sealed. Now, and in every moment on, I am yours."

I slip her wedding band on, watching as it joins her engagement ring.

Taking the ceremonial knife once again, I guide it to the ribbon connecting us. With one quick slash, it severs, leaving only the individual pieces hanging from our wrists.

"You may kiss the bride."

I'm already leaning down before Apollo's cue is finished. Ana's lips part, her breath softly mingling with mine. My ribbon-adorned hand cups the side of her face, and one small press forward seals our fate.

Our lips meet in a chaste but soft kiss, molding together naturally. Loud cheers arise from our audience, and I realize that without the sound of clapping, I may not have been so quick to pull back.

The flush on my wife's face says the same may be true for her.

What have we gotten ourselves into?

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Chapter Twelve



Ana

Cassio and I walk hand and hand all the way inside. Before any sort of debrief, he takes me to the nearest bathroom and begins tending to my cut finger. He disinfects the area, adds some sort of healing cream and then covers it in a plain band-aid. He doesn't do any of the same for his own finger, merely running it under some warm water and ignoring the small opening that remains.

"You're still bleeding," I point out softly.

"It'll stop." Cassio shrugs.

Before he can consider leaving, I take his hand. I'm not sure what comes over me when I pick up another bandage and secure it over his small bleed. He watches me intently, almost as if trying to read my mind.

"They'll be setting up the reception tables now," he eventually says. "Would you like a few minutes to yourself?"

"Yes," I agree quickly. "Just to freshen up, I think."

And to prepare myself for more human interaction.

"Call for me if you need me, okay? I'll be right outside."

"I will."

Cassio looks at the door, hesitating. The back of his knuckle softly caresses the apple of my cheek. "You did so well, *forza*."

"*Forza*," I echo. "You called me that before. What does it mean?"

"Force," Cassio translates, a light smile on his lips. "You, my wife, are a force to be reckoned with. I can't wait until everyone sees for themselves."

He leaves me to contemplate his words, too stunned to reply.

Overwhelmed and alone, I use the bathroom sink to brush some cold water on the back of my neck and sigh. My makeup is still in perfect condition, even my lips—despite the kiss that Cassio and I shared.

A *good* kiss.

Short and sweet, but somehow meaningful, almost passionate.

Needing to sit down, I find myself looking for a quiet corner of the house. Stumbling upon an unoccupied lounge, I forgo a chair in favor of collapsing against a wall and sliding down to the floor. The hard wood is cool to the touch, the temperature helping me ground myself.

You're fine, I tell myself with a sigh.

You did well, Cassio told you so.

Once the internal thoughts start, they're hard to stop.

You're doing this for a good reason.

Cassio has been so nice; you don't need to worry.

In the midst of my mental rambling, my eyes catch on a bright flash of metal. Stashed on the underside of the chair nearest me, an unsheathed knife pokes out. I reach for it instinctively, curious about the weapon.

It's a standard tactical knife with a straight blade. I don't test the tip's sharpness, sure that any weapon in this house is properly kept. In fact, it's so polished that I can see my reflection in the shiny blade. Jade and Matteo have mentioned that the house has stashes of self-defense material in the past, but I've never happened upon them before.

Perhaps I'll start carrying a knife. Maybe even a gun.

I doubt the men who captured us two nights ago even searched me for a weapon. Cole and Killian were always in possession of some kind of defense, but not me. I never saw the appeal or had the need.

Tilting the blade between my hands, I wonder, *would that night have gone differently if I had one of these up my sleeve?*

The satisfying image of a bald head speared with a knife almost makes me smile. But no, a quick blow to the brain would be too kind for that man. If I could pick, I'd want him skinned alive. I think hearing his screams might heal me in ways that nothing else could.

"If you are thinking about ending your life, just know that I'll shoot that knife out of your hand before you make my brother a widow twice over." The deep rumble of Nico Moretti's voice startles me out of my trance.

His cold words take a minute to process and my nose scrunches until I look at the steel blade in my hand once again. He thinks I'm contemplating

offing myself. I can understand his thought process, but he couldn't be further off base.

"I'm not going to kill myself," I mutter numbly. Slowly extending my arm out to the side, my fingers release the hilt and I watch as it clatters against the tiled floor. "I couldn't, even if I wanted to."

Nico eyes me with suspicion and cocks a brow. "Why not?"

Surprised by his candor, I can't help but snort. "If I die, Killian wakes up alone. He's… he's my brother. Cole is gone, Bron is gone. I should have the guts to stick around, otherwise he'll have no one."

It's deadly silent for a moment.

"You and Cassio have more in common than you think."

"Maybe," I reply with a helpless shrug. I can't confirm or deny, I hardly know the man who's now my husband.

"Why the knife?" He nods to the discarded weapon. "If you weren't going to hurt yourself, why were you staring at it like it was your salvation?"

I don't contemplate lying, not even for a moment. "I was thinking about revenge. I want to make whoever did this to me wish they were never born."

His mouth twitches in the barest hint of a smile. "Now you're starting to sound like a Moretti—minus the accent, of course."

"I can do American," I admit, shifting into an impressive impersonation of a standard States' accent. "I'm afraid Italian American isn't in my repertoire. I'll have to work on it."

Nico tilts his head, assessing me. "Accents come in handy for you, do they? Did you learn them for some kind of strategy?"

"I was a bored child," I tell him with a huff. "I liked to mimic people. I can do more. French, Australian, and a few others. The only thing that they were useful for was entertaining myself."

"But you see how they could be useful now?"

"I guess. Disguising myself would be easier with a voice change… but I don't see why I would need to do that."

"Oh, Ana." Nico gives me a dull look, blinking once. "You never know when you need an ace up your sleeve. I'll let you in on a little secret to this life we live. Every single thing you've ever learned, every bit of information you know… that's what makes you a weapon. A one of a kind, never to be replicated weapon."

“I hardly think I’m a weapon.”

“All people are weapons, some of us are just more honed than others.”

I let his words digest and nod solemnly.

“Before they shot Killian, he told them that they would regret it, that we have allies who’d avenge them. It’s stupid… but part of me thought maybe he was talking about me. The men, they told Cole and Killian that I wouldn’t be dying, but maybe he thought they’d change their minds if he threatened them with me.”

I swallow, shaking my head. “They probably would have laughed at the thought. They called me a little girl.”

“Little girls with the right connections can do a lot of damage,” Nico states flatly. “They would have been foolish to laugh.”

“The bald one,” I spit his description. “He laughed a lot. Thought the whole thing was funny. Called me a whore, too. He said he didn’t have a taste for torture, but he’d make an exception for Cole because he was mouthy. I hope someone gives *him* a taste of torture.”

Nico tilts his head, assessing me. “Maybe someone will.”

It almost sounds like a promise.

“Come on, the reception awaits your presence. The sooner you mingle and eat cake, the sooner we can get all of these interlopers out of my house.”

Nodding at his suggestion, I get to my feet and Nico escorts me back to the party. Gone is the aisle with rows of seating—all replaced by long tables and chairs for a proper celebration. He brings me right to my new husband, not stopping to speak to anyone we pass.

Cassio is seated at the head table, and he isn’t entirely alone. In his lap sits the most adorable baby girl dawning a tiny dress the same blue shade as her mother’s. Noticing my appearance, he pulls out the chair next to him and gestures for me to take it.

“Food will be served soon, if you’re hungry.”

Smiling tightly, I dip my head in a nod. “Maybe.”

The truth is, I get hungrier every time I try to eat and fail. I might actually be able to manage a few hefty bites with how empty my stomach feels. I just hope whatever is being served isn’t too heavy.

My eyes catch Isobella as she coos and babbles at Cassio while reaching for his tie to play with. She fumbles with the black fabric, her chubby little

fingers molding around it. Seconds later, she's happily shoving it between her tiny lips and chewing in delight.

"Uncle Armani will not be pleased to see you soiling a Versace tie, piccola," he tells her without making a move to take the cloth from her mouth.

Isobella seems to give him a gummy grin and giggles like they're sharing some kind of inside joke.

Cassio tickles the underside of her chin and smiles back. "Yes, I agree, he will have to get over it."

Seeing such a simple but caring act from my new husband is the most calming thing that's occurred all evening. It's not an orchestrated act like the wedding itself, it's pure and natural—almost soothing to witness.

"She likes you a lot," I comment, watching the soft exchange between uncle and niece.

I was never overly nervous about being paired with a Moretti son. Nervous to be married at all, and at such a horrible time, yes. But I was thankful my options were amongst the Moretti clan. Mostly because of all the things Jade has told me about them.

They're incredibly loyal brothers, and from what I can tell, generally good men. Good is subjective in a world full of mafiosos, criminals, and gangsters. And still, as far as arranged husbands go, I've practically won the lottery.

I have no fairytale delusions about how my marriage to Cassio will go, but watching him dote on such a small, innocent, and sweet baby reminds me that I have nothing to fear from him.

He knows how to handle people with care, that much is evident. I'm afraid I'm going to need a lot of care, and *soon*. The chaos of the wedding has proven to be efficient in distracting me from the dark and depressing monster lurking in my mind, waiting to strike. Not to mention the small dose of mood stabilizer from the Moretti doctor.

Nothing has truly itched at the numbness I've been feeling, nothing besides fear and anxiety. But this small moment of peace feels like *something*. Something not so horrible, indeed.

"Isobella likes everyone, she has a soft heart," Cassio replies diplomatically before letting a small smirk slip. "But I won't deny being a favorite."

I can’t help but admire the small girl, seeing the unbridled joy lighting up her face. “She looks just like Jade, don’t you think?”

Cassio chuckles and nods. “Yes, Dante Moretti has the strongest genes known to man. Cesar looks a bit more like Dmitri, at least. He’s got his nose.”

“Cesar may look like Dmitri but his temperament is all Matteo,” I say, surprising myself when I feel a quirk to my lips.

It’s… easy talking to Cassio. At least when it’s about his—now *our*—adorable niece and nephew. I suppose it makes sense. Children have always been one of my happy places. Caring for the little ones at the orphanage is the thing that makes me feel fullest.

“Cesar is going to be a terror,” he tells me with a half-dramatic sigh. “We’ve already discovered his infatuation with both pretty girls and explosives.”

My eyes widen, mouth agape. “Explosives?”

“Remo and Matteo were testing out some new Tannerite drone in the backyard last week, Dmitri let Cesar watch from the porch,” Cassio explains, reaching into his pocket for his phone. He spins the device toward me and our fingers lightly brush as I take it.

On the display there’s a picture of baby Cesar in his father’s arms, wearing large blue ear protective gear. He’s positively adorable and grinning so big.

“Isobella was asleep, but of course Cesar wouldn’t nap and Dmitri didn’t want the noise to startle him so he figured he’d show him to keep him calm. Some families introduce babies to fireworks, and some families show them an exploding pallet of cinder blocks.”

Passing the phone back, I shrug. “It’s just an advanced science lesson, no harm.”

My husband’s lips twitch in amusement. “A science lesson, that’s a clever way of thinking about it.”

A small ripple of warmth crawls up my neck at his apparent praise, but before I can reply, Jade is at my side and putting her son in my lap.

“Please watch him for a second? I have to pee so bad and Dmitri is talking with Dad,” she pleads and waits for my confirming nod before rushing off toward the house. She calls out her thanks as she disappears.

The soft weight of Cesar sitting in my lap draws my attention, and I look down to find him already grinning up at me. He’s wearing a black

onesie with a tuxedo printed design and the smallest little pair of matching trousers. When he starts to squirm a bit, I help rearrange him until he's burying his head into my chest for a snuggle.

Cassio chuckles at the boy's enthusiastic cuddling. "I told you. Pretty girls are his new favorite thing."

My cheeks burn, realizing that he's just called me pretty. I'm not in denial about being appealing to look at. I've recognized my own beauty for years, but hearing it from Cassio so openly is shocking.

"And how did we discover this quality of yours, young man?" I inquire, playfully poking his side.

"Melani and Cleo came to visit," Cassio answers for him. "He didn't give a shit about meeting Leon or Emilio, but he stole their wives for hours. It's a good thing your hair is currently off your shoulders or he'd have a fistful of it right now."

I haven't formally met Leon, Emilio or their wives. They don't live in the family home with Jade, and they can't come to visit very often. They all have important roles further away in the Moretti territory, but I've heard good things about them still.

I'm sure I'll meet Leon and Emilio by the end of the day, as they both made sure to carve out time for appearances' sake. Unfortunately, their wives both have kids to look after and couldn't join them on such short notice.

Though, perhaps it's for the best. I'm not sure if the threat to me is over, and I'd never want to put anyone else at risk. I already feel a bit guilty for taking so much of Dante's generosity.

"You're a charming young chap, aren't you?" I ask Cesar, letting him snatch up a few of my fingers. He squeezes hard, demonstrating his grip strength and babbles while examining my hand and nails. "Strong too, have you been lifting weights, little love?"

Cassio chuckles. "More like lifting stuffed animals and trying to throw them across the room. He's a chaos ball of destruction waiting to happen. We're lucky he's not old enough to start walking yet, or we'd probably lose him thirty times a day."

"A tiny troublemaker, aren't you?" I coo against the top of his head, breathing in his baby scent.

"Understatement," Cassio concurs.

“I’m sorry to be taking you from them,” I apologize just loud enough for him to hear. “It must be nice being around them. They seem to adore you.” Isobella is perfectly content in his arms, after all. And even though Cesar isn’t trying to wiggle over to his uncle, he keeps sending him gummy smiles while cuddling me.

“It’s not your fault, Ana,” he replies, stern but soft. “They’ve got plenty of family around, and if I have it my way, we won’t be away for too long.”

The sound of swift revenge is terribly appealing.

“Will you want to live here again, then?” I ask timidly. “After, I mean.”

Cassio nods. “Here or close by. It’s safest, and in our family consiglieres stay by the Capo. We don’t operate our own territory like Leon does as underboss. My job is to advise and strategize with my father and Apollo, and being by their side is the best way to do it.”

He watches me process the information and offers a kind smile. “If you prefer we have our own house, we will. If you’d rather live here, we will.”

My throat bobs with a gulp. “It’s up to me?”

“As your husband, I will always take your opinion and your comfort into consideration, Ana,” he preaches the words like gospel. “Unless there is a safety risk, I’ll do my best to honor your wishes.”

Emotion wells in my chest, and I have to take a breath, holding back tears. His proclamation is so genuine and lovely, and not for the first time, I feel incredibly grateful that Cassio volunteered to marry me.

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Chapter Thirteen



Cassio

My blood-bound wife did an excellent job remaining calm for the rest of our reception. She mingled politely, shared small affections with me, posed for photos, and even smiled convincingly when meeting Leon and Emilio. Though she noticeably struggled to eat, she played her part well.

The goodbyes were difficult, mostly on Jade's end. She cried her whole face of makeup off and hugged both Ana and I multiple times before we were able to depart. She's only been my sister for a year, but she fits into this family like she was never lost. If you didn't know her circumstances, you would never guess that she wasn't raised right alongside us.

And though her friendship with Ana isn't one that's existed for long, their bond is formidable. It's one of the reasons I knew a blood marriage would work between Ana and myself. Father has always said that friendship is one of the key components in alliances worth forging.

Our trip into the city was fast. A private jet from Pennsylvania to New York City takes less than an hour, and most of that time was filled with uncomfortable silence. Ana curled up in one of the secluded chairs and stared out her window while Armani and Colton discussed plans with me.

We arrived at the Knight family penthouse only a few moments ago, and so far, I'm not excited about the amount of windows here. My first order of business is to ensure the security of the space, and so many points of weakness do not bode well. At least they're bulletproof—according to Gerard.

Ending my examination of the main floor, I find Ana's haunted eyes scanning the area like she doesn't quite recognize it. This has been her primary home for more than two years, and she looks as if it makes her sick. I know that look, because I've *felt* that look.

She's devastated to be returning to a space that will no longer be home to more than half of her family. Killian may walk these floors again, but she knows that Bron, her mother and Cole never will. I remember thinking the same thing, seeing Isobel in every corner of the Moretti mansion for months after her death. Since her passing, the space has never felt the same, and I doubt it ever will. My new wife is likely realizing something similar now.

Colton and Armani work around us, silently clearing the penthouse—sweeping the place with guns and a team of Moretti guards. Ana doesn't make a move to sit or even put down her bag of clothes from Jade. She's frozen in the middle of her living room, staring blankly at the space.

Without prompting, I approach her and gently take her bag, setting it on the floor by her feet. She's a bit pale and the area under eyes is dark from exhaustion. She hasn't eaten enough in far too long, and she's yet to fully break down after hearing the news of her mother. Holding it in won't last much longer, and I'm prepared to get her through it, no matter how painful it will be. For both of us.

"Drink this," I instruct, uncapping a pre-made protein drink and putting it up to her lips.

She grimaces, nose scrunching in distaste. "I don't want to."

Her voice is so much smaller than I've known it to be and it makes my heart fucking ache.

Lifting her right hand, I wrap her delicate fingers around the bottle. "I'm not going to make you eat, but I'm not going to let you get sick either. You drink this, and I won't bother you again about food until tomorrow."

Still, she hesitates.

"It tastes like chocolate milk, and if you drink it fast, it will be over in less than a minute. Having something in your stomach will help you sleep, too."

Mollified by my words, she tips the drink back and swallows. Like I advised, she takes it quickly, consuming six hundred calories and nearly thirty grams of protein in less than a minute.

Ana wipes her lips with the back of her hand, narrowly missing the sleeves of her wedding dress in the process. She hasn't changed out of the

gown, but since it’s a soft fabric and not too tight, I imagine she isn’t uncomfortable. And if she wanted to get out of it, she would have. I’ve given her three different opportunities to. Before leaving the house, before boarding the flight, and once again whilst on the actual plane.

Every time, she replied with the same three words and a shake of her head. *“Let them see.”*

Before I can say another word, my brother and his friend come back to the main floor, our team following closely behind.

“It’s clear. No cameras, no broken windows, and the vulnerable spots are manageable with the right defenses. It’s safe here,” Armani reports. “Colton and I are going to live on the third level where Killian stays. It’s got its own kitchen and living spaces so we won’t bother you—unless you ask. Second and first floor are all yours.”

“The security team is going to meet up with Gerard now,” Colton continues. “Half of them will work with The Kings’ guards, and the other half will work stealth, keeping an eye on the building and your general area.”

I nod once, firmly. “Good work, thank you.”

“Can I go to bed now?” Ana asks, her voice so close to breaking.

Without a word, Armani and Colton dismiss themselves to go upstairs and I turn to my young bride. “Of course you can, Ana. Show me where you’d like to sleep?”

She mutely nods and begins to walk up to the second floor. Her steps are slow but not sluggish, and eventually she approaches a dark oak door, pushing it open easily.

Her room is elegant but not dramatically so. She has creamy pink walls with white crown molding and gold light fixtures—the main one being an intricate chandelier above her bed. The queen-sized mattress sits atop a dark green frame with a velvety headboard in the same color. Her blankets are a dusty pink like her walls, with different textures coming from her fluffy pillows.

She has a pink vanity covered in various beauty products, a walk-in closet and ensuite bathroom, as well as a large couch that matches her headboard. I didn’t expect it to be like this, but then again, I don’t really know Ana well enough to predict her personal taste.

Like in the living room, she stands still, taking it all in.

“Do you want me to stay here tonight?” I ask softly. “There are guest rooms close by, but I don’t mind staying on your couch if it makes you feel safer.”

Ana turns, looking at me with her lips slightly parted. “Aren’t we going to…” She trails off, awkwardly looking between me and her bed.

Consummate, she means.

I haven’t forgotten that she asked for that in our contract. It stunned me when I saw it, but I could guess why she would request such a thing. Legitimacy is important to her. She understands how our world works, even if she wasn’t born into it like I was.

“Not tonight,” I answer quietly.

I don’t want to upset her, but I can’t comprehend why she would want to do such a thing right away. She’s hurting and certainly not in the headspace to properly consent. I’d die if I touched her and found regret in her eyes the next day.

“Oh,” she mutters, looking conflicted. “Um, you’ll stay, though?”

“Of course I will,” I vow unwaveringly.

She blinks and slowly nods. “Okay.”

“Here,” I prompt, stepping closer. “Let me get your buttons. You need to get into something for bed. You’ll feel a lot better once you get comfortable. You’re exhausted, Ana.”

She looks longingly at her blankets, like she wants to crawl beneath them and never come out.

“Okay,” she agrees. Gingerly, she sweeps her hair off of her back, letting it fall from one side of her neck to her chest.

I use caution when reaching for her top button, trying not to startle her. With already-existing fear, her lack of sleep only aids in making her quite jumpy, and I can’t blame her.

My fingers clasp around the first cotton stud and gently tug, pulling the piece through its hole. Repeating the action at least ten more times, I feel her breath hitch as my finger traces her bare skin. Avoiding her spine while assisting her is impossible, but she doesn’t pull away or make another sound. I continue until most of her back is exposed. Most of her *tattooed* back.

I didn’t expect that.

Her dress isn’t open enough to examine the design, but thick strokes of black ink catch my eye, and I wonder when I’ll get to see the rest of it. It

must be relatively new, because I've seen her back before, and it was completely bare.

Once my hands drop, I find myself wishing there were more buttons.

"Thank you," Ana breathes before scurrying off to her closet and eventually into her bathroom.

Running a hand down my face, I sigh and pull out my phone to update my father. He's not taking this well—not our marriage—but the reason that it needed to transpire.

What happened to Ana is a reminder that no matter how untouchable you may think you are, there's always some crazy son of a bitch that could ruin your life. Somehow, someway, we're all vulnerable. It's a tough pill to swallow, and one that we'll never fully accept.

Ana, for instance, will not have a single hair on her head harmed. Not now that she is my wife. I'll make sure of it. Not a single person alive will come close enough to hurt her again.

The Kings were powerful—*are* powerful—but the Morettis are a whole other beast. Aside from the tragic death of my Uncle Cesar, this sort of thing doesn't happen to us.

The woman responsible for killing him got lucky. She planned and plotted enough with her useless boyfriend to break into our property—which should have been impossible. Instead, she used a weakness within our security in her assault. A weakness that can never be exploited again.

I still don't know every detail of how that night went so horribly wrong, but I know Apollo and my father have handled it. I also know that four guards were executed by them within that very same week, and I can do the math. Traitors are inevitable, after all.

People see power with their own eyes and become hungry for it. They chase greener pastures. But greed is a death sentence when you can't defend what you've stolen.

Stupidity can be forgiven. Betrayal never can—especially when it cost Dante Moretti his brother—and nearly cost me my life.

I grimace, shaking off the dark thought.

Thinking about it only makes me murderous, and now isn't the time for killing. It's the time for recovery. When I agreed to marry Ana, I didn't just agree to help keep Killian's people in line, I agreed to be her husband. I'm here for *her* as much as I'm here for The Kings.

I'll get her through her grief, and then I'll help her execute her revenge. We may not be in love, but we're bound by vows, and I take every vow I've ever promised seriously.

CASSIO

Arrived safely, apartment is swept. Getting Ana into bed now.

I grimace, looking at the text, immediately typing another to clarify.

CASSIO

To sleep.

DAD

Keep me updated, son. Be safe, and take care of that girl.

CASSIO

Will do.

He doesn't need to tell me twice.

Ana is my number one priority, and honestly, this new sense of purpose is something that I've needed for a long time. I would give it all back if it meant Ana could have her mother again, and Killian could have his brother. But I can't, and that will never happen.

So, Ana is my responsibility.

I just hope that the grief and sorrow surrounding her doesn't consume her. I can get her out of it, but it's going to take time.

When she emerges from her ensuite, her face is freshly washed and clear of all makeup. Her thick, dark hair is pulled to the top of her head in a loose bun, and her pajamas are pink and silky. My eyes catch on her wrist, the blue wedding ribbon standing out against her sleep shorts.

She kept it on.

Traditionally, the ribbon can be removed as soon as the wedding party concludes. And yet, we're both still wearing ours. I can't explain the swell of pride that consumes me at the realization.

Focus, Cassio.

"Do you need anything?"

Ana shakes her head slowly. "I don't think so."

"I'm just going to change, but I'll be right back. Get comfortable."

By the time I return with a spare pillow and blanket, she's already lying down, soft ocean noises playing from her phone. I switch off the light and arrange the couch so I can sleep.

"Goodnight, Wife," I mutter quietly, doubting that she can hear me.

Putting my gun under my pillow and a knife beneath the sofa, I blow out a breath and try to clear my mind. I won't sleep if my brain is too busy rolling through all of the things I have to do in the next few days.

By the time I finally drift off, the only thing on my mind is the blue ribbon.

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Chapter Fourteen



Cassio

Soft sobs wake me out of a light sleep, my senses all snapping into clarity with immediate precision. Ana's bedroom is dark, save for the city light trickling in through her tall windows. In the shadows I see her body tossing and turning, rolling around beneath her blankets.

Getting to my feet, I stride over to her side, ignoring the soreness in my shoulders from sleeping on her couch. When I peer down at my new wife, I see the unmistakable glow of her skin, slick with sweat. Tears are streaming down her face, even as she remains in a fitful sleep.

"Shit," I mutter quietly, feeling a familiar sense of grief settle in my gut. It's like her pain and sorrow is seeping into me through the air and I need to brush it off.

Memories threaten to play around in my mind, but I can't lose myself in the past. I have to take care of Ana. Right now, nothing else matters.

Steadying myself with a deep breath, I lean down and reach for her biceps. Trying not to startle her, I caress her skin and squeeze.

"Ana," I whisper gently.

She whimpers in her sleep, face scrunching in sadness. Her sobs quickly grow louder and her chest rises and falls faster. She's terrified or panicking, and I need her to wake up.

"Ana," I say more firmly. "You're dreaming, you need to wake up."

When she makes no move to open her eyes, I grimace.

Fuck it.

Pulling back her covers, I climb into bed next to her. My arms surround her from the side and I firmly tuck her small frame against my body.

“Ana,” I repeat, mouth brushing against her ear. She’s practically vibrating in my hold, shaking and crying so hard it makes me want to kill someone.

Feeling me so close finally causes my wife to startle, and she flinches away. Her eyes slam open wide, fear and tears filling her caramel gaze.

“It’s just me,” I whisper quickly, holding her tighter so that she can’t scramble away and hurt herself accidentally. “You were crying and breathing hard, was it a nightmare?”

Her bottom lip wobbles, and without answering, she throws her arms around me and buries her wet face into the crook of my neck. Ana crushes herself into me so hard that I wince.

“Shhhh, I’ve got you,” I coax, rubbing her back slowly. “You’re safe here. All the guards are awake and alert, Armani and Colton are in the living room still awake. I’m right here. No one can hurt you.”

I’m not lying, I had already woken up some time ago to check on things and was pleasantly surprised to see our ship running so smoothly.

“They a-already did,” she cries, stuttering through the words.

Her words hit me right in the chest. “I know.”

“It h-hurts, Cassio.”

I know. God, do I know…

“We’re going to hurt them worse,” I promise her. “They’ll suffer in ways you never thought imaginable.”

More tears roll down my neck, and she breathes out a long breath, trying to calm herself. Minutes pass and she still cries, but she’s no longer hyperventilating. I keep holding her, rubbing her back, and trying to settle her with soft comfort.

I haven’t felt so close to another person in far too long, and I wish it were under better circumstances. I wish Ana didn’t have to be plagued with such despair, but I’ll continue to wrap her in my arms for as long as it helps.

Sounding impossibly sad, she whispers, “I miss my mum.”

Her voice has cleared up, and her breathing has mostly evened out.

“She was Catholic, wasn’t she?” I ask. “You wear the necklace for her?”

Ana sniffs, nodding into my neck. “Y-yes.”

“Then you know that she’s watching you,” I tell her, hesitant to go this route of consoling. “She’s in a good place, even if we wish she were still

here. Even if it was too soon—”

“Way too soon.”

“Yes, forza,” I agree. “Far too soon.”

I don’t know much about Vivian Knight, but I know she wasn’t even forty years old. Much too young to die as a healthy woman. And from what I’ve heard, much too kind to be targeted in the way she was.

“I love my mom,” Ana whispers, her small voice cracking as she pulls back a few inches to look at me. “I can’t even process that she’s gone… that it happened like this.”

Tentatively, I reach out to brush some hair from her eyes. Her face is puffy and red, and still wet with fallen tears. “I understand.”

There’s not much else to say, and she’s heard enough *I’m sorrys* to last a lifetime.

“Do you?” she asks, a single fresh tear dripping down her cheek.

“I loved my mother too,” I reply simply.

Ana freezes, processing the statement. “I forgot yours has passed,” she admits, sniffing back her emotions. “How did she..? No one ever talks about it.” When I don’t immediately answer, she shakes her head. “Sorry, that was too personal.”

“It wasn’t,” I disagree. With a stranger, it would be. But Ana isn’t a stranger. “All of my brothers, we had complicated relationships with her. Apollo doesn’t speak about her, Matteo won’t even call her mom, and Nico hardly interacted with her while she was still alive. *That’s* why we don’t talk about it, not because it’s too sensitive or too personal.”

“Oh.”

“She wasn’t a bad mother, as far as bad mothers go,” I preface with a slight wince. Matteo might disagree with me, and that would be his right. But our mom could have been a million times worse.

“After she had Matteo, she had this weird mood shift. She told Dad she didn’t want any more kids, so their relationship was effectively over.”

“Which is how Jade came to be,” Ana concludes.

“Exactly,” I concur. “About eight years later, Apollo and Dad found her in her bathtub, both wrists slit up to her elbows.”

Ana gasps, eyes going wide with horror.

“She had a brain tumor,” I continue, not fazed by past grief. This loss was buried a long time ago. “We didn’t know, of course. No one did. For a year she went to every specialist out there, pretending to be on vacations or

shopping trips. But when every doctor she saw agreed it was terminal, she decided to end her own life before the tumor could."

"That's so sad," Ana murmurs.

"It was pretty fucked up," I admit with a shrug. "Leon was hit the hardest. He was always her favorite."

"Parents shouldn't have favorites," she grumbles like she's angry on my siblings' behalf.

"It's not always that simple," I tell her, shrugging once more. "She was raised to be a perfect mafia wife. Having babies and living a lavish life fueled her. Once that was done, so was she."

Ana frowns. "But Dante wouldn't—"

I sigh, cutting off her protest. I already know what she's trying to say. It's what everyone says. Dante Moretti wouldn't treat a wife that way.

"He wouldn't," I agree. "He *didn't*. But one man can't untangle years of conditioning. He loved her, as much as she allowed."

A man doesn't watch a beautiful woman giving him nine children and feel indifferent. That's what Dad has always said, and he meant it.

I hadn't meant to go into such detail, but the information seems to be distracting Ana from her own pain. I'll tell her as many stories as she wants if it keeps her from sobbing uncontrollably.

"He tried but it was never enough. He even tried to stop having kids after Elio and Emilio," I admit. I only know this because of Apollo.

"He was worried that the pregnancies would be too much for her but she cried and cried until he agreed to continue for as long as she wanted. Being a mother was her dream, even though she couldn't quite figure out the *loving* part."

Clearing my throat, I shake off old memories threatening to filter in. "I'm sure if you asked each of us, we'd have a different answer. But I mostly feel sorry for her—Dad too. She lived a painful life and he tried so hard to make it a good one."

"That's tragic," Ana breathes. "Even if it could have been so much worse for both of them. Arranged marriages… they're hard to predict."

"They certainly could have been dealt worse hands," I agree.

She nods solemnly. "I could have been, too. So, umm, thank you for—"

"You don't need to thank me, Ana," I remind her.

She doesn't argue, even though she looks like she wants to disagree.

“I don’t want to plan her funeral,” she eventually admits in a broken whisper. “I don’t think I can.”

“I can do it.”

Her wet eyes burst open. “You would do that?”

“I’ll work with Gerard on it,” I tell her seriously. “All you’ll need to do is attend. I’ll take care of it all.”

Her breath shutters and she tucks herself closer to me. “You promise?”

“I promise, Ana.” Brushing some dark strands that cling to her face away, I softly wipe away her tears. “You don’t need to worry about a thing.”

“T-thank you,” she croaks. “Anything for Cole should be Killian’s decision. I think he wanted to be cremated, but I can’t possibly do that before he’s awake, can I? Can his body be stored for that long?”

“I’ll make sure of it.”

I understand why she wants to get all of this out now, it’s probably the thing that’s bothering her the most at the moment. If she purges her worries, there’s a chance that she’ll experience a bit of the relief she so desperately needs.

“Agnes will be here in the morning. Does she know?”

I don’t tell her that it *is* the morning. Probably around four or four-thirty. But the sun isn’t up, so I know what she means.

“Gerard contacted her,” I start to explain. “We told her to take time off, if she needed it, or if she was scared to come in. She insisted on coming to take care of you, though she promised to give you space.”

I won’t have this woman making my wife cry, even accidentally. She can see Ana if Ana requests it, and she can cook for her, but I will not allow her to burst in here and make anything worse.

“I hope she’s nice to you,” Ana says in a small voice. “She can be a bit overprotective sometimes.”

Oh, you poor thing… you haven’t seen overprotective yet.

But you will.

“I can handle it,” I assure her, watching as her eyes become heavy. “Get some more sleep, hmm? I’ll be right here.”

“In the bed?” Ana asks, grasping me by the wrist.

“If you want me here.”

She breathes out, nodding. “Don’t leave.”

Never.

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Chapter Fifteen



Ana

I spend the next three days in and out of sleep, hardly ever getting out of bed. Cassio brings me food throughout the day, and checks on me periodically. At night, he holds me while I slumber, his presence keeping the nightmares at bay.

Today is the day that my streak of numbly lying in bed comes to an end—at least for now. Staring at my reflection, I wonder how I was able to black out for long enough to shower and do my hair. My slicked back high ponytail isn't as flawless as I would typically make it, probably due to the fact that I half-arsed dried my hair, but I refuse to do it over.

As it is, I'm not putting on any makeup, opting for a blacked out pair of designer sunglasses instead. They'll go nicely with my Dolce & Gabbana dress. The garment that has been sitting in the back of my closet unworn, has a similar fit to my wedding gown, actually. Though it fits well, and looks nice, I'd do anything to get back into my pajamas.

Alas, pajamas simply won't do for a funeral.

Sunglasses and heels in hand, I leave my bedroom with my head down, dreading the event to come. Cassio will be with me, and he'll keep me afloat, I think. But I don't want to go either way. A funeral is final. It means that my mother truly isn't coming back. She's going in the ground.

Voices find me before I've even made it down the stairs.

"Straighten your tie, you neanderthal."

A grunt followed by a muted slapping noise catches my ear.

"You need therapy, my tie is fine."

“Show up looking like you were just caught in a tornado, then, see if I care.” The words are huffed.

“Oh, you’ll care. I won’t hear the end of it for months.”

“So fix your fucking tie then!”

“You fix it, Lord Perfectionist.”

Despite the bickering, I find the parties responsible grinning at each other. Armani’s tattooed hands are carefully straightening Colton’s black cotton tie. They’re both wearing identical suits, but Colton sports a spotless black cowboy hat on top of his head, while Armani wears a six-figure watch around his wrist.

“You guys are coming?” I ask, alerting them to my presence.

“Of course we are,” Armani answers immediately, watching softly as I approach. “You’re my sister now, Ana. We wouldn’t miss it.”

My heart squeezes at the sincerity in his tone.

Colton nods in agreement. “You haven’t been up for company yet—understandable, of course—but you’ll see soon enough. We’re going to be best friends.”

I actually have been up for company. Quiet company, I mean, but being in my room alone all day has quickly gotten lonely. I haven’t wanted to bother anyone by requesting companionship. If they genuinely want to be friends though…

“I’ve actually been thinking about joining you both in the living room sometimes,” I admit quietly. “If that would be okay—”

“Hell yeah, doll,” Colton interrupts. “Join us any time. I could use a break from this one’s pestering. He’ll be nicer to me if we have company.”

“I’m a delight,” Armani argues, smacking his friend’s chest with the back of his hand. “You’re just a slob. Leaving your socks on the floor like you were raised in a barn.”

“I was raised on a ranch, it’s practically the same thing,” Colton quips, smirking like irritating Armani is one of his greatest joys.

Their easy banter makes it hard to feel glum, admittedly. Perhaps spending more time with the two of them will be good for me.

“Are the two of you done harassing my wife?”

Cassio’s deep voice sends a shiver down my spine, and my head spins around to find him standing nearby. He’s dressed impeccably in all black, looking undeniably handsome.

“Harassing is a strong word,” Armani sasses. “We’re mingling.”

“Sure you are,” Cassio drawls. “Tell them to fuck off if they start to give you a headache, *forza*.”

My cheeks flame under his attention, feeling a warmth radiate in my stomach at hearing his nickname for me. I still don’t know very much about my husband, but he’s been holding me in bed every night, and I find myself already growing too attached. I crave his presence, so much so that I become agitated in the absence of it.

I know he’s working while he’s gone, taking care of Killian’s people, but I still wish he could be with me all day. I don’t feel like screaming and crying when he’s by my side, fueling me with his strength.

“Oh!” Colton suddenly exclaims. “Before we go, we have a gift for you. Let me call him.”

Call *him?*

I don’t have time to ask what he means before he moves.

Colton puts two fingers to his lips and blows out a sharp whistle. Following the noise like a command, a fully grown Doberman with sleek black fur and light brown markings trots up to his side.

“This is Sirius, and he’s yours now,” he tells me, a small grin playing on his lips. “He’s an expertly trained protector and I’ve picked him out just for you. He’ll suit your needs just fine, I think.”

Gaping at him in shock, I’m at a loss for words.

“What…” I look back at Cassio, receiving a clipped nod that tells me he’s in on this. Eyes back on Colton, I blink twice. “You got me a dog?”

His chuckle is warm. “Sirius isn’t just a dog, he’s a guard. He’ll attack on command, watch out for you, and keep you company. He’s a very smart boy.”

“You seem familiar with him,” I comment, still digesting the fact that I’m being gifted a living creature. I’ve never had a pet before.

“My mother trained him,” he informs me with a smile, reaching down to pet behind the dog’s ear. “She takes in abused attack dogs and trains them properly. Sirius is one of her best students and we’ve been keeping him for the right family.”

“And you think that’s *me?*” I bristle. “I’ve never even taken care of a *goldfish*. He’s a lot bigger than a fish in a little bowl. I… what do I even do with him? I’m in bed nearly all day, barely alive myself. How can I commit to taking care of him? What if he hates me? I—”

“Whoa, whoa, whoa,” Colton cuts in, hearing the beginning of panic in my tone. “Armani and I are going to help you with the transition, I promise it’s not as complicated as you’re imagining. He’s here to make your life easier, not more difficult.”

“I… are you sure?”

“Sure as sure gets, doll.” Colton nods encouragingly and extends his hand, palm up. “Here, give me your hand.”

Nervously, I step closer and put my outstretched fingers into his. Trying not to startle me, he moves slowly, guiding my hand down to Sirius. Immediately, he begins to sniff me, taking in my scent with enthusiasm. His short tail wags and he licks his lips, sniffing harder. The little huffs of warm air from his nose touch my skin and I withhold a nervous shiver.

“*La jefa*, Sirius,” Colton tells the dog, speaking the command in Spanish.

The dog’s ears perk up and he licks my hand before doing an excited spin around me. Once he’s circled my body, he plops down into a seated position at my side, like he was previously stationed next to Colton.

“Does he only speak Spanish?” I ask while warily petting his soft head.

“Only for permanent commands. I assigned him to you, he knows that you’re his owner now. He knows everything you’ll need in English. Sit, stay, speak, run, attack, guard, and so on.”

“Won’t he get bored with me? Sitting here all day?”

The cowboy chuckles. “He won’t mind. He’ll cuddle with you if you let him, he’s a big softy at heart. But don’t worry about him getting his energy out. Armani and I will walk and run him daily, when Cassio is here with you so that you always have someone close.”

“You’re sure?” I bite my lip in contemplation. “I don’t want to be even more of a burden.”

“Pshhh,” he makes the dismissive sound and waves me off. “You’re not a burden, Ana. We’re friends now, remember? And besides, we all love dogs. You will, too.”

“I suppose he is very cute,” I admit shyly, kneeling down to get a closer look at my new friend. “Do you want to stay here with me, hmm?”

Like he can understand the question, Sirius nudges my face with his head happily.

“I think that’s a yes,” Colton says smugly.

I nod, giving Sirius a few more pets before standing back up. “Does he have, like, food and stuff? Do we need to buy him anything?”

“Got it all covered, don’t you worry your pretty little head about it.”

“He’s coming with us,” Armani adds. “He’s going to be an additional pair of eyes and ears, aren’t you boy?”

“It’s time,” Cassio cuts in, attaching himself to my unoccupied side. His arm carefully wraps around my waist, and his sweet manly cologne attacks my senses. He always smells this way, like masculine vanilla.

“Are you ready?” he asks, voice low and lips inches from my ear.

Gulping, I nod breathlessly. “I just need to put on my shoes.”

Without being asked, Cassio drops to one knee, taking my heels along with him. He lifts my right ankle first, slipping my foot into the simple black shoe. His hands are roughly calloused, but somehow soft as well. I hold my breath as he sets my leg down and meticulously takes the other. Once both shoes are in place, I release a silent sigh and try not to stare at him as he stands back to his full height.

I shouldn’t be so enraptured by him. We’re married, but only days ago we were hardly more than strangers. Only a week ago, I had Cole… but Cassio calls to me in some kind of hypnotic way that I can’t seem to resist.

“Well, you two are getting along well,” Armani muses, pulling me out of my trance. The man is smirking like the cat who got the cream, looking between Cassio and me with a mischievous glint in his eye.

My husband clears his throat and threads my arm through his. “Let’s go. They won’t start without us, but it’s bad form to be late.”

True to Colton’s word, Sirius follows beside me as soon as we begin to move. And like some kind of coordinated celebrity security effort, Cassio, Colton, and Armani lead me out of the penthouse. Gerard is waiting for us in the lobby, and he joins in the formation effortlessly. No one says a word until we’re secured in the SUV, with Armani taking the driver’s seat.

While we make our way to the church, Colton begins telling me about Sirius and what commands mean to him. By the time we arrive, I’ve got a wealth of dog knowledge spinning around in my head. Most of which flies to the back of my mind as soon as we step inside the building.

High ceilings painted with Renaissance style art, textured stone columns, and stained glass windows all draw my eye as Cassio leads me through the pews. I’ve never been inside this place before, but it’s lovely.

Flowers are spread all over the place, and are piled high atop a white, glossy casket that sits in the center of the raised stage.

Cassio watches my eyes scanning the room. “Everything all right, Ana?”

“This cathedral is beautiful,” I tell him softly.

He couldn’t have picked a more scenic location.

“Everything is perfect. My mother would have loved it all—the flowers especially.” Blue daffodils are her favorites, she’s snuck them into more than a few of her paintings. “You did so well, thank you, Cassio.”

“It was my pleasure.” He lifts our intertwined hands to kiss the tops of my knuckles. “You never need to thank me for caring for you.”

No one should be this swoony at a funeral.

We take our seat in the first pew, Colton and Armani flanking our sides while Sirius sits just in front of my feet.

“Guard,” I tell the Doberman, using the command I was taught in the car. He’ll keep his eyes open and ears on alert now but remain silent near me unless there’s trouble he needs to notify me about.

Only a few minutes pass before the service begins. I’m pleasantly surprised to see Father Charles in his robes, standing in front of the audience. He’s the Reverend of my mother’s preferred Catholic Church, and he baptized her himself about twenty years ago. She’d attended his services every time she was in New York for work, and always wished he could be in England while she was home.

Cassio truly pulled out all the stops, and it has me wondering where the bloody hell he possibly found all of this information. He must have researched endlessly to make today as meaningful as he could. Looking at his hand, I squeeze it and sit as close as I can, our shoulders rubbing together.

Cassio squeezes me in return, letting me know he’s got my back.

“We are here today to pay tribute and respects to a woman of God, our sister, Vivian Knight…” Father Charles begins.

Though I’m glad he is here, I tune out most of what the Priest says, staring longingly at my mother’s shiny white casket instead. It’s closed, just as she would have wanted. I’m not sure how Cassio knew her preference, because he didn’t ask me. In fact, he didn’t bother me with a single question about today. He handled it all on his own, and seemingly nailed every detail.

Once the reverend has delivered a homily, and a sermon, he mentions his own memories of my mother. Her art and her passion for the church. Though I have never shared her faith, I feel lightened by hearing about it. Like perhaps she truly is in a place of beauty and peace now.

“Now, I’d like to invite Cassio Moretti to say a few words.”

I barely withhold a gasp, watching in awe as my husband stands. He shares a handshake with Father Charles and doesn’t waste a moment longer before addressing the crowd.

“Vivian May Knight was a woman of many roles. An artist with a passion for philanthropy, a connoisseur of French cuisine, and most prominently, a loving mother. It is with great sadness and regret, that I admit I never had the pleasure of meeting the woman whose life we are celebrating here today. So, while I can’t attest to her character in a personal manner, I can speak about her through what I know to be her greatest pride —her daughter.”

My throat tightens up, hot tears gathering in my eyes.

“Vivian raised the strongest, kindest, and most thoughtful woman I have the pleasure of calling my wife. The qualities we instill in those closest to us, are one of the truest testaments of our integrity and honor. It is without question that Vivian carried a distinction of excellence that many of us strive for. She will be tremendously missed, and I wish her nothing but peace in her life beyond this world. Thank you.”

A round of polite applause rings out as my face becomes wet, tears falling down from behind my shaded glasses.

My husband returns to his seat next to me, immediately threading his fingers through mine.

“That was lovely, Cassio,” I whisper. Leaning closer, a drop a light kiss to his cheek and quickly retract. If I say anything else, or look at him any longer, I might just throw myself into his lap to sob.

He has made this day unequivocally exceptional. I didn’t need to lift a finger, and he somehow delivered a funeral that I know my mother would simply adore. Cassio has once again made it impossible for me not to feel captivated by him and his ability to care for me.

The proceedings end quickly after his speech, and we don’t stick around to hear any sympathies. I would not be able to handle it.

When we finally return home, I skip lunch. Being in public was exhausting and strangely anxiety-inducing. I’d never been one to feel

uncomfortable around large groups of people before, but something about it set me on edge. Pulling off my dress and changing into a set of sweats, I climb into bed, determined to take a long nap.

Sirius is with me, standing at the foot of my bed. When I look down at him, he tilts his head at me waiting for instruction. Not at all sure what I should do, I look at the space next to me and shrug. “Do you want to come up?”

As soon as the question rolls off of my tongue, he springs into the bed with me, flopping his head down on my extra pillow. A laugh bubbles out of me before I can stop it.

“You really are a big softy, aren’t you?”

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Chapter Sixteen



Ana

The next month goes by at a glacial pace. It's filled mostly with crying, nightmares, and being coerced to eat and drink regularly.

It's not all bad, though. I've taken to spending my days in the living room with Colton and Armani, watching movies and curling up on the couch. The two of them provide company without forcing me to join in on their many conversations. Armani *does* compel me to drink water regularly, apparently taking hydration more seriously than anyone else I know.

They're nice, though. They treat Agnes with respect and thank her every time that she cooks for not only me, but them as well. She even cooks for them when I'm not eating, and asks them if they have requests for meals. I think it's her way of showing me that she's here for me, since I haven't been up for much conversation with her.

Agnes has always been a great addition to my life. She's an excellent cook, a meticulous cleaner, and a dedicated listening ear. But Agnes also doted on Cole as much as she did on me. So when I'm looking at her, it unfortunately only makes me think of him more.

It's a strange sort of ache when he crosses my mind. I feel his loss as thickly as I did the night that it happened, but my heart doesn't long for him. I'm not brokenhearted in the way that a woman typically would be after losing a spouse. I miss him as a dear friend, as someone I cared for. And mourn him as a man who died well before his time. I don't understand it, or, I don't want to admit that I understand it.

Sometimes I think I don’t have a right to grieve him at all, since I clearly didn’t care for him as much as he cared for me. I couldn’t even return his declaration of love before he was murdered. *What kind of person does that make me?*

I try not to dwell on it.

I want to get better. I’m sick and tired of crying induced headaches, feeling my stomach protest every time I go too long without food, having dry skin from not showering enough, and I’m exhausted from feeling so endlessly miserable. I need to focus on the good rather than the bad.

Killian is still in a coma, but according to the doctors, that’s not necessarily a bad thing. His body needs time to properly recover, and he would have died if they hadn’t gotten to him sooner. I’m not sure how much longer he’ll remain unconscious, but they’ve assured Cassio that he still shows brain activity.

He’s had multiple surgeries on his heart, and blood transfusions as well. Though he’s not technically allowed visitors, Cassio has said that he would take me to see him if I wanted. I can’t bear the thought of seeing my rock of a stepbrother in that condition though. Killian has always been the strongest of The Knights, and I don’t want to have any more disastrous memories of him.

And Killian doing well isn’t the only good thing in my life. Cassio has been a consistent light at the end of my dark and despairing days. He’s quickly become a friend like I’ve never had before. He’s stable and caring, always checking on me and spending any free time he has in my company. He’s a rock to crash against, and a soft pillow for me to lay my head at night, all at the same time.

Currently he’s in a meeting with The King’s Court, but he should be home in just a couple of hours. In the meantime, I’m bundled up on the sofa, half paying attention to the horror movie on screen and half focused on petting Sirius. He just got back from a run with Colton and Armani, so he’s gotten all of his energy out and is content to just laze about with me.

The Knight Family penthouse is quite cozy despite its dark aesthetic. Perhaps it’s simply because I’ve lived here for long enough for it to feel welcoming, but the rich leather furniture and black wood floors don’t project the coldness one might expect. It’s warm and inviting, possibly due to the faux fur blankets I have scattered around at all times. To a room, texture is able to add just as much as color can.

Finished freshening up, Armani and Colton join me in the living room with damp hair and clean clothes. Showering is always required when they return from running with Sirius. They make sure that they get as good of a work out as the dog does, apparently.

Armani drops down on the cushion closest to me. “Hey, have you heard of a Glen Tilton?”

My brows scrunch. *What the hell does that arsehole want?*

“Why?”

“Johnathan at the front desk said he was down there throwing a fit today, demanding to speak with you.”

“Did he tell him to get fucked?”

Chuckling, Armani arches a brow. “Not in so many words, but he’s gone, yes. Who is he, exactly? Should Colton and I pay him a little visit?”

“He’s an art collector, and a first class tosser,” I grumble. “He’s obsessed with my mum’s work and has been trying to buy her personal collection for years.”

Her personal paintings are mostly locked away in her art room here, while some live at the London apartment. They’re pieces that meant too much to my mother to possibly sell, and ones Bron bought for her to keep.

A darkness pools in Armani’s eyes. “So now that she’s gone, he’s trying to get to them through you? Not even a month after?” The edge in his voice is vicious, the kind of tone that would make a lesser man piss himself.

“I can’t see why else he would be here,” I huff, trying not to frown. I won’t allow this tactless git to make me sad. My anger is all he will get. “I hope Johnathan flagged his name to security. I don’t want him anywhere near this place. He probably gets a hard-on just knowing he’s in the same building as *Vivian May Knight’s* unpublished works.”

I’m no stranger to people fawning over my mother’s art. She’s extremely well-known in England and in the States. Her unique, flowery takes on Renaissance-style art have been talked about for decades now. She painted breathtaking scenery, detailed humanistic characters, and commanded color in such a distinct way. After all, her art is what drew Bron to her originally, and how they bonded before becoming involved.

But fans like Glen Tilton are why people dislike fame. He’s needy and borderline stalker-ish. He takes fixation to an ugly level. There wasn’t a gallery show he didn’t attend. And of course, simply viewing the paintings

was never enough for him. He needed to speak with the artist, to try and get inside her mind and feed his fascination.

My mother was often too polite to chastise the man for crossing boundaries, but I've made my ire for him quite clear. He's had to keep his distance since Bron came into our lives, likely because he was confronted by The Kings at some point—though I don't know for certain.

"He'll be dealt with," Armani vows.

I open my mouth to ask what exactly he means by the declaration, but Colton shouts before I can get the words out.

"Holy fuck!"

Armani and I both whip our gazes to the man, finding him covering half of his face with a pillow.

"Are you guys watching this shit?" He pants, gesturing to the TV wildly. "Dude just got his fucking arm ripped off by a demon!"

A giggle bubbles up in my chest. "Are you scared?"

"Scared? I'm thinking about the sake of my eternal soul!" Colton proclaims dramatically. "I do not claim this energy. I rebuke it. Demons can *not* have my arm, or any part of me."

Armani rolls his eyes. "Excuse him, his grandmother told him that Satan tries to reach us through everything. Scarred him at the ripe age of five, and now anything demon related makes him weird."

"You're in the mafia," I point out, brows furrowing. "Isn't doing sinful, *criminal* work, also attracting Satan?"

"He doesn't even go to church." Armani laughs, tossing his friend a smirk. "It's just one of his many adorable little quirks. Fear of demons, how precious."

"Don't flirt with me, you prick," Colton grumbles. "When a demon rips your arm off and leaves me alone, you'll be sorry."

"I can see why people at Empire thought you were secretly dating," I tease, smiling at the pair of them. "You bicker like an old married couple."

"*As if,*" Colton scoffs.

"We would never work," Armani adds good-naturedly.

"Because you're too much alike?" I guess, arching a brow.

The cowboy grins. "More than you know."

"Let's just say, Colton and I both need the same things, and neither of us possess those things."

"She's not a child, you can speak plainly."

“Who says she wants us to over-share—”

“We both like to be in charge,” Colton cuts him off. “Plus, neither of us are versatile.”

“And there’s the small issue of Colton being in love with my brother.”

My eyes bulge, and the man in question gasps. “You tattletale!”

“Your fault, you’re the one who started over-sharing.”

Before they can continue to jeer at each other, I reach over and pat Armani’s arm lightly. “Thank you.” My quiet words catch both of their attention and my eyes meet Colton’s. “Both of you.”

Eyes soft, Armani asks, “For what?”

“You guys are really good at lightening up my days,” I admit. “It feels like life isn’t so horrible every time I’m around you.”

Well, them, *and* Cassio.

“No need to thank us, doll,” Colton replies, smiling wide. “We like hanging out with you.”

“We do,” Armani agrees.

I don’t detect a hint of dishonesty, and my chest warms with happiness. I’ve never been great at making friends, but it feels incredibly natural with these two. I think the only thing that could make it better, would be if Jade were here with us.

“Pizza for you lot,” Agnes announces, bustling into the room.

She’s carrying two steaming trays of large pizza she’s been making for the past hour. Homemade dough, slathered in her famous marinara sauce, layered with fresh mozzarella, and two different combinations of toppings.

One with Italian sausage, peppers, onions, and mushrooms. The other—my preferred kind—with spinach, chicken, and garlic.

“Agnes, you gem,” Colton hoots, jumping up to help her put the food down. “It smells fantastic.”

She smiles at his manners and dusts her hands off. “You boys eat as much as you want, I’ve got a third in the oven now.”

“You’re the best, thank you,” Armani pipes up.

“Save some for Cassio,” I remind them, watching as both of them grab a plate and two slices to start.

“Oooo, save some for Cassio, she says,” Colton teases, waggling his eyebrows. “Aren’t you a sweet little wife.”

Not yet, I think sadly. *But one day.*

Cassio has more than earned my loyalty, and though it scares me, I don’t think it will be long before he earns my affection as well.

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Chapter Seventeen



Cassio

In the month and a week since her mother's funeral, I've become completely and utterly obsessed with my wife. When I'm not with her, I'm thinking about her, wondering what she's doing and how she's feeling. If I'm not wondering about her, I'm watching her. Either in real time through the Knight's security footage to check in, or scrolling through her social media just to see her face.

Her Instagram is full of old videos and pictures, all of them featuring her smiling face. It's a mixed bag of club openings, night life, fashion events, and more sedate charity galas. I've seen clips of her dancing with friends while neon lights flash around, and perfectly poised photos of her shaking hands with pillars of the community.

She hasn't posted anything new, of course. I honestly don't know if she's even bothered to scroll through her timelines. Though, Jade took the liberty of posting our wedding photos and tagging Ana in them, so everyone is quite aware that Ana Knight is now Ana Moretti. I do hope that my wife will continue to update her social media eventually, for my own benefit. I don't think I'm going to tire of seeing her face on my phone any time soon. Perhaps I should start taking my own pictures of her, and keeping an album of candids all to myself.

As much as I like seeing Ana in photos and videos, nothing compares to watching her in person. Seeing her eyes light with relief when I join her to sleep at night, and observing the way she hides smiles while Colton and Armani squabble. Every single reaction, no matter how subtle, catches my

eye. Her existence alone is utterly fascinating, and I'm self-aware enough to admit that I've become addicted.

We haven't shared more than gentle, comforting touches and soft words, but I feel more connected to Ana than I could have ever expected. I dread having to leave her each morning, but running The Kings have proven to be quite taxing. Even with Gerard's assistance, it's a tedious task to keep the men in line. Not to mention our search for the group responsible for attacking the Knight family.

Interviewing Ana about the events of that wretched night was perhaps the worst time we've spent together, but she understood the necessity of it. With descriptions of the men responsible, I'm better able to search for any intel I need to figure out who they are, and why they've done what they've done. I still felt like an absolute asshole when Ana didn't leave her room for two days following the questioning.

She's been in better spirits lately, for the most part. But as I come home from a long day of combing through The Kings' records, I know today isn't going to be one of her good days. There's a somberness in the air, and I sense that something must be wrong before I even find Armani and Colton. They're both drinking tumblers of amber colored liquor, sharing concerned expressions.

"What's wrong?" I ask, eyes immediately searching for Ana around the common area. "Where is she?"

Armani swallows a thick gulp of whiskey. "She's in Cole's room."

My heart drops. "Shit."

"She's been in there for hours," Colton mutters sadly.

"Not even crying," Armani continues, shaking his head. "She's just on his bed, staring at the wall. She didn't want to come out."

Blowing out a breath, I rub a hand down my face. "Fuck. Did she say anything at all?"

"Just that she wanted to be alone. We sat with her for a while, but I guess it was too much," Armani explains.

Rolling my neck, I shrug off my jacket and fold my shirt sleeves up, determined. "I'll go talk to her."

Colton gives me a hesitant look. "You sure?"

"He'll make it better," Armani answers for me. "Won't you, Cass?"

My head dips in a firm nod. "I've got her."

Seeing the two of them care for my wife, and slowly growing a friendship with her has been easier than I expected. I've become quite possessive of Ana, and if I could steal away all her time for myself, I would. But Armani and Colton don't set off any threatening alarms for me.

Despite Armani's reputation for sleeping with any pretty thing with a beating heart, he's an extremely loyal brother. He'd never go after any of our wives or even women we were simply interested in. And I'm ninety-nine percent sure that Colton is gay with a capital G. I've never seen the man with a woman, or even checking one out, though I think most people assume he's bisexual like Armani.

But that southern gentleman, manly appearance thing doesn't fool me. Gay men come in all shapes and sizes. I mean, look at my brother Nico. He's fit, menacingly unapproachable, certifiably psychotic, and he's been out since he was twelve. He didn't even attempt to hide it. Uncle Cesar asked Nico about a girl he'd seen talking to him at a dinner event, and Nico simply told him. I remember that day so clearly, hearing the family dinner table come to a halt with five words.

I'd rather have her brother.

After the initial shock wore off, Uncle Cesar and Dad both gave him nods of approval. Armani then welcomed him into the *Queer Moretti Club*—which Nico held no interest in joining. And no one has thought twice about it since. He doesn't bring men around, so I'm unsure whether he's even attempted to be with one, but that's his business.

On to more pressing matters, I all but run up the stairs to get to Ana. The need to make sure that she's okay before I begin to spiral.

Sure enough, I find her exactly how my brother described. Sitting back against Cole's headboard, hugging a pillow to her chest, and staring at the wall blankly. She's left the door open, and she doesn't move her gaze when I enter. She continues to sit there, motionlessly, even as I come closer.

Toeing off my shoes, I climb up next to her, legs extended and back against the upholstered bed's head.

"Thinking about him today?"

Mutely, her chin dips.

"Do you want to talk about him?"

Ana doesn't immediately reply. Instead, I listen as she takes four soft breaths. In and out, relaxed and slow.

"I shouldn't."

“Why not, *forza*?”

Her lip trembles. “You’re my husband. I shouldn’t speak about my ex-boyfriend, it’s bad form, even if our marriage isn’t real.”

My hand flexes into a fist, and I have to force my voice to remain controlled when I reply. “Our marriage is *very* real, Ana. I told you as much on our wedding day.”

“O-okay,” she breathes, likely taken back by my stern tone.

“And as for what you should or shouldn’t speak about. I don’t give a shit what’s *bad form* or not. I’m a widow, Ana. Your boyfriend was killed in front of you. We’re bound to speak of them. It’s healthy to communicate when things are on our mind, even if it’s hard or uncomfortable.”

There’s a difference between dwelling on the past and making your partner uncomfortable, and needing your spouse to support you when you’re feeling emotionally vulnerable. Ana could talk to me for hours about her relationship with Cole Knight, and it wouldn’t change a thing for me. He’s gone, and I’m here now. If she needs to get her feelings out in the open, I’ll always be ready to listen.

“Cole scared me at first,” she admits, biting her lip. “When I met him.”

“Did he?” I ask, relieved that she’s changed her mind about talking.

“He didn’t hide how much he was drawn to me. He was utterly obsessed from the minute we met. He wouldn’t take his eyes off of me and I had no idea how to deal with it.”

I had heard as much from Jade in the past, not that it frightened Ana, but that Cole was immensely infatuated with her.

“The mafia thing was still a shock. I mean, this boy who I knew could kill a man without blinking wanted me and how on earth does anyone hear that and not feel a bit frightened?”

“It’s understandable,” I agree.

“I shouldn’t have let my fear keep me away from him for so long,” she mutters, picking at her nails. It’s a bad fidgeting habit, but at least her eyes have finally left the wall. “I could have had more time with him, if I wasn’t so hesitant. Who am I to mourn his death when I barely let him have me before he was ripped away?”

“You loved him, Ana,” I try to reason.

“But I didn’t!” she cries out, startling me. “I-I was starting to, I think. I c-could have, but I didn’t love Cole, I didn’t.”

She’s beginning to cry now, eyes welling up with moisture as she faces me. I want to reach out and cradle her face, to catch the tears before they begin to truly fall.

“Ana…”

“No, no, no, it’s all my fault.”

“It’s not,” I insist.

“I can’t stop crying all the time, and this ache won’t go away, and worst of all I feel like some kind of grief fraud,” Ana whispers, her voice cracking with emotion.

“Everyone deals with it differently,” I begin, trying to comfort her. She shuts me down with a stiff shake of her head.

“It’s not that, it’s just—” she sniffs, trying to find the words. “I feel like I’ve lost everyone, and I nearly have… but I—”

“Take your time,” I tell her encouragingly, threading our hands together. Her skin is warm and soft, even as a storm brews in her sorrow-filled eyes. “There’s no rush, just breathe, love.”

She takes a few moments to collect herself, breathing as I hold her fingers between mine, feeling her heartbeat in her thumb slow from erratic to steady.

“I just feel like a bit of a cunt crying all the time when what you went through was so much worse,” she admits, her chin trembling.

“Ana, no,” I try to cut in, to tell her that she shouldn’t compare tragedies but she refuses to hear it.

“You lost your wife, your *child*,” she croaks. “I lost Cole and my mom. Cole and I had barely been dating. And my mom, I loved her so much, but children always lose their parents eventually. I know that, that’s how the blasted circle of life fucking works but I—”

“Stop,” I try to interrupt again and her shoulders shake.

“I can’t stop, don’t you get it?” she wails. “I’m a mess and I don’t know how to make it better. I hate feeling this way and the frustration is only making it worse. How do you stop yourself from being so upset that you’re only making it worse by thinking about being so upset all the time? What the bleeding fuck am I supposed to do, Cassio?”

I react without warning, snaking my arms underneath hers, wrapping them around her waist and pulling her in tight. Legs straddle mine, and I crush her front into my chest. Her shoulders slump and she cries into my neck, accepting the embrace.

“You’re supposed to lean on me,” I tell her firmly, rubbing soothing circles on the center of her back. “You feel whatever you need to feel for however long you need to feel it, but you don’t do it alone. You come to me, and I make it better.”

“I don’t deserve it,” she protests. “You’re still sad, too. I know it. You don’t cry and lie in bed all day, you just deal with it. And now you have to deal with me on top of it.”

When I get my hands on the people responsible for doing this to my wife, I’m going to channel every bit of my brother Nico in dealing with them. They’ve flayed her open in one of the most horrific ways, and putting her back together again isn’t going to be easy.

She’s so empathetic and compassionate, of course she feels guilty for things that can’t possibly be her fault. She’s too young—too good to understand the complex cruelties this world can inflict on us without warning. It makes me want to tear the city apart—rip it open, find all those who would wish her harm and turn them into ash.

I knew coming into this that it wouldn’t be easy, I knew comforting her in her time of need would tug on old wounds for me. But I did it anyway, and I don’t regret it.

Stroking the back of her hair, I try to coax her into calming down.

“You are just twenty years old, Ana. You lost your mother and the boy you were falling in love with on the same day. Your stepbrother who you care deeply for is in a coma, and you’re married to a man you’re just starting to know. You have every right to be as broken as you need to be.”

“*But Cassio,*” she cries.

I shush her gently, holding her tighter to my chest. “I was twenty-seven when I lost Isobel and Angel. Seven years older than you are now, and *surrounded* by family to help me through it. Yes, it was horrible and I wouldn’t wish it on anyone. But you shouldn’t compare our grief and make yourself feel badly for crying and lashing out more than I did. Our circumstances couldn’t have been more different.”

I don’t mention that I was also born and raised as a made man. I was taught from a young age that horrific shit like this could happen. She wasn’t. She was raised like an ordinary girl and thrust into this life. Of course she’s taking this hard. I’d be more worried about her if she weren’t.

“We deal with agony differently, *forza.* I may not have spent hours on end crying, but I tried to get myself killed more than once. I know it’s hard

to hear, but all that matters now is moving forward. You're not going to feel this way forever. You'll always remember, but the pain dulls. I swear, it really does."

Just as I finish speaking, a piercing ring bursts from the phone in my pocket. I'd hit decline immediately on the call, if I didn't recognize the sound to be massively important.

"Ana—" I start.

She leans back in my lap, sniffing and wiping at her face with the back of her hands. "It's fine, you can answer it."

Before she can get off of me, I grab her by the front of her thighs. "Don't leave. If this is what I think it is, I want you close."

Her throat bobs, and I reach for my phone before waiting for a reply.

"Cassio," I tell the caller shortly.

A quick sputtering of words over the line confirms my suspicions.

"Yes," I speak clearly. "Yes. We'll be there shortly, standby."

"What was that?" Ana asks as soon as I hang up.

I make sure to watch her face as I finally deliver a piece of good news.

"Killian is awake."

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Chapter Eighteen



Ana

My heart is racing so fast, like a high-powered drum pounding in my chest. My trainers slap against the cement tile floors, my steps echoing through the secret hospital's walls. Several guards send cautious looks my way but I ignore them all, rushing to the room where my stepbrother is meant to be.

Cassio tries to get me to slow down—*there's no need to hurry*, he insists. But there is. I need to see this with my own two eyes. I can't believe the news that Killian is out of his coma until I see him. I can feel my husband following behind me, and though he makes no move to stop me, he doesn't match my pace either.

His words from nearly twenty minutes ago ring in my head on a loop. *Killian is awake.*

Killian is awake.

Killian.

Is.

Awake.

When we pulled into the secret facility's parking lot, I jumped out of the car so fast that I almost forgot to ask where to go. Cassio indulged me by giving me quick directions and escorting me from behind. I didn't even bother to take in the sunset, or the fresh air around us. I'd been cooped up in the penthouse for the entire month, and still held no interest in the outdoors. It felt entirely unimportant, as my mind was on one thing alone.

Hell, the entire car ride here was a messy blur.

I nearly trip over my own feet as I swing into the proper room. My eyes snap to the medical bed and the biggest wave of relief hits me like lightning. There he is, sitting up with his eyes open—rather than lying down unconscious and bleeding like last time I saw him. Emotion consumes me and my eyes pool with tears. Tears of joy, for a change.

A sob bursts from my lips. “*Oh thank God.*”

My brother is alive. The coma didn’t kill him.

He fought through his injuries and he resisted the sweet call of death. I practically fling myself across the room, barreling right into the man’s bed. He grunts as we slam together, my arms surrounding his shoulders, fingers digging into the skin of his neck.

“Fuck, Ana,” he hisses in pain. He doesn’t push me away though, he grabs me in return, holding me in a tight embrace. “You didn’t want to take it easy on me, did you?”

“I t-thought you’d n-never wake up,” I confess in a cry. “I h-hoped but—”

“Hey now, love,” he mumbles softly. “Don’t get so worked up, your old man over there is glaring daggers at me. You’re supposed to be keeping your stress in check.”

Stunned, I pull back to look at him. Up close, I notice how sunken in his eyes are, despite the amused sparkle they currently hold. He’s very obviously still weak from recovery, and throwing myself against him was probably not the smartest move on my part.

“How do you know—” I cut myself off, sputtering. *How does he know I’m married to Cassio? How does he know about my stress?*

“What?” Killian asks, lips quirking. “You didn’t think your husband would explain himself to me? He chatted my ear off more than once while I was knocked out. Apparently the rumors are true, some brains don’t turn off when your body does.”

“I knew you could hear me,” Cassio says, folding his arms as he leans a shoulder against the doorway. “I swear your fist twitched when I said I was your brother-in-law now.”

“You visited him?” I ask, throat clogging with emotion. “And spoke with him?”

Cassio shrugs, but his soft gaze isn’t nonchalant. “The doctors said it could help. Spent a few hours a week here, but didn’t want to be away from you for much longer.”

“Ouch,” Killian drawls, sarcasm dripping from the word. “A decade long friendship, thwarted by an arranged marriage. Some best mate you are, I’m putting in a complaint.”

Decade long friendship?

Best mate?

Cassio and Killian are friends?

“Complaint denied,” Cassio replies with an eye roll. “I’ve been dealing with the children you call soldiers for weeks on end. I’ve been thoroughly punished enough, thank you.”

“Oh?” Killian hikes a brow. “Has my time in a coma after nearly bleeding to death been difficult for you? You poor thing.”

“Yes, it has,” Cassio sniffs, pretending to be sincere. “Thank you for acknowledging how much strife your absence has caused me.”

“Git.” Killian chuckles.

“Layabout,” Cassio taunts.

“Oh, sod off.”

The men share a laugh and my eyes swing between my stepbrother and my husband. I’m in shock, watching the pair of them interact with such familiarity. I didn’t even know that they had met on more than one or two professional occasions, let alone that they were close enough to tease each other like this.

“How are you feeling?” I ask, shaking out of my daze. “Are you coming home soon?” The hope in my question dies when Killian shakes his head.

“My body is pretty fucked from lack of movement, and my chest is pretty vulnerable too. They won’t let me out of here just yet.”

My face falls, smile fading. “Really?”

“It’s for the best,” he says, squeezing my hand. “No one wants to see their Monarch in such a weakened state. Cassio can hold things down for a while longer.”

“Besides,” my husband speaks up. “We haven’t found the parties responsible for putting him here, and I’d prefer it if they don’t get a second shot at him before we do.”

“Aww, look at you being such a caring fucker,” Killian snarks. “Don’t want me dead? Maybe you’d be safer with me out of the way, hmm? What if I decide to come for your arse for scooping up my sister without my permission?”

“Try it,” Cassio dares.

“Absolutely not,” I cut in, glaring at them both. “No joking about harming one another, or I will lose it.”

Killian’s dark eyebrows shoot toward his hairline. “Is that so?”

“It is so,” I declare darkly. “We are family now, and you’ll bloody well act like it. You should be proud of your friend for taking such good care of me in my time of need.”

“I’m proud of *you*,” Killian counters, patting my knee.

Dumbfounded, I shake my head, thinking I must have heard him wrong. “What?”

“I’m. Proud. Of. You.”

It’s like the wind has been knocked right out of me, hearing those words.

“You did everything right, Ana. You found an ally, and you kept yourself safe. Your actions kept me alive, and you kept The Kings in order. You’re the reason they’re still being paid and can feed their families. You’re the reason I’m awake right now. Cole would be so fucking pleased with you, love. Your mother as well.”

“You know about my mum?” I croak.

“Cassio filled me in on everything while I was out, and Gerard was here to fill in the blanks when I woke,” he explains gently. “I’m so sorry that we couldn’t save her, but I know she’d be delighted that you’re still here, Ana.”

“I’m sorry that you lost your brother, and Bron too,” I murmur, my throat aching as I offer my condolences.

In a blink, we’re hugging again. Softer this time, and more comforting. Killian smells sterile like antiseptic he’s probably been cleaned with, and his hospital gown is a bit scratchy, but the embrace still feels like him.

“You don’t think Cole would be mad? That I’m with Cassio?” I rasp, voice hardly a whisper.

Killian grabs the sides of my arms, and pulls back to look me in the eye. “Cole has only ever wanted you to be happy, and to be by your side. But he’s gone, Ana. He would never want to punish you for his absence by denying you a future with someone else.”

Desperate to believe him, I swallow. “Are you sure?”

“I’m absolutely certain, love.”

“I missed you so much,” I admit, scanning his face to remember for later. His unkempt mess of dark hair, his strong jaw covered in new stubble, his deep brown eyes, and his slightly crooked smile.

He looks just the same, albeit slightly more ill than normal, but he's still my Killian. The man who's become a brother to me, the one who's never looked at me as anything other than family. The man who made my mom and me feel welcome as soon as he met us, and the one who I know will always jump to protect me at any point.

"I missed you too, little sister."

Cassio and I spend the next hour by Killian's bedside, going over his plans for the next few weeks. He's going to need some physical therapy, and experts in the cardiology field will monitor him as he begins to try more strenuous activity. He's expected to make a full recovery, but they're being cautious after such a serious injury and lengthy coma.

Eventually, it's time for us to leave him. Despite being unconscious for a month, he still needs sleep and medicine that makes him drowsy. And unfortunately, both Cassio and Killian agree that limited visits are for the best. They don't want anyone to follow me here and find him alive, and they aren't sure how long this investigation of theirs is going to take.

Killian doesn't have many more leads than Cassio. He was as surprised as everyone else that his family was made the target of some top secret hit. There was no bounty to be found, no assassins network chatter, and no rumors of money being exchanged. Still, both men remained firm in that they would find those responsible and make them suffer.

Back in the car, I sit in the passenger seat, feeling lighter. Seeing Killian awake and talking has lifted one of the many weights of sadness from my shoulders. What began as a horrid day, ended not so dreadfully.

"Why didn't you tell me that you and Killian are friends? *Best mates*, even?" I ask, looking over at my husband while he drives. We're in one of The Kings' unmarked SUVs to try and remain anonymous. It's quite dark inside, not just due to the time, but the overly tinted windows as well.

Cassio sighs. "Best mates might be a bit of an overstatement. But we attended Empire together, and we've kept in friendly contact over the years. We get drinks from time to time, and we find each other's company tolerable. I hadn't meant to keep it from you, though."

"So why did you?"

"Honestly, Ana?" He reaches toward me without taking his eyes off the road, his hand softly cradling the side of my thigh. "If you knew we were friends and he died, you wouldn't just be grieving for yourself, you'd be sad

about my loss as well. I didn't want that for you. I was only trying to spare you the pain of your empathetic heart."

"How do you do that?" I ask wondrously.

"Do what?"

"Know exactly what to do and say all the time?"

I knew from his reputation that Cassio was exceedingly bright, but he's more than just a man with a big brain. He has depths to him that I can't fully comprehend, the kind of emotional intelligence that men and women strive for and never fully achieve.

"Sometimes I think you know me better than I know myself, and I've hardly done any work to let you in," I continue before he can answer. "It's like you read my mind, and give me precisely what I need or want, before I've even realized that I need or want it."

Cassio's hand flexes around my inner thigh, causing a burst of butterflies to dance around in my stomach.

"It's easy to take care of you, *forza*," he says simply. "Don't worry about how or why, just know I'm never going to stop."

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Chapter Nineteen



Ana

The next morning, I'm jumping out of bed as soon as I hear Cassio leave. He didn't mean to, but he accidentally woke me up early when he got a phone call he didn't ignore. Eavesdropping is typically quite impolite, but in this case, I'm glad I was awake enough to listen in.

I finally have an opportunity to help him, and I'm going to take it. My stomach is in knots with nerves, but seeing Killian yesterday gave me a boost of strength. Perhaps the plan I formulated in a matter of minutes isn't the best one, and sure, I'm not extremely confident in my ability to pull it off. However, I think if I pull it off, it will be worth the stress.

Since I showered last night before climbing into bed, I don't need to wash myself again. I focus on getting my hair styled and makeup slathered on. After twenty minutes, I admire my handwork in the vanity mirror. Slicked-back high ponytail that falls down to the center of my back, smokey eyes and pink-painted lips. My face looks almost unrecognizable after weeks of going without any makeup at all. I used to wear it every single day, enjoying the ritual and the results.

That feels like a lifetime ago, now. Ever since using my disassociation skills to such an extreme on that awful night, my memory has been unreliable. Cole originally started teaching me the ability to help me deal with having such an active eidetic memory. It didn't use to bother me as a child, in fact, I loved it. Being able to remember course material in school without studying, never misplacing anything important, and always remembering important dates.

But eventually, my mind started to feel full. Like there was a capacity I had already met, and still, my brain wouldn't stop trying to stuff more material in. I would get awful, overwhelming headaches where I couldn't stop thinking. A million different topics would bubble to the surface, bothering me with loud and irrelevant thoughts. I wished so hard that I could simply shut down and make it stop.

Cole took notice, and started to help me sift through memories, and trained me to hyper-focus on one thing at a time when I needed. I was doubtful that he could have methods to truly relieve the ache I was experiencing. And yet he did.

And until I needed to fully numb myself, shoving all troubling memories into the back of my mind, it worked perfectly. I became a master of thought sorting, taking back control of my memory. But now? Things that never felt unfamiliar before do, and I feel more forgetful than ever. Part of me wishes I could blame it on the concussion, but it was hardly severe enough to cause this level of disarray.

Maybe I just need more time to heal completely.

Sighing, I straighten my shoulders and disappear into my closet, heading directly toward the dress I want. It's a long black A-line with a plunging neckline, open back, and a deep slit up the right side. It doesn't take long to slip into, nor to add a diamond necklace and a few matching bracelets to compliment the look. A pair of black stilettos complete my ensemble, and click hard against the floor as I rush downstairs.

Just as I predicted, Cassio has already left the apartment. But I find Armani and Colton sipping steaming cups of coffee while Sirius sits near them, watching patiently.

"Umm, hello model." Colton whistles, noticing me first. "What's the occasion?"

"I need to put some people in their place," I inform him, lifting my chin. "Would you gentlemen like to accompany me?"

Armani blinks. "You want to leave?"

"You're definitely not going anywhere without us," Colton declares.

I thought they would say as much.

"Well, come along then." Looking down at my guard dog, I offer him a soft smile and a pet to the head. "Sirius, follow."

"I need to know where we're going," Armani says seriously.

“We’re visiting my husband,” I tell him innocently. “There seem to be some men who think they can question him about my willingness to be his wife. I heard him on the phone this morning, and he’s being accused of holding me hostage. Do I look like a woman being held against my will?”

“You look like a woman with murder in your eyes,” Colton counters, standing from his seat at the kitchen counter. “I love it.”

Slapping his cowboy hat on top of his head, he pulls a handgun from the back of his jeans and begins to check its magazine for ammunition. Armani sighs and begins to do the same, racking a bullet into the chamber before holstering it once more. Now if there’s any sort of trouble, he’ll be quick to draw and fire.

“If I’d known you wanted to stir up trouble looking like that, I would have dressed better,” Armani grumbles, strapping a knife around his ankle.

“You look lovely,” I argue.

Armani is always dressed well, even for hanging out around the house. Today he’s wearing fitted black trousers and a silk button up with the sleeves rolled up to display his many arm tattoos. While Colton is wearing a pair of dark blue jeans and a dark henley, he still looks put together enough to be by my side as well.

“Don’t let Cassio hear you say that.” Colton chuckles. “Armani prefers his pretty boy head attached to his shoulders after all.”

My heart drums an excited beat at the implication. I’m thrilled Colton seems to think that Cassio wouldn’t like me complimenting other men—though I have no true attraction to Armani. But I think if I heard my husband telling another woman she looked lovely, I’d want to remove her head as well. I’m still digesting these new emotions I seem to have brewing for Cassio, but I know they are utterly possessive ones.

With my two new friends prepared to leave, we step into the elevator and hit the designated red button. The Kings don’t always have meetings in this building’s private basement, but they have been convening there more often than not as of late. With security concerns, it’s best for Cassio to be as close to the penthouse as possible.

As we begin our slow descent, I feel my hair being swished to the side.

“Finally showing off that back piece?”

My eyes flick over my shoulder at Armani, a smile playing on my lips. “Been curious about it, have you?”

At this point the two of them have seen several glimpses of my back tattoo, since I don't cover all of my skin while casually existing in the apartment. But I've never entirely revealed it, I'm not even sure that Cassio has gotten a full look.

"Oh, I'm always curious about clean lines and saturated black," Armani answers, eyes scanning the artwork. "This must have taken at least ten hours. How did it feel?"

"She probably sat for it like a champ," Colton muses. "Women take tats so much more peacefully than men."

"It took twelve, and it only hurt a bit over the spine," I mention, smiling with pride.

Colton arches a brow, sensing the hint of wickedness in my choice of attire. "And is there a reason you're choosing to finally display it?"

"The men will understand," I reply cryptically, returning my eyes to the chrome elevator doors. A second later, a small ding sounds, and they part, revealing a cold cement room filled with Kings' soldiers.

Whatever conversation that may have been occurring halts immediately, and all eyes land on me. A rush of anxiety I didn't expect, nor do I appreciate rushes through my veins. It's violently uncomfortable, but my need to keep up appearances is stronger.

Tilting up my chin, I waltz over the threshold, feeling Sirius trot along by my side. A makeshift aisle of shifting bodies reveals Cassio, sitting in the Monarch's chair, Gerard sitting to his left. I've been in this room before, and seen Bron in that very chair, with Killian standing to his right—as it was meant to be. But Cassio doesn't look out of place, he looks just as powerful and regal as the man who takes the throne should be.

Ponytail shifting to one side of my neck, my tattoo becomes a sort of message, flashing all of the subjects behind me. Few have seen it before, but all are aware of what it means.

The delicate skin of my back is almost entirely covered by a large black viper, the snake featured in the Knight family crest. I got the piece when I finally decided to be with Cole, not for him, but to cement myself as a true Knight. I wanted anyone who saw it to know that I wasn't just Brons stepdaughter, or Cole's potential love interest, I was a princess amongst The Kings, and they would do well to remember it.

Cassio's fiery gaze rolls up and down my body and I suppress a shiver, feeling an undeniable heat pass between us. With only a few more

purposeful steps, I'm standing just in front of him as Colton and Armani shift to the side. The two of them give me space to work, while still keeping a very obvious eye on me.

My husband has his eyes on me too, scanning my face for some sort of assurance. Giving him the subtlest of nods, I let him know that I'm okay, despite the awful anxiety brewing in my stomach. I will no-doubt spiral into some kind of panic after leaving this room, but it will be worth it.

Mollified enough, Cassio leans back in his seat, a silent invitation I don't hesitate to accept. Sitting down slowly on his thighs, I cross one leg over the other, and narrow my eyes at the crowd in front of us. They're the reason I'm here, disrupting what could be a peaceful day with childish antics. I wouldn't feel so uncomfortable without being surrounded by unfamiliar faces, any of which could have had something to do with Cole's death and Killian's assault.

"I hear that some of you are daring to question my husband," I speak, voice clear and dripping with disapproval. The crowd shifts, an awkwardness blooming all around, but I'm not quite done chastising this group of men. The ones who aren't guilty won't be affected by my scorn, but the ones who are will take their tongue lashing or face greater wrath.

"Doubting your own Duke's integrity when he reports my well-being," I continue, nodding to Gerard's place to the left, I click my tongue. "I'd like to know who believes their conspiracies to be more trustworthy than your leaderships?"

When no one speaks up, I make a short hmph noise.

"I see." Eyes scanning over the group, I fold my arms and sit back further in Cassio's lap. "I trust that my presence here today clears up any misguided confusion, hmm? I am very clearly alive and unharmed. I do not appreciate needing to leave the solitude of my home for petty theories."

"You haven't been seen outside of yer home for over a month," a throaty Irishman in the back pipes up. "We have a right to be concerned."

It would be touching, if it didn't piss me off so much.

"My mother is dead," I snap, glaring though I can't see him clearly. "I have no desire to return to the social niceties I used to enjoy. I am in mourning. And even if I weren't, Gerard has reported my well-being more than once, has he not?"

When no one answers, I turn to the Duke himself. "Have you not?"

“I have, my lady,” he replies, using the silly title Cole insisted I be called. He was their “lord” after all. Both he and Killian, until Killian becomes Monarch.

“I thought as much,” I reply, looking back at the men with clear disapproval in my gaze.

“What about Cole?”

The quiet question makes my spine stiffen.

“Do not—” Cassio begins, voice dark and deadly.

“Cole would have your tongue for questioning me,” I threaten, wishing I could find the voice responsible for the inquisition. “All of you know it.”

There’s a tense shift amongst the men, and I nod.

“Do not question my safety or my marriage. Cassio is the only reason your ranks haven’t fallen apart in your Monarch’s absence.”

As far as I know, the men have all been made aware of Bron, Cole, and my mother’s death. As for where they think Killian is, I’m not sure. I hope our attackers believe he’s dead, purely so that they won’t come looking for him. But I think Gerard and Cassio have made up some excuse about family business in London to the men.

They can’t believe their Monarch is gone, or they might have a much more difficult time accepting my husband. Temporary leadership from an outsider is one thing, a permanent placement would likely be met with serious outcry. But I doubt Killian would want his people to know about his recovery, needing to remain a figure of strength and hope.

“You may not want to be his best friend,” I continue, voice hard. “But he is taking care of you, just as he takes care of me. Do not make me come back here, or I will not simply scold you as the boys you are acting like.”

“Yes?” Gerard barks, signaling them to answer.

“Yes!” A loud ripple of replies blares.

“I’ll be going now, Husband,” I tell Cassio quietly, leaning back to press a kiss to his cheek. But as I stand, he does as well.

“I’ll escort you, *Wife*,” he returns, voice gravelly.

Sirius follows us to the elevator like the dutiful good boy that he is, but Colton and Armani hang back at Cassio’s instruction. As soon as the metal doors shut, I breathe out heavily and lean against the wall. Delayed panic washes over my whole body and I grimace, feeling light headed.

My eyes slam shut as I try to push away the awful sensation. I never expected to be so unnerved and on edge in that room. But the reminders of

Cole and Killian were everywhere. And though it was nothing like the shotty little room our kidnappers put us in, the basement had the same kind of cold cement walls that made my skin crawl.

"Don't… ever… do that again," Cassio says, his voice thick with tension. His hands are on my biceps, rubbing up and down like he knows I'm in desperate need of comfort.

Startled by this, my eyes pop open. "W-what? I thought I did good?"

"You did fucking amazing, Ana," he grits out.

Sighing, I swallow and ask, "Then what's the problem?"

"You don't do that," he demands, pointing harshly toward the door. "Do not ever put those people above yourself. I don't care if they think my family has you under some kind of spell, or that I have you locked up and shackled to me against your will. You will not make yourself sick with panic to help us, do you hear me?"

He could tell?

"I couldn't give a singular fuck what they think of me, Ana. Your health matters more than any of this shit. *You* matter more. Understand?"

Sniffling, my head bobs. "You're not mad at me, are you?"

"Jesus Christ," he swears, shaking his head. "I'm not mad at you, Ana. I'm upset that you put yourself through that when you didn't need to."

"I wanted to help."

"I know you did," he replies softly, lifting my chin with his thumb and curled pointer finger. "Look, this situation isn't easy for either of us. But you're my wife, Ana. I take care of you, all right?"

"But—"

His stern expression has the protest dying on my tongue.

"We can figure out the rest someday but for now, you let me do that. You need something, you tell me. Having a harder day than most? Let me know. If something makes you uncomfortable, I make sure it stops. Don't hurt yourself more than you've already been hurt. Especially not for political mafia bullshit."

My throat clogs with emotion, feeling a rush of relief blanket around me. "You're a good husband, Cassio," I choke out.

An unfamiliar look lights up in his eyes, and his following words—though barely loud enough to hear—make my stomach flip.

"You haven't seen the half of it."

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Chapter Twenty



Ana

Of course I would crave French onion soup on the one day a week that Agnes doesn't work. I despise cooking for myself, especially when the dish is complicated in any way. I can manage a quick fry up in the morning if I need to, and boiling pasta to eat with some easy jarred sauce doesn't irritate me too badly. Most of the time if I'm craving something specific that I don't have the patience or the skill to make myself, I'll order in.

French onion soup is *not* a takeout food. It needs to be eaten hot and fresh, while the cheese is still bubbly and the broth steams with every spoonful scooped. The idea of it has my mouth watering, and I know myself well enough to know that the fixation will not rest until I feed it.

So, despite knowing it's a bad idea, here I am in the kitchen, fumbling with a bag of yellow onions. I know I'll need to peel and cut at least six of these to make enough soup for myself and the boys. Armani and Colton are currently out walking Sirius, and Cassio is in Killian's office, going over some sort of paperwork. *Seriously, you would think some of these mob bosses were CEOs with the amount of bureaucratic bullshit they handle.*

But with everyone busy, and no Agnes in sight, I'm on my own for this soup mission. I can feel the frustration building even as I pick up the first onion to pick off the skin. I *hate* the way it feels in my hands, and the grating way tiny flecks of residue sticks under my nails. They may be dreadfully unmanicured currently, but that doesn't mean I'll tolerate the awful sensation of flakes invading under the tips.

“I already hate you,” I mumble at the current piece of produce in my hand. “Agnes needs a raise. So many things have onions, and you’re awful to touch, do you know that?”

More of the dry onion skin crinkles off, and I release a deep sigh. “I haven’t even gotten to the cutting yet. You know, the violent part where you make me cry. Arsehole onions.”

God, what is wrong with me? This is what my time being cooped up at home has come to… *I’m speaking to fucking onions.*

It’s not even just the texture being offensive to the touch, it’s the way it litters the counter and feels taxing to even begin. Dropping what I’m doing, I reach for my phone and turn on some soft relaxing music, hoping the songs will tune out some of my annoyance.

I’ve successfully removed the skin of three onions when the sound and the mess start grating on my last nerve. While trying to prepare the fourth, I fumble with it and it falls into the pile of skin. Something in me just snaps and hot angry tears well in my eyes. Screaming in frustration, I pick up the bloody vegetable and throw it as hard as I can across the room.

Not satisfied with the outburst, I pick up another and treat it the same, throwing it further. “Fuck you!”

My face is flooding with angry moisture and the back of my neck goes hot. I feel so uncomfortable and upset. Why did I even try? I knew I wouldn’t enjoy this, but attempting to cook has never pissed me off to this magnitude. What is *wrong* with me?

“Ughh!” I exhale, rushing to the sink to wash my hands furiously.

Heavy footsteps fall closer and closer as I scrub the onion remnants from my fingers, but I don’t look up.

“Ana?” Cassio’s voice, deep with concern, meets my ears. “What’s happened, I heard screaming. Are you okay?”

“No!” I burst out, slamming the faucet off and shaking out my wet hands. “I’m not okay at all.”

I’m practically growling at him, hotly reaching for a dish towel. He must see the cutting board and knife on the counter, because he’s grabbing my hands in a second flat, immediately searching for an injury.

“I didn’t cut myself,” I grumble, snatching my hands back. “I didn’t even get that far, how pathetic is that?”

“What?” He asks, brows dipping in confusion. “Nothing about you is pathetic, Ana.”

“I’m throwing a fit over fucking onions, Cassio,” I exclaim, tossing my arms up in the air. “*Crying* because I can’t have the French onion soup I want. That’s pretty damned pathetic.”

His head shakes and he cups my face with large, steady hands. “Sweetheart, take a breath.” Thumbs brush my cheeks, gliding over the fallen tears and swiping them away softly.

“Don’t call me sweetheart,” I mumble frowning. “I’m not sweet. Dante calls Jade that. She’s sweet.”

“You’re sweet too, Ana,” Cassio says patiently. “But if you don’t like it, I’ll stick to calling you *forza*, and *my wife*.”

“You still want to call me your wife after this little display?” I ask bitterly. “Aren’t you embarrassed?”

“Embarrassed that you threw a couple of onions and yelled in frustration while in your own home?” He breathes out a laugh. “Ana, you haven’t done anything wrong. Some people punch walls or hurt actual people when they’re upset. I hardly think one little outburst is something too concerning.”

“I’m not a good wife,” I rasp, not accepting his sweet words.

Cassio’s hands subtly flex around my jaw. “Why would you say that?”

“I can’t cook,” I start, flicking my ashamed gaze away from his face.

“Agnes cooks. *I* can cook. I don’t give a shit how you are in the kitchen, Ana.”

“I’m a mess,” I continue sadly.

“I signed up for your mess.”

“I’m needy.”

“I like being needed.”

“I’m lazy,” I argue. “I hardly get off the couch nowadays. I don’t even want to take showers anymore, it’s exhausting. I only do it so I don’t smell.”

“You’re not lazy, you’re recovering. I didn’t like showering either after Isobel passed. Being alone with your thoughts isn’t fun when you’re grieving, and mundane activities can feel pointless, it’s *normal*.”

I sigh and Cassio lifts my chin.

“Anything else, Wife?” he challenges, lifting a brow. “Because so far, you haven’t told me anything to scare me off.”

Blinking at his controlled demeanor, I frown. “How can you sound so pleased when you call me that? You get nothing out of this, Cassio… we

haven’t even consummated.”

His jaw flexes, like he’s attempting to control his reaction, like I’ve *angered* him. “I *am* pleased to call you my wife,” he says, voice hard like gravel. “We haven’t consummated because it isn’t the right time. I get more out of this than you will ever know, and I promise you, sex has nothing to do with it. You aren’t just a body to me, Ana. You are… everything. And apparently, I need to do more to make that clear.”

His words make me freeze, spine stiffening. “I—”

I can’t possibly ask for *more*. How could he do *more* for me than he’s already done?

His hands drop from my face, and I watch him in my stupor as he rounds the counter, opening the fridge. He doesn’t explain the action, merely gets what he needs and returns to stand in front of me.

“Here,” Cassio says softly. I blink away the last of the blasted tears in my eyes to find him putting a small box in my hands. It’s chilled from the fridge and is decorated with the logo of my favorite sweet shop. “Take these, go relax in the bath, and then take a nap. I’ll get dinner prepared for later, all right?”

Fumbling with the folded lid, I peek inside the container and almost burst into tears again. “You got me chocolate covered strawberries?”

Peering up at him through wet lashes, I find a softness in his eyes that I’ve never quite seen before. “It’s no big deal,” he says, shrugging it off. “You like them, so I got them.”

“That simple, huh?”

“That simple, Ana.”

Setting the gift down, I throw my arms around my husband’s neck and hug him hard. He grunts softly at my attack, but doesn’t push me away. His arms slowly wrap around my back in return, and I rest my head against his hard chest. We’re only ever this close at night when he holds me until I fall asleep, but I can’t help physically showing him my appreciation.

A brief kiss is pressed to the top of my head before Cassio ushers me upstairs. He leaves me alone in my room, and I take his advice without argument. Soaking in a steamy, bubbly bath, I savor every single strawberry in the box. They’re my favorite kind, after all. Ruby red, perfectly ripe, and only dipped in the finest milk chocolate NYC has to offer.

I hadn’t realized that Cassio paid attention the last time Agnes picked these up for me, especially since he wasn’t home. I did share with Colton

and Armani though—since Agnes was brilliant enough to buy extra—so perhaps one of them told him.

Either way, I'm thrilled that he somehow knew. The treat, coupled with the luxurious bath were enough to pull the tension straight out of me. Enough to make me sleepy and crave the nap Cassio suggested. I doze off only seconds after my head hits the pillow, and dream about absolutely nothing.

A sweet, savory scent lulls me out of the most peaceful sleep I've had in weeks. I wake up smiling, feeling a small ache in my cheeks that lets me know I've been doing it in my sleep.

When my eyes blink open, I find Cassio by the side of my bed, setting a steaming bowl down on my bedside table. Rubbing my blurry eyes, I blink rapidly in disbelief.

"You made me the soup?" My voice cracks, eyes now fixated on the beautifully made ramekin of French onion soup. The bread and cheese on top is broiled to perfection. Just looking at it has my mouth watering. "It must have taken you hours…"

"Only two and a half," Cassio says, trying to downplay the action.

My bottom lip wobbles, an overwhelming surge of gratefulness filling me up inside. This man treats me with the sort of kindness that most people only ever dream about. He's a walking talking fairytale, and his ring is on *my* finger.

My feet are shaky underneath me as I stand, invading my husband's personal space. Like before, he doesn't back away from my approach. He watches me carefully, his gaze hot on my face. Only this time, I'm not going in for a simple hug. My right hand trembles as I lift it to his face, hoping he won't step back as I lay it on his strong jaw.

He doesn't move, hell, I don't know if he even breathes. Rising up on my toes, my chest brushes against his, and our lips hover millimeters apart. Gathering every bit of courage I have, I slowly lean forward and close the gap. As soon as we touch, my knees go weak and my eyelids fall. His lips are so soft, and something inside of me seems to flutter at the taste of him.

For a second, I think Cassio won’t kiss me back—that he’ll just stand in front of me in shock. But before I can pull back to check in with him, he takes me by surprise. Big, warm hands grasp my hips and tug me even tighter against his frame. His mouth presses forward, lips parting to move with sensual precision. A whimper vibrates up my throat, and an ache begins to build in my core.

My fingers migrate around the back of his neck, threading through the soft edge of his hair. I hold him there tight, desperate to draw this out. This kiss isn’t chaste like the one that sealed our marriage bond, this is something else entirely.

After only seconds of kissing, I can feel arousal pooling in my knickers, and heat crawling up my neck. Signs of unmistakable desire that have me craving more. Feeling bold, I move my unoccupied hand from my side, dragging it up the defined muscles of Cassio’s stomach to rest on his firm chest. He kisses me harder in response, forcing an all-out moan to slip from my lips to his.

Our connection breaks and my eyes blink open. He’s still holding me firmly, the space between us hardly there at all.

“Cassio,” I rasp, feeling my heart racing in my chest.

“Who was so awful to you that the simple act of being cooked for earns me a kiss like that?” Tucking a stray bit of hair behind my ear, his thumb traces my bottom lip before he returns his hand to my hip.

“That wasn’t a simple act,” I disagree, shaking my head. “And I didn’t kiss you just because you cooked for me. I’ve been thinking about it for days.”

He makes a deep humming sound. “Is that right, little wife?”

“I don’t even think you see how incredible to me you’ve been,” I admit in a shy murmur. “You do all these considerate things, expect nothing in return, and I don’t know what to do about it.”

“You don’t have to do anything about it, Ana,” Cassio says sternly. “You’re my wife, and I’m going to treat you as such. No matter how we came together, it’s my duty to assure that we stay together. My *honor*, Ana.”

“How can you say things like that and not expect affection in return?” I ask, licking my lips. “You make me feel things, Cassio. Things I never expected…” I trail off, swallowing hard.

“Things you never expected to feel again?” He asks the question like he already knows the answer. Like he’s familiar with the concept. My heart

gives a hard thump, and my head dips in a nod.

“Did you know that you’re only the second person I’ve kissed?”

Cassio tilts his head, and his hands momentarily flex around my hips. “I guess that’s something else we have in common then, isn’t it?”

Shocked by his confession, I blink and try to digest it. “You were only ever with Isobel?”

He nods once.

Just like me with Cole.

“We’re both each other’s second kiss,” I realize aloud.

“We are.”

When I was younger, I fantasized about sharing all my firsts with my future husband. I wanted every milestone to feel special, even if it was unrealistic. It’s part of the reason I didn’t have sex until I was nineteen.

But Cole and I didn’t share that first. He had been with plenty of girls before meeting me, and I couldn’t exactly fault him for it. He didn’t know I existed, let alone that he would want me. He did tell me that once we met, he never even considered pursuing another girl. Cole was hooked, and that’s probably why I eventually fell for him. His obsession felt like a warm hug, or a comfy sweater—once it stopped frightening me.

But in falling for Cole, I resigned myself to losing my naive dream of sharing firsts with the man I would share my life with. And with Cassio, of course it wasn’t a possibility for either of us. So it seems we won’t share a bunch of firsts, but maybe we’ll have plenty of seconds in common.

“Am I the second person you’ve shared a bed with?” I blush a little as I ask.

A soft smile tugs at his lips. “Unless you count my brothers, yes.”

“I like that,” I admit shyly.

“Yeah?”

“Yeah,” I confirm quietly. “I almost wish Cole and I married, because then this would be a second marriage for both of us.”

“No, Ana,” Cassio says with the shake of his head. “This marriage is a first for us both. A Moretti Blood Marriage isn’t something either of us have shared with another. It’s entirely ours.”

His words echo around in my mind and all I want to do is kiss him again.

“Come,” he insists, taking my hand. “Eat with me downstairs. You’ll want this while it’s still hot.”

But French onion soup isn’t what I’m craving anymore. And if my husband didn’t just spend hours making it for me. I’d tell him to hell with the food, and drag him straight into bed to kiss me breathless once more.

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Chapter Twenty-One



Ana

JADE

We miss you!

Attached to the message is an adorable photo of my best friend holding her babies, a huge smile on her face. Cesar is fisting her hair and trying to shove it in his mouth while Isobella is staring at the camera lens with wide eyes.

ANA

There are my three favorite people. I miss you all too. Sooo much.

JADE

I wish we could come see you! :(

Smiling sadly down at my phone, I silently wish for the same. Unfortunately, there's no possible way to visit my best friend without putting her in danger. We're not positive that whoever killed Bron and Cole are secretly plotting to appear again, or if they care about me at all, but I'm not willing to risk it.

Until Cassio and Killian decide there's nothing to worry about, we'll continue to play it safe. Part of me is worried that Killian will be ready to return before we've found the parties responsible. And what then? Do Cassio and I stay here to keep our distance from the Morettis? Do we return

to his home and move in, risking all the other inhabitants with my proximity?

Sighing, I try to shake off the unnecessary overthinking. Cassio has told me to trust him to take care of it, and for my own sanity, I need to listen and believe in his assurances.

ANA

I'm counting the days :)

ANA

How is everyone there?

JADE

Good! Matteo caused a bit of a ruckus when he announced he wouldn't be returning to Empire next semester. He refuses to go without me, and won't be swayed. He wants to stay home and help me and Dmitri with the twins.

JADE

But Dad and Apollo eventually relented and agreed not to push. It's not like Empire graduation holds that much weight in The Outfit, anyways. It's mostly just tradition.

I smile at Matteo's undying show of love and loyalty to Jade. And she's right about what graduating from Empire Academy means. To some syndicates, it's make or break. You either finish, or you're disowned and thrown out on your arse. But to families like the Morettis, blood is more meaningful than any sort of tradition.

And it isn't like Matteo truly needs more training to survive, he's likely been a formidable man since his early teens. Dante Moretti isn't the kind of man who leaves preparing his children entirely up to strangers. He would have taught them all various skills from a young age. Fighting, weapon handling, the ways of business, and more.

ANA

Good for him. Good riddance to that blasted island, I say. I wouldn't mind never going back.

Empire isn't all bad, but it puts me on edge. I don't trust strangers, and at a college of any kind, you're surrounded by them. When that college is

full of mafia heirs, heiresses, and soldiers, it only adds to the possible dangers.

JADE

Well…

JADE

I hope you wouldn't mind coming back for a wedding? Dmitri and I are thinking about having our ceremony there.

My heart leaps with an excited beat. Oh… that would be gorgeous! Empire Academy is seated on a secluded forest-like island, and the land itself is beautiful. Its black sand beaches, tall dark trees, and foggy air makes it feel more like the Pacific Northwest than any kind of tropical paradise. A wedding there would be lovely.

Not to mention significant for Jade. She would have likely never met Dmitri without attending Empire. And if she did somehow cross paths with the Russian heir one day, they wouldn't have had the opportunity to see one another intimately. Their families wouldn't have allowed it. Dating him in secret, sneaking around the campus, that's how their love story began, and having a wedding there would only make it all the more special.

Though they're technically married on paper, they haven't had an official ceremony. And of course, I would never miss my best friend's big day. I'm getting excited jitters just thinking about it.

ANA

That's a wonderful idea! Of course I would go back for you. You name the date and I'm there.

JADE

Phew! I was hoping you'd agree to be my maid of honor? Honestly I wanted to ask you in person with a cute little gift or something, but I'm too impatient! I've been itching to ask.

My cheeks pinch in a smile. *God, she's too cute.*

ANA

I'd be honored, Jade. You were by my side for my wedding, and I'd love to do the same for you.

JADE

Ugh, I’m gonna cry. I’m so excited!

JADE

We don’t have a date yet, but you’ll be the first to know when we do. I’ve got to go wrestle Cesar away from Matteo, I do not trust how quiet they’re being right now!

I snort while reading the message. Matteo is probably plotting world domination with the six-month-old, talking to him like he can truly comprehend. I worry about the days when Cesar is finally able to walk and talk. He has his uncle’s love for mischief sparkling in his eyes already.

ANA

Good luck! Talk soon, xx.

I’m thinking about tossing my phone to the side when I bite my lip in contemplation, my thumb over the Instagram icon. I haven’t updated any of my socials since getting married, and I’ve been purposely avoiding them. I know news of my marriage will have gotten out—Dante asked Jade to post pictures so I didn’t have to, after all. But I haven’t sought them out, wanting to steer clear of any outside reactions.

But with how much better I’ve been feeling, and how secure Cassio has made me lately… I want to look.

Tucking my knees up, sinking deeper into the cozy living room sofa, I open the app and go to my profile. I get lost in notifications quickly. Finding unseen messages, tagged posts, comments and more. All the Moretti siblings have followed me, and Jade must have used my phone to make sure I followed back for appearances. I apparently liked her wedding post as well, which I assumed she handled for me.

I should send her flowers, or a fruit basket… or no, some kind of dessert basket. She truly thought of everything.

Scrolling through the multi-picture post from my wedding day, I feel my chest warm. Everyone looks so lovely. I wish I was more present in the moment, but I’m glad there are so many pictures to help me experience it again—without so many dreadful emotions.

Taking a screenshot of my two favorite images, I move to make my own post. The first being Cassio and I at the altar, our blue strings in place, just

before our kiss. And the second, a picture of the whole family surrounding my new husband and me.

Tagging everyone, I quickly caption the photos and hold my breath as I hit *post*. Within seconds, likes begin to filter in and I smile, closing my screen. I don't think I've ever felt such a jolt of satisfaction after uploading anything on social media before.

"*Mine?*" a rumbling voice asks, inches from my ear.

A gasp catches in my throat, recognizing Cassio's scent before I even process the sound of his question. He's leaning over the back of the couch to speak to me, and I didn't realize he'd come home.

His phone is suddenly presented in front of me, my one-word caption on display. He must have notifications turned on for my posts, because it hasn't even been up for a full minute.

"Mine," I agree breathlessly. "Problem?"

His freehand glides up the back of my neck, leaving a trail of goosebumps in his wake. He rests his hand there, holding me close as his lips gently press into my temple.

"No problem, Wife," he whispers. "The sentiment is mutual."

My head turns, putting our mouths only millimeters from brushing. I don't need to make the first move this time. Instead, Cassio leans in, pressing deep. The kiss steals my breath and makes my toes curl. His thumb rubs circles under the back of my hairline, making me shiver. Kissing Cassio feels unlike anything I've ever experienced before. It's utterly consuming, and I'm not sure I ever want to stop.

His hand flexes around my nape and a whimper muffles into our kiss.

"Fuck, forza," he groans, pulling back and dropping his forehead against mine. "I need to take a shower before dinner, and if you keep making sounds like that, it'll need to be a cold one."

Before I can quip that it wouldn't need to be cold if he simply asked me to join him, he kisses me twice more. Quick smacks of his lips against mine, but they still feel wonderful.

"Never mind," he grunts. "Just looking at your pretty little flushed face is too much. Be back in fifteen."

A protest dies on my tongue as he rushes toward the stairs and Armani and Colton saunter into the living room, Sirius trotting happily along with them. My sweet puppy joins me, flopping his head into my lap, and I chuckle, rubbing the top of his soft head.

“We’re chopped liver as soon as he sees you.” Armani pouts. “All those runs and all those treats, and it’s like we’re invisible now.

“Smart mama’s boy,” Colton coos, playfully pushing his friend to round the sofa first. “You can’t compete with the *La Jefa* bond.”

Armani rolls his eyes and reaches for the telly remote. “How’s it going, pretty girl? You look happy today.”

I *am* happy today.

“And what’s that blush for, doll?” Colton teases, flopping down on the couch. “Your cheeks are positively rosy.”

His question only makes my face warmer, but I don’t want to hide my newfound relationship to Cassio. And I think I would feel strange gushing to Jade about kissing her brother. That has to be odd, right?

And sure, Armani is his brother as well. But brothers talk about more with each other than they do with their sisters, don’t they?

“I kissed Cassio last night,” I admit shyly. “And he kissed me again just now.”

“Oh, did you now?” Armani asks with a wicked grin. “How scandalous.”

“Was there tongue?” Colton chimes, waggling his brows.

I gape at the two men. “Neither of you seem surprised.”

Colton chuckles, rolling his eyes. “Breaking news, husband and wife share kiss. In our next top story, fork found in kitchen.”

Armani ignores his antics but asks, “Should we be? You’re married.”

“We didn’t exactly have a traditional start to this arrangement,” I answer, folding my arms. “You know that. Did you two expect this?”

The men share a look.

“I mean…” Armani rubs the back of his neck. “Ana, darling, the two of you have been sharing a bed for over a month now.”

“I’m surprised you didn’t start sucking face sooner,” Colton adds. “You’re both hot. Hot people make out, it’s simple math.”

“*Math?*” I ask incredulously.

“Hot wife plus hot husband equals—” he stops speaking and starts making smoochy noises.

A high-pitched laugh erupts from me before I can stop it. “You are incorrigible.”

“You love it,” Colton tosses back, grinning wide. “I’m delightful.”

Armani scoffs. “Ignore him. The point is, we’re happy for you. And for Cassio. You both deserve to find happiness together.”

Colton nods rapidly, agreeing without question. “And Cassio is a ride, girl. I want details when you finally get on that thang.”

My mouth drops open, and I watch humor light up in his eyes.

“Oh my god,” Armani groans. “No details for me, thank you.”

“What if I need advice?” I ask, nibbling on my bottom lip. “I can’t exactly ask Jade, and I was only with Cole once…”

The tattooed Moretti brother goes from a little disgusted by the idea of details to giving me a soft and encouraging smile in an instant.

“Advice I can do, pretty girl,” he says happily. “Colton just likes to taunt me about my good looking family. I don’t mind hearing details if it’s about you and my brother—and Colton keeps his fake thirsting to a minimum. Sex is as natural as it gets.”

“He would know,” Colton quips. “Armani is *King of The Sluts*, after all.”

The cowboy is shoved unceremoniously, and I laugh at their antics.

“Dick.”

“That’s hardly an insult. You love dick.”

“Quit talking about dick in front of my wife,” Cassio demands, returning to the living room with damp hair and dawning a dark blue set of loungewear. His arm wraps around my shoulders as he settles onto the couch, tugging me close. “What do you want for dinner?”

You.

Swallowing hard, I suggest, “Steak frites?”

Cassio nods. “Whatever you want, *forza*.”

All I want is him.

God, when did that happen?

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Chapter Twenty-Two



Cassio

Kissing Ana tastes like liberation. Our wedding kiss was a performance, meant for outside eyes. It didn't last long enough for me to truly take it in. But the first after that… it was a lightning strike of shock, shooting me right through the chest. I hadn't expected Ana to initiate the contact as I wasn't sure how close to moving on from Cole she was. But as soon as I felt her lips press against my own, I felt *free*.

Chains of the past that once held me tight, shattered into a million pieces. I didn't think or feel anything other than her. Ana Moretti consumed me. My once hopelessly grieving wife became my salvation, waking me up from years of bitter sleep.

I had expected to feel guilt moving on from Isobel. I'd expected it to eat me up inside, to feel anger at myself for going forward without her. I'd come to terms with marrying another woman, I wouldn't have offered to help Ana if I hadn't. But a marriage of convenience and caring was much different than what has begun to brew between Ana and me. This wasn't simply a friendly arrangement any longer, and yet, I couldn't bring myself to fear it. I *relished* it, instead.

I'd always mourn my son, and I'd always carry love for his mother. How could I not? But my previous love for Isobel didn't prevent me from finding something entirely new with Ana. Something I didn't quite understand, but craved like a man starving. Watching her heal before my eyes built something unbreakable inside of me, something I'd protect with my dying fucking breath.

Which is exactly why I'm so on edge right now. My wife wants to leave the house today—*without me*. We haven't received any threats or any signs that she may be in danger since that awful fucking night, but we're still operating under the assumption that she could be targeted at any time. After all, the original attack occurred without any warning signs at all.

So when Ana came to me with her plan for the day, I was torn. She wanted to visit with a few of her society acquaintances to show face, and perhaps learn any helpful information she could. Part of me wanted to dig my heels in and forbid her from leaving the safety of our temporary home without me. The other part of me knew that she shouldn't be punished for something so utterly out of her control. And that meant compromise.

"If anyone even looks at her, I want to know about it," I relay to Armani for the third time, giving him my best stern look.

My younger brother sighs, scrubbing a hand through his stubble. "Yes, Cassio. I heard you the first time. And the second."

"You gotta relax," Colton says, clapping me on the back. "You're going to give yourself an aneurysm over a lunch with rich girls who's greatest weapons are their sharp ass tongues and daddy's wallet."

"It's not the girls I'm worried about," I grumble, shoving him away. "It's a public restaurant, strict privacy or not. I'm tempted to put her in a fucking Kevlar vest."

"It would be a shame to smother a dress like that with Kevlar," Armani suddenly says, eyes fixated on the opposite side of the room.

Head swiveling, I find my wife and curse silently.

Cristo.

Sia bellissima.

Her legs have my attention before anything else. Long and limber, covered in sheer black tights and tall shiny black boots. Her dress is tight but flares out from her waist, falling above the middle of her thighs. The material is grey and plaid patterned with sleeves that widen at the cuffs, like some kind of designer uniform. She looks like a college student who studies fashion and vacations with her family in the Swiss Alps.

My eyes fixate on her hair next. It's styled down with thick waves and not a single piece out of place, all held down by a thick black headband that I'd love to push back to run my fingers through her scalp. She's wearing her wedding rings, and a few other pieces of jewelry, and a fresh face of makeup that accentuates her features beautifully.

By the time I've thoroughly gawked at her, she's by my side and pressing a soft kiss to one of my cheeks. Her scent swirls around me like a greeting, calling me to inhale more. She smells like spiced apple cider, like she's dripping in liquid fall, and I want to lick her neck to see if she tastes like it too.

Tugging her by the waist, I drop my mouth to her ear and whisper, "How am I supposed to let you out of the house when you look like that, Wife?"

"I'd like to see how you plan to stop me," she returns, batting her lashes and toying with the end of my tie.

My hand slips around the back of her neck before I can stop it, pulling our faces merely inches apart. "Are you challenging me, *forza*?"

"I would never," she replies, a subtle smirk playing on her lips.

"All right, wrap it up, you flirts," Armani gripes. "I feel like I'm watching softcore porn."

Ana giggles when I shoot him a furious look. The sound of her amusement helps soothe my anger at my brother's fucking annoying interruption. Ana's laughs are rare, but every single one of them feels like a win. They're just further proof that she's healing daily.

"Pull up the side of your dress."

"Whoa," Armani blurts, hearing my command. "When I said wrap it up, I didn't mean with a condom, buddy. I did not sign up for a peep show."

"Shut it, you imbecile," I snap, reaching behind me to the counter. "It's for a weapon, not to cop a feel."

Ana watches us, amusement dancing in her sunny brown eyes. Her fingers lightly tug up the right side of her dress, flashing the majority of her leg. With quick and nimble hands, I secure a snug garter band around her upper thigh. Once the black material is locked in place, I sheath a push dagger into it, making sure its position is on the outside for easy access.

"Anyone tries to touch you, aim for the throat," I instruct, pulling her dress back down.

"Or the balls," Colton suggests through a chuckle.

"Violent," Ana comments. "I like it."

Despite having just equipped her with a weapon for self-defense, and knowing Armani and Colton will keep an eye on her, I want to make her stay. Or act like a total creep by following them. Ana didn't explicitly tell me not to come, but I have work to do, and she didn't ask me to be there

either. So I'll have to settle for remaining in the area and trying to stay calm.

"I've got to be going," she says sweetly, rocking on her heels to press a swift kiss to my lips. "Thank you for the pretty new accessory. And don't worry, Husband, we can continue our standoff later… if you'd like."

"I'll take you up on that, devious girl."

Ana

Four familiar faces greet me as soon as I step into *The Modern Luxe*, an upscale private restaurant beloved by many of the elite. Reagan, Emma, Charlotte, and Morgan are my closest acquaintances in the criminal underground society of New York. I've developed relationships with each of them through years of parties, galas, and fundraisers, some of them more friendly than others. Each of them possess different associations that allow them to exist in this world.

Reagan Carrington's father is an Irish assassin for hire who works for some of the most prominent mafias in all of New York City. Her fiery red hair, pale skin, and face full of freckles are unmistakable. She's also incredibly skilled in combat and weapons handling, but with a dad like hers, her name is enough to scare any possible threats away.

Emma Swanson and Charlotte Astor are both daughters of shady billionaire tycoons. Their fathers invest heavily in several illegitimate businesses and cooperate with crime syndicates as well as corrupt politicians. The two girls fell in love at fifteen and had been secretly dating for years. When they turned eighteen last year, they married in secret, forcing their disapproving families to either disown them, or accept their relationship publicly.

Their fathers despise one another—and have for decades—but have begrudgingly accepted their daughter's relationship. Thankfully, because not only are they perfect together, they're also one of the most stunning couples I've ever seen.

Emma has the most ethereal beauty, with her dark umber complexion, black waist-length curly hair, and the body of a slim runway model. While

Charlotte is the beachy blonde with crystal blue eyes and curves that Hollywood magazines dream of.

And then there's Morgan. We've never been close. She's the niece of some millionaire casino owner, and she's far too rude for my taste. But Charlotte went to boarding school with her, and even though I can tell she gets fed up with Morgan's demeanor sometimes, she doesn't cut her off.

And unfortunately, she's the first to greet me.

"Ahhh," she shrieks excitedly, jumping up from her seat, bouncy brunette waves swaying around her shoulders. "There she is!"

I try to hide my cringe as she hugs me tightly and air kisses the side of my face. Moving on to softly hug the other three, I release a breath and take my seat with a forced smile. "Hello, everyone."

"I want to catch up and ask you how you are," Reagan starts, white teeth flashing in a smile. "But I have to ask, who were the absolute smoke shows that just escorted you in here?"

I chuckle, eyes finding Armani and Colton sitting at a table close by. "The one with the tattoos is one of my brothers-in-law, and the cowboy is his best friend. They're staying with Cassio and I for a while."

"Is the cowboy looking for a cowgirl?" she asks, waggling her brows.

The table all share a laugh, and I shake my head while smiling. "I think cow*girls* aren't quite his fancy."

"Damn," she curses, playfully sighing with disappointment.

"Still single then?" I ask, flipping open a menu.

"Dreadfully so," Morgan answers for her, trying to hide a smirk.

"Who cares about me," Reagan cuts in, ignoring the obvious jab. "Let me see that gorgeous ring, please. I can't believe you're married!"

Flushing, I extend my hand, allowing them all to get a good look.

"Wow," Emma says, peering at the jewelry. "Is it true the engagement ring is an heirloom? It's stunning."

"Your connection to the gossip network never ceases to amaze me," I tease, retracting my hand.

"Bagging Cassio Moretti is a win, heirloom or not," Morgan notes. I wish she weren't in the seat right next to me, because she's already rubbing me the wrong way. I don't like the greedy glimmer in her eyes as she says my husband's name.

"I don't want to bring the mood down," Charlotte says quickly, likely knowing I wouldn't have a pleasant response to Morgan. "But I wouldn't

forgive myself if I didn't say how sorry I am for your loss. Daddy donated a few million to the orphanage in her name, because we didn't want to send flowers or anything that might get in your way. We know how much that place means to the both of you. And Vivian was so lovely… when I heard the news, I was so devastated for you, Ana."

A month ago, Charlotte's condolences would send me into a dark place, possibly even cause me to burst into tears. But now, it warms my heart. She's always been the kindest member of our little group, and probably the one I would consider close to a friend.

"Thank you," I reply softly. "That means so much."

Emma and Reagan express similar sweet words before our server comes to collect our orders. Once they've left, the conversation takes a more upbeat turn.

Emma and Charlotte have adopted a puppy together, prompting me to share pictures of Sirius in exchange for pictures of their little golden retriever called Aurora. Reagan has spent the past few months learning to rock climb in her latest adrenaline-seeking pursuit.

When the conversation shifts once more to Morgan, my ears are filled with her struggles to find a man she deems worthy of marrying. Someone tall, handsome, rich, and obsessed with her seem to be the qualities she's seeking. I can't blame her, I enjoy all of those things too. But once again, Cassio's name comes out of her mouth, and my fingers start to itch.

"Not all of us get lucky enough to find someone like Cassio, you know," Morgan muses, swirling her glass of chardonnay. "He's not just a catch, but a widow too. Giving him love after loss, he's probably eating right out of your hand."

"Morgan!" Charlotte gasps. "You can't say things like that."

My hand clenches in my lap, a silent disbelief washing over me.

"What?" Morgan huffs, throwing her hands up in mock defense. "I'm being honest. And it's a good thing. From what I've heard his last wife couldn't give him a child, so you know exactly what to do if you want to keep him."

"Holy shit," Reagan hisses. "Morgan, that's so out of line."

"You're being awful," Emma agrees, looking extremely uncomfortable.

"Don't speak about Cassio's family," I warn, voice cold and hard. "You know nothing about what he's been through."

“Oh my gosh, you guys are so sensitive! I’m only saying that you don’t have much competition,” she defends, sticking her nose up in distaste. “His previous wife couldn’t even do the one thing we’re designed to do. As long as everything is in working order for you, Ana, I’m sure you’ll keep him.”

Her words ring in my ears, and like on autopilot, my body reacts. Hand slipping up the skirt of my dress, I grab cold metal and lunge forward. Morgan’s eyes flare wide and her lips part, but no sound can come out before my knife plunges into her chest cavity, ripping through flesh and bone. Blood spills, soaking my hand in an instant while fire courses through my veins.

My heart beats so hard, I hardly recognize the sound of gasps and screams breaking out all around the room. Morgan’s skin goes pale and cold in a matter of seconds, and her body slumps from her chair to the floor and I retract my knife.

“You shouldn’t have said that.”

Just as I put my blade back on my thigh, blood dripping down my tights, Armani scoops me up and throws me over his shoulder. I don’t fight him or ask a single question as he ushers me out of the building. Instead, the recent memory of stabbing Morgan plays on a peaceful loop in my mind. It calms me after the horrible words she uttered made my skin crawl.

No one speaks about Cassio’s loss that way.

I only wish I’d thought to stab her twice.

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Chapter Twenty-Three



Cassio

W*hat the actual fuck.*

"You stabbed her in the chest?"

"I wanted to crack her chest open to pry out her heart and force feed it to her," Ana growls. She's standing stiffly by my side as I scrub blood from her hands in the kitchen sink, having returned only moments ago. "She's lucky I nicked an artery and she died quickly."

The feral glint in my wife's eyes stirs something deep inside of me, something I need to ignore so that I can clean up her mess. A public murder is never ideal, and Ana has apparently just committed one.

I knew something was wrong as soon as Armani called me, before they had even made it back to the penthouse. I assumed Ana got upset and wanted to leave early, or that they didn't feel the building was secure enough to stay. I never would have guessed that Ana took it upon herself to end some socialite's life. Luckily, Colton and Armani were quick to react, pulling her out of the building and beginning the cover up process.

"What did she say to you?"

"You don't want to know," she rasps. "I don't want to repeat it."

"My father and Apollo are on their way," I tell her instead of prying. She'll tell me when she's ready, or I'll find out another way. "You'll need to talk to them, to give them details so they can handle this."

Her gaze becomes vulnerable as she peers up at me. "Am I going to be arrested?"

“No,” I don’t hesitate to answer. “You don’t need to worry about that, I promise.”

She breathes out, letting my vow sink in.

“Are you okay, *forza*?” I ask softly, beginning to dry her hands. She’ll need a shower, but at least her hands are mostly clean. “Killing for the first time can be very difficult for some.”

Our eye contact breaks as she drops her gaze to the floor. “I don’t think this is the first time I’ve killed someone.”

Her words are so quiet that I almost don’t hear them, but she sounds utterly defeated as she mutters them. I don’t know whether she’s ashamed to admit it, or fearful of how I might react.

Lifting her chin with my fingers, I tilt my head. “Why do you think that?”

“Memories,” she mumbles. “They’re fuzzy—like they’ve been buried deep for a long time. But today seems to be bringing them to the surface. I think this has happened to me before. Losing my temper and… I didn’t remember, Cassio, I swear.”

“Hey, it’s all right—”

“I wouldn’t have married you without telling you if I knew,” she interrupts, eyes swimming with emotion. “You shouldn’t be saddled with a killer basket case. You didn’t sign up for this.”

“Don’t say that,” I snap, pinching her chin between my fingers. “Stop acting like I should be upset or fucking disgusted, Ana. You killed someone, you may have killed more in the past. So fucking what? You think I haven’t delivered more souls into the afterlife? I guarantee my body count is higher than yours, Wife. Want to compare?”

“How can you be so okay with this?”

“Because I know you,” I insist, moving to cup the side of her face. “If she said something so vile you don’t even want to repeat it, she clearly deserved exactly what you gave her.”

“I shouldn’t have made a scene,” she argues, frowning. “Now you have to take care of another one of my messes. Aren’t you exhausted?”

“Not even fatigued, Wife. You think I can’t handle you?”

“You’re crazy for even wanting to,” she breathes.

“Then call me crazy, baby.” My forehead drops to hers. “Cause more mayhem, I won’t even blink. I don’t give a shit if you drop more bodies as long as it doesn’t hurt you, Ana.”

“It doesn’t. That’s the problem isn’t it? It should hurt me. Normal people don’t feel indifferent about killing someone.”

“You don’t feel entirely indifferent,” I point out. “Otherwise you wouldn’t feel bad about not feeling bad.”

“God, I’m a mess.” Ana sighs, tilting her head to lay on my chest.

“My mess.”

Kissing the top of her head, I rub up and down her arms, trying to assure her further that she has nothing to fear from me. I won’t reject her or show a single sign of distaste after what she’s done. Something tells me the woman she killed made a comment about me or our relationship, and Ana’s fierce reaction only captivates me further.

“Do you know why Cole liked me so much?” she whispers, her head lifting to show me that her eyes have shifted to appear cold and haunted. “He knew that deep down… I was a killer just like him. He saw it in my eyes, and he was right. I don’t care that she’s dead, I’m glad I ended her.”

“You say that like it scares you.”

“I don’t like it,” she admits. “I don’t know who I am, Cassio. I think this is why we started the memory sorting and disassociation lessons. I don’t think it was just to help me clear my head from overwhelming information. I think Cole helped me bury the parts of myself that I couldn’t stand to remember.”

My poor girl, she’s so confused right now. Wrapping her up tight, I pull my wife into my chest and hug her hard.

Her next words muffle into my chest, but I hear them loud and clear. “I don’t want to forget this, I need to remember what I’m capable of.”

“I don’t want you to bury anything, forza. I want you exactly how you are. You don’t need to be afraid of yourself, or scared to make mistakes. I’ll always be right here to pick up after you.”

“You mean it?”

“Baby, until you started to look sad, I was seconds from kissing the fuck out of you. I like all the parts of you, feral murderous ones included.”

Her breath hitches. “Yeah?”

“Fuck yeah,” I agree, kissing the top of her head. “Why don’t you go shower off and I’ll make sure everything is set for my father’s arrival, okay?”

I reluctantly let her go when she agrees, and prepare to address my capo. As much as he is my father—and a good one—Dante Moretti is also

my boss. He will neither yell or punish me or my wife, but our meeting will likely be a bit formal. We have rules for a reason, and trying not to break them is expected.

By the time they arrive, Ana has showered, erasing all traces of blood from her body. She's wearing a pair of black leggings and an oversized crewneck sweater, with her still-damp hair braided on one side of her head.

I've set up Killian's office that I've been using for the past few weeks, and my father, Apollo, and myself bring Ana inside to discuss the matter at hand. She doesn't seem as gloomy as she became in the kitchen, which is a relief. In fact, she looks a bit angry again. Likely still upset with the woman whose life she took.

Dad takes a seat in Killian's chair while I sit across from him next to my wife, holding her hand for support. Apollo surveys the both of us with an assessing stare, but his composure gives him away. Everything is going to be fine. If it weren't already handled, he would appear more agitated. Apollo hates when things are out of order, and most people would never pick up on his tells, but I've known the man my entire life.

"Take us through the events of today, Ana," Dad requests, hands interlocked on top of the oak wood. "Don't spare any details."

Squeezing my hand to steady herself, Ana takes a deep breath and begins. She explains about meeting her old acquaintances, even giving notes about who the girls are and what their families do. She mentions the small talk, the donation made to the orphanage, sharing pictures of Sirius and more.

"And then Morgan opened her bitch mouth and said something she could never take back," Ana mutters darkly.

"What did she say?" Apollo asks, pinning his deep gaze on Ana. I try to give him a warning glare, but he doesn't spare me a glance.

Ana's hand shakes and she flexes her fingers around my knuckles. "She made comments about Cassio being a widow. That I probably have him eating out of my hand by showing him any affection. And—" She stops, swallowing hard and flicking her eyes sideways to look at me.

"It's okay," I assure her, keeping my tone steady. "You can tell us."

My wife nods and turns back to Dad and Apollo.

"She said that Isobel couldn't do the one thing women were designed to do, and that if everything was in working order for me, Cassio and I would be fine."

The echoed words of a dead girl don’t faze me, but something else does. The realization that Ana didn’t just kill a woman for insulting her or me or our relationship. She killed her for speaking ill of my deceased wife. Of my *child* who only lived for minutes after his birth.

And it’s now, with full clarity that I understand Ana Moretti isn’t just my wife. I don’t just care for her. I *love* her.

Ana

Just relaying those hideous words makes my stomach churn. A hot tear begins to roll down my cheek, falling into my lap as my eyes drop. A crack of silence follows my story, and I don’t dare look up from my hands, staring down at them folded in my lap.

“I couldn’t let her get away with that,” I add in a rasp.

I didn’t know Isobel, but no one deserves to be spoken about in such a way. Especially not someone who matters so much to this family. Someone who they all lost tragically. Someone who Cassio…

I needed her to never be able to say another word again.

“Good,” Dante finally says, the word like a declaration of law. “That’s certainly worth the sizable check I had to cut to the governor.”

I blink, looking up at him in surprise. “You already handled it? Even before I explained…?”

The man smiles softly, blue eyes crinkling at the sides. “I take Moretti Blood Marriages very seriously, Ana. You became my daughter the day you said your vows to my son, and spilled your blood for him.”

My heart gives a funny beat.

“I didn’t expect that you would fill the role so quickly nor so perfectly but I’m glad to see that you have.”

“Thank you, Dad,” Cassio says, noticing my stunned silence.

“Apollo would like a word with you, Ana,” Dante tells him, his thick Italian accent lightening up with his soft tone. “If that’s all right.”

“Why?” Cassio demands, tensing by my side.

“It’s okay,” I tell him, patting his hand. “You know I’ll be fine. He’s your brother, darling.”

“Come on, Son,” Dante encourages, standing up to head for the door. “Share a drink with me before I have to go.”

“Do anything to upset her, and I’ll kick your ass.”

Dante chuckles at Cassio’s threat, but Apollo merely rolls his eyes.

“You could try.”

“Armani would join me,” my husband promises. Pressing a kiss to the top of my head, he follows his father from the room, allowing the door to shut behind him.

Apollo gives me an assessing look, not saying a word.

“You wanted to speak with me?” I ask awkwardly.

“Next time you want to kill someone for saying something you don’t like, agree with them.”

“W-what?” I stutter, not sure I heard him correctly.

He continues to look at me in a way that I can’t decipher. “Agree with them, *bond* with them, and then invite them to a private location. Once you’re secluded, *then* you kill them.”

“Oh.” I blink, processing the advice. “So, Dante isn’t mad at me, but you are?”

“I’m not mad,” he disagrees. “I’m taking care of you. What if she had a guard, hmm? What if someone shot you in retaliation? What if the wrong person caught you on camera?”

Guilt flushes up my neck and I frown. “I didn’t think that far ahead, I was just so furious…”

“Which is why you’re not being reprimanded. You think you’re the first Moretti to do something dangerous and illegal unplanned in public? You’re not. But now that you’ve done this, you’ll remember it. You’ll *think* before you act again. If Nico can restrain himself, so can you.”

My stomach clenches and my reply is a broken whisper. “You think I’m like Nico?”

First I’m like Cole and now this?

“Similar,” Apollo tells me with a shrug. He doesn’t comment on the scared tone of my question, merely answers it as he would anything else. “But no, not the same.”

Tears well but none fall as I blink them away.

“Being like Nico isn’t a bad thing, Ana.”

He has to say that. Nico is his brother, and he loves him.

Looking at the apparent despair on my face, Apollo sighs and rolls his neck. “I’m going to tell you this because you appear vulnerable and unnecessarily disappointed and I *don’t like that*.”

Swallowing, I meet his eye. “Tell me what?”

“Nico… Nico is my favorite brother.”

I did not expect that. In fact, I couldn’t have guessed he was going to say that if there were a million dollars on the line.

“He is?”

“Do you understand how special it is to kill without remorse? The vast majority of human beings have to be trained in order to take a life at all, and they tend to be riddled with guilt and regret following the act. Literal soldiers freeze on the battlefield before pulling the trigger and they’re actively under attack.”

Tilting his head, he pauses like he’s watching the information sink in through my eyes. “People like to think that the world is overflowing with evil, and it is, but they forget just how drastically normal almost everyone is. That’s why it’s called normal. Nico, like you, like me… we are not normal.”

I breathe out shakily, listening as Apollo continues to speak.

“Nico enjoys the kill. He thrives in a torture session, and he’s methodical even in his enjoyment of it. You don’t hesitate to kill, and you don’t feel guilty, but you worry about what that says about you.”

“And you?” I ask, voice wavering.

“I care about this family and nothing else,” he replies without blinking. “Nothing. Else.”

I don’t understand how, but Apollo seems to be making me feel better. Perhaps he’s right. Why should I feel shame for something that isn’t shameful in this family? I don’t live in the normal world, so maybe expecting myself to be normal is silly.

“Shouldn’t you not have favorites?” I blurt out suddenly. “How can you choose between so many brothers?”

Apollo laughs dryly. “Nico is my favorite brother because he’s somehow got a piece of all of us in him. He’s quiet like Remo, determined like Leon, brooding like Elio, charming like Emilio—even if he’s acting while he does it. He’s picky with his clothing like Armani, he’s calculating like Cassio, and despite his typically dark demeanor, he’s as sarcastic as

Matteo. And like me, he doesn't give a singular fuck about anyone outside of this family."

So… Nico is his favorite, because he's actually all of them?

Why is that incredibly sweet?

"He's more than just an efficient and psychopathic killer. So, trust me when I tell you that being compared to him isn't something that should concern you. You should feel proud of it."

Maybe one day I will.

Clearing my throat to avoid getting too emotional, I stand up and nod slowly. "But just between us," I start, trying not to grin. "Jade is my favorite brother."

Apollo huffs. "I take it back. You're not Nico, you're Matteo."

A spirited laugh bursts from my lips.

I think I'm going to enjoy being a part of this family.

Ana Moretti *does* have a lovely ring to it.

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Chapter Twenty-Four



Cassio

"Things are going well with your wife, I take it?"

Glass half raised to my lips, I freeze, digesting my father's question. He's giving me one of his knowing looks, the kind of expression that tells me he already knows the answer to what he's asking.

"We've become close," I answer diplomatically, sipping the Italian rum I only keep on hand for family. Drinking alcohol isn't something I typically enjoy, but I'll do it sparingly with my father and brothers.

"I'm happy for you," he replies, folding his hands on the counter.

Dad may be fifty-one now, but he's aged incredibly well. He looks just like Apollo, just like everyone says, but has some faint wrinkles and gray speckling his dark hair.

"She seems to care deeply for you," he adds, watching my face for any subtle reactions to his words. "Killing someone for disrespecting Isobel and Angel, though she never knew them… she is a good match, yes?"

Good is too weak a word.

Still, I agree. "Yes, she is."

"And you care for her as well?"

"You know I do."

Dad hums, hiding a smile. "Indeed. I see the way you look at her, Son. I did not think I would be able to witness you in love once more. Though… this love is different than before. *New,* but powerful, isn't it?"

"You'd have a lucrative career as a psychic in another life, do you know that?" I drawl, setting my glass down. "She doesn't even know yet, I

haven’t said a word to you, and still you’ve got it all figured out.”

“I know my sons,” he explains simply.

“Thank you for coming so quickly,” I say, shifting the topic.

I’m not comfortable having my feelings for Ana dissected before I’ve explored and confessed them to her. I have no idea if she’s ready to receive that kind of information, and god forbid she overhears it.

“It was no trouble,” Dad tells me, a smile lifting the sides of his mouth. “Armani’s phone call was frantic and unexpected, but I’m glad he knew to come to me. My blood hasn’t been pumping so hard in the middle of the day since I found out your sister was pregnant.”

I huff through a chuckle. “Still an adrenaline junkie at your age? You’re playing with fire, old man.”

Dad scoffs. “Old man? I’m still in my prime, Son.”

He really is. Sometimes I think my age is wearing on me harder than his is, and he’s got over two decades on me.

“Anyway, you shouldn’t have any issues arising from this little incident,” he states, polishing off his drink. “Cameras have been wiped, witnesses have been spoken to, and the girl’s uncle has been threatened. His niece went “missing” on vacation and if he doesn’t want to join her, he’ll keep to that story.”

“Her body?”

“Cremated.”

Good. No body, no crime.

“And Ana’s other friends?”

“Shaken up a bit with shock, but smart enough to know not to say a word. I think they might be a bit scared of her now, but a little fear is good for the soul.”

“They weren’t very close anyway,” I inform him with a shrug. “Ana’s only true best friend is Jade, and Armani and Colton are certainly working their way up there. She isn’t quick to trust.”

“Except with you,” Dad remarks, smiling softly. “She’s taken to trusting you quite quickly, hasn’t she?”

Arching a brow, I reply, “You’ve never been so keen to gossip, Father.”

“I’ve never seen you so fulfilled before,” he tosses back.

His words send a surprised jolt to my gut.

“Never?”

“Never,” he agrees.

I blink, digesting his firm declaration.

“You were happy before, in love, even. But you’ve grown as a man, my son. Ana brings something out in you that I don’t think anyone—including you—expected. She’s good for you, and you’re good for her. A perfect match born from the ashes of disaster. It’s a bit poetic, honestly.”

Swallowing, I drop my gaze. “It’s still new.”

“Which means it will only continue to grow,” Dad warns. “Are you ready for that?”

Before I can answer, footsteps sound and within seconds, Ana and Apollo find us. Since she doesn’t look sad, I don’t have to punch my brother for upsetting her.

“Are you staying for dinner?” Ana asks the two men, taking the stool nearest mine. Apollo joins Dad on the other side of the counter but doesn’t pour himself a drink, answering Ana’s question without a word. If he’s not taking a glass, he’s not planning to stay.

“No, unfortunately, we need to get going,” Dad replies. “But don’t hesitate to reach out if you need anything, okay? Cassio will give you our numbers. Check in once and a while, won’t you?”

“If you think it won’t be a bother,” Ana agrees hesitantly.

Dad gives her a patient look. “It’s never a bother to hear from one of my children.”

“You’re one of Dante Moretti’s daughters now,” Apollo adds, smirking. “Milk it for all its worth.”

Ana laughs awkwardly. “If you say so.”

“That’s the spirit.” Dad chuckles.

“*Armani*,” I call up the stairs, hands cupped around my mouth. “Come say goodbye to your father!”

“Coming!” Colton calls back, rushing down the stairs to beat Armani to it. He comes running into the room with a big goofy grin while my brother trails behind him, rolling his eyes.

“Father Dante, Son of Zeus,” he greets, using his preferred nicknames for the two men. “Are you going to miss me?”

“Not even a little bit,” Apollo replies dully.

Colton pouts. “Grumpy.”

“Don’t be too offended,” Armani drawls. “He won’t miss me either.”

Ana covers her mouth to hide a giggle.

After quick goodbyes and promises to keep in touch, they let themselves out. Armani and Colton are quick to follow when Ana says that she's tired. They'll go out for a bit or go upstairs since I'm home with her, but either way, I'm glad to have my wife all to myself for a little while. I like that she's developing a friendship with them, but I'm greedy and haven't had nearly enough time with her recently.

"I feel exhausted and wired at the same time," Ana complains, climbing into her bed. She asked me to hold her so that she can attempt to nap, but I don't know if she'll be able to fall asleep.

Drawing her blinds to black out the room, I take a deep breath. Holding Ana has become more and more difficult as our connection has grown and my feelings have developed. And God, since kissing her… every time she's in my arms now, I have to restrain myself. Especially when I can feel her soft skin under my hands, yearning to explore more of it.

When I round the bed, I wish I'd taken the time to change into something more comfortable. I'm still wearing my button down and slacks, but thinking quickly, I roll up my sleeves and remove my belt, making my clothes less restrictive. Ana watches me with rapt attention, eyes tracking my every movement, traces of hunger in her stare that I need to ignore.

She's had a stressful day and she needs rest, she doesn't need me thinking corrupt thoughts about her.

"Turn on your side," I tell her, gently crawling into bed. "I'll rub your back."

"That sounds so nice," she gushes, immediately flipping over to face the wall. Just as I'm about to reach forward, she blurts, "Wait!" Scrambling with her sweater, she tugs it off, tossing the ball of fabric off the bed, to reveal a tight little camisole.

Jesus fucking Christ. The white fabric barely covers anything, leaving the center of her back, her shoulders and her arms entirely bare. Ana keeps her braid lying around her neck so that her hair isn't in the way, and sighs into her pillow, anticipating the soft caresses her back is about to be lavished with.

Starting with the back of my hand, I glide my knuckles up and down her spine slowly, listening to the soft breaths she releases every few seconds. Her skin pebbles under my touch and she wiggles back to get closer to my body. *Give me strength.*

"You're so good at that," she whispers, voice breathy and light.

Showing me her skin, lying so closely that I can feel her body heat, and now praising me in her sexy little accent? She's trying to kill me.

"I'm glad you like it," I husk, holding back any possibly inappropriate response.

"Can you do that here?" she asks, capturing my wrist and pulling my hand around to her front. I have to hold my breath as she slips my fingers under her shirt, showing me exactly what she'd like.

She wants me to run my knuckles up and down her stomach like I was doing with her spine. *Definitely* trying to kill me.

Biting the inside of my cheek, I do what she asks, almost groaning as she sighs happily. Her sweet little breaths are driving me insane, and somehow she's positioned herself even closer to me. Her back is flush against my chest, and my only saving grace is that her ass hasn't pushed back far enough to feel the obvious bulge expanding in my pants.

"Are you sleepy, Ana?" I whisper, continuing to caress her silky skin, fingertips occasionally teasing the band of her leggings.

"No, I'm too wound up I think," she murmurs, turning over her shoulder to look at me. "Are you tired?"

"No."

Leaning forward an inch, I capture her lips with mine. A keen sigh leaves her throat, muffling into our kiss. The sound parts her lips, and I use the opportunity to slip my tongue past them, groaning at the flood of her taste. Her tongue sweeps tentatively with mine, like she isn't quite sure how to properly move. She hasn't done this before, or she has limited experience. But no matter, I'll show her everything she needs to know.

Time bleeds around us as we share long and passionate kisses, slow fucking each other's mouths like a couple of eager teenagers. Rubbing her stomach quickly shifts into just her lower abdomen, toying more and more with the edge of her pants.

"Touch me," Ana whimpers against my mouth.

"Fuck," I growl, nipping her bottom lip. "You sure?"

"I'll be so fucking cross with you if you stop now, Cassio," she threatens, fingers reaching back to grab my thigh and squeeze.

There's no way to deny her now. Not when we both want it so badly.

Slipping beneath the band over her leggings and her panties, my fingers glide over smooth, soaking wet flesh.

"*Fuuuuck, baby*. You're drenched."

Ana whimpers, eyes fluttering shut as I explore her sex, locating her sensitive little clit in seconds.

“These panties are fucking ruined, Ana,” I taunt, peppering her jaw with rough kisses, heading for her nape. “Is this all for me?”

“Yes,” she hisses, arching her back to give me access to her neck. “Cassio, I need… I need more.”

“Tell me what you want,” I demand, circling her clit hard.

“Inside,” she rushes out. “Please, I need you inside me.”

I don’t need to be told twice.

Dragging my fingertips down to her slit, my middle finger teases around the opening before pushing forward. Hot skin hugs the digit tight as Ana clenches around me.

“Goddamn, baby,” I groan, planting open-mouth kisses up the side of her throat. “You feel so fucking good.”

Pumping my finger in and out, I relish the way her mouth drops open and unfiltered moans of pleasure spill from her lips.

“Please,” she rasps. “Don’t stop, Cassio, I—”

“Don’t worry, my pretty little wife. I’ll give you exactly what you need.” Pressing forward, my cock grinds against her ass while I slowly work a second finger into her dripping wet cunt.

Ana whimpers and wiggles, her pussy constricting around me hard. She’s so wound up, and the temptation to flip her on her back and pound her into the mattress is growing stronger with every moan she releases.

“Shhh, relax for me, baby,” I encourage, rubbing her clit with my palm as my fingers plunge deeper. “I’ll take care of you, just breathe. Let me play with this sweet little pussy.”

She takes a deep and shaky breath, dropping her head back against my shoulder. My fingers curl up, dragging against the sensitive top wall.

“Cassio,” she moans, rolling her hips into the sensation. “God, *Cassio*—”

“Mmm,” I hum, breathing against the side of her throat. “That’s a good girl, my name has never sounded better… say it again.”

“Cassio,” she gasps, hand clasping around my forearm for support. She digs her nails into my flesh, but doesn’t try to pull away. She’s so responsive, my dick is fucking throbbing behind my zipper.

Thrusting my fingers rough and fast, I pull heartier moans from her throat. “You like that, Wife? Getting fucked nice and deep on my hand?

Imagine how much deeper my cock will go, how much fucking harder it will be to keep those pretty little sounds you're making under control."

"I want that," she pleads breathlessly. "Please?"

"Look at you being so polite," I bite out, jaw flexing. She has no idea how much her words affect me. How badly I want to give her exactly what she's asking for. "Come for me, and maybe you'll earn it."

My efforts pick up, leaving no room for her to reply. She babbles senselessly, a jumble of moans, begging, and the wet sounds of her arousal filling the room. It doesn't take long before my increased speed sends Ana over the edge.

Her hot cunt clenches hard, pulsing around my fingers, and flooding my hand. Soon, her legs tremble and her climax peaks with a long drawn-out moan. I have to bite my lip to stop myself from breaking, watching and feeling her orgasm shatter through her.

Ana slumps heavily against me, trying to catch her breath as I withdraw my fingers. Unable to resist, I pull the digits between my lips and groan, sucking on her taste.

"So sweet," I drawl, licking every drop.

"That was incredible," she husks, heated eyes watching my every move.

"Good."

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Chapter Twenty-Five



Ana

Cassio just blew my fucking mind. I've never had an orgasm that strong, not even on my own with the assistance of my buzzy little toys.

"Please don't tell me we're done," I rasp, turning over to face my husband. I don't think I've said the word please this much in one day in my whole entire life. Something about Cassio just has me willing to beg.

Wanting to explore his body like he's explored mine, I run my fingers down his chest, running them over his soft shirt I wish would disappear.

"Let's walk before we run, forza," he says, snatching my hand before I can drag it all the way down.

"I like running."

Before he can rebuttal, I press forward, sealing my mouth over his. He lets me kiss him, returning the affection momentarily. All too soon, he pulls back, grasping my face with his clean hand.

"I want you," I pout.

"You think you know what you're asking for, don't you, Wife?" Cassio asks, running his fingers over my jaw. His gaze is so intense, pulling me into a sea of blue as I stare back into it. "You think I'll be gentle and calm, holding you close and muttering sweet nothings as I take you slowly. You think you're ready for it, because you know I love taking care of you—that I'd never hurt you."

"You won't." I shiver. "You'd never hurt me."

"No, my sweet wife, I'd never hurt you," he agrees, leaning forward to tease the shell of my ear with his teeth. "And I can be gentle, sometimes I

will be… but if you think I can contain myself the first time I fill your snug little pussy, you'd best think again, love."

My stomach flutters, but Cassio isn't done tormenting me with his sensual promises.

"I'm going to lose myself as soon as I feel how hot and tight you are, Wife. I'll be brutal, demanding, and I'll pound into you so hard, you'll feel me in your stomach. Your screams will only spur me on, especially since you'll *like it.*"

"Please," I whimper, asking—no *pleading*—for him to make good on his word.

"You'll like it so much, Ana." He tilts my head back to brush his lips against mine, moving back when I attempt to make it deeper. "But you won't be able to handle it, sweet wife. I'll drive you mad. You know why?"

"Why?" I demand.

"Because, eager girl," he teases, grinning. "I won't let you come, not at first. I'll drag it out for so long, you'll want to cry. You'll curse me, and you'll protest with threats, but I won't listen. I'll take you higher and higher until you're brought to the brink of insanity. Then and only then will I allow you to burst."

"I can handle it," I practically snarl, fisting his shirt. "You told me I'm strong, were you lying?"

"Oh, you're strong." Cassio's hand moves down to my camisole, tugging it down on one side to free a breast. My nipple pebbles from the touch of air and he snatches it between his thumb and forefinger, smiling when a moan escapes me. "But are you strong enough to take this without preparation?"

Before I can ask what he means, he detaches my hands from his shirt. Guiding me by my wrists, he plants my palm against the bulge in his pants.

Oh, bloody *fucking* hell.

He's *huge*.

A rush of adrenaline slams into me and my eyes snap up to meet his.

"Yeah," Cassio rasps, squeezing my hand around his length. "You see, Wife, I can't just lay you down and take you with this, now can I? I'll need to stretch you with my fingers, and toy with you with my mouth first. Why do you think I'm going to edge you so hard once I finally get inside of you, hmm?"

My husband brushes his lips forward, but nips at my bottom lip instead of kissing me soundly.

“You’ll already be three or four orgasms ahead of me, and I can’t have you being too spoiled, can I?” He tsks, shaking his head. “No, you’ll need to wait until I’m ready. The first time you come all over my cock, I’ll be filling you at the same time. I’ll have earned that, won’t I?”

“Cassio, I swear to god—”

“Swear all you want, Wife,” he cuts in. “I told you, I’m going to drive you mad.” His mouth descends on my breast, leaving no room for argument. His warm tongue twirls around my sensitive nipple, causing my head to tip back as a carnal moan bursts from my lips.

“If you want my cock as badly as you claim, you’ll lie back on our bed and spread your gorgeous legs for me.”

“I—”

“You won’t be needing these,” he continues, ripping my leggings and knickers in one swift tug. He’s torn the black cotton and pink lace straight from my body like a caveman!

Gobsmacked, I breathe out hard and blink at him. His eyes have darkened, searing me with his hungry leer. “I liked those leggings.”

“I’ll buy you more,” he huffs, tossing the tatters of fabric away like they’ve offended him by hiding my body. “Fifty more if you do as you’re told.”

Oh, I like that stern, dominant tone.

“Make your mind up, Wife,” Cassio commands. “Lie back and let me devour you, or my cock isn’t going anywhere near your sweet little pussy tonight. Come on, Ana. Show me how brave you are. Be a good girl for me.”

He wants brave? I’ll be downright fearless.

Thumbing the edges of my shirt, I lift my back from the bed and shed the white material. Entirely nude while he’s still fully dressed, I center myself on the bed, pulling off the tie that keeps my braid in place. I want to feel my hair sprawled out all around me while we do this. I want it to get messy and wild, unrestrained in every way.

“Let me see you,” I request, pulling my fingers through my hair to undo the braid.

Cassio pops open the buttons on his shirt, his eyes never leaving me as he sheds the garment. He moves to work on his trousers next, and my

greedy eyes soak up every detail. His tan skin, all the curves and edges that make up his body, the happy trail of dark hair from his belly button to beneath his boxers, and the deep v-lines of his hips.

He's an absolute vision. More muscular than I imagined he would be, with toned lines and thick biceps I'd like to sink my teeth into. He has a slimmer frame than some of his brothers, but it's clear he's expertly crafted his body, taking care of its pristine condition over the years.

My teeth sink into my lip as he strips down to nothing, his rock-hard cock slapping against his strong thigh as he moves. It's a little bit darker than his naturally sun-kissed complexion, sitting on top of his swollen balls. A pearl of precum glistens from the fat tip, and my mouth waters, wondering what he'd taste like if I licked him.

"Spread your legs," he instructs, fist circling around his thick shaft. "Show me what I'm about to feast on, *forza*."

Watching with rapt attention as he pumps his length twice, my legs part, exposing myself to him fully. Like he can't wait a second longer, he descends, kneeling on the bed and lowering his face down. I suck in a breath, seeing his back for the first time. Two black and gray fallen angels paint his shoulder blades in perfect ink, one smaller than the other. For his lost loved ones, I assume.

We both have tattoos on our back for our families.

Another sign that has me believing my husband and I are somehow meant to be. We found each other in the most unconventional of ways, but I can't help suspecting that fate played a hand in bringing me to him.

Chills crawl up my arms as Cassio inhales, gliding his nose up to the innermost part of my thighs. He rumbles with a groan, like he's basking in my scent and the sight of me. He's so intense in everything he does, and I brace myself for what's about to come.

But nothing could prepare me for how his mouth feels when he roughly rolls his tongue up the length of my slit. A gasp flies from my lips and my ribs lift, back arching high. There's no easing me into it, Cassio *devours* me like a man starved. He licks and sucks, hitting every sensitive bit of flesh with skillful precision.

A broken moan vibrates in my throat, and my hands pull my sheets into tense fists. I find myself creeping closely to a peak, chasing the feeling with abandon. I'm going to come embarrassingly fast, and I couldn't give a fuck if I tried.

He feels *amazing*.

“You taste so fucking good, baby,” Cassio groans, punctuating his claim by twirling his tongue around my clit.

“Mmmmf,” I whimper. “Make me ready for you, I can’t wait, Cassio. Please, please—”

Nudging my legs open further, he answers my prayer, pushing two digits inside me. The added pressure of being fingered while he licks me out sends me tumbling into an unstoppable climax. My eyes flutter shut, and I twitch hard, rocking into his face to chase the high.

“Oh god, oh god,” I babble hoarsely.

“That’s one.”

Oh bloody fuck, he sounds so goddamn pleased with himself. I can practically feel his grin against my cunt.

There’s no time to rest as Cassio starts using his tongue to lavish my overly sensitive pussy over and over. He uses the cum from my latest orgasm to slip a third finger inside of me, thrusting and twisting the digits to stretch me out faster.

He’s fueled by every moan I let out, and every unrelenting twitch of my body. He’s undeniably talented with his mouth, giving me exactly what I need and more. He doesn’t force me into a quick orgasm again, instead he makes strange patterns around my clit with his tongue, changing the pressure too often for me to fixate on one feeling.

“You know what I’m doing right now, Wife?”

“Driving me crazy?” I breathe.

“I’m spelling my fucking name on this greedy little clit. She likes it so much, doesn’t she?”

No fucking way.

Sure enough, if I focus on the way his tongue moves. I can make out every letter.

C. A. S. S. I. O.

He repeats the pattern at least three more times, meticulously drawing most of the letters in a slow pace, but speeding up with the O.

Cassio works me over like he knows my body better than anyone ever could. I can’t help but think that he was fucking made for me. Needing to feel him closer, my fingers delve into his soft hair, holding him while he works. My husband moans happily and somehow manages to shoves his pinky alongside his other three fingers.

Instantly, it all becomes too much. I explode without warning, a scream rippling from my chest.

“Ahhhh, yesss,” I hiss, throbbing around his fingers and throwing my head back.

“Fuck yeah, baby,” Cassio encourages, thrusting harder and faster, fucking me through it. “Just like that, come all over my fingers, Ana.”

Seconds maybe minutes pass as unending pleasure soars through me. When it finally fades, Cassio slows down, kissing my clit as if praising the bundle of nerves. Dazed from the three orgasms he’s inflicted, I look down at his glistening lips with a tired smile.

“Will you fuck me now?”

Cassio sits up, licking his lips and retracting his fingers. Reaching between my legs, my fingers wrap around his dick, trying to replicate the way he tugged himself earlier. I scoot down, needing to feel him against me. One swipe through my soaked cunt, and he becomes tense.

“Fuck, wait—” He pulls away, scrambling for his pants and I whine.

“What, why?”

“Condom,” he explains, grabbing his wallet from his trouser pocket.

“I have the arm implant…”

Cassio hesitates, hands tightening around the leather fold.

“Don’t you want to come in me?” I ask, biting my bottom lip.

“Fucking Christ, Ana,” he groans. “You have no idea how badly I want to take you raw. I just… can’t. If I get you pregnant… I can’t.”

Noticing a panicked shift to his mood, I don’t press. “It’s okay,” I tell him, smiling. “We can talk about it later.”

Breathing out a relieved puff of air, Cassio nods. He pulls a roll of three condoms from his wallet, picking one and tearing it open with his teeth.

“How long have you had those there?”

“Far too soon into our marriage to admit.”

“Tell me,” I demand, flattery flushing up my neck.

“The first night when you asked me to sleep with you,” he confesses, rolling the rubber over his cock. “Grabbed a box that morning, just in case.”

My chest flushes with warmth. “You wanted me.”

“You have no fucking idea.”

“I have some idea,” I retort, looking him up and down. “Have you seen yourself, Cassio? You’re ridiculously sexy.”

He pins me with a searing look. “I need to be inside of you.”

Without another word, he lifts my hips and shoves a pillow under my arse, maneuvering me into position to fuck me. The next second, he's lining himself up, prodding my opening and pressing forward.

His cock is so much thicker than his fingers—more intense too. His skin is soft but surrounded by something so incredibly hard, like stone. The blunt tip meets resistance, even with how much he worked me up to this. We're both desperate now, though, and there's no going back.

"I can take it," I tell him, despite feeling a slight burn. "Take me, Cassio. Show me that I'm all yours."

Spurred on by my encouragement, Cassio grips my hips hard and slides home. I'm split open and filled to the brim, legs forced to open wider by his hips. A yelp spills out of me, but it doesn't quite hurt. It's overwhelming and intense, but I quickly decide that I love it.

"You're squeezing me so fucking hard," he grits out. Pulling back an inch or two, he rocks right back in, absorbing the feeling.

"You're too big," I cry out, but it's not a complaint. My hands lift instinctively, reaching up to hold on to his shoulders.

"Not too big," he argues, giving another short stroke. "Just fucking right, baby. We're a perfect goddamn fit, you and me."

My pussy clenches at his assessment, and I pant heavily. "I thought you wouldn't be able to hold back?"

"Smart fucking mouth," he tsks, one hand leaving my side to cup my breast. "You better hold on, my mouthy little wife. And don't you dare fucking come until I tell you to."

Oh god.

All the air is knocked right from my lungs as he pulls out and slams back in. His cock thrusts into my cunt so fast that his balls quietly slap against my ass, and my toes curl into the mattress. Like he promised, Cassio starts fucking me without restraint, thrusting in earnest. Slick noises, moaning, and breathing fills the room as my body goes slack.

"*Holy shhhhhit,*" I moan, feeling my breasts jump, one captured under his palm, the other free to bounce as he moves.

"Yeah," he grunts in agreement. "Holy. Fucking. Shit."

His hips slam forward, pumping harder, using his grip on my hip to keep me close, our bodies molding together. I'm throbbing around his cock, legs twitching while my nerves crackle and become entirely overwhelmed by every sensation Cassio provides.

“You’re doing so fucking good for me, aren’t you?”

“Y-yes,” I gasp.

Letting go of my side, he hooks that arm under one of my knees, hand splaying on the inside of my thigh. He’s holding me so tight, I hope he leaves a handprint.

“It’s t-too much,” I stammer, feeling heat building below my stomach. “I’m gonna… Cassio, I can’t take it.”

“You’re taking it just fine, baby,” he disagrees, continuing to pound into me with deep strokes. “You need to come, is that it? Feels too good, huh?”

“Please, please, please,” I beg, squeezing his shoulders hard. My nails bite into his skin and he groans like he enjoys it.

“Since you’ve been so good…” he trails off, teasing me for a moment longer.

“*Uhhh, please!*”

“Come now,” he demands, voice steely and rough.

The hand on my breast leaves and drops to my clit, pinching hard, forcing an orgasm to crash through me at lighting speed. Delicious warmth ripples over every inch of me, as my vision begins to black. Cassio groans loudly, slapping a hand against the headboard and gripping it hard. His cock throbs inside of me as he spills into the condom, moaning deeply.

Rolling off of me and onto his back, Cassio breathes hard, catching his breath. I don’t know how long I lay by his side, panting and trying to get my breath back. After a while, he kisses the side of my face and clammers out of bed to dispose of the condom.

Rushing water pricks at my ears, and before I know it, my husband is carrying me right out of bed and depositing me into a warm bubbly bath. I sigh in appreciation as my sore muscles sing happily. Joining me on the other side of the large clawfoot tub, he catches my eye.

“That was…” I start, unable to find the right words.

“Yeah,” he agrees, brilliant blue eyes twinkling. “It was”

Cassio plucks up one of my feet and begins to knead the arch of it, rubbing the bath bubbles into my skin. It feels even more intimate than the wild sex we just partook in.

“Has anyone ever made accusations about our union being false?”

Cassio frowns, continuing to massage my foot. “Why do you ask?”

I shrug slightly, trying not to blush. “When Dmitri was advising me about the contract, he said it wasn’t hard to tell when a man has never seen

his wife naked. And we didn't consummate for over a month."

"We didn't make very many appearances together," Cassio points out. "But even if we did, no one would suspect a thing, I assure you."

"You sound so certain." I laugh.

"I never needed to see you naked to look at you like you were completely and utterly mine, Ana."

My heart thuds in my chest, stomach tightening with a mixture of shock and desire.

"Dmitri didn't give you bad advice, in another circumstance it may have made all the difference for you. But I think we've both realized by now, there's nothing typical about our connection, *forza*."

"I can't believe you feel it too," I admit in a whisper. "Sometimes it feels like this is all one big dream…"

"Believe me, Wife, no dream could possibly capture what we've found together."

My heartbeat picks up tempo, digesting his statement. Without another thought, I move. Water sloshes around the tub's edges as I prowl toward him, straddling his lap. I need him again, right here in this bath. His obvious erection seems to agree with me. Sinking down on his length, I let my head fall back, releasing a long breathy moan.

There's no way we're leaving my bedroom tonight.

I'm not done being fucked by my husband.

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Chapter Twenty-Six



Ana

Familiar footsteps tumble down the stairs, and I don't need to open my eyes to know Armani and Colton have arrived. The two huge men make quite the ruckus when they aren't trying to be stealthy, but the sound is almost comforting at this point.

I like them. I like how effortless it is to be friends with them, and I really like how genuine they are. I was worried when they first started to bond with me that their presence in my life was purely out of pity, but they've shown me how untrue that is every day since.

A small smile tugs at my lips, maybe their company will distract me from the ache between my legs and the cramping in my gut.

I've been lying down with my legs propped up on the back of the couch, my hair flowing off the edge of the seat while letting the sunrays warm my face through the window. In this position, I'm able to keep the bag of peas between my legs without holding it there, using the back cushions to prop it up.

Having been icing my vagina for an hour now, I thought my soreness would be lessening but I still feel wrecked. Cassio did a number on me, but I can't be mad at it. Last night was phenomenal, even if he had to leave for work early this morning.

"Is there frozen produce on your lady bits right now?" Colton asks with his amused southern drawl.

"Did you just call my cunt *lady bits*?" I ask in return.

Armani laughs. "Did you just say cunt?"

My shoulders draw up in a shrug. “I’m English, it was either cunt or fanny.”

I hope they’re smiling, finding this interaction as humorous as I do. My eyes are still closed, but I can feel both of them watching me from only a few feet away.

“And does icing your *fanny* have anything to do with all the screaming you got up to last night?” Colton teases.

His words make my face flush with heat, and I can’t help the grin that forms on my lips.

“I haven’t the foggiest idea what you’re speaking of,” I reply in my finest prim accent, tipping my chin up. I allow my eyes to flutter open once I’ve angled them far enough from the sun and smile. “You look so weird upside down, like you’re standing on the ceiling but your hat isn’t falling off.”

Colton snorts at my comment and folds his arms. “Didn’t you know? It’s sewn into my hair.”

I giggle at his deadpan tone. “Efficient.”

“You’re happy this morning,” Armani comments, tilting his head. “Did Cassio sex your brains out?”

Sighing dreamily, I nod. “And apparently rearranged my internal organs while he was at it. I feel like there’s a knife in my cervix.”

“Ouch,” Colton says with a wince. “Did you take anything for the pain?”

I groan and shake my head. “Not yet, I was hoping it would pass quickly. I don’t think it should hurt this much, honestly. It didn’t last night.”

Immediately their faces both shift into concern and I don’t like it. It makes me uneasy, more so than I already am.

“What?”

“Ana, if it hurts more than you think it should, maybe it *is* hurting more than it should,” Armani suggests gently. “I’m going to call Doc.”

He reaches for his phone before even waiting for my reply, and I grimace. “No, no, don’t bother him. I’m probably just being a baby about it.”

“Don’t play off pain because you think it will inconvenience someone,” Colton chastises. “If it hurts so much that it feels wrong, it could be something internal.”

“Really,” I insist, seeing Armani begin to type out a message. “I’m fine, see.” I try to hold back my wince as I swing my legs down and stand up from the sofa. I let the bag of peas fall to the ground and attempt to ignore the way my head swims. Getting up so fast was a bad idea, I just went ahead and made myself dizzy. Great.

Blinking twice, I steady myself as much as possible and look up from the rug to my two friends. “Perfectly fine,” I say, attempting a smile.

My stomach is protesting with sharp cramps but Colton and Armani are the ones who look like they’re about to be sick. They’re not meeting my eyes, both of them fixed on my lower half. Suddenly frightened by their intense gaze, I look down and gasp.

Blood.

So. Much. Blood.

It’s dark and soaked through my shorts, starting to roll down my thigh. The bag of peas by my feet has stained the carpet pink, and my head spins, finding a puddle has accumulated on the coach where I’d been lying.

Nausea hits me like a storm, and my body starts to feel cold.

“Oh god,” I whimper as a roll of dizziness takes over.

My vision goes hazy, and my ears ring.

Colton’s loud voice seems muffled and panicked. “Cassio, fuck, get up here. Ana’s bleeding!”

I feel hands surrounding my biceps… and then it all goes black.

Consciousness comes back slowly, aided by the sounds of chaos surrounding me. Familiar voices are yelling and barking orders. Eyes fluttering open, I wince at the bright lights overhead. White surrounds me on every side, and the smell of sterile chemicals fills my nostrils.

What the fuck?

Am I in the hospital?

“Cassio, you need to calm the fuck down,” Armani’s voice floats through the door. “You heard him, she’s fine. Stop throwing shit!”

“I did this to her!” my husband yells back. The hurt and panic in his voice makes my stomach drop.

“You know that isn’t true—”

“You’re awake,” a deep voice says from my side, startling me out of my eavesdropping.

“Doc?” I gape, recognizing the familiar man. “You’re in New York? Wait, we’re still in New York, aren’t we?”

“Yes, we haven’t moved states,” he answers patiently. “I’ve been staying here in case any of the Morettis need me. Dr. Petrov has taken my place with the rest of the family temporarily.”

Dr. Petrov is one of the Morozovs’ trusted doctors. He worked at Empire Academy while Dmitri and Ivan attended. He’s the man who confirmed Jade’s pregnancy.

Suddenly remembering what happened to bring me here, I swallow. “I was bleeding. What happened? Why is Cassio yelling?”

“You lost about two ounces of blood,” Doc begins to explain slowly. “It scared you, and you fainted.”

“I’m okay, aren’t I? You don’t seem very concerned.”

He nods, lips twitching at my assessment. “Yes, you’re perfectly healthy. You experienced some spontaneous Menorrhagia—heavy menstrual bleeding—likely brought on from an increase in hormones after intercourse. I did an ultrasound to rule out any sort of internal bleeding, and a vaginal exam to check for any tearing, both came back negative.”

“Jesus,” I mutter. So, *that’s* why Cassio is blaming himself. He thinks he put me here because we had sex. “How long was I out?”

“You’ve been in and out of consciousness for a half hour. Your bleeding has mostly stopped, only some light spotting now. I’d given you morphine for the pain before we discovered the cause, the men insisted upon it. It was a bit overkill now that we know, but it will certainly take care of any remaining cramps you may be having.”

The ridiculousness of this situation hits me, and giggles of disbelief start to fall from my lips. Doc gives me a questioning look, tilting his head and arching a brow. It only makes me laugh harder.

“S-sorry, sorry,” I chuckle, trying to calm down. “It’s just—I haven’t had a full period since I got my implant. And now you’re telling me that I essentially had a whole menstrual cycle in a matter of hours, bleeding enough to scare myself into fainting.”

“It’s uncommon, but hormone changes can do very intense things to women’s bodies,” Doc replies. “Especially when coupled with long term use of birth control. Your implant has regulated you to a new normal for your body, and any changes can create a reaction. Not to mention the immense stress you’ve been under after what has happened to you…”

Right, I frown. People say that stress can kill you, after all.

“It’s unlikely that you’ll experience anything like this again, as it’s quite rare. Try not to let it cause you too much concern, you appear to be in good health otherwise.”

Sighing, I try to wrap my head around the concept. I’m almost pissed for the female kind. We don’t have enough to deal with as women already? Now I know that *this shit* can happen?

“Can you tell Cassio I want to see him?”

“Of course.”

Just before he reaches the door, I remember my manners.

“And thank you,” I blurt quickly. “For helping me.”

Doc pauses, hand latched around the door handle. “It is a privilege to serve the Moretti family.”

As soon as he opens the door, Cassio is standing in front of him.

“Is she awake?” he demands, peering around the man. His eyes find mine and his shoulders drop in relief. Barging past Doc, he storms over to my bedside with wild eyes. “How do you feel? Are you in pain? I’m so fucking sorry, Ana.”

“*Cassio*,” I interrupt his panic. “I’m fine, I’m not in any pain. The morphine you insisted upon has taken care of that, I assure you.”

In fact, I might be a little buzzed from it. But I can hardly confess that to my overly worried husband without sending him into some kind of tizzy.

“Now, what’s this shit about you being sorry?” I demand, reaching for his hand to pull him closer. He sits on the side of my bed as I tug him down, a guilty look painting his face.

“I did this to you, Ana,” he croaks, looking away in shame. “Why does this keep happening to me? We shouldn’t have sex anymore, I can’t hurt you again. I always end up hurting the women I’m with.”

He’s so scared and sad, it’s obvious in the way his body remains tense and his voice cracks with emotion. I want to be able to be sweet, to mutter sweet words and tell him everything is going to be okay. But I’m *pissed*.

I don’t know whether it’s the morphine, or the fact that I haven’t been able to eat yet today. Either way, I want to bite his head off instead of comforting him.

“Don’t say that,” I snap, squeezing his hand. “You didn’t do anything to me. It was a freak accident. I loved having sex, and I’m certainly not agreeing to stop now.”

“You don’t understand—”

“*You* don’t understand,” I growl. “I’m so sorry for what happened to you in the past, Cassio. But I’m not Isobel, and I’m not dying. And you didn’t do that to her either. You can’t blame yourself for acts of God.”

“I got her pregnant, I killed her.”

I can practically feel my heart crack. I can’t let my anger take over now, Cassio needs me. He’s been here through my grief, and I need to do the same. We’ve both been through too much, but we’re stronger with each other. He’s shown me that time and time again.

“Jade said Matteo told her you tried to get pregnant for years,” I tell him patiently. “You didn’t force that on her. She wanted a baby, didn’t she?”

He stubbornly shakes his head. “It doesn’t matter.”

“It *does* matter.” My hands lift from the bed, reaching for his face. His cheeks are warm under my palms as I turn his head. “If I blamed myself for Cole’s death, you would tell me the same. You *did* tell me the same.”

“It wasn’t your fault.”

“And Isobel’s death wasn’t yours,” I tell him slowly—*firmly*. “I’m sorry if seeing me bloody triggered something for you, but you have to know that I don’t blame you. And even knowing as little about her as I do, I know she wouldn’t want you to blame yourself either.”

Cassio sighs, leaning forward to brush my lips in a kiss. “This scared the fuck out of me, Ana. I saw you bleeding and thought I fucking died. I was transported straight to Hell in an instant. I need you, you can’t leave me.”

“I’m not going anywhere,” I whisper, pressing our lips back together. I smile into our kiss before pulling back. “But you can’t treat me like glass after this, Husband. I’m going to want you again, and soon.”

“Minx,” he accuses, a tentative smile pulling at his lips.

Caressing his face, I ask, “Do you feel better?”

“I’m better,” he confirms, breathing out. “You calmed me down. I didn’t mean to go doomsday and bring up Isobel like that.”

“You said it before, we’re bound to talk about them. I’m not upset.”

It isn’t like Cassio just started waxing poetry about her and how much he loved and missed her. No, he was consumed by guilt from his past coming back to haunt him.

“I *am* hungry though,” I admit, nudging him playfully. “Think you can pick me up something to eat without throwing anything or hitting anyone? Where are we, anyway? Are we close to food?”

Cassio chuckles. “Yes, we’re close to food. The Kings own the basement floor of the hospital closest to the penthouse. Doc has a few rooms here for us and got you in quickly. I can go grab something. What are you in the mood for?”

“A fried chicken sandwich,” I decide, mouth watering. “With pickles, and I want a chocolate milkshake too.” My stomach growls loudly. “I think the morphine is really kicking in.”

Chuckling, my husband stands from the bed. “I’ll be quick.”

“Send in Armani and Colton?”

“I wouldn’t leave you alone,” Cassio agrees. “We were only in the hallway to try and calm me down.”

Dropping a kiss to the top of my head, he lets himself out and seconds later, two bodies emerge from the hall.

“I hear you’re all better now,” Colton chimes, being the first to speak.

“Much, *much* better,” I agree. “Stress and hormones gave me my period, and after years of barely having it, there was *a lot* of blood.”

Grimacing at the memory of the bloody couch, I shake off the thought in favor of waggling my eyebrows at my friends. “But it’s okay, Cassio’s giant dick didn’t injure me, so I can have it again.”

Colton sputters with a surprised laugh. “His giant dick, huh?”

“Huggggee,” I confirm, tilting my head at the tattooed man by his side. I lower my voice and lean closer to whisper, “Do you think that’s hereditary?”

Armani snorts. “Wouldn’t you like to know, you flirt.”

Colton doubles over bellowing with laughter. Between my crass question and Armani’s responding teasing, I’m about to start giggling to join him. But with the shift in his body, I find Dante and Apollo are near the doorway, only a few feet from us.

“Uh-oh,” I mumble, eyes flaring wide. I reach out and smack Armani’s forearm. “Why didn’t you say you weren’t alone? Do you think they heard me talking about Cassio’s… package?”

He cracks an amused smile. “No, no, you’re very discreet, sorellina.”

With the drugs coursing through my system, I can’t tell if he’s being sarcastic or not. I choose to believe him for my own sanity.

Apollo knocks on the open door as if he hasn’t heard a thing, and Dante steps inside as Armani waves him in.

“You guys came back?” I ask nervously. “You didn’t have to do that, you *just* went home.”

“As if,” Armani chuckles. “They got notified as soon as we called Doc, and hearing that you were bleeding? No way they’d stay home.”

“What’s the point of owning a jet if you don’t use it?” Colton jokes.

“Too bad they missed Cassio’s meltdown, Apollo could have slapped some sense into him.”

“I handled him just fine without violence, thank you,” I gripe, folding my arms. I don’t like the idea of anyone hitting my man, even his brother.

Dante chuckles good-naturedly. “Could I have a moment with my daughter, boys?”

Armani nods, grabbing Colton’s arm and heading for the hall again.

“No fair, Father Dante never wants a moment alone with me.”

“Ana’s prettier than you,” Armani deadpans.

Colton gasps. “You take that back.”

I snort at their antics and watch as the door clicks shut.

“How are you feeling, Ana?” Dante asks, a soft concern in his voice.

Unexpected giggles bubble out of me. “Doc gave me Morphine, I feel *very* good.”

A tentative smile twitches on his lips. “I’ll bet you do. You gave us all quite the scare, I’m glad it turned out to be a false alarm.”

A big sigh leaves me and I nod slowly. “Meeee too. I’m tired of bad things happening all the time, Dad.”

It doesn’t occur to me what I’ve just said until I see the shift of surprise on his face.

“I-I mean…” I cringe, not knowing what to—

“Don’t correct yourself, Ana,” he cuts in. “I told you, you are a Moretti daughter. *My* Moretti daughter. Call me Dad, or Father, or whatever it is that feels natural to you.”

Suddenly misty-eyed, my throat bobs. “You don’t have to—be so good to me, I mean. You’ve already given me so much, more than I’ve ever had.”

“It’s not a burden to bring you into this family,” Dante tells me sternly. “I have extensive practice being a father. I assure you, one more daughter won’t break me.”

His words warm my stomach and cause a singular tear to fall. Sniffling back the tender emotions, I offer a watery smile.

“I didn’t honestly expect a whole family to come with my wedding vows,” I admit quietly. “It’s nice… more than I need, really. Cassio would be enough.”

Dante’s tentative smile broadens into a full-on grin. “Now, how couldn’t I make the woman who brought my son back to life one of my own, hmm?”

I’ve never had a dad before, not really.

Bron has only been in my life for a few years, and he never cemented himself as a father figure. But somehow, after less than a year of knowing him, calling Dante ‘Dad’ just feels right.

“Okay, Dad,” I murmur.

His smile of approval feels like a warm hug.

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Chapter Twenty-Seven



Cassio

The Moretti brother group chat is going wild by the time we get home from the hospital. Apparently Apollo hasn't seen fit to keep his mouth shut.

ELIO

Heard your wife offed someone, nice.

MATTEO

Our little Ana did? Why is this the first I'm hearing of this! I want details.

NICO

I'm not surprised. I'd stab someone if I had to live in that dreadful city too.

MATTEO

Yeah, THAT'S why you'd stab someone. *eye roll emoji*

Sighing, I start to type.

CASSIO

MY Ana, Matteo. There is no "ours" about her.

LEON

Oh it's like that, is it, brother?

ELIO

Possessive, that's new.

MATTEO

Jade says you have to share with her at least.

CASSIO

No.

MATTEO

She was my best friend first! —Jade

CASSIO

Husband trumps best friend.

EMILIO

Melani says that's debatable. Luckily, she has no best friend.

MATTEO

I'm Melani's best friend ;)

I snort at Matteo's antics. The boy has been teasing Emilio about how pretty his wife is since before they even officially married.

EMILIO

I'm going to block you.

NICO

I'm going to block all of you.

ARMANI

For the record, Ana is also one of my best friends now. Jade better watch out. Colton and I are here every day, we're stealing her away.

MATTEO

She said, and I quote "bring it on, bitch!"

MATTEO

I did not! —Jade

Jade isn't permitted to be in this particular chat, as it isn't always appropriate conversation meant for her eyes. But Matteo sometimes fills her in on what we're talking about, and we have another chat that she's allowed to be in. Dmitri is in that one as well.

My phone pings again and I smile softly while reading the message.

REMO

Is Ana all right? Dad said he needed to visit her in the hospital?

MATTEO

The hospital?!

CASSIO

She’s fine, it was a false alarm. Thank you for asking, Remo.

MATTEO

Jesus Christ, you should really keep us updated on this shit. Jade just pinched my arm so hard trying to climb over me to get her phone to call Ana.

CASSIO

Tell her to take it up with Apollo. He was here for both events. I was a bit busy taking care of Ana.

APOLLO

Oh? You want me to clean up your messes and inform the masses as well? I didn’t realize I was on your payroll now.

ELIO

Snarky. Who pissed in your cornflakes?

ARMANI

He just misses me. Only got to be graced by my beautiful face for a few hours. Must have been devastating.

I huff at Armani’s cocky comment.

APOLLO

You are all exhausting.

NICO

This show of familial bonding is becoming nauseating.

CASSIO

I’m going to bed. Send all your Ana related questions to Dad. I don’t have time for your pestering.

MATTEO

Rude!

CASSIO

Except for Remo, he gets a pass for caring about her safety.

MATTEO

THIS IS AN OUTRAGE.

Nico has left the chat

LEON

What did I do?

ELIO

You’re blonde and it repulses him.

CASSIO

I’m not even going to entertain that with a response.

Matteo has added Nico back to the chat

Tucking my phone away, I shake my head. This family is fucking nuts.

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Chapter Twenty-Eight



Ana

I wake up in a cold sweat, flying up into a seated position, gasping. My sudden jerking movement snaps Cassio out of his sleep, and he sits up to reach for me.

"Fuck, baby, are you okay? Are you in pain again?" he asks, immediately kicking our blankets away to look for blood.

"Nightmare," I croak, trying to calm him. "I'm fine."

"You're not fucking fine," he disagrees, scrambling around the bed to my side. "You're panting. Drink this." A bottle of water is thrust in front of my face, cap already unscrewed.

Feeling the cool liquid ease the ache in my throat, I swallow a few mouthfuls. Sweat has perspired in the hair behind my neck, forcing the dark strands to cling to my skin. After a few deep breaths, I hand Cassio back the bottle and feel the content of my bad dream sink in. The images clarify but jumble around, unwelcome memories taking advantage of my weakened state.

"You haven't had such a bad dream since the first night," Cassio says, placing the back of his hand against my forehead. "You're a little warm too, are you all right, *forza*?"

"Four people," I mutter cryptically.

"What?"

"I've killed four people, I think."

Cassio blinks. "Is that all?"

He's so unfazed, and somehow that calms me.

“I don’t know,” I admit. “I’m just seeing flashes of things. A woman I don’t recognize bleeding from her head. A man with a shoe stuck in his eye, and someone foaming at the mouth like they’ve overdosed.”

“You killed a man with a high heel to the eye?”

“*That’s* your first question?” I ask incredulously.

Cassio’s eyes soften. “I don’t know how you want me to react, Ana. You seem distressed, but I’m not sure why. Are you afraid of knowing what you’ve done? Or how I’ll react to knowing what you’ve done?”

Emotion wells up in my throat, and my eyes start to sting. “I don’t know what happened… what if Cole helped me forget because they didn’t deserve it? What if something is wrong with me?”

The rugged scent of vanilla and wood surrounds me as Cassio pulls me into a hug, embracing me in bed. “Do you feel the craving to kill, Ana?”

“N-no,” I admit shakily. “Maybe toward the people who killed Cole and my mother. I don’t care about doing it myself though, I just want them to pay for what they’ve done.”

“Exactly,” he murmurs into my hair. Withdrawing to meet my eye, Cassio cups my face and smiles softly. “How can you think something is wrong with you? You don’t have a secret addiction to murder buried somewhere in that big brain of yours, love. I have no doubt you’ve killed for good reasons, and I wouldn’t look at you differently even if that weren’t true. You’re still my wife, no matter what you’ve done. I know who you are, and you aren’t a monster.”

My husband possesses the uncanny ability to tell me exactly what I need to hear, and I don’t understand what I could have possibly done to deserve it. Insecurity nags at my mind, picking and prodding mercilessly. These past two days have pulled fragile strings inside of me, and it’s all bubbling to the surface, aided by a single nightmare.

“How can you even look at me?” I rasp, peering at him with tear filled eyes. “Knowing I’m a killer? Knowing I’m not *her*?”

His strong hands twitch around the sides of my face. “Honestly, Ana, I find it hard to look *away* from you.”

He’s so firm in his statement, the words hitting me straight in the chest. He really means it. Overcome with emotions that are too potent to bury, I wrap my fingers around his wrists, trying to keep him close.

“I love you,” I confess, feeling a tear fall. “I know it’s too soon, and I know you might not be there yet. But I love you so much, Cassio. I didn’t

even know it was possible to feel this way. My chest feels like it's going to explode half the time I'm with you, and I'm never as happy when you're not around."

"Ana—"

"Let me finish," I plead. I'm not ready to face his possible rejection. "You don't have to say it back. I just… I love everything about you, Cassio. The way you know how I like my food, the soft touches you share with me to let me know you're here, and *god*, I love how you look at me. I know you might need more time, and I know what you had before was stronger than what I had with Cole, but I just—"

"I don't need more time, Ana," he professes softly, cutting in. "I've never needed more time. As soon as I bound myself to you, I was all in."

Stunned by his response, my lips pop open. "W-what?"

"I love you too," Cassio confesses.

"You do?" I breathe out. "Why?"

He chuckles, tucking a piece of hair behind my ear, his fingers brushing my cheek bone as they go.

"Why? Isn't it obvious?"

My head shakes. "Tell me."

"There are too many reasons to list," Cassio says softly. "You're beautiful, funny, and intelligent. You care about the people you keep close, even if you're quiet about it. Like the way you always make sure there is dinner left for me when I come home, and how you watch basketball with Armani and Colton even though you hate sports."

"Basketball isn't so bad," I say, flushing under his attention.

"I love that when you're still sleepy in the morning, you cuss almost exclusively in your strange little British terms," he continues. "Armani still won't stop laughing about the time you called him a *bleeding pea-brained tosser*."

"He was being a git," I mumble, smothering a smile. "Holding my morning tea hostage, he was asking for it."

"I like that you hate to cook, so that I can do it for you. I love that you think spiders are scarier than bears, and that you scream just as loud at lady bugs being in the apartment as you would for a cockroach."

"Ugh, don't remind me," I say with a disgusted shiver.

Cassio, Armani and Colton were all present for the great lady bug incident of two weeks ago. Agnes keeps this place impeccably cleaned, but

insects still occasionally slip in when doors open and close. A lady bug had made it through the cracks apparently, and landed right on my arm one evening after dinner. I screamed so hard that my throat hurt for two days.

"What happened in the past is in the past, Ana," Cassio says, tone becoming firmer. "When I think about the future, I don't think about what could have been with her. I think about what *will* be with you."

Oh, my heart…

"I think about us too," I admit, trying not to get choked up.

Cassio grins. "I think about how many memories we'll make, all the food you'll get mad at and throw, the many ways I'll find you passed out around our home." He pauses, waiting for my responding giggle to pass.

"I think about how in a few years from now, some adorable little child at that orphanage is going to burst your heart wide open, and what room we're going to put them in when you can't bear not to bring them home."

Here come the tears.

"Cole and Isobel are always going to be in our hearts. They're our past, and our memory of them won't just disappear. But that doesn't mean what we have isn't real or all consuming, because it is. The way I love you, baby… it's confounding."

It's as if the nightmare didn't happen at all, the way pure joy radiates through me, settling happily in my chest. Launching myself at him, I tackle Cassio to his back and plant my lips on his. He chuckles against my kiss, one hand dropping from my face to my hip, holding me close.

"My vicious little wife," he teases. "So strong, aren't you?"

"I'm a black belt in Judo, you know?" I tease back. "A *Shodan*. I could probably toss you on your ass in the right circumstance."

His responding grin is filthy. "I *did* know that, and I wouldn't mind having you throw me around a little bit, baby. As long as I get to throw you into bed, after."

"How do you know everything about me?" I ask, mesmerized. "I'm not good at talking about myself, and yet, you know me like the back of your hand."

"I studied the fuck out of you, Ana," he admits. "Been obsessively learning about you since before *and* after our vows. I'm basically your stalker, you know?"

"Why do I find that so hot?"

Cassio chuckles, kissing me quickly again. "Because you're perfect."

I’m seconds away from pulling him into a deeper kiss when my phone buzzes, shaking obnoxiously against my bedside table top. Frowning, I shift my gaze to the device, watching as the screen lights up and then darkens again. *Who the hell is texting me in the middle of the night?*

I’m about to ignore it, when it buzzes again, the screen flashing bright.

“Are you going to check that?” Cassio asks, tilting his head.

“I was going to ignore it, we’re having a bit of a moment here,” I huff, crawling up the bed to grab the stupid thing. “But it could be Jade, and it’s the middle of the night, so.”

Only, as soon as the phone unlocks, it isn’t Jade’s name on my screen. It isn’t *anyone’s* name.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

Well, wasn’t that just touching?

“What the…”

I freeze, eyes catching on the next message.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

Speaking of touching, you better stop letting him. You wouldn’t want Cassio to meet the same fate as your beloved Cole, would you?

Sensing a shift in the air, Cassio jumps into action, sitting up straight. “What is it, *forza*?”

My mouth opens, but no words come out as my phone vibrates again.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

I thought I’d taught you a lesson, Ana. Do you need another demonstration?

“Cassio…” I croak.

Buzz. Buzz. Buzz.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

Marrying him for protection, I could understand. You were scared.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

But kissing him? FUCKING him?

UNKNOWN NUMBER

LOVING HIM?

UNKNOWN NUMBER

You’ve gone too far.

The air is knocked out of me in an instant. Cassio grabs my phone, reading the messages rapidly, eyes narrowed at the screen.

“Go get Armani and Colton,” he instructs rigidly. “Quickly, Ana. I need to call Remo to have him try and trace these texts.”

Not one to be told twice, I jump out of bed and rush toward the door. Sirius perks up from his fluffy bed on the floor, and follows behind me without needing to be told.

“Colton!” I call out, climbing the stairs two at a time. “Armani!”

I reach Killian’s floor just as they both emerge from their bedrooms, eyes wild. Armani’s hair is disheveled, and Colton is tugging a T-shirt over his head like he’s just put it on.

“What’s going on? Is everyone okay?” Armani is the first to ask, eyes scanning my wrinkled pajamas for any signs of distress.

“Cassio said to get you,” I pant, winded from racing up here so quickly. “My phone… someone’s been watching us. I got these awful texts.”

“Fuck, come on,” he grunts, rushing past me to descend the stairs to my room.

Colton, Sirius and I follow in a dash, feet thumping down the steps. When I get back to the room, my lights are on and Cassio is pacing back and forth, speaking hurriedly on his own phone. Pausing to address Armani, he gestures to the space surrounding us.

“There has to be a camera in here,” he reports, eyes dark and fierce. “Look at this shit.”

My phone is thrust into Armani’s open palm, and Colton immediately moves to look over his shoulder. Both men stiffen as they read, anger stirring around them like a storm beginning to brew.

“Tear this place apart,” Armani snaps, looking like he might crush my phone in his meaty fist. “We should have looked harder before.”

Colton practically growls, beginning to scan my space like it’s a vile enemy. My phone is passed to me as Armani begins to look as well, pulling open drawers and looking behind paintings and mirrors.

A dreaded cluster of vibration draws my eye to the device once more.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

I don’t need the cameras in your room to keep an eye on you, Ana. I’m always watching.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

You’re not his to touch.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

Behave, or else.

Cameras. Plural.

My stomach roils with nausea, and bile burns the back of my throat. Shoving my phone back into Cassio’s hand, I rush into my bathroom, slamming the door shut. I barely make it to the toilet in time before vomit spews from my lips.

I was so happy a few minutes ago, and now it feels like everything is coming crashing down around me. It’s so frustrating and confusing that I want to scream.

Why is this happening to me?

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Chapter Twenty-Nine



Ana

After I finish tossing my cookies in the bathroom, I scrub my teeth for a full five minutes. As soon as I return to my room, I find it in utter disarray. Armani and Colton have already found two hidden cameras, tiny and meticulously hidden to deceive the eye. Cassio is fuming, but pushes his anger aside to comfort me without prompting.

"Don't let the messages get to you, *forza*. No one can touch you while I'm here. Whoever this is, they're taunting you over text because they know they don't stand a chance against all of us."

"They threatened you," I croak. "They killed Cole because of me. That's what those messages meant."

"Whatever their motivations were, it was not your fault. I've told you that before, and I'll say it again. You aren't responsible for the insane things this lunatic does."

Breathing shakily, I nod. "What do they want with me? Why me?"

"I don't know yet, love, but I'm going to find out. We're not listening to his fucking threats either, Ana. I won't bow down to some faceless fuck who thinks he owns you. You are mine. My woman. My wife. Mine to touch, to love, to *fuck*, to do whatever the hell you want from me. Do you hear me?"

A sigh of relief tugs on the tether of tension in my gut. "You mean it? You won't avoid me now to keep me safe or some bullshit?"

"Never going to happen, Wife."

The next few hours pass in a blur of phone calls, camera hunting, and stiff conversations. Remo isn't able to trace the phone responsible for ruining my night. It's a burner phone, and whoever bought it, covered their tracks. No one is happy with the news, least of all Remo. He takes pride in his hacking abilities, apparently, and not being able to help irks him.

Though Colton and Armani are able to find a total of four cameras in my bedroom, they aren't confident that more won't pop up. Which means that Cassio insists we move into another room. Bron's to be exact. The likelihood of the Monarch having his room bugged is slim, but the boys still do a thorough sweep before moving my clothes and toiletries over.

By the time the dust has begun to settle, and the unknown number has been blocked in my phone, no one is tired enough to go back to sleep. The sun has risen, and the stress of dealing with the situation has us all wide awake. Cassio leaves me to decompress in the shower, while he decides to take my phone to visit Killian. He hopes that the two of them might be able to dissect the messages, and even if they can't, he's due to check in on my brother.

The hot and steamy shower does a good job of waking me up from the small pity party I was throwing for myself earlier. Whatever I've done in the past, it's not going to scare Cassio away. He *loves* me.

He isn't afraid of what's happening now, either. He's pissed, actually.

Armani and Colton are too. They looked like they wanted to obliterate every camera they found. And watching their faces screw up with wrath while reading the anonymous messages on my phone, I know they won't rest until they punish whoever is responsible for them.

One thing is for sure, I'm glad I haven't made it back to volunteering yet. I wouldn't be able to live with myself if this psychopath somehow used the orphanage to get to me. I might need to keep my distance until this is done. I care too much about those kids and the women who run the place to put them at risk.

Deciding I need to eat, I towel-dry my hair as best as I can before slipping into a clean outfit. A simple pair of cotton shorts and a vest top.

When I enter the living room, I don't find the typical sight. Normally I would walk in on Armani and Colton eating breakfast while some kind of sporting event plays on the telly. Today though, there's a familiar hum in the air as I find Colton topless, lying on his side while Armani leans over him.

He’s laser focused on the cowboy’s ribs, etching some sort of design into his skin. My interest is immediately piqued.

Armani does tattoos?

I knew he had most of his body decorated in ink—obviously—but I was completely unaware that he also knows how to do the art himself. I should really make a better effort to get to know him. I think he’s one of my best mates, honestly. Silently, I make a promise to be a better friend.

“I’m offended,” I tell them primly, getting their attention. “Why wasn’t I invited to this little party?”

The buzzing cuts off as they both look toward my voice.

Armani gives me a beaming grin, ignoring my comment. “Hey, pretty girl,” he greets happily. “We needed to blow off some steam. We’ve only been going for about twenty minutes now. Of course you’re invited.”

Trying not to smile, I fold my arms. “So many minutes I’ve missed, how will I recover from such a betrayal?”

“Twenty minutes of pure torture without your company, doll,” Colton quips. “Come join us and see Armani in his element—making me suffer.”

“You asked for this, drama queen.”

“You’re making it more painful on purpose, I know you are.”

“That doesn’t even make any sense. How would I do that?”

“You tell me, you’re the sadist with the needles.”

An easy smile creeps on my face, feeling so at home while witnessing their spirted banter. These two could do this fake bickering thing all day long, if they wanted.

Armani rolls his eyes. “Shall I stop then, your highness?”

“Don’t you dare leave me half finished, fucker,” Colton grumbles.

“That’s what she said.”

“You’re a child.”

Arching a brow, Armani drawls, “You’re letting a child permanently alter your body?”

“Can I go next?” I cut in, taking the closest seat to the pair.

Armani’s eyes light up. “Really?”

“Fuck yes you can, doll,” Colton cheers. “You want more ink?”

After this morning? I think a few tattoos might be just what the doctor ordered, actually.

“I do,” I admit, biting my lip. “But you can’t tell anyone about it. At least until after I show Cassio.”

Colton whistles. “*Secret* ink? I am soooo in.”

“What are you thinking?” Armani asks, tilting his head at me. “Do you want to add to your back piece?”

“No…” I pause, feeling a bit shy about my request. “You might think it’s a bit crazy.”

“Doll, crazy is *fun*.” Colton grins. “Hit us with it.”

“Well, I want Cassio’s name—”

“Oh, shhhhit.”

“—in seven places.”

Both men go silent and blink at me, digesting the confession.

“Seven places?” Armani eventually asks.

“Just in small cursive script,” I clarify quietly. “But yes, seven places. I’ve been thinking about getting his name, and every time it’s come up, I can’t decide where I’d like it best.”

Colton chuckles. “So you’ve decided you want it everywhere?”

“The number seven is considered lucky for relationships in Chinese culture,” I explain, wringing my hands. “My mum always used groups of seven in her more romantic paintings. And I know people say name tattoos are bad luck, but let’s face it, mafia marriages are forever. Even if they weren’t, there’s no scenario in which I let Cassio get away from me now.”

You’d have to pry that man from my cold, dead hands.

“Plus, it would be a huge *fuck you* to whoever the hell thinks they can tell me who I belong to,” I add, a dangerous thought glinting in the back of my mind. I hope this psycho figures out what I’ve done and it makes them weep like a baby.

“You’ve got a devious side, doll,” Colton drawls, flashing an approving grin. “You may look like a proper little mafia princess, but you’ve got the edge of danger about you that I *love*.”

“Agreed,” Armani chimes, smirking. “Cassio said we aren’t allowed to tell you this, but you looked hot as fuck dropping that bitch Morgan. I barely caught what she said before I saw you attack.”

“Like a runway model playing an assassin in an action movie.”

Laughing, I rub the back of my neck awkwardly. “I guess I don’t need to worry about my little incident scaring you both off.”

“Pffft.” Colton waves me off. “Armani has a little book of creative ways to kill people for fun. He’s not quite Nico-level murderous, but we’re no strangers to putting people down for crossing a line.”

“Can’t scare us off,” Armani agrees. “Now, let me finish up this rib piece, sort out some clean materials, and then I’ll get you stenciled up, girl. You know every spot you want them?”

“Sure do.”

Five hours later, my new tattoos are all done, out of their wrapping and slick with Aquaphor. Armani did an amazing job, scripting my husband’s name by hand and printing seven identical stencils to mark me with. Cassio is due home at any minute, and I’ve decided exactly how I want to reveal my little surprise. I just hope he doesn’t think I’m insane for going this far. I want him to like it—no, *love it.*

I don’t have a lot of lingerie in my collection. In fact, most of it is unworn, only purchased when I’ve been in one of my slutty little moods. I like to feel sexy, but I’ve never put anything special on for a man before. The blue lace teddy that matches impeccably well with my wedding ribbon was too good of an opportunity to pass up. It hugs my waist tight, and pushes my breasts into a relaxed position closer together. The fabric is so soft, even the cheeky bit that rests between my arse cheeks.

I’ve put the ribbon bracelet on along with my teddy, having saved it. I know Cassio had to cut his off, but my wrist was small enough to slip right out of the material, and I couldn’t bear to part with it.

Normally I’d like my hair down, to feel it all over my skin, but I’ve tucked it up into a ponytail instead. I don’t want it hiding any part of me from Cassio. As it is, I’m going to need to move some fabric out of the way to show him a couple of the tattoos.

Bron’s bedroom door creaks open, and I hold my breath, spinning around to watch. Cassio has shed his jacket before coming upstairs, apparently, and he’s right in the middle of rolling up his sleeves. He’s too occupied with the task to notice me right away, but I don’t mind. I soak up the view of his fingers flexing and working around his thick, veiny forearms, licking my lips as the show goes on.

“*Dio onnipotente,*” Cassio breathes, catching sight of me.

“Is that good?” I ask, taking a few steps forward to lay a hand on his chest. “You know I don’t speak Italian, though I love the way it sounds when you do, Husband.”

“It means *God Almighty*,” he explains, the words hot on his tongue. “And it’s definitely good, *Wife*. You look edible.”

His eyes roam over me, freezing as he gets a closer look at the hand holding his heart.

“Is that what I think it is?” His voice is like gravel, sending a shiver down my spine.

“Keep looking,” I purr, turning my head to the side.

Rough fingers catch my jaw, pulling my face closer to examine what he’s found behind my ear. Cassio breathes hard, body going taut while he takes in the sight. But I’m not done helping him explore more of what I have to show him. I lift and shift my lingerie around, maneuvering my body multiple times before I’ve given him a peak at every tattoo.

Every brand of his name etched into my skin forever.

One behind my right ear, the next under my left breast, then the right side of my hip—just above where my knickers sit. Next, the top of my left thigh, and then the inside of my right wrist. On the side of my left ring finger, and finally along my ankle on the right. They crisscross down my body, wrapping me in a path of Cassio.

“Are you scared of me yet?” I ask, peering up into his searing gaze. “Do you still love me like this?”

“Ana…” His face moves to hover just above mine. “There are no words. You marked yourself all over this gorgeous body just for me?”

“Seven times.” I sigh. “Do you like it?”

“I fucking love it. But why… how did you decide to do this?”

Biting my lip, I let my fingers dance along the buttons of his shirt. “The number seven sounds like the word “even” in Mandarin, you know? It’s meant to be good for relationships. I don’t speak the language as well as my mother did, I wouldn’t even consider myself half-fluent. But she believed in this sort of thing, and I believe in you—in *us*.”

“Can I fuck you without hurting them?” He asks the question like a demand, desire dripping from every word.

“I have something else in mind,” I rasp, grabbing him by the back of the neck and forcing our lips together.

Our tongues tangle and our bodies mold against each other. Moaning at his taste and the incredible pressure of his mouth, I drop my hands and get to work. Fumbling with his belt, I’m undeniably eager to rid him of the leather. Cassio breaks our fevered kiss with a groan, pressing his forehead against mine.

“What are you doing to me, Wife?”

“Worshipping you,” I whisper, brushing my lips over his lips… his chin… and down his neck. I continue to trail soft kisses down his bare chest and fall to my knees to lavish his toned stomach. The wood floor is cold against my skin, sending a chill up the back of my legs, radiating all the way to the hot nape of my neck. I resist a shiver and peer up at Cassio through hooded eyes, fluttering my lashes at his gorgeous face.

“You are a fucking dream, Ana,” he husks, watching me with his blistering gaze.

“I’ve been thinking about doing this for so long,” I admit in a seductive purr, pulling on the band of his boxers and trousers. The tailored fabric slips down to the ground, pooling around his ankles and releasing his thick cock in the process. Every time I lay my eyes on this part of him, I’m stunned by the sheer size of it.

I don’t waste a second, caressing his warm cock greedily. My fingers struggle to surround his girth, he’s velvet soft to the touch but impossibly stiff at the same time.

“You’ve been such a good husband, Cassio,” I say, my breath teasing the underside of his shaft. “I think you earned this, don’t you? Will you take my mouth? Will you fuck it?”

Before he can answer, I punctuate my question by pressing a wet kiss to the crown of his throbbing dick. Precum smears against my soft skin, and my lips warm just by touching him. The heat is like a siren call, pulling me in to repeat the action.

“Fuuuck, Ana,” he growls, reaching out to twist my hair around his hand and wrap the gathered bundle into a tight fist. “You want to reward me for being good to you, is that it? You think I need your mouth around my cock to honor me? It’s an honor just breathing the same fucking air as you, *forza*.”

The most sensitive bit between my legs throbs, and my stomach flips, hearing the conviction in his tone. I didn’t think it was possible to want him even more than I already do, but here I am, panting for it.

“I think…” I tease the words slowly, tilting my head up at him. “I think that you’ve tasted me more than once. And now… it’s my turn.”

Having said my piece, I part my lips, opening wide to accommodate his size. His cock twitches as I close my mouth around it, stroking the underside tentatively with my tongue. Holding him in place by the base of his length, I push forward, greedy for more.

“If you could see yourself right now, baby,” Cassio groans. He reaches out with his freehand and strokes the back of his fingers down the side of my face. “You have no idea how irresistible you are, do you, Wife? My name all over your body, your sweet lips wrapped tight around my cock, *fuck*.”

His praise feels immaculate, sinking into me like a physical touch. I hollow my cheeks and suck him once hard before pulling my mouth off of him entirely. His cock comes out shiny, falling from my lips with a wet sound.

“You’re the only man I’ve ever done this to,” I confess sweetly. “Do you like knowing that? Knowing that I’m learning how to pleasure you with my mouth for the first time? And that I can’t get enough of it?”

“I may not allow you to get enough of it if you keep speaking to me that way, Ana,” he warns, voice dark and raspy. “You’re practically begging me to put you on your back to fuck all those pretty little words right out of you.”

“After,” I suggest, seeking out his balls with my unused hand. I gently cup the firm sack from below, fondling them with a squeeze as I bend forward to suck on his tip. Mumbling into his skin, I quietly add, “After I devour you.”

Cassio’s hand tightens in my hair as he rumbles with a deep moan. His pleasure is evident in the sound and in the way his jaw tightens. His eyes become hooded and heavy, the deep pools of blue sparking with delicious arousal. The air feels electric around us as the taste of his arousal begins to coat my tongue.

No need for further prompting or permission, I continue, sucking his cock back in my mouth, aiming for more depth. My lips tingle as they roll around him, arousal further lighting up in my center. I feel unstoppable, like a queen kneeling at her king’s feet. The act is powerful, even in its submissive nature.

“Mmm, there you go, forza,” he encourages. His hips rock forward gently, trying to stuff as much of his length in my mouth as possible. But no matter how deep he attempts to press, the back of my throat won’t budge.

My eyes prick with tears, a small gag sounding from his efforts.

“Such a shame,” Cassio murmurs, caressing my face once again. “There’s no way I can fuck your tight little throat is there, baby?”

“Uh-uh,” I slur, bobbing my head while sucking him.

“It’s a good thing you have two other perfectly fuckable holes for me then, isn’t it?” His teasing tone is torturous, his deviant words reminding me just how much I enjoy being filthy for my husband. “Nod to answer me, sweet wife.”

An unstoppable whimper crawls up my throat and I do as instructed, nodding eagerly to agree with him. If it were physically possible, I’d allow him to fuck every part of me—too snug throat and all.

As if he can tell that I’m struggling to breathe, Cassio uses his grip on my hair to pull me back, allowing me to suck down some new air. Twirling my tongue around his cock’s sensitive head, I sigh happily and moan.

“I can’t wait to do this for the rest of our lives,” I tell him, using the saliva remaining on his length to stroke and circle him tightly.

I want to know Cassio’s body like the back of my hand. To keep him satisfied through each and every encounter. I want to know how to make him tremble with my touch and to make him crave every moment with me by his side. I crave my husband like a sweet, sweet drug, and I never want to stop.

“You thinking about the rest of our lives while sucking me off, Ana?” Cassio’s jaw ticks and his head tilts to one side, assessing me.

“I’m always thinking about the rest of our lives,” I confess.

“Yeah?”

One word has my pussy clenching around air, *pulsing* for him.

“Yeah,” I rasp. “But enough of that now. You might not be able to fit your big fat cock in my throat but you can certainly fuck my mouth with it.”

His eyes flare and his fist flexes, my scalp prickling in reaction to the tug. “Slap my thigh if you can’t breathe, do you hear me? If you pass out on me, I’m going to punish you, and not in a way that you’ll like.”

I blink at him, startled by the seriousness in his voice. “I hear you.”

“I mean it, Ana. You won’t let me hurt you, even by accident, yes?”

Softening at his concern, I smile hesitantly. “I understand, Cassio.”

I might not be able to take it when he lets go, especially with my inexperience and his size. Still, I can promise him that I’ll tap out if it’s too much. One of the things I love most about my husband is his insatiable need to keep me safe, after all.

Rolling my lips around my teeth, I take Cassio’s cock back into my mouth. My heart races with anticipation, and my hands rest at my sides. I peer into his crystal blue eyes and let my trust ring through.

I gasp as he thrusts forward, surprised by the strength of it.

Within seconds, I'm captivated. My mouth becomes sensitive and pliant, craving every minute of the act. I relish every moan, groan, and curse that Cassio releases. I'm obsessed with how much power I have over him, even as he controls my face like it's his own personal fuck toy.

And when he comes? I don't let him pull out to spill on my breasts, I suck down every single drop. As his softening cock twitches in my mouth, I just know I'm going to want more.

This won't be the last time I find myself on my knees, begging to have my husband fuck my wanting mouth.

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Chapter Thirty



Cassio

Looking at my wife now, you'd never guess that I practically fucked her into a coma last night after she blew my mind—and my cock. She looks refreshed and glowy, picking at a bowl of fresh berries while scrolling through her phone. Lying on her stomach, feet in the air, swaying back and forth happily.

She is so incredibly beautiful, it's not difficult to see why someone might go crazy for her. There's something so elegant about her, and so naturally lovely. It makes it hard to look away. It's unacceptable, of course, that someone else thinks they can lay claim to her.

It's also exceedingly frustrating that my wife is clueless as to who might be mindlessly consumed by her, enough to torment her for being with me—and Cole before me. Hell, if I hadn't seen his dead body with my own two eyes, I might believe he somehow made it out alive and began stalking Ana. He's the only person Ana has ever known to be obsessed with her, and he's firmly beyond the land of the living.

We have no real leads. With only vague descriptions of the men who carried out Cole's assassination, we have no names, and only theories to work with. I'm quite certain the men who Ana saw in the basement were hired muscle, and even if we found them, our problem wouldn't be solved.

I have a bad feeling that things are only going to get more tense now that this fucker has decided to make contact. He's toying with us because Ana and I fell in love and became physical—the thing that leads me to

believe he's a man more than anything else. He thinks he has claim to my wife's body—to her fucking heart—and he couldn't be more wrong.

At least The Kings have become steadily more self-sufficient and more trusting. Now I can spend more time at home, and less time worrying about being away while something bad could happen.

The sound of coughing pulls me out of my reflection, and I turn my head to find Ana choking down her most recent bite of blackberry. Scooting over to pat her back, I watch her eyes go wide as she gapes at her phone, swallowing the fruit.

"Cassio, why is there fifteen million dollars in my account?"

I breathe out, relieved. "Is that why you just sputtered on a berry? Are you just looking at your bank account now? It's been like a month and a half—never mind. Relax, *forza*. It's just your wedding gift."

Ana blinks at me with round eyes. " I didn't need to log into my banking app until now. I haven't exactly been planning any shopping sprees, Cassio. I was just checking to see how much I could send to *St. Mary's.* I haven't been able to volunteer in so long that I wanted to give a donation—so they'd know I was still thinking about them."

Nodding, I comment, "That's a nice idea."

"Cassio," Ana breathes out. "That's not the point. Fifteen million dollars is insane. Most arranged marriages come with a few million exchanged between families, not a direct deposit into the bride's personal account. I—"

"Our marriage wasn't exactly standard, love. Some of that money is yours just for being a Moretti. Dad takes care of us all. You should have seen Jade's face when she realized she had a ten million dollar limit on her card."

"Fifteen million is really crazy," she tries to reason. "I don't need this much. Surely you understand this is overdoing it."

"Donate it all if you don't want it." I shrug. "But it's yours, Ana."

"But… I already had money?"

Ana had a few hundred thousand in her bank account before we wed. Mostly deposits from her mother, and some from Bron. She also didn't have many outgoing payments, likely because Cole and Killian paid for anything she wanted or needed before she could do it herself.

"I have money as well, and my money is *our* money. But this money is *only* your money."

"How much money *do* you have exactly?"

Chuckling at her incredulous expression and the curiosity in her question, I tilt my head like I'm considering the numbers. "*We* have about six hundred million in liquid assets. More tied up in businesses and real estate. But the family account is larger. Dad and Apollo manage about one-hundred and fifty billion in various cash accounts. And I'd say our family businesses add another couple billion. Then there's property, stocks, bonds, trusts, and—"

"Okay, I get it," she blurts out, interrupting. "You're richer than God."

"Matteo calls it *fuck you* money," I offer, trying not to grin. "And stop implying I'm the rich one. I told you, it's *our* money. You've had full access to everything since you signed our contract."

"So if I just wire the orphanage ten million dollars, you won't even blink," Ana says, trying to wrap her head around the concept.

"Would you like to take it from our account instead of your private funds?" I ask innocently. "Or would you like me to match your donation with one of my own?"

Lost for words, my beautiful girl jumps up from her stomach to throw her arms around my neck. She practically smothers me with her breasts, hugging me so tight that I'd be glad to die right here in her embrace.

"Will you come to see the kids with me?" she asks into my neck. "When it's safe enough to go? I want you to meet everyone."

"Of course, I will." She moves back to show me her beaming smile. "But I'm not sure that it's unsafe to go. If you miss it terribly, I think we could manage a visit."

She captures her bottom lip between her teeth, considering it. "You don't think whoever messaged me would use them against me?"

Shaking my head, I give her a small frown. "Ana, if this person knows you as well as they seem to, they already know about the orphanage. I don't think going there will put it on their radar. They haven't used it against you before. As much as I despise it, this person seems to care about you in some sort of twisted way."

Buzz. Ana's phone lights up with a notification and my shoulders go rigid, seeing the unknown title flash.

I swear to God, if there are more fucking cameras here—

UNKNOWN NUMBER

I'm still going to destroy him for putting his hands on you, but he's right. I care for you more than you'll ever know. Your orphans are safe. The little boys you're playing house with? Not so much.

Ana reads and sucks in a breath. "Can he hear us?"
"Little boys?" I huff. "I'm nearly thirty."
"Do we need to look for more cameras?" she asks, sounding defeated.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

Don't bother. There aren't any hidden. I told you, I don't need cameras to see you, Ana.

"We're looking anyway," I reassure her, pulling out my phone to text Armani. I need him down here, stat.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

But back to the matter at hand…

UNKNOWN NUMBER

To show you how generous I can be. I'll give you a free pass. Eight hours, no spying. Only for you to go see the children. Say, this Friday?

I hate that I believe him. It could be a trap, but I know he won't use it as one. He wants to appeal to Ana, to make himself more desirable by giving her something that she wants. And I love her too much to deny her the opportunity.

She gives me a hopeful look, like she's asking for permission. Despite my better judgement, my head dips in a nod of approval.

ANA

Promise?

UNKNOWN NUMBER

Cross my heart.

Ana swallows hard. "My mom used to say that."

He's been watching her for a long time. *I'm going to have his eyes in a fucking jar for that.*

Shaking off the fear the messages bring her, a hesitant smile tugs at her lips. “I get to see the kids.”

“You do,” I agree softly.

“I’m still going to send in a donation,” she decides, growing excited. “Ooo, let me go get my photo albums. I can show you some of them while you look for cameras.” A kiss is smacked against my lips in a rush, and she’s springing off the couch before I can reply.

When she returns minutes later, Colton and Armani have already joined me in scouring the living room for listening devices and cameras. Carrying two big books, she flops down on the sofa, immediately beginning to thumb through them.

She calls us over to look at memory after memory, attaching little tidbits of information and stories about the children and the other volunteers as she goes. She’s so enthusiastic that we abandon our search in favor of sitting with her and hanging on her every word.

But one picture changes everything.

“Oh my gosh, this is Elliot,” Ana gushes, waving the polaroid for all of us to see. “His mum Heather, she works at St. Mary’s full time. And she was eight months along when she went into labor during a snowstorm! I had absolutely no idea what I was doing, but I was the only person around. So an EMT coached me through the phone and I caught him as she delivered. Scariest shift of my *life*.”

“You delivered a whole freaking baby?” Colton exclaims. “That’s fucking bad ass, doll.”

I hardly hear it as Armani agrees with him, my ears starting to whoosh, sound becoming muffled. My eyes are glued to the photo, a sickness churning deep in my gut.

Afterbirth and blood painting pale skin.

Dark hair stuck to a tiny head.

It’s like I’m punched in the stomach and violently attacked by remembrance. I’m not seeing the little boy Ana describes.

I’m not seeing Elliot.

I’m seeing Angel.

I need to leave.

Pretending to be alerted by my phone, I pant a distracted kiss on the top of Ana’s head and remove myself from the group.

“I’ll be back soon,” I tell them, voice strained.

“Where are you—”

I can’t hear the end of my wife’s question because the door is already swinging shut behind me. Rushing to the parking garage on unsteady feet, I send a text, praying for a quick response.

CASSIO

Are you still in New York?

Just as I start the engine of my Aston Martin, an affirmative response lights up my screen. I breathe out hard, and fucking drive. A blur of traffic and buildings whirl around me as I try to control whatever the fuck is happening to me. I feel like I’m losing it, and I don’t know how much longer I can take this agony.

Parking illegally on the street outside a Moretti-owned hotel, I toss my keys at the concierge and storm into an elevator. I press the correct button rapidly until the door shut, breathing wildly until the telltale ding sounds, delivering me where I need to go.

I pass by familiar guards, watching as they examine me and then respectfully avert their eyes. Knocking hard on a solid oak door, I pound until it swings open, revealing the man I’m here to see.

The floodgates of emotion burst open and I’m lost.

“Cass?” Leon asks, eyes wide. “What’s wrong? You look like—”

He can’t finish his question as tears spill down my face. I step inside, slamming the door shut behind me, collapsing into my brother’s frame.

“My s-son is dead,” I stutter, gasping for air. “He’s dead. I c-can’t—”

“Oh fuck. Hey, hey, shhh.” Leon hushes me, patting my back hard. “I know Cassio, shit. You’re okay, I’ve got you.”

It was exactly like this before, finding Leon a week after Angel’s passing. He’s the only brother I’ve cried in front of, the only one I’ve ever brought myself to open up with. We were so close as kids, and I’ve leaned on him more than I deserve to. I constantly push him away and pull him back since losing my son, and he’s never complained.

“It’s all right, let it out,” Leon tells me softly. “No one else is here.”

I think about my son every day without fail. He’s always on my mind and in my heart. But today is different. Today I saw him, saw his lifeless tiny body flash in my mind. And it fucking broke me all over again.

“It’s not fair,” I lament, choking back a sob. “My son, Leon. My fucking son. Why?”

“Just breathe,” my brother rasps. “I got you, Cass. Just breathe.”

I don’t know how long the tears flow, but when I’ve finally begun to calm down, I have a pounding headache and my eyes burn.

“Tell me what happened,” Leon says, guiding me into a leather armchair. “Talk through it, Cassio. You’ll feel better after.”

Nodding mutely, I blow out a breath and dry my face.

“There was this picture…”

Leon listens with rapt attention as I go through my story, never interrupting, even as I pause to collect myself. He gives me every bit of his undivided attention, and soaks up the retelling in a comfortable silence.

“And I just fucking left,” I finish, rubbing a heavy hand down my face. “I didn’t want her to see me like this, but I shouldn’t have run off without a word of explanation.”

“You hardly abandoned her,” Leon replies slowly. “She’s with Armani and Colton. And it isn’t like you left without reason. You’ll return within the hour, it’s okay, Cass.”

His reasoning assuages some of my guilt.

“I’m supposed to go with her to the orphanage soon,” I grimace, pressing the heels of my palms into my eyes, rubbing. “How the hell am I supposed to handle seeing her there? The kids all love her, I know they do. And I couldn’t see a *picture* of her holding that baby without… fuck!”

Leon doesn’t react to my outburst, only moving slightly to squeeze my arm in support. He’s always been good at silent solace, like a rock to crash against. I don’t know how he does it.

But maybe I do, maybe I’ve done something similar for Ana.

“I thought I was past this,” I admit, throat choking up. “I’m supposed to be the one being strong for her. How can I do that if I’m breaking down like this, Leon?”

“You needed a minute to break.”

“Yeah,” I chuckle humorlessly. “A minute until the orphanage sends me into a fucking spiral too.”

“The picture was of an infant boy, still wet from birth, Brother,” he reasons. “It wasn’t seeing Ana with a baby that triggered you. You’ve seen her with Cesar and Isobella. None of the other pictures made you react this way. It hit too close to home, but it’s not going to happen again.”

I swallow hard, trying to digest his point.

“Ana isn’t going to help someone through a spontaneous birth again, and even if you see that picture again, it won’t hurt the same. We adapt and we overcome, it’s in our fucking blood, Cassio. You’re stronger than the past, you know you are.”

Maybe I am, but maybe I’m not.

But I know one thing for certain. Without Ana, I’m *nothing*.

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Chapter Thirty-One



Cassio

"I can't fucking lose her, Leon," I croak, letting the brutal honesty flow from me. My freak out today wasn't just because I saw an infant that reminded me of Angel, it was seeing Ana—*my Ana*—holding him.

One glance at a years old picture and I was assaulted with the thought of my wife in Isobel's place. My mind taunted me with the idea of being cursed. I could get Ana pregnant, and she could end up dying in my fucking arms… all my fault. The mental torture brought me to my goddamn knees.

"I barely made it through before. With my son and Isobel, I felt like I was going to die. But Ana? Jesus Christ, I can't. It *will* kill me. I mean it."

"You love her," he states simply.

"Too much," I confess. "Way too fucking much, man. It's different than before. She's not just my wife, she's like a *limb*, Leon. I need her."

I can't believe I'm even admitting this out loud, even to one of my most trusted brothers. Isobel was supposed to be my one, and she was, but falling for Ana wasn't something I could escape. It's not something I would ever *want* to escape now that I've experienced it. I didn't think there were levels to being in love, and maybe levels is the wrong way to describe it.

All I know is, Ana can't leave me. I need her like I need oxygen. Waking up next to her is what gives me the ability to get through each and every day. The way she looks at me, the way her every touch feels, I need all of it. I crave it more than anything else.

I expected to come to care for her. I knew she was a sweet girl, and I knew in helping her that I would develop some kind of emotions toward

her. But this? This undying devotion and utter passion that I have for her? I couldn't have seen this coming. And when she confessed she felt the same? It was like experiencing true heaven on earth for the first time in my life.

"You two need to talk," Leon advises after a moment of silence. "I know I'm not exactly the picture of a perfect husband, but if your relationship is going to work, you have to lay all your cards out. Have you talked about kids? At all?"

I feel the blood drain from my face and he shakes his head.

"Yeah, I figured."

Sighing, he stands up from his chair and walks over to the small bar cart. Glasses clank and liquid bubbles as he pours two glasses of dark liquor. The drink rolls across the end table nearest me, and I catch it with a quick hand. Fire burns at the back of my throat as I drain it in one go.

"Only you would shoot vintage scotch like it's cheap tequila," he grumbles disapprovingly. He sips his and lets out a deep breath. "Guess you're still not much of a drinker."

Never have been, likely never will be. Alcohol dulls the senses and lowers inhibitions. I like to be alert and on my game at all times.

"No," I agree, wiping my mouth with the back of my hand.

"Always the practical one." Taking another sip of booze, he sets his glass down and crosses his arms. "So be fucking practical, Cassio. Can you handle Ana being pregnant? Is it something you ever want to try? Because if it's not, you need to talk to your wife about it."

"What if she wants it someday? What if she *needs* it and I can't?"

"From everything you've mentioned, and everything Armani tells me, the girl is just as in love with you as you are with her. You know what that means? It means she doesn't need or want anything more than she needs you. Talk to her, make a plan. You'll feel better once you do."

He's been talking to Armani, too? I've been texting him more recently, needing to share some of what I've been going through with Ana. I had no idea that my younger brother has been doing the same thing.

"Will I?" Somehow I doubt it. "Ana deserves to be a mother if she wants to be one."

"Sometimes, for someone so smart, you can be so fucking dumb." Leon groans and I frown. "Cassio, there's more than one way to be a mother. You said the girl used to volunteer at the orphanage like it was her damn job

before this whole mess, for fuck's sake. If she wants kids, a pregnancy doesn't need to be the way to make it happen."

She could want to adopt.

"I did tell her that," I remember, like a light clicking on. "I said when I see our future, I think about her wanting to bring a kid home one day, and what room we'll put them in."

Hope swells in my chest like a balloon of relief. I latch on to the idea hard. I could handle that. I could be a father again. I could make Ana a mother if it meant not risking her life with a pregnancy.

"Cleo and I are considering it too," Leon mentions hesitantly. "Adopting."

I blink in surprise. "You are?"

He shrugs. "She wants another, and it hasn't been happening."

Oh, wow.

"Why didn't you say anything?" I had no idea they were trying and struggling with fertility.

"Honestly? I didn't want to freak you out."

"Because Isobel and I had trouble," I surmise with a small frown. "You didn't want to upset me. Fuck, Leon… I feel like an ass. You're always here for me and I—"

"Wasn't ready," he cuts me off. "Emilio knows, Cleo and Melani have started talking."

That's even more surprising than the previous news. Cleo has never wanted anything to do with making friends. She's always been extremely introverted, and never responded to Melani's attempts in the past. Maybe after years of being married into the family, she's starting to warm up.

"And you've talked about adopting?"

He nods, finishing off his scotch. "Pretty sure that's the route we're going. Cleo likes being a mom. It fulfills her."

"But you two still aren't..?"

"In love?" He laughs. "No. Our relationship is clinical at best."

"Fuck, I'm sorry."

"She's a good mom," Leon says. "It's enough."

I'm not so sure he means it, but I'm not going to pry. He'd tell me more if he wanted to. There are some things a man has to keep to himself.

"The expansion here is taking more time than we thought, so she'll be here with Bastian tonight. They're going to stay with me for a few weeks.

I’d say we should have dinner—”

“But you know I won’t let my nephew anywhere near the mess I have going on,” I cut in, interrupting.

Leon smiles. “Yeah, that.”

“One day,” I add, lifting my chin. “We’ll get together when this is all over. Ana will love meeting Bas.”

“It’s a plan.”

Ana

“Oh thank God,” I breathe out, rushing toward the door. Cassio grunts as I tumble into his chest, catching me around the waist. “I’m so sorry. Leon texted Armani that you were with him. Did the picture—did I? Are you okay?”

It didn’t take me long to assume that the photo of Elliot was probably difficult for Cassio to see. I cursed myself for the oversight, and wished I could take it all back immediately. Colton and Armani tried to keep me occupied with a camera search, but I was nearly chewing off my nails as nerves ate at me. And we didn’t even find anything!

“I’m all right, forza,” he mutters into my hair. “I just needed a minute.”

Puffing a reassured breath, I relax against him. I never wanted to trigger Cassio, or hurt him in any way. He was already worried about the lunatic stalking me.

“We’ll give you two some space,” Colton says from across the room. “This whole place is clean, though. Not a trace of a bug in sight.”

“I have no idea how that fucker is listening to us,” Armani adds in a grumble. “But I’m going to find out.”

“Thank you,” Cassio tells them both, watching as they retreat upstairs. Running his hands up and down my back, his lips press into my temple. “Can we talk, baby?”

“Of course.”

We sit on the sofa together, and Cassio takes a minute to compose himself. He looks more nervous than I’ve ever seen him.

“Leon said that we should talk about children,” he eventually says, looking conflicted.

“I know kids are hard for you,” I begin cautiously, fiddling with my hands. “I’m sorry if it’s difficult to think about going to St. Mary’s with me. I wouldn’t blame you, if you didn’t want to come. I would understand.”

His throat bobs with a rough swallow.

“Kids aren’t hard for me,” Cassio replies gruffly. “Babies were difficult at first. Any time I saw one, I saw Angel. But when Jade had the twins, it became pretty evident that children weren’t the issue—pregnancy was.”

Which explains his insistence on using condoms. He’s worried that even with my birth control implant, we could accidentally conceive. I figured he thought it was just too soon to risk it, but this makes much more sense. His fear is deeper than *timing* being the reason.

Making a small noise, I encourage him to keep going.

“Melani’s pregnancy with Mila worried me, but she already had Valerio, so I latched on to that fact. I convinced myself she would be okay because she had done it before. Jade’s pregnancy, on the other hand, *terrified* me.”

He breathes out a shaken breath.

“I kept fixating on the idea that it could happen to her—what happened to Isobel. They both had perfectly normal pregnancies. They were both young and healthy, too. When Jade said she wanted to give birth at home I thought I was going to lose my fucking mind. I couldn’t watch my little sister die in the same place that—”

Getting choked up, he cuts himself off, shaking his head bitterly. “There was no reason. *No fucking reason*, and it still happened. We had every resource, we did everything right. She was fine and then she was dead.”

My stomach churns with an awful wave of grief for him.

“And our son… he was only alive for three minutes. Three minutes. One hundred and eighty seconds and he was gone. He wasn’t sick, he wasn’t even a premature baby. *It just happens sometimes,* that’s what every doctor said. Every expert and no one could give me a goddamn reason.”

“I’m so sorry,” I croak, whispering the words into his shoulder where my head now rests. “Life can be inexplicably cruel. I wish you didn’t have to experience the depths of its viciousness.”

Cassio seems to deflate, his chest falling with a long sigh. “We’ve both been given a fair share of the world’s wickedness, *forza.* It’s only right that

we try to make the best of the time we have left. Helping out at the orphanage is what you love, and I have no problem going with you."

Biting my lip, I tuck into his side further. "Do you see us adopting one day? Can you picture it… like you said before?"

He stiffens ever-so slightly. "You wouldn't want a biological child?"

"Absolutely not," I reply, my eyes snapping up to meet his. "I'm not putting you through that, Cassio. As it is, I've never had the dream of carrying my own baby. I've always sort of assumed I would adopt one day."

"I could handle it," he tells me, the words barely a whisper. "If you wanted to get pregnant, I could give you that."

"Just because you're capable of enduring it, doesn't mean I would want you to. The stress alone would be unbearable. I don't want you to hurt any more than you want me to hurt. You're… you're a wonderful husband, Cassio. I want us to be happy together. I can be happy with or without children, I just wanted to know if adoption was something you can see for us—whether it's months or years from now."

"You mean it?"

I really, *really* do.

"My mother adopted me when I was three," I reveal, fighting a watery smile. "From the same orphanage she grew up in, in Birmingham."

"I didn't know you were adopted," Cassio says quietly.

"Nobody really does," I explain slowly. "My mom was never adopted, she lived in that place for fourteen years. From age four to eighteen, she watched adoption after adoption and it was never her. She was quite literally a starving artist until she turned twenty-two. This socialite in New York saw one of her paintings while visiting London and her career shot off from there."

"People have a tendency to fall in love with her work, don't they?" my husband muses, making my lips tip into a wistful grin.

Nodding softly, I continue. "She told me the first thing she wanted to do when she got her first big check was to go back to the orphanage and take a little girl just like her home. She said when she saw me, three years old with the same dark hair and sad eyes she used to have, she couldn't let me stay there a second longer. When she found out I was abandoned with no details just like her, it felt like fate."

"It sounds like fate," Cassio agrees, squeezing my hand in his.

“She had just moved into her new house,” I keep going, sniffing back the impending emotions. “She didn’t even have a couch yet but I thought it was the most magical place in the world—half-empty or not. She had a huge pink bedroom made for me the very next day.”

Cassio’s thumb traces a small pattern into the back of my hand. “That’s why the orphanage is your passion.”

“And exactly why I don’t need a baby with our DNA to know we could be loving parents one day. We can keep using condoms until you decide you want to do something more permanent to prevent it, but just know, I’m one hundred percent content with this, Cassio. All I need is you.”

“You’re incredible,” he declares, lifting my chin to lock our lips.

The feeling is so mutual.

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Chapter Thirty-Two



Ana

Unbridled excitement is bubbling up inside of me as I step inside the brickstone building, hearing the familiar sounds of children laughing and playing. Pulling Cassio behind me by the hand, I eagerly approach the front desk of St. Mary's, smiling as I lock eyes with a friendly face.

"Ana!" Heather squeaks happily, her kind brown eyes lighting up. "I can't believe you're here, I just heard about your donation." Rounding the counter, the petite woman wraps me in a friendly embrace. "It's so good to see you, you look amazing."

"It's good to see you too." I smile, as our hug ends. "How are you and Elliot?"

"Same old, same old. He's growing too fast and I'm trying to keep up." She rocks on her heels happily, taking note of the man next to me, her brows lift. "And who might this be?"

"Cassio Moretti," he introduces himself before I can, holding out his hand for a shake. "Ana is my wife."

Heather's eyes go round, dropping his hand mid-shake. "Wife?" Blinking at me she stammers, "You got married? To a… to a *Moretti*?"

I giggle at the way she whispers the name, as if Cassio isn't right next to me to hear it. "I sure did," I tell her proudly. "You really need to get on social media, love. You miss everything."

"I guess so!" She laughs. "Congratulations. You look stunning together. Does he know that he's absolutely blessed to be with a woman such as yourself?"

“He’s well aware,” Cassio drawls, tucking me into his side.

Both Heather and I chuckle at his possessive move.

“So, tell me, what’s new here? I’ve missed it so much.”

“We have a new boy today,” Heather says, her smile dimming slightly. “He hasn’t spoken a word, and we’re still waiting for more information on him. He’s three-years-old from what we know, and so adorable, but he seems so sad.”

My heart gives a sad ache. “Oh no.”

“It breaks my heart. His big eyes are so full of confusion and it’s like he doesn’t hear a word we say. He can physically hear just fine but he won’t respond or even try to speak on his own without prompting.”

“Well, we’re here to volunteer for a few hours. Maybe we can get him to open up. Is there anything you all need help with today or is it just activities and free time?”

“Oh girl, we got the boring stuff covered. Since the donation in your mom’s name—I’m so sorry about your loss, by the way. And the donation you just sent, we’ve been able to keep more staff around and it’s been a huge help. A lot of the money is going directly to the kids as well, of course. We’re replacing some older beds and getting higher priority supplies for them. Gifts, too. It’s been high spirits around here for weeks.”

I soak up the good news, and silently thank Heather for not dwelling on my loss. She knows me well enough to know that I want to focus on the children while I’m here. All of my problems get checked at the door. These kids don’t need sad adults moping around. They need encouragement, love, and fun.

“That’s so good to hear.”

Heather waves us back, allowing us access to one of the main common areas. Children of all ages hang out here during the day. They can play games, explore instruments, make arts and crafts, or just relax while watching movies. There are staff around, keeping a close eye on the youngest of the bunch, and directing any games that others want to play.

I feel instantly fulfilled just walking into the room, witnessing the controlled chaos with a blissful grin.

“Miss. Ana!” a little voice cheers, and my heart soars.

Hearing my name, a little gaggle of precious faces swarm in my direction. I crouch down and greet each and every one of them by name,

offering a quick cuddle to the ones who ask and listening to their rapid chatter as they talk over one another, vying for attention.

Once they've calmed down, I look up at my husband with a fond smile. "Everyone, this is my husband. Can you all say *hi* to Mr. Cassio?"

"Hiiiii, Mr. Cassi," they echo, slurring his unfamiliar name.

"Close enough," he returns, smiling softly.

"Mr. Cassi, are you a lawyer?" Brennon asks, blinking up at my husband while craning his neck like Cassio is a tower. "You dress like one."

My hand covers my lips to smother a giggle. Cassio is so far from a lawyer, and I can see the same thought bringing amusement to his eyes.

"I'm a businessman," he replies, fibbing.

"Ohhhh," a few voices sound.

A tiny hand fists into his pant leg. "Play?"

"Yeah! Play with us?"

"Okay," Cassio agrees without hesitation. "What do you want to do?"

For the next two hours, Cassio and I are pulled in every direction. Boys asking him to help build blocks, little girls lining up to have me braid their hair. An older girl asks Cassio to fix her tablet, and somehow he does. We help make crafts, and my husband doesn't complain when a four-year-old spills blue glitter all over his lap.

It's absolutely magical.

But one child has my smile dimming every time I see him. He's been sitting by himself, staring aimlessly around the room, even when I try to approach him to join us. He looks so lost, and I wish I could just jump inside his mind to find out how to help.

Deciding I need to try harder, I excuse myself from a group playing board games and make my way over to his corner.

"Hello," I say quietly, sitting in the bean bag chair next to him. "Are you okay, little love?"

He turns, blinking at me with confused eyes, but doesn't answer.

I bite the inside of my cheek, trying to remain calm. I could burst into tears, seeing how downcast he looks.

Seeking out my husband in the crowd, he meets my eye, like he could feel me searching. He begins to approach when he stalls, sighing. Pulling his phone from his pocket, he looks around and decides to answer the call he's apparently getting.

"I'll be quick," he mouths to me, looking regretful.

I smile reassuringly, I won't be mad if he picks up the phone to make sure whoever is calling isn't having some kind of emergency. Lives depend on him sometimes, that's just a fact of his life.

I turn back to my quiet new companion as soft Italian words spill from my husband's mouth. I'm not sure whether he switched to his second language for privacy or necessity, but I'm too shocked by what comes next to contemplate his reasoning.

The little boy's head snaps up, his dark, curly hair bouncing with the swift movement. He immediately staggers out of the bean bag to his feet, wobbling in an unsteady stride, heading straight for Cassio.

Slightly worried but curious, I let the shy child make his way over to my husband. I follow the short path, watching in amazement as he reaches for Cassio's pant leg. He tugs on the fabric urgently to get his attention.

"Aiuto, aiuto," he babbles to Cassio. "Mio mama, aiuto, aiuto." His voice is cracked and his words come out slightly slurred, but it's like a weight immediately lifts from my shoulders.

He hasn't spoken since arriving because he doesn't speak English. He overheard Cassio on the phone speaking Italian and he rushed to his side without a second thought. My heart clenches in my chest as I watch Cassio completely disregard his phone call. He immediately kneels to tend to the boy, concern furrowing his brow.

"Come ti chiami?" he asks in the softest tone.

The boy sniffles, overwhelmed with emotion. "L-leeeo."

"Leo," Cassio repeats to him. He must have asked for the boy's name. "Stai bene, Leo?"

"Adesso," Leo babbles, sniffling. Without caution, Leo throws himself against Cassio, tucking into his chest for comfort.

My husband stiffens, but quickly recovers, offering the boy an embrace in return. "Va tutto bene, shhh," Cassio coos softly. "Va tutto bene, Leo."

Only a few minutes into calming him, Heather finds us.

"He's asking for help for his mother," Cassio tells her, holding an emotional Leo close. "His name is Leo, and he doesn't speak English."

Biting her lip with emotion swimming in her eyes, Heather nods. "We just got a call about him. He can't understand me, right?"

"Not a word," Cassio confirms. "What's happened?"

"His mother abandoned him at a hospital two days ago, and instead of bringing him to the cops and getting him shucked into foster care, he was

brought here. One of The Kings' wives is a nurse there and she risked her job to do it. But now I'm not sure how to help him." She knits her brows in contemplation.

"That call about him was from our lawyer, she overdosed the day after she left him. Apparently Leo's father died a week ago in a car accident, and she couldn't handle it. The lawyer confirmed that Leo has no other family. But if we inform the state about him, he could be taken somewhere so much worse for god knows how long until we can get him back—"

"Don't call anyone about him," Cassio interrupts. "We'll take it from here."

Eyes widening, my mouth pops open. "What? We will?"

"Tell your lawyer that The Moretti Family will take care of him. If anyone here sees fit to report this, I assure you, we have friends in higher places than they do. Leo will have a home tonight."

"I… are you certain?" Heather hesitates. "That would be incredible."

"I have a place in mind, and a backup if that doesn't work out. I'll make a call and handle it."

"I'll go shred the paperwork we have started for him," Heather declares with a look of determination.

"See if you can find out what nurse brought him here," Cassio requests, pulling his phone off the floor.

"What for?"

"I'm going to make sure she gets a bonus for her quick thinking, and that the hospital doesn't find out and fire her."

Is it possible to fall in love all over again?

Grabbing a stray plastic truck off the floor for Leo, my sweet husband encourages the boy to explore it. Shyly, he does, using the wheels to roll it around Cassio's body rather than the floor.

I take a seat next to them, not minding the hard floor one bit, seeing the immense change in Leo. Somehow, Cassio is able to be attentive toward the small child and make his phone call. I can hear the line ringing shortly until someone picks up on the other side.

"Leon, hey," he says, letting Leo continue to roll his toy truck up and down his legs. "Any chance you and Cleo are ready for another kid sooner than expected?"

A pause, and then:

"St. Mary's, yeah. Come quick."

My lips spread into such a wide smile that my cheeks ache.

I'm a small part of such a large, wonderful family.

A half hour later, Cassio's brother arrives with an absolute bombshell on his arm.

I met Leon briefly at my wedding, but it's still surprising to see how little he looks like the rest of his brothers. With dirty brown hair, darker blue eyes, a smaller nose, and a slimmer face shape, he apparently takes after his mother—the only one of the Moretti boys to do so.

Cleo, on the other hand, is entirely unfamiliar to me. I've never even seen photos on social media. Melani, Emilio's wife, I've seen plenty of times in the press, but never Cleo. The illusive woman is gorgeous, though. She has perfectly blown out beachy waves of brunette hair with warm blonde highlights framing her face. Her hazel eyes are brushed with smokey eyeshadow and her plump lips slathered in clear gloss.

She's holding their four-year-old son's hand as the group of three approach the front desk. Bastian is an adorable combination of the two of them. He has shaggy blonde hair, the famous Moretti blue eyes, and Cleo's button nose.

I've been waiting for them since Cassio got a text that they were almost here, wanting to give them a little rundown before they meet Leo. I wanted Cassio to stay in the room with him, trying to prevent any tears or confusion by his only source of comfort leaving the room.

"Hey, Ana," Leon greets politely. "This is Cleo, and our son Bastian."

"Hello, Aunt Ana," Bastian says shyly, looking at his father for approval. When Leon dips his chin, the boy beams.

"Hello, young man," I reply with a big smile. "I'm thrilled to meet you. Are you excited to see your Uncle Cassio?"

"Is he here?" Cleo asks anxiously, skipping right over the pleasantries. I can tell she isn't asking about her brother-in-law. She wants to know about the child she's here to meet.

Leon's expression tightens, but I'm not offended. I can clearly see the motherly glint in her eyes, and I totally understand the hurry.

"His name is Leo," I reply kindly. "He's three, and he only speaks Italian. Cassio has noticed that he can pick up on some English words, but he won't respond to them. He's quite shy, but I'm sure if you speak with him in his language, he'll latch right onto the both of you. Would you like to see him now?"

Cleo nods rapidly. “Please.”

Guiding them back into the room, I quickly add, “We suggest you spend a little while here, acclimating with him but as soon as you’re all comfortable, he’s all yours.”

“Thank you,” Leon says, voice deep and genuine.

I find Cassio exactly where I left him, reading books in the quiet corner of the room, translating the English stories into Italian seamlessly. Watching with hope swelling in my chest, I hold a hand over my heart as introductions are made. Within seconds, Leo is smiling. Within minutes, he’s hugging Cleo and bashfully speaking with Bastian.

Cassio and Leon have the task of explaining to the boy that he is going home with them. That his mum has gone away but that they’re going to take good care of him. I’m expecting tears, but the boy only seems relieved.

By the time they’re ready to leave, I feel twenty pounds lighter. We couldn’t have picked a better day to visit. Leo has a home today because of Cassio. He must feel as accomplished as I do, because once we’re in the car, he doesn’t want to head straight home.

“We should celebrate,” he suggests. “Let me take you to dinner?”

“Like on a date?” I ask, smirking. “Our first official date?”

“Our first date was our wedding,” he jokes. “But yeah, like a date. Can’t a man take his gorgeous wife out for a bite?”

“He certainly can.”

We aren’t dressed for anything too fancy, but Cassio takes us to a quaint Italian restaurant—fitting for the day we’ve had. I’m so excited to be out with him for the first time, but my mood is tested as soon as we meet the hostess. She looks at Cassio like he’s her next meal, but if she isn’t careful, I’ll have her heart on a platter and she’ll be mine instead.

“Mr. Moretti,” she purrs. “Table for two?”

“Yes,” he replies, firmly ignoring her flirtatious tone—if he notices it.

Gesturing to her side, she replies, “Right this way.”

I don’t miss the way she reaches for his arm with her grubby little hands, nor the way my husband steps to the side to avoid it. Once we are seated, she pushes further, setting her hand on top of his shoulder.

“Welcome back, Mr. Moretti.” Her suggestive tone and the way her nails lay against his suit jacket makes my skin crawl.

Cassio glares at her in response and she awkwardly retracts her fingers. I can tell he doesn’t actually know this woman, but she knows exactly who

he is and thinks this is the way to shoot her shot.

Not on my fucking watch.

“Do you need anything else?” she asks.

“Yes, actually,” I chime, lips twisting into a devious smile as I slowly lift the small knife in my silverware bundle. The blade flashes under the fluorescent lights above our table. “If you touch my husband one more time, I’m going to put this through your palm and *twist* until you pass out screaming and crying. Understand?”

The woman goes pale. “I-I—”

“Yes or no?”

“Yes,” she rushes out, and rushes off.

Cassio’s hot gaze licks up and down my skin. “Are you trying to make me hard before we’ve even left?”

“Save that energy for later on,” I tell him, licking my lips. “I have plans for you tonight, Husband.”

He huffs like he’s hot, taking a gulp of the complimentary table water. “I’m the luckiest bastard in here.”

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Chapter Thirty-Three



Ana

There are a few benefits to being with a man who runs as warm as Cassio does. When you're cold, he's a walking furnace to snuggle into, his body temperature transforming your own like magic. He never complains when I slip my freezing cold feet in between his thick and blazing hot thighs, letting me fall asleep with them there if I want.

But the best benefit is how little he wears to bed in order to get some sleep himself. The tiniest little briefs that barely pass for shorts and nothing else. He must have been overheating for weeks when he would hold me at night, wearing a shirt and sleep pants so that he wouldn't make me uncomfortable with his near nudity.

Now he sleeps on his back, the silky bed sheet only covering half of him, one leg hidden and part of the fabric splayed over his middle. I could watch him sleep for hours, just being mesmerized by his rising and falling chest. He's so sculpted it's hard to take my eyes off of him in the daylight, let alone while he's basking in a peaceful sleep.

It's a mutual obsession, since I've caught Cassio watching me as I wake up on more than one occasion. But it's not often that he's in bed when I'm not by his side, making it difficult for me to admire him as much as I'd like.

I never considered myself an obsessive person, but something about my husband drives me mad. I can't get enough of his sight, watching him whenever he's near, not bothering to look away when he catches me gawking. Tonight, though, he won't catch me. He's in a deep sleep, utterly unaware that I'm standing above his side of the bed… observing.

Being patient isn’t something that I’m usually fond of, but I have the strangest need to take my time. I have Cassio all to myself. I could do anything to him and he wouldn’t see it coming. I could hurt him, or worse, end his life. There’s an unspoken trust between people who share a bed, sleeping is one of the most vulnerable states for a human to be found in.

Even the dark parts of me, the parts I can hardly control, don’t have the smallest desire to hurt my husband. Not the tiniest bit of murderous temptation calls to me. No, hurt is not something I ever want to inflict on this man. Truthfully, all I want to do is play with him—to touch him while he rests and all the control falls upon me.

I like being submissive to my husband, *love* it, even. I enjoy letting go and feeling all the incredible things he does to my body. It’s freeing, feeling pleasure that’s entirely decided by someone other than myself. But while Cassio is sleeping, a different sort of freedom sings to me.

My hands creep up from my sides, gliding up my soft thighs and caressing the pink nightie I put on after my shower. My hair is still slightly damp, hanging down around the center of my back and my ribs. I’d have dried it, but I couldn’t risk the sound of the hair dryer waking Cassio up. I need this tonight, I need it so badly that my hands itch to reach for him.

Cupping my breasts, the small burst of pleasure sends a shiver down my spine. Keeping one hand over my sensitive tit, I drop the other to reach for my husband. The barest brush of my nails over his exposed thigh causes his flesh to pebble and I grin at the sight. It feels naughty, like I shouldn’t be doing this. The emotion doesn’t scare me, no, it *fuels* me.

The soft rise and fall of Cassio’s breath is the only notable sound as I delve deeper into exploring his unconscious body. After only a few minutes of my hands roaming all along his warm skin, the blanket covering his crotch begins to lift. His breathing hasn’t shifted at all, but he’s becoming aroused in his sleep.

The sight causes a bubble of enthusiasm to burst, some of my patience melting away. Carefully, I begin to rid him of his shorts, desperately needing to see more of him. Once his cock springs free, all control is lost. Foil packet in hand, I climb into bed, careful not to stir him.

Pushing my lace knickers to one side, I glide my fingers through my slit, finding my cunt utterly soaked. Unrelenting desire claws at me, and I reach forward, petting his cock with my arousal-coated fingers.

I need him inside of me, *now*.

Hurriedly gliding a condom down his shaft, I straddle his hips in a ravenous rush. I stroke his cock once before lining him up to notch at my entrance. Letting my weight fall, my pussy slides down, swallowing him inch by inch.

It's so sneaky, so forbidden, and so fucking good.

Rocking on my knees, I start to ride him slowly, not knowing how much I can take while remaining quiet. My skin is covered in gooseflesh, the wispy hairs on my arms standing straight up. I already feel like I could burst, my walls constricting around my husband's rock hard erection.

I have to cover my mouth to muffle a whimper, not wanting to be caught before I've gotten my fill. My hips swivel in a slow, sensual circle, savoring the way Cassio's cock throbs inside of me.

"God," I whisper, gasping and continuing to rock back and forth.

Breaths growing shorter and shallower, I lose some of my composure. Every movement becomes more erratic, an undeniable climax approaching fast. Throwing my head back, a silent scream of pleasure aches in my throat. My pussy spasms around his length, clenching and squeezing as spots dance in my vision.

Cum soaks my thighs and drips onto Cassio's pelvis, but I don't feel him orgasm with me. What I *do* feel? His eyes snapping open and his hands clasping around my hips.

He doesn't take a moment to recover, flipping me onto my stomach with the barest effort. His lips meet the shell of my ear and his deep raspy voice makes me whimper. "Did you enjoy that, Wife? Did you like using my cock as your personal toy *without permission*, hmm?"

"Yes," I croak, feeling his large hand snake into my hair.

He tugs the hair close to my scalp, fisting the damp strands into a tight grip. "Yeah? I could fucking tell with how hard you came, darling girl. You soaked me and the sheets, didn't you?"

Bloody hell, I think automatically. Cassio taking charge after such a strong orgasm has my brain swimming.

His hand suddenly bounces off my ass with a crisp *smack*.

"Didn't you?" he repeats firmly, not appreciating my delayed response.

"*Oh God,*" I moan. "Yes, Cassio."

"My slutty little wife, using me in my sleep," he tsks, his voice raspy and dangerous. "What did you think I would do if you woke me up while having your fun, baby? Did you think I'd let you get away with it, huh?"

“N-no,” I deny, shaking my head as much as his hold will allow.

“No, of course you didn’t,” he agrees, quickly spanking me again. *Harder*, this time. A gasp flies from my mouth and he chuckles. “Did you think I would *punish* you, Ana? Did you *want* me to?”

“I-I,” my voice stammers, and my mind whirls as he slaps my ass twice more. I feel some of my release starting to seep between my thighs as I grow more aroused. I don’t think I’ve ever been so fucking wet.

“I, I?” he mocks, imitating me. “What’s wrong, baby? Is your brain still fried from all of that work you just put in bouncing on my dick?”

“You liked it,” I accuse, wiggling to push my backside further against him.

“My, my, aren’t we feeling bold tonight,” Cassio drawls. “I think I like it better when you’re too exhausted to give me lip, *dearest wife*. What shall I do about that?”

“Use me in return?”

He groans huskily. “Good guess, baby.”

In a bold and swift thrust, Cassio plunges his cock into my dripping wet cunt. It’s tighter like this, his thick length stretching me further than riding him ever possibly could.

I cry out at the fullness, my scream muffling into the pillows. Cassio shows no mercy, pulling me up by my hair so that he can hear me.

“Don’t fucking hide from me,” he growls. “Every sound you make is fucking mine. Every little whimper and every single scream. Mine, Wife. Say it.”

“Yours,” I whine, gasping as he pulls back and snaps his hips forward. Having my way with him was spectacular, but this… *God, I can never get enough.*

“Cross your legs, Ana,” he instructs and I quickly comply. His fit inside of my pussy becomes even more snug with the action and my eyes threaten to roll. “Mmm, you listen so well when you want me to pound you into the mattress, don’t you, love? Greedy girl.”

“Yesss,” I hiss automatically.

Feeling Cassio take charge and be rough with me is indescribable. Fire sizzles through my blood with every move he makes, burying himself as far inside of me as he can get. He knows me like the back of his hand, touching exactly where I need, controlling my pleasure like it’s an art he’s mastered.

“You like when I treat you like my little whore, Wife?” he demands, punctuating his question with a hard thrust. “You like when I grab you by your hair and fill your needy little cunt full of my cock, don’t you?”

Gasping, I swallow hard. “I love it.”

I love you, I don’t say.

“My perfect fucking girl,” he praises. “So honest about how naughty she is, fucking me in my sleep. So obedient for taking her punishment after, too. How did I get so lucky, hmm?”

I can only whimper in response.

“You should see yourself,” he says, caressing my scalp with his thumb, still holding a fist full of my hair. “The posh little Moretti wife being properly debauched. It’s unbelievable, baby.”

Blinding pleasure hits me in the gut and I clench around him. He knows just how to work me into a hazy mess.

“It’s so good,” I confess, becoming overwhelmed.

“*Fucking hell*, Ana,” Cassio curses. “You have no idea how fucking good you feel like this.”

“Cassio,” I whimper, gripping the bed sheets tight. “I’m so close. Please, don’t stop. *Oh God, please—*”

“You want to come, Wife?” he groans, continuing to slam into me. “Tell me how badly you want it.”

“Please, please, please,” I cry. “I need to, Cassio. Make me come.”

“Since you begged so pretty for me,” he growls, maneuvering his hand under my hip. He finds my clit without struggle and immediately strokes the slippery bud with his thumb.

“Cassio!” I shout, unconsciously humping his hand.

He shifts slightly, causing his fingers to press down harder on my clit and the change in pressure is all it takes. I see stars, voice cracking with how hard I moan. He groans along with me, feeling my walls constrict around his throbbing cock.

Seconds of hard thrusts later and I feel him swell up before warmth floods between my legs. I can’t wait for the day that the condom isn’t in our way, and he can stuff me impossibly full with his hot cum.

When he finally pulls out, my ears are still whooshing with blood and my body feels limp. My poor pussy is swollen, deliciously used and stretched. I’m going to be sore tomorrow, that’s for sure.

“Wow,” I murmur, breathing hard.

He chuckles. “Anymore kinks you want to explore, baby?”

I grin lazily, thinking of our conversation before he went to bed early. I told him my fantasy, and he made it come to life in the most incredible fashion.

“Not yet, darling.”

With him as my husband, I’m sure that there will be more eventually.

Recognizing that he’s stolen all of my energy, Cassio begins to take care of me with little help. He carries me to the bathroom and proceeds to get me warm and clean once more. Putting me into one of his shirts, he guides me back into bed.

It’s not long before both of us are fast asleep.

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Chapter Thirty-Four



Ana
One Month Later

It's officially been two and a half months since my wedding day, and a month since receiving my first message from *Mr. Unknown Number*. A lot has happened since, but his contact has dwindled quite a bit. The messages are few and far between, each of them bothering me less than the last.

I easily brushed off things like…

UNKNOWN NUMBER

If you continue to test my patience, you'll regret it, Ana.

And:

UNKNOWN NUMBER

Leave him, and I might let him live.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

Actually, no I won't. I want to rip him away from you properly. You clearly didn't learn from Cole. I'll be more obvious about your lesson this time around.

The only correspondence that was truly chilling came two days ago, and I've been a little bummed out ever since.

UNKNOWN NUMBER

I’ve been counting, you know? Every time you let him touch you, I add a tally. Do you want to know what I’m going to do with that number when the time comes?

UNKNOWN NUMBER

I’m going to carve it into his fucking heart.

I don’t understand who could possibly be behind these threats or why they’re so focused on me. Cassio says they feel possessive of me, and he thinks that killing Cole was meant to be a punishment for acting out. By being with him physically, I signed his death warrant—though Cassio continuously reminds me that I’m not responsible for someone else’s delusions.

It still doesn’t add up to me. Why weren’t there warnings before? There were no threatening texts, or any connection to this anonymous sender at all before. Why did Cole get immediately targeted after being with me? And were Bron and Killian meant to be collateral damage, or were they targeted for being compliant in my relationship with Cole?

Is this bigger than some crazed obsession with me? And why *me*?

It gives me a headache, trying to think about it too much.

I try to live in the moment instead, reminding myself how grateful I am for the people surrounding me. Cassio, Armani, and Colton make every day feel easier. Even my daily texts with Jade, and our occasional video chats make me feel lighter.

Napping also helps, and I’ve just gotten up from quite a pleasant one. *If only waking up was as satisfying.* Narrowing my eyes at my bedroom door, I slip my hand into my bedside table, seeking out the handgun Armani gave me a few weeks back. It’s meant to be for emergencies, in case there’s a break in of some kind, but something is telling me to keep it close now.

I hear voices coming from downstairs. Some I recognize, some I definitely do *not*. Suspicion has my hackles rising as the sound of a feminine voice registers. It’s too far away to make out any of the words being said, but I know it’s not Agnes, and it’s certainly not Jade.

Creeping down the stairs, gun in hand and Sirius padding behind me, the sight I stumble upon in the kitchen makes my blood boil.

Red hair, slim build with curves, and a smile curling her lips.

Manicured fingers brushing against a masculine wrist.

My eye twitches, and I react without thinking, making myself known.

“Who the fuck are you and why are your hands on my husband?” I demand, pistol pointed firmly at her center mass.

“Ana—” Cassio starts, only to be interrupted by the mystery woman’s soft laugh.

My finger itches to move to the trigger and my teeth gnash. “Laugh at me again, and I swear to God—”

“*Ana*,” Cassio says more firmly. “This is Winona. She’s showing me a forearm strap for tactical knives, and she’s not a threat.”

“*Winona*,” I mock, tasting her name like it’s sour. “Is your name supposed to mean something to me?”

“Winona *Wyatt*, darling,” she clarifies, a southern twang in her sweet tone. “I believe my son calls you ‘doll’, but you’re not a doll at all, are you? You sound more like a viper to me.”

Slowly lowering my aim to the floor, I assess the beautiful redhead with narrowed eyes. “You’re Colton’s mum?”

“His very married, very not flirting with me, mom,” Cassio confirms.

“I heard New Yorkers weren’t very friendly but I did expect a warmer welcome,” Winona pipes up teasingly.

“Yeah?” I challenge arching a brow. “Do I sound like a New Yorker to you? And would you be welcoming to a pretty stranger you find feeling up your husband in your house without your knowledge?”

“She most certainly wouldn’t be,” my favorite cowboy answers, sauntering into the room. “Did you pull a gun on my mother, doll?” His voice is full of amusement and it makes me want to smack the smug little grin right off his handsome face.

“I wouldn’t have killed her,” I tell him with a tight smile in return. “At first.”

“You’re the most possessive woman in an arranged marriage I’ve ever met,” Colton says through a chuckle. “Holster your weapon and play nice, will you? I can’t have my two favorite ladies fighting.”

His mother laughs happily. “Who says we’re fighting? I already like the girl.”

“Of course you’d imprint on her after she held you at gunpoint,” Armani chimes, shaking his head while smiling. Looking her up and down and whistling appreciatively, he adds, “Looking fine as hell as always, Mama Wyatt.”

“And you wonder why my father despises you,” Colton says disapprovingly.

Armani flashes his playboy smile. “Oh, Daddy Levi can get it too. Talk about a dream three-way—”

“Disgusting,” Colton grimaces, cutting Armani off.

“And people think you two are dating,” I scoff, finally putting my weapon in a holster at the small of my back.

Cassio approaches, ignoring the banter around us and cups my face on both sides. We share a soft and intimate kiss before he asks, “You okay, baby?”

“Better now,” I say, releasing a sigh. “A heads up when we’re having guests would be appreciated next time.”

“I didn’t want to wake you,” he explains but brings my hands to his mouth to kiss in apology. “It won’t happen again, my love.”

“See that it doesn’t, Husband.”

“She’s here for you anyway, doll,” Colton chimes. “She brought gifts.”

“Gifts?” I ask doubtfully, allowing my husband to guide me into the group. *Why would a woman I’ve never met before have gifts for me?*

But I suppose she must since Colton’s mom waves a small black box, holding it out excitedly.

“Winona makes self-defense jewelry for women,” Cassio explains, taking the box from her. “I reached out a little while ago to have her make you a few things.”

That makes more sense. Winona didn’t go out of her way to give me a present from herself, she’s simply the maker of the gift and Cassio is the giver. I imagine she only decided to deliver them herself to see her son.

“You did?” I ask, softening up immediately.

My husband is spoiling me with weapons instead of diamonds… *God, why is that so sweet?*

When Cassio opens the little black box, my eyes light up as he starts to show me the various contents within. A belt that hides a knife in the center clasp that I can wear with jeans, a stick of deodorant that opens to a taser, rather than antiperspirant, and more. The lipstick tube that twists up a triangle knife instead of makeup gets the biggest reaction.

“That one’s great because it may look small, but the shape makes it very strong. And triangle wounds are more difficult to stitch, which can mean the fucker you stick with it bleeds for longer,” Colton tells me enthusiastically.

“You can fuck someone up real bad with that thing,” Armani agrees, grinning. “Imagine the dent it would put in the jugular, ouch.”

“I like them all,” I say, grinning at my new possessions.

“We haven’t even gotten to the best one,” Cassio tells me, kissing my temple before nodding to Colton’s mother. “Show her.”

The weapon Winona pulls out of her purse is… confusing. It looks like a scrunchie with a covered knife dangling upside down from the loop. My face must betray my bewilderment, because she chuckles lightly.

“This one is great for you because you have this gorgeous thick hair,” Winona says, gesturing for me to spin around.

“Thank you,” I reply, accepting the compliment and turning on my heels. I can’t stay mad at one of my good friend’s mothers, after all.

I know I take a while to warm up, and Winona and I definitely didn’t start on the right foot. But she seems willing to brush the confrontation under the rug, and I need to attempt to do the same. For Colton.

Using my existing ponytail as an example, she wraps the scrunchie around it twice, tucking the hanging knife seamlessly into my hair.

“Perfect,” she comments happily. “You can’t see it at all. If you need it while you’re wearing it. Simply pull on the handle, and the sheath will stay attached to the base, that way you can tug it out easily.”

Colton chuckles. “This way the blade stays covered while in your hair, and doesn’t give you a choppy ass cut while swaying around in there.”

“I’m going to wear this one all the time,” I declare, chin lifting high. “It’s genius, Winona. Thank you.”

“Thank your husband,” she tells me with a smirk. “He’s the one who rush-ordered all of this. I just stopped by to see my boy, and that beautiful pup of yours if you’ll let me.”

Remembering that she’s the woman who saved and trained him, I don’t have to contemplate my answer.

“Sirius, come,” I command softly. He trots right up to my side, tail slowly wagging. Pointing to his former trainer, I add, “Sirius, play.”

Hearing the word that assures him he’s off duty, he yips gleefully and lunges for Winona. Tail wagging fast and jaw dropped open to pant, letting his tongue flop around, he weaves around her legs in an excited huff.

“Who’s a good boy?” she coos, petting him in return.

“The dog gets a warmer greeting than I do,” Colton sulks.

“The dog didn’t put me through twenty-eight hours of labor,” his mum quips, smirking up at him.

“Point taken.”

Cassio

After Winona leaves, I whip up a quick lunch for all of us. It’s Agnes’ day off, and if I didn’t cook, we’d be eating leftovers or takeout. Cooking was apparently the right choice, because my wife loves it.

“Ohhhh my goddd, *Cassio*,” Ana moans. Her eyes flutter shut like she’s just been transported to heaven.

Armani snorts, leaning down to take a bite of his own sandwich. “I do not need to hear your fuck noises at the table, love.”

Ana ignores him, swallowing her next bite. “I would fuck this tuna melt.”

“You could fuck the man who made it for you instead,” Colton suggests, giving me a wink.

“Right after I brush my teeth,” my wife agrees, nodding.

“God, I need to get laid,” Armani groans. “I’m in a responsible brother dry spell, hanging out around here all the time.”

“A sex detox was totally in order,” Colton tells him, patting his back. “Now you know you can go weeks and weeks without it. I’m so proud.”

“Fuck off.” My brother huffs. “Not all of us want to wait around for it.”

Colton shrugs. “You just need to meet the right person.”

“Your *right person* won’t even text you back, let alone fuck you.”

“I’m playing the long game.”

“I hope your dick shrivels up from prolonged neglect.”

“I hope your community cock gets an infection,” Colton retorts.

Ana almost chokes on her sandwich laughing.

“I do not understand your friendship,” I say, eyeing the two men. I’ve never wished an STD on Killian, and certainly never wished Leon’s dick would shrivel up. I’m pretty sure they’re joking and don’t actually wish undo harm on each other’s pricks, but who knows with them.

Just as I'm about to take another bite of my lunch, a knock sounds against the front door, and I immediately stiffen. Armani and I reach for our guns at the same time, Colton quickly following in suit. Our bodies shift in unison, blocking Ana from the view of the door as we stand up from the kitchen counter.

"Oh, would you relax?" Ana huffs, getting up and maneuvering around us before I can stop her. "I ordered something, it's just Gerard bringing it up. He made sure the package wasn't tampered with."

Sure enough, when she swings open the door, Gerard is standing there. They exchange a few quick words before he hands her a blue gift bag and excuses himself.

"What'd you get?" Armani asks, eyeing the delivery as Ana returns to the counter.

"Something for Cassio," she answers cryptically. Sliding back into her seat, she starts to eat again, ignoring the elephant in the room.

Colton snorts. "Way to leave us in suspense, doll."

"I'll give it to him as soon as you both leave."

"Umm, rude," Armani gripes.

Dramatically holding a hand over his heart, Colton pouts. "We were here for your gifts! Why can't we see his? Why don't we have any? What kind of backwards Christmas is this!?"

"It's March," Ana replies blandly, not allowing their antics to make her crack. "And Cassio can show you after, if he'd like to."

"It's a sex gift, isn't it?"

"Oooo, is it a butt plug? There's no shame in the anal game, Cass. The prostate is the male g-spot, you know?"

Give me strength.

"It's not a butt plug, and if it were, it would be for me," Ana tells them matter-of-factly.

The goofy grins my wife's over-share causes end my patience with these two little shits.

"All right, time for you two to go," I gripe, nodding toward the stairs. "Take your lunch and fuck off."

Huffing, they both do as they're told, grumbling about my *bitchy attitude* the whole way. Ana finds it quite amusing, giggling as she watches them go. If they didn't bring her so much joy, they would probably drive me nuts.

Raising a brow in her direction, I nod to the bag. “You got me something on the same day I had your gifts delivered?”

Smiling wistfully, she nods. “I didn’t even plan the delivery date, I had it delivered to Gerard’s place so it would be a secret and he just texted me after my nap. Funny how fate works.”

“Yeah,” I agree softly. “Fate.”

Fate is exactly the right word to use concerning Ana. It’s like she was dropped down straight from the sky, destined to land in my lap.

“Now finish your lunch, I want to give you this.”

Chuckling, I do just that. After we wash up, Ana corrals me to the couch, pushing the baby blue bag into my hands.

“Open it,” she insists.

Riffling through the tissue paper, my fingers clasp around a thick, square box. It has some weight to it, and as I pull it out, I notice hinges on the side for an easy to open top.

I can feel my wife’s eyes on me as my thumbs push open the lid. Seeing what’s inside, I freeze before lifting my gaze to her.

“It’s like three months early,” Ana says, biting her lip. “But I wanted to get you something for Father’s Day, and I couldn’t wait to give it to you once I saw pictures of the final product.”

I swallow hard, looking back down to stare at the gift in awe. It’s a custom white gold *Cartier* watch, with glacial blue gemstones framing the circular clock, and the minute and hour hands in a matching shade of blue.

“The aquamarine stones,” she continues, sounding nervous. “They’re your son’s birthstone. I asked Dad what month he was born before I designed the watch. I know talking about him is hard, but even if he isn’t here with us, you’ll always be Angel’s father. I’d like to celebrate that every year… if you’ll let me.”

If I’ll *let* her?

Cristo, she is too lovely for words.

Shedding my current watch, I quickly replace it with the new one. Ana beams at me, emotion dancing around her caramel eyes.

“Come here.”

The following kiss I plant on her makes my fucking head spin.

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Chapter Thirty-Five



Ana

Today I woke up with one nagging thought. *I need to punch something.*

There isn't a huge pit of rage in my stomach driving me toward aggression, but frustration that sex can only do so much to cure instead. I'm getting restless as days without answers continue to pile up.

Killian is mostly recovered according to Cassio, and he'll likely be able to show face around here soon. But anonymous messages continue to ping on my phone—no matter how many numbers I block—and my mother and Cole have yet to be avenged.

When I thought of the mafia before being a part of it, I thought these men were nearly invincible. That problems could be solved at the drop of a hat, and sometimes that can be true. Unfortunately, this situation is shady with a capital S. Someone is pulling the strings too well, and it's impossible to take scissors to threads we can't see.

I want Killian home, and I want *Mr. Creepy Texts* to fucking die.

So, I'm going to take my resentful attitude down to the gym and see if I can't sweat it out. I haven't used the Knight family gym in far too long, but it's perfectly equipped with anything I could need. Exercise machines, several different punching bags, mats for judo sparring, a balance beam, pull up bars, and more.

I start with a quick run around the area, getting my blood pumping and my body warmed up to stretch. It's quickly apparent that my stamina has taken a hit after months of being mostly sedentary. I used to work out at

least three times a week, cardio and keeping up with Judo mostly. It can be therapeutic, and the endorphins are good for stress.

Thankfully, by the time I start heading for a punching bag, I'm not overly winded. I'm warm, sweating a little, but breathing quite easily. It seems I haven't entirely fucked up my endurance.

"Hey, pretty girl, I heard you wanted to hit someone," a flirtatious Armani greets, waltzing into the gym with Colton in tow.

My eyes bulge at the sight of them, both men are entirely missing shirts and dawning athletic shorts that hit just above the center of their thighs. If they were barefoot, I'd assume the pair were going for a swim. They might as well be wearing boxer shorts with their trainers.

Armani is slightly bulkier than Colton, but they're eerily similar in stature. Both with wide, toned shoulders, slim muscular waists, and thick thighs that could crush a grown man's head. Both are intimidating to look at, but Armani most of all.

Despite his Fabio-like silky hair that sways just past his collarbones, his stark tattoos make him look more like a prisoner than a pirate. He's covered in ink, arms, chest, legs… dark intricate designs decorate more than seventy percent of his visible skin. He's like a work of art himself.

"Bloody hell," I blurt, unable to hide my astonished face.

"Are you checking us out right now, doll?" Colton teases, waggling his brows.

"I feel objectified," Armani tacks on in mock offense.

Sputtering, I fold my arms over my chest. "*You* feel objectified? I feel like I'm watching Magic Mike! Those shorts would be small on *me*," I exclaim. "Do you two seriously work out in that?"

"Like your sports bra and fuck-me leggings are any less scandalous," Armani challenges, looking me up and down before arching a brow.

"*Fuck-me leggings*." I scoff. "These are the most basic—"

The two burst into laughter, cutting off my rant.

"Something funny?" I demand, hands flexing into fists.

"We're only fucking with ya, doll," Colton soothes, putting his hands up in surrender. "We figured if we were going to let you pound on us for a few hours, we would get a little ego boost out of it first."

"So worth it," Armani tacks on. "Besides, it's good to keep Cassio on his toes. He has to know he's not the only eye candy rolling around here. He needs to behave to keep his wife, lest one of us tries to swoop in."

“I doubt either of you have ever truly been in need of an ego boost,” I grumble, trying not to smile at their antics. “And a pretty face isn’t enough to sway me from Cassio, Armani. He’s mine, if he doesn’t *behave*, I’ll handle him myself.”

“I knew I should have volunteered to marry you,” the tattooed man groans, clutching his heart with false pain. “A possessive woman after my own heart.”

“Yeah right,” I huff. “You don’t want to be tied down, and I like my men firmly bound. Besides, I would have picked Cassio even if you did volunteer.”

Colton cracks up and Armani makes a sound of protest. “Now you’re just being mean.”

A giggle leaves me and I shrug. “Now I’m laughing too.”

“All right, where do you want me?” Colton flings his arms out to the side, offering himself up like a sacrifice. “I’m ready to be thrown around.”

I snort, nodding to the practice mats. “We can do some sparring, treat it like No-Gi Judo.”

Rubbing his hands together mischievously, Colton grins. “Sounds good, doll. Don’t embarrass me too badly?”

“I’m going to record her hurling you across the floor to send to everyone we know,” Armani declares, smirking.

“I’ll happily return the favor.” Colton faces me in the center of the mat. “Okay, so how are we—*oh no*—”

I rush at him full speed, jumping to wrap my legs around his neck and fling myself downward. Colton flips to the ground, landing with a hard thud as I hop back to my feet. Armani is cackling, holding his phone up and clutching his stomach.

“I don’t think that was Judo,” Colton groans, rolling onto his back to stand up again.

“It wasn’t,” I quip, trying not to giggle. “That was just for fun.”

“Vicious, little doll,” he grunts, rubbing the back of his neck. “I think it’s Armani’s turn to get abused.”

“All right, pretty girl, I’m coming for you.”

Armani jogs toward me, extending a hand like he might grab me with it. I snatch it instead, turning to the side. Using his momentum and body weight against him, I throw Armani off-balance, maneuver him over my hip, and send him crashing into the ground.

I know that in a life or death situation, both of these men could probably take me down without much effort. But it's nice that they're allowing me to show my skills anyway. For me, Judo is meant to help even the playing field. It's great for women, focusing on technique rather than brute strength to be successful.

We spend the next hour laughing, sparring, and even breaking out the boxing gloves to do some hitting drills. I'm breathing heavily and sweating far too much for my liking by the time we call it quits.

Sitting down on a foam chair, I swipe some hair from my eyes and wait for the boys to come over with cold beverages. Having a fridge in the gym is a luxury I appreciate every time I come in here.

"We've thought of an idea," Colton pipes up, flopping down onto a clean, folded mat near my feet.

"Did it hurt?" I joke.

"Ha-ha," he deadpans, rolling his eyes.

"When Jade first came into the family, Matteo gave her a bunch of information about us," Armani interrupts, passing me a bottle of chilled electrolyte water. "He wanted her to feel like one of us, and she couldn't do that if she knew nothing about us."

"So," Colton says, clapping his hands together. "We're going to do the same thing, twenty questions style."

Armani nods, dropping into a large bean bag chair to face us. "Unlike Jade, you already know all our names and some of what we do. But hit us with those burning questions, and make them juicy. We're family now, after all."

"I like this idea," I admit. "I feel like we're really close somehow, but I still don't know a ton about either of you."

"We feel the same."

The questions start slow and innocent enough.

When did you two meet? Armani was eight, Colton was seven.

Did you go to high school? Both had tutors privately, just like me.

Favorite kind of music? Country for Colton, Rock for Armani.

Do you have a favorite Moretti family memory? Armani says it's too hard to choose, but Dad and Apollo teaching him how to shoot his first gun, and the day they found Jade came to mind.

What did you want to be when you were little? Colton wanted to be a cowboy like his father, and Armani never wanted a job. He wanted to

collect clothes and shoot guns—which he brags is literally what he does now. When they ask the same thing to me, I tell them I wanted to be an artist like my mum, until I realized I hate the smell of paint and don't have the attention span to stick to any medium.

Oddly enough the thing that steers the conversation toward a more salacious direction begins with me asking Armani, "Which sibling are you closest to?"

"I'm a certified middle child," Armani replies with a sigh. "Close with everyone, closest with no one."

Colton nods along. "Which is why he has me."

"But you two have never…"

"Nope," Armani confirms, popping the p. "Tried to drunkenly kiss once as teenagers, It did *not* go well."

"And before you ask, no, we've never considered sharing a partner."

I gape at him before blurting out, "People ask you that?"

"Allllll the time," Colton confirms. "I'm far too possessive to even consider it."

"And he doesn't do one nighters," Armani adds. "Such a bore."

My brows lift. "So you're saying you would have a threesome… just not with Colton?"

"I've done plenty of group activities, pretty girl." Armani lifts his shoulder in a half shrug. "It's not that special, but *your* interest seems piqued. Would *you* ever have a threesome?"

"Sure, if I could clone Cassio to do it."

Colton cackles. "That's my kind of answer."

"Ick, I do not need to hear your fantasies about cloning my brother."

Sitting up straighter, I pin Colton with a curious look. "Speaking of that… which Moretti man are you chasing after, mister? This is the second time I'm hearing of it with no further context."

"We should do something when this is all over," Colton muses, changing the topic with ease. "Something siblings would do. Family bonding, but not juvenile."

I snort at his obvious avoidance but don't push. He doesn't need to tell me just because I'm his friend. He's allowed to have some privacy if he wants it. Arching a brow at his suggestion, I play along. "Like what?"

"Well, what did you do with Killian for fun?"

“Fun?” I snort. “Killian isn’t much of a *fun* sort of bloke. Most of the time we spent out together was at events. Fundraisers, galas, grand openings… and well, fights, I suppose.”

“Fights?” Armani perks up, attention caught. “Underground stuff or, like, UFC events?”

“Underground,” I confirm. “Killian has fought at a few. There’s a mutually owned club that a lot of syndicates use.”

His eyes sparkle with interest. “Killian fancies himself a fighter, does he? Is he any good?”

“He’s good.” My shoulder’s lift in a shrug. “He doesn’t do anything too competitive or crazy. It’s mostly to stay in shape and to remind everyone that he’s the heir to the Monarch for a reason. He’s only ever been in one deathmatch, and that was to put down a traitor.”

“They took you to this place? And let you watch *deathmatches*?” Colton questions, jaw hanging open. “Are they insane?”

“Oh please,” I scoff, rolling my eyes. “I was fine. And for your information, the only deathmatch I’ve seen was Killian’s—and I knew he would win. I typically have no desire to watch a grown man gamble his life for the sake of pride.”

“Still,” Armani winces, shaking his head. “I wouldn’t let Jade within ten miles of an underground fighting ring, especially if one of her brothers were in the ring. Shit can get ugly on the outside too.”

“Okay, *Dad*,” I drone, shaking off his overprotective nature. “Do you guys even fight?”

“Of course we fight,” Armani declares loudly, looking scandalized by such a question. “What do you think we do to keep our power? Sit around singing songs and braiding each other’s hair? The Moretti’s create some of the most lethal fighters in the country.”

Holding up my hands in surrender, I chuckle. “Such passion! I’m so sorry to have offended your delicate sensibilities. I take it you’re one of the better fighters in the family?”

Armani’s chest puffs up and he grins big. “You know it. Apollo and Elio have got me beat, I’m man enough to admit it. Those two are monsters in hand to hand. Elio hits harder than anyone I know, and Apollo is lightning fast. But after them, it’s me.”

He hums like he’s considering his next words. “I’d say Leon and Cassio are next. Matteo is scrappy as fuck, but he doesn’t care for it unless there’s

a reason. Remo prefers digital violence. And you know how Nico is, he'd rather skin someone than spar with them."

"Don't forget Father Dante," Colton remarks with a flirty smirk. "He might be in his fifties, but the man can brawl."

"Fuck," Armani grunts, puffing out a breath. "I definitely wouldn't want to get in the ring with him. I watched Uncle Cesar train with him when I was younger and they were brutal."

"All right, so we'll plan something not so dangerous once it's safe. But right now? I need a bloody shower."

The boys agree, and we go our separate ways.

It's been a good day, I think to myself, heading up to my room.

So good that I don't notice the feeling of being watched.

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Chapter Thirty-Six



Ana

"Sirius, shhh," I mumble, trying to bury my head further into my pillow. *God, I'm so tired. It can not be early enough for Sirius to want to get up.*

A soft whine and the touch of his wet nose against my elbow make me frown. *Where are Armani and Colton when you need them?*

Forcing myself to wake up, I rub my eyes and blink rapidly to clear my vision. The bedroom is mostly shadows, hardly any light seeping in from the stars outside. When I find my dog, he isn't trying to wake me anymore. He's lying on the floor, disturbingly still.

My heart races as an eerie awareness creeps up the back of my neck.

That's when I see the flair of red sticking out from his side. A puffy unidentified bit of material, like the tail end of a tranquilizer dart.

"*Oh God,"* I gasp.

I thought Sirius was bothering me in the middle of the night to go to the bathroom, but he was trying to bark to alert me, but whatever drug he's been stuck with drained him too quickly. He could only whine and try to nudge me before succumbing to the sedative.

Something is very, *very* wrong.

Reaching behind me in a blind panic, I try to nudge Cassio awake, only to find his side of the bed empty.

Sitting up in alarm, I flinch at the sound of a click, low lamp light flooding the room. A scream catches in my throat as I find an intruder, gun in hand. Cassio is being held on his knees, the barrel of a pistol against his temple.

“Miss me?” the bald man asks, a monstrous smile playing on his lips.

Cassio growls. “If you touch her—”

“Shut it, or I’ll stop playing so nice.”

My stomach churns. *How could this happen?*

We had a completely normal evening last night. There were no unsolicited messages, nothing out of the ordinary. We didn’t even have sex since I was so tired from working out hours before.

And now *this*?

Please, please, let this be a nightmare.

But it can’t be. It feels too real. Too terrifying.

My blood runs cold. “Let him go.”

“Where would be the fun in that? We’re just getting started.”

My eyes dart to my side table, wishing the gun inside my drawer was already in my hands.

“Ah, ah,” Baldy tsks. “Don’t do anything stupid, or these walls will get a fresh coat of brain matter. I don’t have time for the dramatics. I already had to hold you at gunpoint to get this one out of bed and into position quietly. You are both terrible at cooperating and *he’s* still waiting for us.”

He, who?

I don’t have time to ask before the bald man barks his next order.

“Take her.”

Three bodies emerge from the shadows, surrounding me in seconds.

My husband looks like he’s going to risk being shot to lunge for me, when the bald man shoves a needle into the side of his neck. In an instant, he releases whatever is in the syringe, and I scream.

“No, no, Cassio!” I cry, trying to claw, kick, and elbow my way out of being captured. Heavy hands clasp around my arms, squeezing hard enough to bruise. I hiss, managing to swing one of my knees into someone’s chin.

“Fucking bitch,” he spits, grabbing me again, harder.

“Armani! Colton!”

“Don’t bother calling for them—they got the same treatment as the dog,” a slimy voice says with a chuckle.

“Just drug her.” The bald man sighs like he’s bored. “Her whining is giving me a headache.”

“I’m going to fucking kill you,” I scream, still trying to thrash and fight. It’s no use. Four on one are horrible odds, especially as someone my size without a weapon.

“Good luck with that,” he says, condescension dripping from every word.

A prick in the side of my neck burns, and my arms go weak. I can’t keep my eyes open, and after a few heavy blinks, everything goes dark.

Soreness seeps into my very bones, a deep radiating ache that only adds to my fatigue. I can’t see a thing, and my eyes feel too irritated to open. Brain foggy and head pounding, I try to feel myself breathing, to focus on the rise and fall of my ribs. My tongue moves over my teeth, trying to swipe moisture around and cure my cottonmouth.

“Wake up, love.”

Groaning, I latch on to the distant voice, trying to follow it.

“There you go, Ana. Wake up for me.”

Flickers of memory spark behind my eyes, confusing me further in my disoriented state. I feel cold but not so scared anymore.

Did Cassio wake up and save us?

Are we somewhere safe now?

The feeling of my body becomes more obvious, and I’m able to wiggle my toes and move my fingers. I feel less like an unconscious zombie and more like a living human being.

My eyelids finally crack open, shocked by bright light overhead.

“So nice of you to join us, love.”

My stomach drops, ears registering the familiar voice.

I look up, seeing the man responsible for speaking come into focus.

It can’t be…

“H-how?” I croak. “I watched you die.”

Bron chuckles. “Did you enjoy the show?”

My heart feels like it’s in my throat as I stare at him. He’s an older version of Killian. Dark hair speckled with grays, stubble on his jaw, and a similar fit build despite his age.

“I asked you a question, love. Don’t forget your manners,” he chastises. “Did you enjoy the show?”

“Did I enjoy watching you die? Watching *Cole* die right after? Are you insane? No! It was horrifying. I hated it.”

“Pity.” Bron frowns. “I put it on just for you.”

No.

He can’t mean…

“You did all of this?” I ask and then swallow hard.

“Of course,” he answers like it’s the most obvious thing in the world. “No one cares for you as much as I do, Ana. I’ve been *trying* to show you that.”

“By killing your son?” I wheeze, finding it hard to breathe. “By texting me those awful things and kidnapping me?”

This is too much.

Before Bron can answer my demands, I get a better look at our surroundings. Spot lights are lighting up the room, hanging above us from high ceilings. The white walls are deteriorated with chipped paint and the remnants of nails and installations.

My mother’s old art study… A building Bron bought for her as a wedding gift. I’ve only been here a handful of times, but the faint smell of paint thinner and the specks of color tattering the wood floor have me convinced that I know exactly where we are.

And we aren’t alone. Tightly bound to a support pole behind Bron, I find a familiar face. Not the one I’m most concerned about, but a friendly face all the same.

“Killian! How did you find him? You better not hurt him again,” I growl, teeth bared. “He hasn’t done anything.”

I’m not tied to the floor like my stepbrother, but I’m not strong enough to spring to my feet either. And even if I was, there’s a shiny, black Glock in Bron’s hands that makes running sound like a terrible idea.

“Oh I caught my dearest son on his way back to you,” Bron explains dully. “I’m a bit disappointed I’ve been able to get the drop on him twice, but he’s still got years to learn.”

My fists clench. “He won’t have any years if you have your goons try to kill him again.”

Bron waves me off. “He’s alive, isn’t he? I have no intention of killing my only heir. The bullet was a lesson, and witnessing this is the review.”

“Witnessing *what*?”

“So eager.” He clicks his tongue. “Don’t you want to catch up, love? I’m sure you’ve got a million questions swimming around in that head of yours.”

“Cassi—”

“*Not* about him,” Bron snaps, interrupting. “We’ll deal with him in a moment. I meant about *me*, Ana. *Me*.”

Swallowing, I attempt to cooperate. “How did you even get into the building? I thought it was supposed to be secure.”

“It *is* secure,” Bron says with a chuckle. “For *our* family. It’s my building, Ana. You think I don’t know about every weakness? About every hidden door?”

“Hidden door?” I gape.

“There’s a hidden elevator in my closet, has been since I bought the place. It came in very handy to keep an eye on you after you found most of my cameras.”

Most of. There’s somehow more?

“Its location also tested my ability to risk rushing my plans. I mean, my bed, Ana? You let him fuck you in my bed? You thought I was dead, and you pissed on my memory like that? I wanted to fucking strangle you for crossing that line, and I’ve never wanted to hurt you physically, love. Ever.”

“Why do you care so much who I touch?” I sniffle, trying not to cry. I need to stay composed. “That’s what this is about, isn’t it? Cole and I had sex, so you had him killed? Now you want to do the same to Cassio?”

Bron’s face hardens. “Stop saying his name! You know what? Let’s get started, I need to see him bleed.”

I watch in horror as the same men from the apartment drag three bodies into the room with us. Armani is still half-unconscious, Colton is fuming mad, and Cassio looks like he’s analyzing every detail around us, formulating a way to get us all free.

“The big one fought like a tiger,” Bron tells me, lips flat and unamused. “Had to shoot him up twice and double knot his binds. He’ll probably barely feel his death, what a shame.”

Waving his weapon in their direction, he sighs. “Maybe killing him first will add to your *husband’s* torment more, though.”

“You can’t kill them,” I protest, getting to my feet with a renewed sense of energy. Bron allows me to stand but acts as a barrier between me and the men. “Please, think about this! You think you can just kill two Morettis and get away with it?”

Bron arches a brow at my pleading tactic. “I think once I get you and Killian on a plane back to London, they won’t risk more Moretti deaths by coming for us.”

“And what about me?” I croak, breathing hard. “You’re going to take away the only real best friend I’ve ever had? You think Jade will still like

me after you kill two of her brothers?”

His jaw ticks. “Perhaps losing a friend will be the punishment that you finally learn from.”

Do not cry, do not cry.

Keep going.

Wear him down.

“What about Dante?” I blurt, rounding Bron to put myself in front of Cassio, Armani, and Colton. “Even you have to admit he’s been nothing but kind to me. You want to reward the man who took me in and kept me safe with no ulterior motive by killing two of his *children*?”

“You’re trying to change my mind.” He gnashes his teeth, eyes dark and untamed. “I don’t appreciate being manipulated, Ana. You think I don’t know that if Cassio remains alive, he’ll come for you?”

“No, he won’t,” I argue.

“Yes I fucking will,” my husband rumbles.

I whip around to look at him, pleading with my eyes to let me handle this. I don’t know what I’m doing, but I’ll say whatever it takes to get him out of here alive.

“I won’t go with him,” I vow, spinning back to face Bron. “Let them live, and I’ll go with you. Cassio won’t kidnap me, and I won’t go willingly if he comes for me. I’ll do whatever you want, just don’t kill him because I broke rules I didn’t know I needed to follow.”

“Ana—” Cassio tries, his sentence dying on his lips as I shoot him a glare that could incinerate a weaker man.

“He has to pay,” Bron maintains, but there’s a shift in his demeanor. He’s considering it, my offer. He doesn’t want to take it, but if I push harder, maybe I have a chance.

“Isn’t losing me payment enough?” I swallow hard. “You know he loves me, you know about his past. Taking another wife from him? Isn’t that a worse fate than death?”

God, please forgive me for this, Cassio.

“I don’t like how hard you’re trying to save his life, love,” Bron purrs, using his gun to lift my chin. “He isn’t right for you, you understand that, don’t you?”

“What does that even mean? If not him, then who?”

Bron’s eyes darken, and he refuses to answer.

An idea bounces around in my mind, and I latch onto it.

“Are *you* in love with me, is that it? You killed Cole because he had me and you couldn’t?”

“Don’t be ridiculous,” he hisses. “You’re too young, too good. You were supposed to be untainted, and he ruined you.”

“Ruined me for who?” I scream. “I don’t understand. If you wanted me for yourself, why did you marry my mother?”

“You were sixteen when I wed Vivian.” His face screws up. “I didn’t look at you like that. I only wanted to keep you safe. You were so delicate and out of control. I kept you safe, ME!”

He crowds me, hands shaking around his gun.

“*I* covered up your little murderous mishaps. *I* told Cole how to help you. I thought he was like me—in *awe* of you—I never expected his fascination to be so twisted.”

In awe of me? Is that what he tells himself? That this *obsession* is innocent admiration?

My throat constricts and I choke up. “So, you won’t have me but no one else can? You want me to live a life without romantic love? Without sex?”

His jaw clenches and a nefarious look flashes in his eye. “I think you’ve had enough of both for quite some time now, Ana. First my delinquent son and now this Italian beast you’ve sullied yourself with.”

“You’re angry with me—”

“Of course I’m angry with you!” Bron shouts, making me flinch. “You let them touch you. You *asked* them for it. You aren’t theirs to touch!”

“You could have had me, if you tried,” I rasp, grasping for anything to keep him calm. “I l-liked you. I knew you took care of me. We could have—”

“No, no, no,” Bron tsks. “Don’t think you can save their lives by sweet talking me, love. I know you won’t forgive me for what I’ve done to Cole. In time, you’ll learn to live with it, though.”

“I could forgive you for Cole,” I offer, anger threatening to destroy my plans. “But my mum, Bron? How could I ever learn to live with that?”

“You think I killed your mother?” he scoffs. “Vivian was no threat to me. She was good for you, even if she was a bit of an obstacle. I’m not a *monster*, Ana.”

You killed your own son! I want to shout.

“How am I supposed to believe you? She died that same day. With pictures—”

“Yes, yes, I know, it was all very dramatic. You have Mr. Tilton to thank for that. He had a tail on you three the night my men took you. Instead of helping, or running away, the man did his job and took pictures.”

Glen Tilton? The arsehole art collector?

“W-what?”

“He sent them all straight over to *Mr. Tilton*, and the fucker thought he struck gold. He wanted to use them to get to Vivian in some way, and of course, he had already followed her to London weeks ago. It was incredible timing for him, so he used the security shift change as a distraction, slipping into the flat undetected.”

Fighting back tears, I sniff. “How do you know all of this?”

“I see everything, love. If I wasn’t so preoccupied faking my own death, I might have been able to stop him. But no, within minutes of breaking in, he realized his mistake. Vivian would never believe you were dead or dying without true proof. Photos could be staged or doctored. And he knew if he left, she would alert security and he would be killed. So he decided to gamble. Stage a suicide, hack the security footage to delete his time there, and then seek you out later on. Hoping to use your grief to take as many paintings off of your hands as he could, I suppose.”

“And you just let him get away with it?”

“Have you seen or heard from him since he tried to visit you at the penthouse?” Bron challenges, lifting a brow. “Yeah, I didn’t think so, love. His body has been rotting at the bottom of the Hudson for weeks.”

“Okay,” I breathe, digesting the information. “Then let them go. Take Killian and me back to London. We’ll act like all of this was a blip, like it never happened. We can move on, and I can follow whatever rules you want. I’ll never look back, I promise.”

Bron looks contemplative, tilting his head at me.

“Just don’t make me live with more deaths on my conscience,” I whisper, reaching forward to lay my hand on his chest. “I can’t bear it.”

“Fine,” Bron acquiesces.

Exhaling a relieved breath, I open my mouth to thank him, only for a scream to replace the words. My ears ring as a shot fires from Bron’s extended arm. I watch in horror as blood blooms from Colton’s stomach, drenching his white T-shirt.

“Fuck,” he groans, hunching over in his binds.

“*No*,” Armani slurs, his heavy eyes on his best friend. He tries to shift to get closer, but he’s too out of it to even move an inch.

“Why would you do that!” I shout, my hands crossing up to clutch my shoulders, folding in on myself in shock.

Rolling his eyes, Bron hums. “They’ll need incentive not to follow us. He won’t die, as long as these two break out of their binds and get him to a hospital in time.”

Bile creeps up my throat, sickness threatening to spill.

“You’re not backing out on me now that I’ve shot your little friend, are you, Ana?” Bron challenges and lifts a brow.

“N-no,” I answer, stuttering.

“I think I need you to prove it, love.” He looks me up and down, making my skin crawl. “How should I have you do that, hmm?”

“Father, don’t,” Killian says, voice weak. He’s been drugged too. He sounds so exhausted, like he could pass out at any moment. That can’t be good for his heart.

Voice hardly audible, I whisper, “Anything.”

“Anything?” he drawls, desire lacing the word.

“Don’t you touch her, you sick fuck,” Cassio growls, but I tune him out. I have to.

“A kiss?” I try, hoping to God that I’m right about his yearning for me.

Like he can’t believe his ears, he nods. “Go on then.”

Lifting up on my toes, using all my might to keep my legs from shaking, I close my eyes and lean forward. Bron swoops down to my height, done pretending to be some kind of virtuous avenging guardian as he seals our lips together.

The kiss burns against my lips, and a deep groan vibrates from Bron’s throat. I knew it. He didn’t want to admit it, probably ashamed of it, but he wants me in the same way his son did. And that want sealed all of our fates.

He deepens the kiss, and I retreat into my mind, trying to stay calm. My heart feels like its breaking in my chest, wondering what Cassio must feel, having to watch this.

Our lips finally part, and my once stepfather tips his head back, eyes shut with bliss. “Bloody perfect,” he mutters. “I knew it would be. I told you, you weren’t meant for them.”

Exhaling, I nod. “You did.”

I’m waiting for him to pounce, hoping he won’t subject me to another kiss. But he doesn’t move, which means now is the time for action.

No more stalling, Ana.

Fingers reaching back, I toy with the ends of my hair, putting on a flirty show for the guards who continue to stand around.

“Bron?” I whisper, purring his name against his chest. My lashes flutter as I sneak a peek at his face.

“Yes, my girl?” he mutters, eyes filled with adoration.

“You shouldn’t have touched my husband,” I inform him, voice shifting into cold indifference. His brows furrow, and before he can truly process his confusion, my hidden hairpin knife is gliding straight through the skin of his throat.

I smile, watching as blood spills from his neck in a liquid line, pouring out of his body faster than I thought possible.

He drops his gun to reach for his wound, but no amount of covering it, or added pressure to the area will save him. The front of his suit is already soaked with the evidence of his impending death.

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Chapter Thirty-Seven



Cassio

Bron falls to his knees, clutching his gaping throat. Ana breathes out, her shoulders dropping in relief. As proud of her as I am for tricking us all and taking that son of a bitch out, it's too early to celebrate.

All of Bron's guards shift, their guns swinging from Colton and me to her, uncertain whether they should shoot. My heart slams against my ribs, not trusting these men for a single moment.

"What the fuck do we do?"

"Stand… down," Killian tries to instruct.

He's the Monarch's heir, but these men aren't Kings. They're thugs that Bron hired externally. He didn't have a single leak amongst his ranks, probably knowing that his son is more favored than he is. Killian has The Kings' respect in a way that could never inspire treachery, at least from what I've seen.

"You ruined everything," one of the men growls, finger twitching over his trigger.

"Ana!" Her name is a warning cry that breaks from my throat seconds before the all too familiar bang of a gunshot sounds.

My heart stalls in my chest. I blink, staring at the man who just yelled at her—now on the floor, blood pooling beneath his head. Confusion and relief crash over me at once, but the gunfire hasn't stopped.

More rounds go off, and the room collapses into chaos.

Descending from the ceiling by thick dark rope, the mysterious gunman fires rapidly, hitting every visible guard with expert precision. Not all of

them are kill shots, some are meant to disarm, instead.

Bron had a team of twelve from what I could tell, some standing guard close by, and others on standby. The five inside of the room have just hit the ground. Doors bang open at the same time the man's boots hit the ground. He doesn't even bother glancing at the noise, and in one swift move, he makes it clear why.

Lifting the black balaclava up and off of his face, Nico shakes out his hair. Apollo, followed by several of our other brothers and Moretti soldiers storm into the room behind him. Nico didn't need to look at the doors slamming open, because he knew who would be coming through them.

My family is here.

Thank. Fucking. God.

"I want that one alive," Nico barks at our men behind him, pointing to the bald man who Ana once described to us. He's bleeding from his hand, from the bullet Nico shot straight through his palm, knocking his weapon out of his grasp.

Looking right at the man in question, Nico's mouth turns up in a cruel grin. "I hear you don't typically have a taste for torture. Don't worry, I'll be happy to show you what a healthy appetite for torment looks like."

Apollo drops to his knees at my side, beginning to cut off the ropes that have my arms bound behind my back. Remo does the same for Armani, quickly breaking him loose. Through his groggy state, Armani immediately moves to push Colton on his back, pressing his freed hands over the wounded man's stomach.

"My shoulder's out," I tell Apollo, gritting my teeth. "Push it back in."

"How'd he dislocate your shoulder?"

"He didn't. I did, trying to get to her."

I thrashed so fucking hard to try and get out, to get to my wife, and I pulled my left shoulder straight out of its damn socket. I wouldn't have stopped until it came off entirely if I thought Bron was going to hurt her. As soon as he made it clear he was going to let her live, I started to accept my fate.

I could die for her, if it meant she'd still live.

I didn't want Armani to die by my side, and I certainly didn't want Ana to be trapped with that fucking psycho pervert. Falling into unrequited love with your stepdaughter is vile, whether she was eighteen when he started to look at her or not.

But anything was better than picturing my Ana lying lifeless on the ground. She needed to live—and I would have done anything to ensure she did. By some miracle, I didn't need to do a thing. She saved herself. And our family arrived just in time to make sure no one got the chance to retaliate.

"All right, brace for it," Apollo advises, putting his hands on either side of my shoulder.

Breathing in, I make a fist and shut my eyes.

The sound of snapping hits me before the pain does.

"Fuck," I yell through my teeth.

"You'll need a sling, but you're good for now." Apollo pats my back and stands up, holding out his hand for my good one to take.

"How did you find us?" I ask, grasping his outstretched hand and letting him pull me to my feet.

The only reason I don't immediately rush to Ana's side is that I see my father helping her, holding her hair back and patting between her shoulder blades as she throws up. Kissing Bron sickened her, that much is evident by the way she heaves and gags.

"Your wife chipped you," Apollo replies, huffing like he can't believe it.

Confused, my brows dip down. "What?"

"In your watch," Apollo explains, nodding to my wrist. "Apparently, she convinced Remo to keep her secret because she wasn't using them to track you daily. She gave him the security logins in case either of you went missing. But if you ask me, she's probably got more hiding on you somewhere. If you feel a prick in your arm in the middle of the night, it's probably because she's injecting one inside of you."

Perhaps I should let her; her planning just saved our asses.

"Fucking move," a deep voice growls. I look down to see Remo pull Armani off of Colton, but he's not the one who spoke.

Shoving a medic to the ground, Nico drops a bag of supplies, ripping open a package of wound-packing gauze with his teeth.

"If he fucking dies, so do you," Nico barks, kneeling down by Colton's side to look for more injuries while the medic begins to work. "So fucking stupid, getting yourself shot. What were you thinking, huh?"

The bleeding cowboy tries to laugh, a crimson grin painting his face. "Knew you cared about me, maniac."

I hope the blood is coming from Armani accidentally smearing it and not from inside his mouth. Because either he bit his tongue when he was shot… or he's bleeding into his fucking lungs.

"Shut the hell up before you bleed out," Nico snaps back.

Colton doesn't care that Nico appears pissed with him, he uses what little strength he has to grab the front of his shirt and tugs him down. Their lips meet in a harsh crash, more like a punch than a kiss, but Colton sighs like it's the greatest thing he's ever felt, and Nico freezes for a moment before shoving back.

"Goddammit, why would you fucking do that!"

"Just in case," Colton whispers, a new kind of relief in his voice. Like dying doesn't feel so horrible now that he's kissed my brother.

Nico looks like he wants to hurt him for pulling that stunt—he looks like he's malfunctioning like a robot with a glitch. The two men aren't together. Nico has never been *together* with anyone, but it seems that Colton doesn't care.

"Don't do it again," Nico demands in a cold tone.

"Uh-uh. Gonna kiss you so much more if I don't die," Colton slurs with an attempted smirk.

"You're not going to fucking die," Nico snaps.

"Hopefully," Colton agrees. He's starting to doze off and I'm growing more concerned. My brother is too.

"If you die, I'll kill Dustin," Nico threatens. "You hear me? You stay awake or your little brother is joining you in the afterlife, asshole."

"*God*," Colton swoons. "You like me soooo much."

"We need to move him," the medic reports. He's packed the wound, but they'll need blood to give Colton and to repair any internal damage before sewing him up properly.

"Let's go."

Apollo joins in on the effort, helping to lift Colton onto a board and get him the hell out of here. Remo is helping Armani to his feet, allowing him to lean on him and limp toward the exit. They can go ahead, but I need to see my girl before I go anywhere.

Ana is done hacking up her stomach contents by the time I stumble over to her. She's wiping her mouth with one of Dad's handkerchiefs while he checks her over, making sure she isn't hurt.

“Cassio,” she breathes out, tears swimming in her eyes. “I’m so sorry. For what I said, and what I did, I was just trying to—”

“Shut up,” I mutter tiredly, pulling her into my chest by the back of her neck. “Don’t ever apologize for what you just did, Ana. You saved us.”

My shoulder screams at the pressure of having her against it, but I don’t give a fuck. Nose dropping into her hair, I inhale deep, breathing in her familiar scent. I could hold her like this for hours—days, even—fucked shoulder and all.

“Colton,” she cries, shoulders shaking. “Is he going to be okay?”

“He will be,” I say, though I’m not one hundred percent sure.

“Let’s get you both to the hospital,” Dad suggests, softly patting Ana’s arm. “I want to torch this building.”

“Is it over?” Ana sniffs.

“It’s over,” Dad assures her. “All the guards are taken care of. The ones Nico wanted alive will be relocated to a more secure warehouse, and the others will go up in flames with this wretched place.”

“Good,” she husks.

Putting my good arm around her, I follow as Dad guides us out of the building and into the cool city air. Dusk is quickly fading as morning chases the shadow of darkness from the sky.

We climb into an SUV together, refusing to be separated again so soon. Dad takes the driver’s seat and begins the journey to whatever hospital Nico, Apollo, and Armani are headed toward to help Colton.

“I hear you put trackers on me,” I whisper, my hand stroking her shoulder as I tuck my wife in closer.

Ana flushes, looking sheepish. “Just in your watch. And some of your tie clips… and some of your shoes.”

I laugh incredulously, unable to help it. “My *shoes*?”

“Yeah, don’t tell Armani but I kind of sort of cut the soles off, stuffed a tracker chip in and glued them back together.”

“I think if I told him that you cut into custom Italian leather shoes worth more than a mortgage payment, he’d have an aneurysm.”

“Precisely,” she agrees, giving me a conspiratorial grin. “So, it’ll just have to be our little secret.”

“Why do I find it incredibly hot that you chipped my personal belongings without my consent, Wife?”

Ana blushes harder. “Well, if you think that’s hot, I guess I can tell you about the one I stashed in your car.”

I laugh so hard that my shoulder pangs, giving a painful throb.

“I love you so fucking much.”

“Good,” she declares. “Because I love you more.”

I don’t think that’s possible, but I don’t argue.

“You’re never getting away from me, Cassio Moretti.”

“I’d never dream of it, Ana Moretti.”

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Chapter Thirty-Eight



Ana

"I'm sorry."

Killian's head snaps up at the sound of my small voice. His eyes are bloodshot and tired, but they widen as he registers what I've just said.

Bewildered, he blinks. "What do you possibly have to be sorry for, Ana?"

"I murdered your father, Killian. Right in front of you. I had to do it, I know you know that, but I'm still sorry you had to see it."

"I'm sorry I didn't get to do it myself," he shoots back firmly. "I can't believe I didn't notice his fixation on you. You look so much like your mother, but I thought he was properly besotted by Vivian. He hid it well, too well."

I try not to smile at the comparison to my mum. Everyone has always said we look just alike, which made my adoption a bit of an inside joke between the two of us. It was pure coincidence that we're both a mix of European and Chinese heritage. We have no biological connection to be found, and yet she looked like my mother in every sense of the word.

"You couldn't have known," I tell Killian kindly. "I didn't even know, and it was me he was obsessed with. I don't understand it either."

Eyeing the tube coming out of his arm, I try not to frown. "Are you starting to feel better?"

Killian and Armani are both hooked up to IV bags, trying to hydrate and flush the remaining sedatives out of their systems. Armani's lip is pretty

purple from trying to fight the guards, and his ribs are black and blue, but he's mostly just exhausted.

Killian is in fine shape, thankfully. Cassio made sure to force him to get his heart looked at, just in case. I guess Bron wanted him docile, but was careful not to overdo it. He really did want to dispose of my husband and friends, and then whisk the two of us away to London. How could he ever think that would be okay? That we would just accept it?

Killian didn't need to say it, but I knew he would have found a way to kill his father for what he did to Cole—for what he did to *all* of us. Killian nearly died himself, and Bron's actions broke me in ways that might have ended my own life if I didn't have Cassio to keep me afloat.

And my mother… he may not have lifted a finger to kill her, but his antics led to her murder all the same.

"I'm getting there," he replies, forcing a smile. "I had Cole cremated a little while ago. I didn't know how to tell you, or if you wanted to hear about it. But since this mess has finally been resolved, I thought you should know I took care of it. He didn't want to be buried to become *worm food*, he wanted his ashes to be thrown into the ocean. Ashes to ashes to earth, or whatever."

Smiling sadly, I nod. "I knew you would know what to do."

"Gerard called," Cassio says, joining us. "Sirius is fine, he's taking him to the vet for you just to be safe, but he's walking around fine."

"Thank goodness," I breathe out, relieved.

I would be so gutted if I lost him. I was hesitant about having a pet, and I really didn't like knowing that Sirius would probably jump in front of a bullet for me. But I've really come to love having him around. He's my little cuddle bug.

"Colton is probably going to be in surgery for a while," Cassio continues. "We can go home, if you want to clean up and take a moment to yourself."

A shower sounds great, especially after having to touch Bron, but there's no way I'm leaving here until I know my friend is okay.

My face screws up at the suggestion, and he laughs softly. "I thought not. Agnes will bring some clothes to change into and grab our phones. She heard about you being taken and has been at the apartment ever since."

At the mention of changing, I flush, looking down at my silky pajama set. Being kidnapped in the middle of the night was not ideal. I'd started to

sleep with my hair tie knife, but not with a bra, go figure.

"Good idea," I tell him, biting my lip. "Some shoes would be nice, too."

The hospital socks Cassio found for me are better than being barefoot, but they still feel weird to walk in.

"I couldn't agree more," he says, nodding to his matching bright blue grippy socks. "These aren't exactly to my taste."

Hiding a smile, I lift a shoulder. "I think they look very dashing."

"I am not going to get used to that any time soon," Killian sighs, looking between the two of us. "Do you two always flirt with each other?"

"Yes," Armani answers from his nearby seat. "Yes, they do. Wait until you walk in on them mauling each other in the kitchen."

"Mate," Killian groans, rubbing a hand down his face.

Cassio just smirks. "She's my wife, I won't apologize."

"We were just kissing," I grumble, folding my arms. Noticing Armani's tired eyes, sympathy grows stronger in my chest. "Come here, you. You need to lie down."

Armani shakes his head. "I won't put my face anywhere near a hospital seat, disinfected or not."

Rolling my eyes, I sit on the end of the long padded bench-like chair, motioning over my lap. "Rest here, and I'll play with your hair."

His eyes light up like I've just offered him a big fat check. Within seconds, he's maneuvering his big body, head landing on my thigh. He barely fits on his side with his knees tucked up, but he heaves out an exhausted sigh that lets me know it's not as uncomfortable as it may look.

My fingers sink into his long brown hair. It's somehow disheveled and still silky smooth. When I look up, I find Cassio watching us with a soft smile, not a trace of jealousy in sight. He knows he has nothing to worry about—especially when it comes to his own brother.

Though, this is the closest Armani and I have ever been. Most of our friendship is far less physical than the one he shares with Colton, or the one Jade shares with Ivan. Armani and I have hugged a handful of times, and given each other playful nudges here and there. But for the most part, our friendship is a mental connection. We make each other laugh, and we spend time together. It's effortless.

And right now, he doesn't know if his best friend in the whole world is going to make it out of surgery—after getting shot protecting me. The least I can do is offer him the small comfort of running my fingers through his

hair while he rests his head in my lap. I've seen Colton do the same thing to calm him on more than one stressful day.

It feels almost motherly, but I suppose sisterly would be the more accurate term. The Morettis really do feel like family, and I feel protective of them, even the ones I don't know very well. I mean, most of them dropped everything in the middle of the night to come find us.

Leon and Emilio are with their families, and Matteo stayed behind to be with Jade, Dmitri, Ivan and the twins. But Dante, Apollo, Elio, Remo, and Nico all came running, backed by a whole crew of Moretti soldiers. Corresponding with Remo about Cassio's trackers was the smartest thing I've ever done. He's usually up late at night coding for fun as it is, and as soon as he got wind that the penthouse had been broken into, he acted.

He may be the quietest Moretti, but he's one of them all the same.

A couple hours later, the drop in adrenaline and lack of a full night's sleep is starting to get to me. Agnes has come and gone, so my feet are cozy in my slippers, and my leggings and jumper are a much welcomed upgrade from the previous skimpy pajama situation. She also came bearing phones and pastries, which livened some spirits around the waiting room.

We're on a different floor of the same facility Killian was in, separate from the general public but not as hidden as before. Doc is helping with Colton's case from what I know, but like Killian, he needs professional surgeons too. It's a bit of a confusing collaborative effort, but Dante is handling everything, so I'm confident what needs to be done is being done.

I'm considering asking Armani for a turn lying on him, or just using Cassio's shoulder to rest my head, when yelling jolts me wide awake.

"What do you mean he's still in surgery? It's been hours!"

All around me, Moretti men sit up straighter.

"I want to see him, *right now.*"

"Sir, you can't see him while he's being operated on—"

"He's my fucking son—"

Oh God, Colton's family.

"Dustin," Armani calls out, trying to wave him over. "Over here."

I look down the hall, finding Winona, Dustin, and a man that must be Levi Wyatt. Winona looks distressed, and worried, but her husband looks like he's going to blow his top at some poor nurse.

Dustin winces as his father snaps his gaze toward our group, rubbing the back of his neck like he's severely uncomfortable. I'm sure he's just as

worried for his brother as his parents are for their son. But he also knows that confronting hospital staff isn't going to help Colton.

"How are you all just sitting around here?" Levi demands, throwing his arms out. "Why isn't he fixed yet? Why aren't you *doing* anything!"

"You need to calm down," Apollo barks.

"Calm down?" Levi Wyatt rages. "My son is half fucking dead, and you think I need to calm down?"

"Levi—" Winona tries, but it's like he doesn't hear her at all.

Spinning from Apollo to Armani, he points an accusatory finger at him and shouts, "This is your fucking fault. If you didn't keep dragging him into trouble, this never would have happened!"

Winona gasps. "Now, you know that's not fair—"

"Dad," Dustin attempts, but it's no use.

"I told him getting involved with your family was a death sentence, and look at where we are now—"

"Colton made his choice," Armani states firmly, interrupting the man's tirade. Despite having a busted lip and bruised ribs, he doesn't let Levi intimidate him. "He wanted to protect his friend—an innocent woman. He did something *honorable*, something you should be proud of."

The argument isn't coming to a solution anytime soon, and my stomach churns at the fury in Levi's eyes.

"Like you know so much about what he wants—"

"He'd want you to get out of his best friend's face," Nico snaps, cutting into the older cowboy's rant. He hasn't spoken much since arriving here, but apparently he's decided now is the time to step in. "He'd be *embarrassed* by your little display."

"What the fuck would you know about him?" Levi shouts furiously. "You want nothing to do with him for years, and suddenly you have something to say?"

"This isn't helping," I finally burst out, standing from my seat and looking at Winona with a pleading glance. "I'm so sorry that Colton got hurt trying to save me, but it happened and yelling isn't going to make him heal."

The man stares at me, eyes hot with rage.

"Colton loves this family, and being angry with us for something none of us could control won't help him heal. It'll only make him upset when he wakes up."

My rationale only seems to piss him off more. “Who the fuck do you think you are? You’ve known my son for a couple of months and you think you can speak for him?”

Levi takes a step in my direction, and I brace for my husband to jump in, knowing he won’t stand for even the barest hint of a threat.

But it isn’t Cassio who stops the man in his tracks. The body in front of me is wider and more seasoned. It’s the figure of someone who could strike fear in the heart of Lucifer himself. Dante Moretti steps between me and Colton’s dad, a lethal silence echoing around him.

“Speak to my daughter again, and your son won’t be the only one on the operating table,” he threatens, voice raspy and cold. “I’ve let you yell at my kin because I know what it is to be a father whose child is in danger, but my girls are off-limits. Zero fucking exceptions. Do you understand?”

When Levi doesn’t immediately respond, Dante takes a threatening step forward and asks again.

“Do. You. Understand?”

“He understands,” Winona answers, gritting the words, but not at Dante, at her husband.

“See that he does,” Dad commands, continuing to stand in front of me until she pulls Levi away.

“Sorry about him,” Dustin mutters, looking embarrassed.

“S’fine,” Armani says, clapping him on the back. “Colton will be fine and he’ll cool down.”

From his mouth to God’s ears.

Not even five minutes later, Doc finds us with good news.

Colton lost a bunch of blood, and his stomach needed to be repaired carefully, but he’s out of surgery and his vitals are good. He’ll need to stay at the hospital for a few days at least, maybe a week.

He’s okay.

Colton isn’t dying.

No one else is dying.

Breathing better than I have in hours, I throw myself into Cassio’s arms, hugging him tight. We decide to let Armani and Colton’s family see him today, and we’ll come back once he’s more awake and aware.

“You can stay with us,” Cassio tells his family as we all get ready to leave. “If you’d rather rest before heading back home.”

“We’re good,” Dad answers, smiling. “We’ll be seeing you both soon, anyway. Won’t we?”

Apollo arches a brow. “You planning to move back now?”

“Yes,” I answer before Cassio can. “If you’ll have us.”

I miss Jade, and I want to be with the rest of the Morettis, even if I’ll miss some parts of the city.

Dante nods happily. “You’re always welcome home, Ana.”

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Chapter Thirty-Nine



Ana

Packing up most of my life was easier than I expected it to be. Since I'll be sharing a room with my husband now, I don't need my bed or any of my big furniture. Most of my boxes are stuffed with clothes, shoes, cosmetics, and bits of memorabilia from my mum that I didn't want to part with.

Her personal collection of paintings have been mostly auctioned off. She wouldn't want me to have them around collecting dust when I don't have the eye to appreciate them like a true art lover would. I kept a few of my favorites, even setting two aside for Dante and Jade. An Italian countryside, Renaissance-style piece for the man I call Dad, and a floral painting that I found covered with sage for Jade. Sage is the name Dad gave to her twin she never got to know, and I think she'll really love the sentiment.

Though I've spent most of my life in between New York and London, I don't think I'm going to miss it much. Plus, Cassio has already promised me that we'll return to the city at least twice a month to visit Killian, and Agnes, and to volunteer at St. Mary's. So I'll never be deprived of the parts of the city that I love now that we're leaving it.

He also put me in contact with a woman who runs a local orphanage twenty minutes from the Moretti mansion. They have a smaller staff, but a good facility and will take any help I'm willing to offer. I've already started planning a fundraiser for them, focused on earning enough money to give the children an incredible Christmas this year.

As the car comes to a stop, I squeeze Cassio's hand and unbuckle my seatbelt. Jumping out of my seat, I tip my head back to look at the clear blue sky. The air already feels cleaner as I inhale, breathing in the familiar scenery.

"You're here!"

A soft, slim body slams into mine, pushing me back against the car with the force of it. My face is buried in Jade's hair in a whoosh as she clings to me.

"Don't break my wife," Cassio gripes, standing with our eldest brother.

Apollo came to New York to help us move, apparently wanting to go over some business discussions with Killian too. The Kings and The Outfit now have an official alliance. I'm not sure what it consists of, but I'm content to know that the two sides of my family—though Killian is the only Knight left standing—are on friendly terms for good.

Jade ignores Cassio entirely, pulling back to look at my face with gleaming blue eyes. "I'm so excited! I've been waiting for you all day. I'm pretty sure I've been stressing Dmitri and Ivan out with all of my pacing and window watching."

"Did you have sweets for breakfast?" I chuckle. "You've got energy pouring out of you, babe."

"Martha made raspberry strudel, I may have over indulged," she confesses, grinning. "Come in, come in, I can't wait for you to see your room. It's huge!"

From what Jade has told me over the phone, Cassio and I are going to be on the same floor as Nico, but not in his old room. We'll have a suite like Jade's, all to ourselves. A fresh start for both of us, and somewhere to call our own.

"I'm here as well," Cassio points out before she can drag me off. "You know, me, your loving brother?"

"Unload the boxes, loving brother," she shoots back. "You have manual labor to attend to. I'll keep Ana company, don't worry."

Cassio turns to Apollo. "Has she gotten sassier, or is that just for me?"

"She's been living with Matteo for nearly two years now, what do you think?" he deadpans. "Speaking of Matteo, tell him to get his ass out here to help with these boxes."

"Will do," Jade chirps, wrapping her fingers around my wrist and pulling me toward the large house. Once we step over the threshold, she

cups her hands around her mouth. “Matteo, Apollo demands you help unload the truck!”

“Yeah?” Matteo calls back. “Well, I demand he fucks off.”

“They need the biggest, strongest Moretti to assist them.”

Finding us, Matteo crosses his arms, giving Jade a doubtful stare. “Don’t try that flattery shit on me, little sister.”

“Oh, go help,” Jade chides, smothering a laugh.

“Hello, Matteo,” I greet, smiling. “There aren’t that many boxes, if it helps.”

Sighing dramatically, the youngest Moretti boy relents. “Fine, I’ll help. But I’m only helping since it’s for Ana, not because Apollo summoned me.”

“Such a good brother,” Jade coos approvingly, patting his cheek as she maneuvers around him. “Come on, I have to show you the cutest thing.”

Strolling into the family sitting room, we find Dmitri holding their daughter and Ivan on the ground with Cesar, watching the boy intently as he does his tummy time.

“Isobella,” my best friend says gently, approaching her husband’s side. “Who am I?”

Giving her mother a gummy grin, the baby girl’s brows knit, like she’s thinking of the answer to Jade’s question.

“Ma… Ma,” she babbles, spitting out the word.

“*Mama*!” Cesar screeches, prompted by his sister.

My heart swells and I jump in excitement. “Oh my gosh! When did they start that?”

“Just a couple weeks ago,” Jade tells me, eyes sparkling. “They say Dada too, it melts my heart.”

Like he wants to prove his mother’s claim, Cesar shouts, “*Dada*!”

“Oh my goodness.” My hands cover my heart, and I resist the urge to scoop him up and hug him for the accomplishment.

I know from working with countless babies at St. Mary’s that all children develop at their own pace, but six to nine months for basic words is quite common. The twins are seven-months-old now, their birthday coming up in August, so they are marvelously on track.

“They’re growing so much,” Jade marvels, caressing Isobella’s little face. “I feel like they were in my stomach yesterday.”

“Did you show her the room yet, Krasotka?” Dmitri asks, kissing the top of her head.

“I’m about to take her up,” Jade replies, blushing.

“Ana, I’m kidnapping your dog,” Matteo declares, sauntering into the room with Sirius in tow.

“Good luck with that,” Armani drawls, walking in behind him, boxes in hand. “He’s loyal to her, no matter how many runs you take him on or how many treats you sneak him.”

Matteo shrugs, petting Sirius’ head. “We’ll see about that, won’t we, boy?”

“Take him outside,” Cassio instructs as he passes by.

“I’m going, I’m going.”

“Dad made sure that part of the yard was fenced in for him to get some fresh air and space to himself,” Jade tells me. “Dmitri and I brought the twins to see Emilio and Melani recently. We wanted to make sure they weren’t allergic to dogs, and they have two Doberman guard dogs just like yours. We’re all clear on that front.”

My brows rise up. “You’ve thought of everything.”

“What are sisters for?” She grins. “God, I’ve been waiting to call you that for ages. It feels amazing, doesn’t it? You try it.”

“You’re the best sister a girl could ask for, Jade,” I tell her seriously.

“Stop, I’m going to cry,” she croaks. Shaking off the emotion, she threads our hands together. “Room tour, first. We can cry another time.”

I quickly agree and allow her to sweep me away.

The room she brings me to is, in fact, huge. It’s mostly bare bones, aside from a large king bed, frame, vanity, and dressers, all matching in design. The floors are dark hardwood, and the walls are a warm gray.

The walk-in closet and the bathroom are both oversized too. I’m definitely thinking of all the lovely things Cassio can do to me in the deep soaker tub, and the rain shower looks immaculate as well.

Several Moretti brothers come in and out, dropping off boxes as their sister chatters on, showing me the place.

“You can paint or change anything you want,” Jade finishes, flopping down onto the unmade bed.

“I can’t believe we get to live together,” I say excitedly, dropping down by her side. “And this house… It’s a bit magical, isn’t it?”

“Definitely. I adore it here,” she agrees, biting her bottom lip. “Though, Dmitri and I are talking about building our own place. It would be on the same property, of course. Just a short walk in the back.”

Surprised, my brows lift. “Really?”

Nodding shyly, she explains, “We’re going to want more kids, and even though this place is huge, it might start to feel crowded in a year or so.”

“Wedding planning and house construction,” I comment, grinning wide. “Look at you, Ms. Domestic.”

Jade shrugs, grinning. “Guilty as charged.”

A throat clears and we look down the bed, finding way more boxes than before. Cassio and Apollo are watching us, a fond smile on my husband’s face.

“Having fun?” he asks.

“Loads,” I answer, smiling playfully.

“That’s the last one,” Apollo reports, setting it down and nodding. “I’ll see you all at dinner.”

“Thank you for the help.” I’m barely able to get the polite words out before he leaves. Turning to Jade with a huff, I ask, “Is he always so…”

“Prickly and aloof?” she guesses. “Yeah, that’s our Apollo. You’ll come to love it, and learn how to force bonding time with him. He’s not mean, just a little impersonal and distant sometimes.”

Understandable. I’m not exactly warm and fuzzy all the time either.

“I need a shower,” Cassio says suddenly, dipping his head down to kiss the side of my neck. “Join me?”

“Fat chance!” Jade exclaims, scoffing. “She’s mine now, bucko. You’ve had her for months.”

I giggle, looking up at him. “I think she just told you to piss off, Husband.”

“How utterly impolite,” he sulks.

“You’ll get over it,” Jade says matter-of-factly, crossing her arms. “Be gone, dear brother of mine. We have catching up to do.”

“Gossip to share, you mean?”

She rolls her eyes. “That’s what I said, isn’t it?”

Leaving Cassio to shower in our new ensuite, Jade and I head back downstairs and start chatting about anything and everything.

I fill her in on all that went down with Bron. She tells me Cesar and Isobella are eating some soft foods now, but they both *hate* pea purée. We talk about the orphanage, and getting Leo to Leon and Cleo. She asks about Sirius and how things are with Cassio.

She also tells me that she started texting Anya, Dmitri's little sister. Nothing overly friendly, as the teen seems shy. But she sends her pictures of Cesar and Isobel, and has started to talk about wedding planning with her. She really wants Anya to come, and she's hopeful that she will.

Since Dmitri and Jade are planning to host on Empire Academy's campus, and Anya's family will all be there, it should feel safe and inviting enough for her. I completely agree and hope she'll come. She's a part of Jade's family, and I know it would mean so much to Dmitri and Ivan. They hardly get to see her anymore.

My jaw hurts by the time our chattering begins to slow. It's almost overwhelming how nice it has been to just sit back and have a conversation with her. We get on so well, and I feel like we could prattle on for hours.

Cassio finds us having a snack sometime later, greeting me with a kiss to the temple before his lips brush the shell of my ear.

"You know, this is the second time I've dried off from a shower and found your hair literally wrapped around my balls, Wife."

A girlish laugh bubbles from my chest. "Oh?"

"You think that's funny, do you?" He chuckles, eyes sparkling at the joy on my face. "I suppose I should get used to it. I don't think there's a washer in the world that can keep up with how much you shed from that pretty little head of yours."

Giving him a coy grin, I shrug. "It's just another reminder of who you belong to."

"Ugh, you guys are so cute!" Jade squeals.

My face heats, and I don't think I stop blushing for the next several hours. Not while unpacking, or while every member of the family comes to check in on us. It's a wonderful feeling to be flooded with so much hospitality. They truly see me as a member of the family.

All thanks to Cassio.

At dinner, the table is piled with delicious food, and surrounded by friendly faces. Cassio's hand is wrapped around the back of my neck while we eat, his thumb lazily dragging up and down the side of my throat. I'm tempted to ask him to stop, because as amazing as it feels, the affectionate petting is starting to stir something up inside of me. And we aren't alone.

Being alone in a house this full already feels impossible, but I find that I love it. Whether it's babies screaming, brothers squabbling, dishes banging, or cozy conversation, the Moretti home is *lively*.

Yes, I can tell that there will be moments where I could scream for some alone time with my husband, but mostly I know this experience is going to be incredible. And besides, I know I can count on Cassio to sweep me away from the chaos to lay me down for a nap… or lay me on my back.

I don't think it's possible to be any happier than I am right now.

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Chapter Forty



Cassio
Six Months Later

"I knew I should have gone to the bachelorette party instead," Matteo sulks, tossing his cards into the center of the table with a huff. "I'm going to tell Jade that her husband keeps stealing my money."

Dmitri simply smirks, collecting his chips. He doesn't reveal his hand, having forced Matteo into folding. He wants him to wonder whether or not he bluffed. Dmitri plays poker like he was born doing it, and it irks Matteo.

I, on the other hand, find it quite amusing.

"Were you hoping that she'd pity you enough to let you tag along?" Apollo inquires, snark dripping from his tone. "It's ladies only, Brother. She told you this."

"Twenty times," Elio tacks on, twirling his glass of scotch.

"Ivan and Anatoly are there, it's hardly ladies only," Matteo grumbles in response. "So not fair."

"They're guarding the girls," Dad reminds him. "I'm sure they're not having a ton of fun either, Son."

"I'm having a great time," Apollo says with a mischievous grin. Getting under our little brother's skin is one of his favorite pastimes.

"Bachelor parties are supposed to be comprised of half-naked strippers, irresponsible drug consumption, and loud music," Matteo says, ignoring him. "Not card-playing, cigar smoking, and whiskey sipping at home."

"The idea of half-naked women who are not my wife coming within a mile of me is revolting," Dmitri grimaces.

“Good,” Nico declares, beginning to deal out the next hand of cards.

“I’m too old for strippers,” Dad adds on. “The last woman who tried to get my attention for money called me *Daddy,* and I thought I was going to be sick. I told her that my daughter calls me that, and she scurried off, thankfully.”

Matteo bursts into a fit of laughter at the admission and most of us chuckle alongside him. The party has been surprisingly nice, and despite Matteo’s whining, I think even he’s been having fun.

All Dmitri wanted to do was have a guys’ night, and everyone was more than happy to comply. Since the wedding is only a couple days away, all of us were in town and available.

Cleo, Melani, Jade, and Ana are out dancing and have been for a few hours now. Ivan, Anatoly and a team of guards are with them, keeping a very close eye on the group. I’m not worried for their safety, though. They’re in a Moretti-owned club, in *our* territory. As much as I’d prefer to be with Ana, it’s nice having all of my brothers in one room again. It doesn’t happen often.

It’s interesting having the original nine of us with the addition of new blood. Apollo, Leon, Elio, Emilio, Armani, Nico, Remo, Matteo, Colton, Dmitri, Dad, and me. We’re all family, even if it’s in different ways for some of us. Dmitri by marriage and Colton, unofficially, but close enough to count. He isn’t just Armani’s best friend now, he’s Ana’s chosen brother. Her, Armani, and Colton are as close as Jade, Matteo, and Ivan. Their friendship isn’t as cuddly, of course, but just as meaningful if you ask me.

Naturally, I’ve always cared for Armani as my younger brother. But watching him with my wife, seeing him pull her further into the family, it’s strengthened that bond tenfold.

I used to consider Leon my closest ally in the family, followed by Apollo. I think it’s Armani now, and I’m glad for it. He brings a new kind of life into my days. I can’t put into words how much it means to me every time he gets my wife to smile when she’s stuck in her darkness.

Like he knows I’m thinking about him, Armani decides to join the conversation. “I don’t mind the daddy thing,” he proclaims, waggling his brows. “There are way worse things to be called in bed.”

“Agreed,” Elio quips. There’s a look in his eye that has me thinking he’s more serious than Armani. He’s always been private about his romantic life, but I could see him being interested in deviant things.

“I do not want to know,” Dad tells them with a huffed laugh.

“You’re no fun,” Armani accuses. “You used to be so much more vulgar. Being a girl dad changed you.”

Dad clicks his tongue and grins. “Thank god for that.”

“I don’t know,” Colton muses. “I miss watching Dante Moretti make pretty little society women faint. It was absolutely *legendary*.”

“That only happened twice,” Dad defends, brushing off the praise.

Dmitri chuckles, out of the loop. “There’s a story there.”

Dad shakes his head. “It’s hardly a story.”

Apollo doesn’t let him get away with it so easily. “A simple case of overzealous mafia princesses trying to be the next Moretti mommy.”

There’s a rousing laughter around the table and Elio picks up where Apollo left off. “One of whom thought promising him more heirs would seduce him. Dad just looked her up and down and told her that he’d break her *tiny little body,* and she shouldn’t make promises she couldn’t possibly keep.”

Dad wrinkles his nose at the memory. “She was *twenty*.”

“And the other one?” Dmitri asks, an amused smile on his face.

Leon takes the pleasure of explaining that one. “One of Cleo’s older cousins. She was laying it on thick and Dad told her that he wasn’t looking for a wife, but she could try her luck with his brother. Uncle Cesar tortured her last husband. Suffice it to say, she was properly spooked and took a nap in the middle of the party.”

Again, the table shares a laugh, even Dad can’t hide his chuckle. The mention of our deceased uncle doesn’t go unnoticed though, and the air shifts. Nico shares a look with our sister’s husband and he nods sympathetically.

“To Cesar, then,” Dmitri says, raising his glass.

“To Cesar,” each of us echoes, joining him in the gesture.

We lapse into one comfortable hand of poker after another, conversations popping up and shifting every so often. I didn’t expect to feel so content going into this night. I expected to feel a constant nagging urge to flee and find Ana. Since losing Isobel, my relationship with my brothers has been strained at best. I didn’t want to be around anyone, and none of them knew how to help me.

Being with Ana has been like a breath of fresh air after years of barely sustaining oxygen. I feel most whole when she’s by my side. She fuels me.

And I do miss her, but I expected to dread missing her more. As fucked up as it is, I think I forgot how much I loved my family. Loving Ana didn't just wake up my cold broken heart, it reminded me who I am, and how lucky I am to have our family.

I missed my brothers and our father. I missed feeling alive in their presence. They couldn't heal me, they didn't have what I needed. But they didn't leave me either. No matter how hard I shoved them away, they've always been waiting. Morettis are forever, and with Ana as my wife, I don't think I'll ever take that for granted again.

Matteo has finally won some of his money back when the door creaks open. My heart immediately soars, the beat hammering hard as my wife comes into view. Her silky black hair is tumbling around her tight blue dress, properly mussed from her night out. With pink flushed cheeks and a stunning smile, she waltzes into the room, making her way to my side.

"Hello, everyone," she greets happily. "Sorry to interrupt."

"You're fine, darling," Dad says, immediately making sure she's welcome. He's done everything in his power to make her feel like a part of the family, and I can't express how much that means to both of us.

"Don't worry, I won't be long," she tells the table before sliding into my lap. Crossing one long leg over the other, her warm body molds against mine—a perfect fit. "Hello, Husband."

Ana is practically purring in my lap and I arch a brow at her tone. "Hello, Wife. What are you up to?"

"Oh, nothing too serious," she assures me but there's a sultry glimmer in her lovely caramel eyes. "I was just going up to our room and wanted to let you know that we're home when I had a thought."

The table has gone quiet, no one bothering to pretend not to be listening in on us. Nosy bastards.

"Did you?"

"Mhmm," Ana hums. "Remember how you were a little concerned about my dress being so… tight?" Teasingly dragging her fingers down my chest, she makes my skin pebble under my shirt.

Where is she going with this?

"I recall," I reply gruffly. The fabric is like second-skin, it would be hard to forget.

"Well… I thought about it, and you were right."

Nothing good can come from your wife telling you that you were right. It's a trap, it's always a trap. Men are never right.

"Oh?" I ask, eyeing her suspiciously.

"Yes, I hadn't even thought about how snug it truly was until coming home," she explains with a seductive smirk. "I thought, how embarrassing it would be if I came in to say hello to you all, and my poor brothers had to bear witness to something as scandalous as panty-lines."

Oh, shit.

Oh, fuck me.

I watch in utter fascination as she pulls a hidden item from behind her back. Twirling familiar white lace around her manicured fingers, she pushes the fabric into my chest like a gift and grins. "So, here you are, my love. No lines to worry about."

My hand shoots up, wrapping around the lacy scrap of material, attempting to conceal it from the table of men. They've all already seen it, of course. I'm torn between being pissed that other people are witnessing this moment and thrilled that Ana feels safe enough around us to pull off such a stunt. My vexing little wife is going to be the death of me.

I barely hold back a groan as she smacks a quick kiss to my cheek, inhaling her sweet scent. "Enjoy the rest of your little game, hmm? I think I'm going to take a nice hot bath."

Before I can object, she's off of my lap and strutting out of the room, leaving her soaked panties in my hand. Every eye in the room is on me, some of them glinted with amusement, others with distaste.

"*Jesus Christ*," Matteo—of course, it's Matteo—breaks the silence. "Is *that* what being married is like?"

My lips spread into a small smirk. *It is for me, apparently.*

"Yes," Emilio brags at the same time Dad replies, "Not even close."

Leon just frowns and shakes his head. "Definitely not."

"No comment," Dmitri adds, being the only other married man in the room. No answer is all the answer my brother needs in this case.

"Three out of five, then," Matteo concludes. "I like those odds, maybe I need to start looking for a wife."

"God help us all," Apollo mutters before tipping back his drink.

Matteo rolls his eyes. "Dick."

"I don't think many marriages are like Cassio and Ana's," Armani tells him. "She has his name tattooed in seven different places on her body."

“She does?” Dad asks, bewildered at the new information.

Fuck yes, she does.

And now I have her name inked on the right side of my heart, taking up most of the space on my peck. *My three favorite letters, branding me for life.*

“Yep,” Armani confirms, smirking. “I would know, I put them there.”

My smirk dies. As much as I enjoy my name being permanently etched into my wife’s skin, I despise the reminder that my brother put it there seven times over. At least we’re well matched, because he did my tattoo of her name too.

“I saw the one on her ring finger, but where…” Dad stops himself. “I don’t even want to know.”

No, you do not, I think deviously.

Bored of them and hungry for my girl, I stand up and toss my chips in the middle. “I’m out.”

“Have fun,” Colton says with a sultry tip of his hat. He’s probably so proud of her. I wouldn’t be surprised if he and Armani encouraged this from her.

As much as I detest sharing my girl in any way, having those two as her friends has helped her grow in ways I could never have expected. They’ve emboldened her with a confidence that I not only admire but crave. She’s so utterly herself, and it makes me deliriously happy.

Nico huffs with disdain. “Can we return to the game? This is revolting.”

“If his wife is home, that means mine is as well,” Emilio states, standing up from the table alongside me. “I’d much rather see her stunning face than continue this, no offense.”

“None taken,” Dmitri tells him. We all know he’d rather be with Jade too.

Matteo starts to complain, but I can hardly hear him as I leave the group, venturing off to find my minx, her panties held tightly in my fist. I’m going to make her pay for that sexy little stunt.

Here I come, *forza*.

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Epilogue 1



Ana

"Keep it down, baby," Cassio says, lips hot against my ear. "You don't want everyone here to know what we're doing behind this tree, do you?"

"I can't help it," I whine, rocking back against his thrusts. "It feels so good raw."

My husband getting a vasectomy a few months back has been a game changer for our sex life. I'm addicted to feeling him without a barrier, and he's addicted to stuffing my cunt full of his cum.

"Naughty girl," he hisses, teeth nipping at the side of my neck. "Getting off on your man's bare cock while all of our friends and family are within yelling distance. Getting bent over a tree on *Empire Academy grounds*, no less."

Yeah, I'm letting my husband hit it outside while a whole crew of people finish setting up for my best friend's wedding. *Sue me.*

"I'm close," I whimper, thighs starting to shake.

Cassio groans, digging his fingers into the muscle of my ass. "Rub your clit under your dress. I want you to keep quiet and come for me. That's it, good girl."

My eyes roll back, fingers trembling around my clit while Cassio continues to pound into me from behind.

"There you go," he rumbles. "Fuck, you take it so good, Wife. Let go. Come on, baby. Come for me."

I choke back a scream, and walls tighten around his thick cock in a fluttering pulse. Cassio's hips buck hard three more times before he

unloads. His final thrust shakes as warm liquid floods my pussy.

“So are we adding semi-public sex to your list of growing kinks?”

“Definitely,” I breathe.

Cassio pushes my knickers back into place, lightly tapping my cunt. “You walking around all these people, full of my fucking cum, that’s on the list too?”

“I can neither confirm nor deny,” I quip teasingly.

Cassio huffs at me, giving me a headed kiss before lightly smacking my ass. “Let’s go maid of honor, the sooner we get this thing going, the sooner I have you back on my cock.”

“You are insatiable today.”

“You make it hard not to be.”

Before I know it, it’s ceremony time. Despite the gorgeous and expansive setting that the ruins garden at Empire provides, Jade and Dmitri decided to keep their traditional wedding party small. The front row on either side of the aisle are filled with their families, but they each only have one person standing in front of the crowd with them.

And incredibly, I’m one of the two.

Soft music floating around the mossy green setting cues the beginning of the proceedings. I hold my breath as I take my place, standing out of view at the end of the trail. Dmitri is already standing at the altar in his tuxedo, an arch of greenery framing him from above.

Ivan goes first, walking down the white rose petal aisle while holding Cesar. The squirmy one-year-old baby flaunts his little ring bearer box like it’s the most amazing treasure, waving at the audience. There are a few chuckles, but mostly a collection of feminine coos.

With Isobella tucked against my hip, I walk slowly, helping her toss tiny handfuls of flower petals to the ground. When she tries to stuff some in her mouth, I catch her hand just in time. Ivan hands Cesar off to Apollo, and I pass Isobella to Matteo’s waiting arms before taking my place.

Tears prick in my eyes as the music shifts and a flurry of white fabric catches my attention. Jade ended up falling in love with a pure white, silk ball gown with a corset back. It fits her incredibly well, and she looks absolutely gorgeous with her long brown curls styled to perfection.

Arm and arm with a tuxedo clad Dante, she walks down the path, emotion welling up in her eyes. From the corner of my eye, I see Dmitri’s fist clench, like he’s fighting off the urge to get choked up.

I see the love between them clear as day as Dad gives Jade's hand to her husband, sharing a thoughtful look with the man. They may have been technically married for over a year now, but Dante will always treat Jade like his little girl. He missed out on too much to not be overprotective where she's concerned.

The ceremony goes off without a hitch, and the reception is now in full swing. It's time for the thing I've been anticipating the most. My maid of honor speech. Public speaking isn't my favorite thing, but Jade asked, and I could hardly deny her on her big day.

"Hello, everyone. If we haven't been introduced, I'm Ana Moretti—our lovely bride's sister," I start, holding the microphone tightly so that it doesn't slip from my clammy hands.

Cassio catches my attention in the crowd at our table and offers an encouraging smile.

"When I first met Jade, I told her I didn't want to be friends." A confused murmur breaks out and I huff good-naturedly. "Yeah, I know. Something you'll learn about me, I'm a tad wary and untrusting of new people. I'm sure plenty of you can relate."

A good number of guests chuckle and I breathe a little easier.

"I couldn't open myself up to a friendship with someone new at Empire, telling her that true bonds were forged in the real world, where actions could have consequences. But after we left the island, and only a few days into getting to know Jade Moretti, I knew no consequences would be necessary."

I watch as Jade clutches her heart, listening with undivided attention.

"Jade ended up being one of the most beautiful, selfless, kind-hearted, and loving people I have the pleasure of knowing."

Keep it together, Ana. Don't get emotional.

"I never wanted a sibling growing up," I admit. "I enjoyed being spoiled, and existing in my own little world. But being Jade's friend, and now her family, I can't imagine living any other way."

"I love you!" Jade calls out.

The Morettis surrounding her laugh, and so do I.

"I love you too," I reply, straightening my shoulders before continuing with my planned speech. "Speaking of love… I have to say that I couldn't be happier with Jade's choice in husband."

Dmitri pats my friend's hand as she grabs it, like she can't wait to hear what I have to say about the man she loves so deeply.

"I knew that I liked Dmitri for Jade as soon as I saw her smile at him, but I knew that Dmitri was a truly good man when I first saw him with his children. Cesar and Isobella are a testament to the undeniable love shared by these two incredible people.

"My brother Killian once told me that a good man has happy children—that a good man's family fuels him. A good man does everything in his power to provide, protect, and preserve the lives of the people he cares for. I can say without question that Dmitri Morozov is a good man, and I couldn't have asked for a better match for my best friend."

A round of clapping allows me to pause, checking my index card. I memorized my lines already, of course, but it's a comfort to hold a reminder when doing something so important.

"After marrying Cassio, I knew things with Jade could change," I carry on lightly. "We weren't going to be just friends who texted every day and visited when they could anymore. We were going to be sisters."

I catch Cassio smiling, and breathe easier.

"And since I'd never had a sister before, I wanted to make sure that our new relationship remained as true as our friendship. So, in true neurotic fashion, I made a list of things we have in common. I needed to assure myself that there would always be things for us to bond over, even if we were apart. And if you all don't mind, I'd like to read you some of what I came up with—"

There's a loud cheer, most of which can be traced to the Moretti siblings.

I chuckle, feeling nervous but happy to share. "Well, if you insist…"

Taking a deep breath, I find my center in Cassio's eyes. Just one look at that man and I feel like I'm on top of the world.

"We're both brunettes," I note first, smiling as the crowd titters in response. "We value the same things—namely kindness, honesty, strength, family, and trust. We've both secretly developed an obsession for zombie films after Matteo's insistence upon them."

I hear the youngest Moretti brother's burst of laughter in response, and grin as I continue, "Neither of us enjoy music older than the seventies, we both detest Brussels sprouts, and we'd both rather spend a day in the house

with family than go out. Not to mention our shared appreciation for our half-dressed husbands post work-out."

Jade's face flushes, and I snicker at the collective groan of our brothers.

Steering away from the humor, I take a deep breath. "But most notably, the thing Jade and I have in common is that Dante Moretti saved us," I say, choking back the emotion creeping up my throat and looking at the man in question. "He knew neither of us well enough to do the incredible things he did, and yet he leapt at the chance to take care of us both. For Jade, because she was his blood. He knew it as soon as he saw her. And for me, simply because his daughter called me her friend."

Do not cry, do not cry, do not cry.

"The world knows Dante Moretti as a ruthless Capo. An Italian man with a long legacy and immense power, a man known for greatness and strength. He is, of course, all of these things. But Dante's greatest strength isn't the men he has at his back, it isn't the money in his bank, or the countless connections he's forged in blood and gold. It's his unflinching ability to take care of his own. Dante Moretti is first and foremost, a father of the utmost excellence."

My lips tremble as I look at him, the man who's come to be a true father to me. "He takes care of his children. He didn't just mold his boys into men, he showed them love, tenderness, and respect in a world that is full of the opposite. Through Dante, Jade and I both gained not only a father, but a force of brothers to guide and protect us. We found friendship in each other and in them, we found our husbands—even if Jade wasn't supposed to be looking for one of those."

Dmitri smirks, holding back a laugh.

"I apologize that this speech has gone a bit long," I note with a nervous smile. "I just couldn't possibly say what Jade means to me—what this family means to me—in only a few short lines. So, I'd like to propose a toast, not only to the happy couple, but to the Moretti-Morozov families. I can't wait to share the rest of this life with all of you."

Jade thrusts her glass into the air.

"Cheers," I say, tipping my champagne toward her.

"*Cheers,*" the crowd echoes.

I excuse myself and take a few centering breaths.

That went really well, I think.

Before I can rush off to find Cassio and demand he be honest about my performance, I come across the most adorable sight.

Anatoly is holding Isobella while she tries not to doze off on his chest. She's tired from such an exciting day, the poor thing. I'm sure someone will take her to bed soon, probably Melani and Emilio when they take Mila up. And little Leo is practically glued to the guard's side, fisting his pant leg into his small hand and leaning against the solid man.

"Awww, Anatoly," I gush, getting a fierce case of cuteness aggression. I just want to squeeze something small and fluffy, but settle for getting closer to the adorable sight. "Leo has had a lot of trouble with men, especially large ones. I'm so happy that he likes you!"

The big guy flushes a bit and shrugs a shoulder, trying to remain nonchalant. "He sees small baby girl safe in my arms. He knows I am not a threat if little baby Isobella does not cry while I hold."

"*Toly*," Leo babbles, tugging his pant leg.

"Oh my gosh." I clutch my chest and breathe out. "He calls you *Toly*, that is absolutely precious."

"Name is mouthful, not easy for small child," he replies with another shrug. Anatoly is a tough nut to crack, always so kind but so distant. I can't complain though, he'd push a moving train off its track if it meant keeping my niece and nephew safe.

"Any chance you have an Italian twin?" Leon inquires, joining our small group. "We could use a trustworthy guard around the house but Leo here is still struggling with English."

"Da, da, da," Leo says excitedly, rushing to his adoptive father's side. "*Toly*, baby."

"Yes, Anatoly is holding the baby, very good," Leon says right before repeating the same sentence in Italian for his son. Leo smiles bright in response and tucks himself into the side of Leon's legs.

"So, no brother?" Leon asks with a chuckle. "And I doubt I could bribe you away from Jade and Dmitri—"

"Not on your life, Brother," Jade cuts in, still glowing from the joy of the day. "You'd have to pull Anatoly out of my cold dead hands; he's family now. But if you want a quality guard, I bet Apollo can find you one that he trusts."

"Apollo can do anything," I agree with a bright smile.

“And he wants us all to know it,” Leon comments, a bit of bitterness in his tone, but it’s mostly teasing. “I’ll work with him on it. Having two boys running around now is going to be a lot.”

“Are Bastian and Leon getting along?” Jade asks, softly pinching Isobella’s little cheeks.

“As well as brothers get along at their age,” he replies, smiling. “They love each other for most of the day and have some little spats here and there. Reminds me of me and Cassio growing up.”

“So Bastian is hiding Leo in closets?” my husband inquires, sliding a hand to the small of my back.

Leon snorts. “You’re never going to let that go, are you?”

“Never,” Cassio agrees. “Don’t hold your breath on that one.”

“Brothers,” Jade huffs. “Such drama queens.”

And we wouldn’t have it any other way.

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Epilogue 2



Cassio

"Your speech was lovely," I tell my wife for the third time. I know she was nervous about it, but she really did a great job. I know she made Jade cry, and if we weren't in public, I think Dad would have shed a tear or two.

Ana sighs. "This whole day has been lovely."

That it has.

But the night isn't over yet, and with a guest list full of gangsters, anything could go wrong. I'm not on edge, per se, but I'm certainly on alert. The only people in attendance are trusted family and friends, coupled with some staff for food and cleanup, but still. Being prepared is the key to keeping everything in order.

My eyes scan the party, catching on the sight of my youngest brother approaching the Morozov table. Having shed his jacket, Matteo swaggers over to Dmitri's father with his sleeves rolled up and hands empty to demonstrate a lack of threat.

As much as he's a jokester, my little brother is intelligent too.

Anton Morozov doesn't greet him with a warm look, but he isn't exactly a welcoming kind of man. He's a Pakhan through and through. The chilly stare he hits Matteo with doesn't faze him, of course.

Sharing the same table, his daughter Anya is flanked by her uncles Lev and Mikhail Morozov. Their icy glares match their eldest brother's. And still, Matteo greets the group with a wide, boy-ish grin.

I can't hear him from where I'm standing, but given the absolute shock on Anya's face, Matteo has addressed her directly.

“Excuse me for a moment, *forza*,” I murmur to my wife, kissing the side of her face. “I need to go make sure Matteo doesn’t get himself killed on our sister’s wedding day.”

Ana giggles and watches me go. As I pass by him, I grab Ivan by the arm, tugging the man along with me. He doesn’t protest.

“Aw, shit,” he curses, seeing what I’m seeing.

We stop a few feet short of the scene, standing by in case something goes terribly wrong and guns get drawn. Only Matteo hasn’t seemed to piss anyone off to that level yet.

My eyebrows shoot to my hairline as I watch him pull out a pair of handcuffs from his slacks. The three Russian mobsters stare at him like he has seven heads as he locks both of his wrists into the metal constraints.

Finally able to hear him, I listen in as Matteo continues to address the youngest Morozov sibling.

“Now, I know being handcuffed isn’t exactly enough reassurance that you’re safe with me—we are strangers after all. So, I’d like to ask that your father and uncles keep their… *aim* on me while we dance. That is, if you’d like to? I promise, I won’t lay a hand on you.”

A dance. He’s asking her to *dance*.

Fuck, he is such a sweet little moron. I know I said he’s smart, but my God. Asking Anya Morozov to dance with you is *bold*. Even speaking to the girl is brave, in-laws or not.

“My dad’s going to lose his shit,” Ivan whispers, but there’s a glint of hope in his eyes as he watches this unfold.

Anya worries her bottom lip, and turns to her father. She looks almost hopeful, too.

“Jade told us all that Anya doesn’t touch men,” I say quietly, even though Ivan is well aware. “He handcuffed himself and all but told your father to point a gun at him so your sister can dance at this wedding. Matteo is going to let their only point of contact be her touching him while his life is quite literally on the line. Your father won’t lose his shit.”

“Matteo is too nice for his own good,” Ivan mumbles. “If he were anyone else, he’d be on the ground already.”

But he’s not anyone else. He’s a Moretti. And contrary to how some assholes will see it, he isn’t offering her a pity dance. Matteo doesn’t do anything he doesn’t want to. He *wants* to dance with Anya, to make her feel safe and a part of the night.

“Can I, Father?” Anya asks, her voice a bit unsteady. “Please?”

Anton hesitates, but ultimately dips his head in approval. The smile that spreads across Anya’s face in response makes him freeze, like he hasn’t seen it in months or years—and maybe he hasn’t. From what I know, the worst day of her life occurred over three years ago now, when she was fifteen. I doubt she’s spent much of her time smiling since.

Matteo smiles too, standing still while she tentatively rounds the table. “You want my hands behind my back or do you want to step under them? I won’t touch you either way.”

“Would it be too much work to put them behind your back?” she asks, her pale cheeks turning pink.

Matteo chuckles happily. “Nah, I got this,” he tells her smugly.

Bending down he steps through his connected hands one foot at a time. When he straightens back up, he has his interlocked fingers firmly behind his back.

“We’ll go dance near Dmitri and Jade, okay?”

Anya looks hopefully at her father, and again, he pauses before nodding.

“If anyone gets too close to us, I’ll sic Nico on them,” Matteo tells her, walking slowly by her side. “He looks bored anyways, he’d love an excuse to shed some blood.”

Anya giggles and it’s like the sound scares her. She clasps a hand around her lips and her eyes go round. A second passes before she shakes off her shock and she looks up at Matteo.

“You didn’t have to do this,” she says shyly.

Matteo scoffs off the comment. “No one *has* to ask the prettiest girl at the party to dance, but I could hardly miss the chance.”

Her face flames and she gapes at him like a fish out of water. “You can’t mean that. You don’t have to be so nice to me, you know?”

“Oh, I never lie about pretty girls, Anya.” He chuckles. They’ve stopped walking and are now just standing in the middle of the dance floor, in no rush to start. “Well, I do give Emilio shit about Melani, complimenting her a lot. She’s beautiful of course, but married women aren’t *really* my thing. Don’t tell anyone I said that, I have a reputation to protect.”

“A reputation as what?” she replies, looking amused to share a secret with him.

Grinning, he tells her, “I’m a bit of a tease. Someone has to keep my tight ass brothers on their toes.”

Anya hides her smile, a bit of her honey blonde hair falling in front of her face as she looks down.

“You can hold my shoulders if you like,” Matteo offers. “Or we can kind of just hover around each other. I’m game either way.”

Ivan holds his breath as his little sister tentatively reaches out, extending her hands to set them lightly on Matteo’s shoulders.

“Fuck,” he breathes in disbelief. “He just made more progress with her in two minutes than we have in two years.”

I nod proudly. “Matteo tends to have that effect on people.”

Ears twitching with awareness, I turn my head from the scene. It’s subtle, but I pick up on the sound of a confrontation.

“Watch him, will you?”

Before Ivan can agree, I’m abandoning him to locate the noise. I’m not the only one who senses something amiss, Apollo is heading in the same direction, shoulders straight and jaw hard. After distancing further from the crowd of wedding guests, the sound of yelling becomes clearer.

We move faster, zeroing in on the conflict, no discussion needed to get involved. Especially since what we find is un-fucking-acceptable.

A teenage boy is guarding a woman with his body while a grown ass man crowds him, shouting in his face and shoving. The woman is struggling to push the teen away, trying to keep him safe, I imagine. She’s here with the catering staff based on her outfit, but she isn’t a civilian. The company we hired is owned and operated by The Casa Nostra.

Known for being a particularly ruthless Italian mafia, our alliance with them was forged when Emilio married Melani—who is the daughter of one of the group’s most prominent Underbosses.

“I swear to God, Federico, don’t you put your hands on him,” the woman hisses, still trying to get between them. “You can hit me all you want, but if you touch my little brother even once, I will poison you in your sleep! Wives get away with that kind of thing all the time, and I won’t be the exception.”

Hearing her offer herself up to be assaulted leads me to believe he’s put his hands on her before, and that won’t do. It doesn’t matter what family she belongs to. She’s at a Moretti event, and that makes her our business. Apollo seems to agree, because he doesn’t even stop to confront the man—he comes out swinging.

A loud crack breaks through the argument as Apollo drops the asshole Federico with a single punch to the side of the head.

“Piece of shit,” he spits, adding insult to injury by kicking the man in the stomach.

“Holy shit.” The boy gapes, stepping back, still protecting his sister. “You’re Apollo Moretti.”

Hearing his name, the woman gasps. “*What the hell?*”

“What’s your name, kid?” Apollo asks, as I join him, giving the teenager an assessing look. “And hers… she’s your sister, yes?”

“Yordan Todorov,” he replies. “Rayna is my sister, and I am not a kid, I’m sixteen.” His chest puffs a bit, adding a firmness to his words.

Todorov is not an Italian name. She was married into the Casa Nostra, then. Poor thing got saddled with a fucking prick, too.

The corner of Apollo’s lip twitches up. “Sixteen *is* a man in our world,” he concedes. “Would you like to learn what men do to those who hurt their families?”

“W-what?” Rayna stutters from behind us but Apollo doesn’t look at her. He focuses entirely on the task at hand. He’s testing Yordan as much as he’s offering to teach him.

“I know what they do,” Yordan counters.

“Good,” Apollo comments, rolling his shoulders. Turning to me, he gestures to the half-unconscious piece of shit on the ground. “Ocean?”

“Ocean,” I agree.

I hadn’t come to my little sister’s wedding with the intention of getting my suit wet nor my hands bloodied, but when duty calls.

“Follow us,” Apollo instructs the teen. He listens immediately, ignoring his sister’s soft protests. She’s worried for him, and she should be. Not because we’ll hurt him, but because we’ll change him.

What she can’t possibly realize is that he’s already changed. Seeing your sister being slapped around isn’t something a boy—nor a man—in our world stands for. She had to know what this life would turn him into. She should be grateful that he seems to have a decent head on his shoulders. If any of us had caught a man assaulting Jade, Ana, Cleo, or Melani we would have dropped him in a near instant.

Once we’re waist-deep in the cold water, we’re far enough from the Island to be excluded from the no murder rule.

Apollo slaps a Glock into Yordan’s waiting palm. “Your sister, your kill.” The kid doesn’t even look scared as he accepts it.

“What the fuck?” Federico slurs. “You can’t just tell him to kill me! Do you even know who I am?”

“A wife beater?” Apollo drawls.

“A spineless cunt?” I offer.

“She deserves everything she gets,” he snaps. “She doesn’t fucking listen. She’s supposed to serve me!”

Cocking the gun, Yordan presses the end of the barrel against Federico’s forehead. “I told you I would kill you for hitting her. Rayna didn’t want to risk being stuck with someone worse than you, she begged me not to. But I won’t let her be saddled with another son of a bitch like you ever again.”

Anger is replaced by fear in an instant.

“I’m your brother,” the worthless man tries to plead.

A dark look flickers through Yordan’s eyes. “Says who?”

A shot rings out, and something like pride seems to rush through my brother as a triumphant smirk spreads his lips. We release his now dead weight and Yordan blinks, extending his hand to pass Apollo’s gun back to him.

“You keep it,” he tells the teen, starting to guide him out of the water. “Let it serve as a reminder of what made men do to those who hurt their family.”

“Might need it,” Yordan muses, smiling weekly. “Just killed one of Abramo Guliani’s men with the help of two Morettis. He’ll try to have my head before I can even start to defend myself.”

“You let me handle Abramo,” Apollo says darkly. “You won’t be going back there.”

“We won’t?”

“No, you’re coming home with us.”

Yordan gapes, feet hitting the dry, black beach sand.

“We are?”

Apollo opens his mouth, only to be silenced.

“How dare you?” Rayna demands storming up to us with wild eyes and a sneer on her lips. “He’s just a boy, he has no business killing people! You’ve just given him a death sentence.”

“Tell your sister to pack her things,” Apollo instructs Yordan, flicking his gaze between the Todorov siblings. “We’re staying in the west building

tonight, I'll make sure you have a room there. We leave on the jet tomorrow morning, nine sharp."

"What are you talking about?" Rayna rears back in shock and outrage. "We aren't going anywhere with you, we don't even know you."

Apollo blinks at her tone, surprised anyone is bold enough to speak to him in such a way. "I wasn't asking for your input. If you want to be free of Abramo's wrath, you'll come with us."

"So, what? You can give me a price for that freedom that I could never dream of repaying? Fat chance! I am *not* trading one jailer for another."

"I'm sure you'll find I don't have much taste for holding hostages."

"There will be no payment," I inform her, attempting a lighter tone than my blunt older brother. "Morettis take care of women, no questions asked, no compensation required. You want to protect your brother, don't you? You'll be safe with our family."

She shrinks in on herself, like she's recognizing that she may have overreacted. She shouldn't be embarrassed or ashamed, there's no right way to react to Apollo inserting himself in your life, especially in a way that ends up with a dead body.

"Nine," Apollo repeats the time, pulling off his soaked suit jacket.

"We'll be ready," Yordan assures us, grabbing his sister's hand to calm her. "Thank you."

Nodding, I make a move to depart. "Anyone bothers you, you come to us."

Yordan agrees, and as I turn to walk back up the beach, my wife is running toward me. Bare feet, blue dress swaying behind her, and towels in hand, she almost slams right into me.

"Are you okay?" Ana fusses, wrapping a towel around my wet tux. "Did you guys just kill someone? What happened?"

Chuckling at her worrisome expression, I swoop in to give her a hard kiss. Ana grunts, pushing me back.

"Cassio," she complains. "Seriously, what just happened?"

"Pretty sure Apollo just made a couple more Morettis."

THE END

Want to see more Cassio and Ana? Read their honeymoon bonus scene here: Free Bonus!

Or Preorder Book 3, Savage Empire Here.

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Endnote

Thanks so much for reading Ana and Cassio's story! This book was such a labor of love and took me forever to write (mostly due to personal issues). But I'm so glad I took the time to make sure these two got the care they deserved. It's always difficult to write grief, especially with characters like these two who have experienced such profound loss.

Over the past year, and especially the last few months while trying to write this, I've struggled so incredibly with anxiety and panic attacks. But after some medical intervention, I've made huge strides and feel so much better. So it's almost like I healed right alongside these two lovely characters. But I'm definitely ready for a change of pace…

Which is part of why I'm so excited to jump into Apollo and Rayna's story. Preorder **Savage Empire** here, and follow me on social media to stay tuned for updates. Apollo has been one of my favorite characters to write since the beginning, and Rayna is proving to be quite the spitfire already.

I can't wait to continue The Moretti Empire, and I hope you all feel the same! Book 4 hints were totally dropped as well, if you couldn't tell. A certain Russian ballerina and youngest Moretti boy haven't shared their last dance.

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First and foremost thank you to everyone who read and enjoyed Hidden Empire. That book has truly been such a turning point in my career. I genuinely did not expect it to gain so much traction (hence why I never promised a series at first). But I'm so insanely thrilled that I get to continue this world because of your support!

I want to thank my good friends Sarah and Brooke for the constant encouragement while I struggled this year! Author friends are unrivaled, and such a blessing personally and professionally.

As always, a big thank you to my lovely cover designer Sandra for absolutely crushing it once again!

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Some Other Works

Fun, Cute, and Cozy Books:

Invasion of Sorority Z (M/F, Alien Romance)

Dealing With Drak (M/F, Alien Romance)

Stand-Alone Novellas:

Candy Lips (FF, Stepsisters, Halloween)

Gifted To The Billionaires (MMF, Brother's Best Friends, Breeding)

Deep Desires Novellas:

Daddy's Perfect Ballerina (MM, Age Gap, Single Dad)

Daddy's Lost Rebel (MM, Age Gap, Mountain Man)

Daddy's Sweet Streamer (MM, Age Gap, Handyman)

Daddy's Grumpy Cowboy (MM, Age Gap, Rancher)

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